

VIDEHA

THE NAME WRITTEN WITHIN THE LEAF

A MAITHILI NOVEL



GAJENDRA THAKUR

Translated from the Maithili by the author

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*Translated from the Original Maithili into English
by the Author Himself*

VIDEHA

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CHAPTER 01

The Day the House Was Opened

The old lock hanging from the gate did not, at first glance, seem to Mrinalini as old as the hesitation within her. Green tarnish had crept over the brass, yet around the keyhole the wear of fingers still shone—as though, despite having remained shut for so long, the house had gone on waiting for someone. Across the lane, sunlight had slid as far as the shade of the peepal tree. It was a Bhadon afternoon; the air was heavy and still. She set her bag on the ground and took out the ring of keys. She already knew three of them, but on the fourth—the smallest—Basanti Kaki had tied a red thread. She remembered Kaki's words on the phone: "The key with the red thread is for the gate. Don't force it. Turn it gently; the lock has grown old."

Mrinalini did not laugh. An old lock, an old house, an old memory—the years she had spent in the city after leaving home had thinned her patience for such words. But when the lock resisted her first turn of the key, she found herself coaxing it almost as if it were human. She turned the key once the other way, then pushed it gently inward. A dry grinding came from inside the metal. On the second turn, the lock opened.

As she pushed the gate, a fine smell of dust and the rot of old leaves came out together. Mango leaves, withered flowers, two or three scraps of paper, and a light piece of plastic blown in from somewhere lay across the courtyard. Mrinalini's eye went first to the plastic. Plaster had fallen from the walls, moss had gathered in one corner of the veranda, and the wooden window had gone grey; yet the white-and-blue scrap of plastic in the middle of the courtyard was the newest thing there, and therefore the most out of place. She bent, picked it up, and slipped it into the outer pocket of her bag.

Standing in the middle of the courtyard, she looked all around. Up to what age had she belonged to this house? It was not a simple question. In childhood there had been summer holidays, weddings, shraddh ceremonies, an elder falling ill, someone being born—the house had once been the family's register of events. Later there were fewer people; rooms began to close, the

women who dried clothes on the roof were no longer there, and the laughter of the courtyard shrank into voices on the phone. The last time she had come was five years ago, when Baba was still alive. He had said, "One day, look through the papers of the house. Fewer and fewer people remain who can understand what survives." She had laughed and replied, "As long as you're here, where can their meaning run away?" Baba had not answered.

Now the whole house stood before her as the answer to that sentence.

When she opened the first room off the veranda, shut-in air struck her face. The weave of the cot had slackened. An old framed image of Krishna and Radha hung crooked on the wall. In a corner, the brass lota used for the ancestors lay overturned, dried lizard droppings inside it. Mrinalini tried to open the window, but the shutter had jammed. She pushed harder. The wooden panel suddenly gave way, and a square of sunlight fell across the floor. Dust motes floated through it as though countless tiny letters were flying inside sealed-up time.

Mrinalini took out her phone and took one photograph, then another. Photographing things was a habit of hers; proof that something had been seen could be made at once. But as soon as she lowered the camera, she understood: smell did not enter a photograph. The smell of this room held damp, old cloth, mustard oil, incense, and something left in the wood itself that carried her straight into an afternoon when she was seven years old, hiding beneath that very cot and eating pirukiya.

"Take a little time. Let the house become familiar again."

The voice came from behind her. Mrinalini turned. Basanti Kaki stood inside the gate, a cotton end of sari over her head, a small cloth bag in one hand and a steel container in the other. Her walk had slowed since Mrinalini last remembered it, but the brightness in her eyes was unchanged.

"You said nine o'clock," Mrinalini said.

"I did. But after coming here, is there any need to look at the clock?" Basanti Kaki smiled. "The house waited five years. You could not wait half an hour?"

Mrinalini was still looking for an answer when Basanti Kaki took the ring of keys from her hand, swept one glance over the courtyard, and without comment went straight toward the back. Mrinalini followed.



Basanti Kaki opened the kitchen door off the small rear veranda without a key. "This lock was never shut," she said. It was dark inside. Kaki first removed the

wooden cover from the ventilator, and only then could Mrinalini see the old layer of soot on the walls, the mouth of the brick hearth below, the newer gas stove beside it with its pipe long disconnected, and brass and bell-metal vessels on a bamboo shelf above. In one corner stood the grinding stone, turmeric and chilli ground so deeply into its edge that their colours had become part of the stone.

“Will you keep all this, or sell it?” Basanti Kaki asked.

“Nothing yet. First there will be an inventory.”

“Will the grinding stone go into the inventory?”

“Yes.”

“And will you write that mustard ground on this stone by your grandmother’s hand gave flavour to fish curry?”

Mrinalini looked at her. “How am I supposed to put that in an inventory?”

“Then the inventory will be only half an inventory,” Kaki said lightly as she took down the vessels.

This was her old way. She tossed a question so casually that only afterward did the person answering feel its weight. Mrinalini said nothing.

Kaki opened the steel container. Inside was flattened rice. From the bag she took out a small earthen pot of curd, two bananas, a little jaggery, and a packet of salt. “The gas won’t work. There’s no point wrestling with a fire just now. Eat something first.”

“I’ve already had breakfast.”

“Breakfast in the city is not breakfast for opening a house.”

Mrinalini tried to laugh again, and this time a laugh came. “There is a separate breakfast for opening houses?”

“Of course. Open a locked house on an empty stomach and every object begins to feel like a burden.”

Kaki washed an old brass plate. When she turned on the tap, brown water came first, then clear. Mrinalini said, “Not in that plate—there’s a steel one, isn’t there?”

“Why?”

She could not say. Fine scratches ran around the rim of the brass plate; the centre had gone pale, the outer ring darker. Basanti Kaki put down the flattened rice, spooned curd over it, sliced the banana, placed a small piece of jaggery at the side, and set apart a pinch of salt. “Mixed together, or separate?”

“Separate.”

“Still?”

“What do you mean, still?”

“Even as a child you wouldn’t mix your curd and flattened rice. You used to say every ingredient should remain visible in its own form.”

Mrinalini looked at the plate. She had no memory of saying this. Yet for a moment the seven-year-old child who refused to mix curd into her flattened rice stood before her—the child who arranged round slices of banana in order, saved the jaggery for the end, and sprinkled her pinch of salt not into the curd but along one edge of the rice.

With the first mouthful, the smell of the house changed. Over the damp came the faint sourness of curd, the dry earth-like smell of flattened rice, the sweetness of banana, the smoky taste of jaggery. The food was exceedingly simple; perhaps that was why there was no ornament in its flavours to stand between her and memory. Mrinalini began to eat slowly.

“Is the curd from the market?” she asked.

“No. I set it last night.”

“It set this well?”

“Shall I put curd-setting in the inventory too?”

“You’ve started again.”

“Not me. The house has started.”

Mrinalini stopped with a mouthful half-raised and looked at Kaki. Kaki was soaking flattened rice in her own plate, her eyes lowered. There was no theatricality in what she had said. That made it strike more deeply.

As they ate, Kaki began opening old stories—what year the mangoes had been abundant, what year the pond had dried up, where Grandmother had brought the tilkor vine from, whether Baba had truly loved kurthi dal or whether even Kaki was unsure of that now. “For one month in winter, kurthi used to be cooked in this house without fail,” she said. “Janaki Dai would say, eat it one month every year and you won’t get stones. We all listened. How much was true and how much was household belief—that you educated people can decide.”

Mrinalini almost opened the notes app on her phone by reflex, then stopped her hand. Kaki was eating. It felt right that, before becoming paper, this should remain speech for a few moments longer.

“Janaki Dai?”

“Your great-grandmother’s eldest sister-in-law. In that kitchen, her word carried the greatest authority.”

“Is there a photograph of her?”

“There may be a photograph. But where is the voice in a photograph?”

Mrinalini fell silent. For the second time that afternoon the same blow had landed—first, a photograph held no smell; now, it held no voice. She began to understand that her task here would not be merely to save papers.

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After the curd and flattened rice were finished, Basanti Kaki insisted on washing the plates. Mrinalini did not stop her. She pulled a chair into the courtyard and opened her phone. There were five missed calls from Ishan. The moment she called back, his brisk voice came through: “You reached? The broker will come at four. The man who measures the property will meet us too. We need to inspect the rear portion.”

“Today?”

“I wrote to you three times.”

“I thought we were looking at the papers first.”

“Look at the papers, but the matter of the house has to be finished within three months. Buyers won’t wait. The roof needs repairs again, the tax has been paid only up to now, and an empty house costs money every month.”

Mrinalini looked around the courtyard. Ishan’s argument on the other end of the phone was not wrong. Emotion did not make this house tax-exempt. Walls did not repair themselves. Doors were not protected from termites by the force of memory.

“Three months is fixed?”

“At most. Everyone agrees. Just sort the papers, photographs, and whatever is to be kept. I’ll take care of the rest.”

The words everyone agrees pricked her. How many of that ‘everyone’ could still recognise the smell of these rooms? But she did not argue with Ishan. “Come at four. But nothing leaves the house today.”

“Fine. Make the collection inventory first. That is why you were called.”

The call ended.

“Three months?” Kaki asked from behind her.

“You were listening?”

“In this courtyard, even if you speak softly, you can still be heard. Once that was considered an advantage. Now call it a defect.”

Mrinalini set the phone on the table. “The house will definitely be sold.”

Basanti Kaki was silent for a while. Her eyes rested on a patch of wall where, beneath the fallen plaster, a red line of an old Mithila painting showed through. “A house remains a house while people live in it. Once it is empty, it becomes a body. How long can one keep tending a body?”

“So you are not against selling it?”

“Who gave me the right to object?”

The question came again in a light voice, yet Mrinalini had to search for an answer. For more than forty years Kaki had been bound to this house in different ways—first working with Grandmother, later looking after the place, coming to sweep and clean for festivals and rituals, and, after the house was shut, opening the windows once a month. On paper she owned not even a handspan of its land. In memory, perhaps many of its rooms would have been incomplete without her.

“Does a right exist only on paper?” Mrinalini asked, more of Kaki than of herself.

Wiping the plate, Kaki said, “You are asking very difficult questions today. Such difficult questions should not be asked while eating curd and flattened rice.”

She smiled, and the knot of tension loosened a little.

Mrinalini began to make a work plan. First week—separate papers, manuscripts, photographs, letters, certificates, old account books. Second—vessels, clothes, paintings, handicrafts, family objects. Third—photograph or scan whatever could be digitally copied. In her notes she wrote: “Throw nothing away until it has been checked twice.” After thinking for a moment, she added: “Keep papers without names too.”

Basanti Kaki leaned over her shoulder to read. “People without names?”

“What?”

“You have written that nameless papers should be kept. What about nameless people?”

Mrinalini switched off the phone. “You are not going to let me work today.”

“The house will make you work. I only came with curd.”

Kaki left. Before closing the gate, she said, “Don’t open the upstairs room alone. The bamboo ladder is loose.”

“Why? What is up there?”

“When you open it, you’ll see.”

“You know?”

Kaki stood outside the gate for a moment, thinking. “I knew. I don’t remember now. In an old house, ‘I don’t remember’ and ‘I won’t say’ are two different things. I am saying the first.”

The gate closed. Mrinalini was alone in the courtyard.



There were still two hours before four. Mrinalini began with the first room. She opened each section of the cupboard and sorted photographs, papers, and clothes. Her grandparents' wedding picture, Baba's appointment letter, an old radio licence, two leaves from a Sanskrit manuscript, a tattered issue of a Maithili magazine, school certificates, a letter with half the stamp peeled from its envelope. Some things declared themselves at once; others had lost their introductions.

In a small tin she found seeds. They were very old, dried out, difficult to identify. In pencil on the lid was written: "Tilkor—back garden." Mrinalini turned the tin in her hand. Tilkor had not figured in Kaki's stories over the curd and flattened rice that afternoon, but the word was familiar to her—a plate of tarua, a wedding feast, Grandmother's voice. She placed the tin in a separate box labelled "Plants/Seeds."

Just then something fell upstairs. First a faint rustle, then a knock. Mrinalini froze. There was no one else in the house. She came into the courtyard and looked up. Was the door of the small room near the roof half open, or did it only seem so? Basanti Kaki had told her not to go there.

A prohibition has its own attraction, especially when the reason given is "the ladder is loose" and some suspicion inside you insists that the real reason lies elsewhere.

The bamboo ladder leaned against the veranda wall. Mrinalini pressed the first rung. A creak. The second. The third. She slipped her phone into her pocket and climbed one step at a time. At the top, she saw that the door really was half open. Perhaps the wind? But where was there any wind in the house?

She pushed the door. Darkness. She switched on her phone light. The room was very small; because of the sloping roof it was difficult to stand upright. An old cot, a bamboo basket, two iron trunks, a wooden chest, vessels wrapped in newspaper, a broken spinning wheel, and something covered with cloth against the wall. There was so much dust that every step made a mark.

The source of the knock was immediately clear—a brass lid had fallen to the floor. Tiny rat tracks crossed it. Mrinalini exhaled in relief. She liked the thought that the first cause of a mystery was often a rat.

But her eyes stopped when they reached the wooden chest. Iron bands ran around it, and a thick layer of dust lay on top. In the middle was a small rusted lock. A paper label pasted to it was almost destroyed, yet two letters could still be read: "Bha..."

Mrinalini knelt. She did not make the mistake of blowing away the dust; she wiped it gently with a handkerchief. The shadow of ink emerged on what

remained of the label. “Bhanas...” perhaps. Below it, some numbers? 19...? Nothing more was clear.

The keys were downstairs. She went back for them. The one with the red thread was for the gate, two large ones for cupboards, and one with a round head—perhaps for the chest. Not the first. Not the second. The third went in, but would not turn. She was about to force it when Basanti Kaki’s words returned to her: the lock has grown old; turn it gently. She drew the key out slightly, turned it back, pushed it in again, and eased it slowly to the right. Click.

The chest opened.

On top lay a fold of muslin that seemed to crumble into dust at a touch. Mrinalini lifted it by one edge. Beneath it were bundles of papers, two old account books, a manuscript wrapped in cloth, a small box, and several loose sheets. Between the papers were turmeric-yellow stains, and here and there round marks left by oil. These looked different from ordinary family papers.

She lifted the cloth-wrapped manuscript. When she opened the wrapping, a brown cover appeared. In the middle, in handwriting, were the words: “Bhanas-Pothi”—Kitchen Book. The letters were in Devanagari, written in dark ink. Below, in smaller writing: “Devakant Jha”—or perhaps only “Devakant”? The surname had blurred.

Once again Mrinalini heard Baba’s voice: “One day, look through the papers of the house.”

Before opening the manuscript, she took out her phone and photographed the chest. Then the cover. Then the first page. The first page was comparatively clear—a date, headings for ingredients, the names of a few dishes. The Devanagari was orderly. She turned the page. The second. The third. The fourth.

On the fifth page, her finger stopped.

The main writing was dark and upright. But in the margin was an altogether different, finer hand—curving, intricate, familiar and yet strange. Mrinalini could not read it at once. Tirhuta? Had Baba once shown her something like this? She was not completely sure.

She brought the phone light closer to the margin. The main text gave quantities of ingredients. After the marginal letters, someone had added a small word in Devanagari: “Season.”

Mrinalini did not close the manuscript. Her breathing slowed.

Below, in the courtyard, someone knocked at the gate. Perhaps Ishan had arrived.

She opened her mouth to answer, but no sound came at once. Her eyes remained fixed on that fine marginal writing. Until now, through the afternoon of opening the house, she had thought she had come merely to make an inventory—papers, vessels, photographs, clothes, manuscripts; what to keep, what to leave, what to scan.

For the first time, it occurred to her that perhaps she was not making an inventory of the house. Perhaps the house was making an inventory of her.

The gate was knocked again.

Mrinalini did not wrap the manuscript back in its cloth. She pressed it against her arm and moved toward the ladder. In the dust were the fresh marks of her feet; now, as she descended, a second set of impressions was forming beside them.

CHAPTER 02

The Second Hand

The gate was knocked for the third time while Mrinalini was halfway down the ladder, the Bhanas-Pothi in one hand, the bamboo rung gripped with the other. As she descended, it occurred to her that in an old house even the manner in which one lifted an object was a decision—some things could be left in a chest; others would not let the mind rest unless they were carried in one's hands.

"If you keep pounding on the gate like that, it will break before the house is sold," she called from inside.

Ishan's voice came from outside. "Then there'll be one less thing to sell."

Mrinalini opened the gate. Ishan stood there with two cups of tea and a paper packet of namkeen. His eyes went first to the dust on Mrinalini's clothes, then to the manuscript pressed beneath her arm.

"I take it you went upstairs."

"You all seem very fond of telling me the ladder is loose."

"Kaki called and told me you were not to go up."

"That is why I went."

Ishan laughed. "That is the misfortune of old household rules—the new generation reads a prohibition and takes it for an invitation."

He came inside. Mrinalini shut the gate and placed the manuscript on the veranda bench. Setting down the tea, Ishan asked, "What did you find?"

"Wash your hands first."

"Are we going to eat the manuscript?"

"No. But there is oil from the namkeen on your fingers."

Without arguing, Ishan went to the tap. Mrinalini set the manuscript before her and looked again at its cover. "Bhanas-Pothi"—nothing more. No author's name, no name of the house, no year. Inside, the first page carried a date and a list of ingredients; from the fifth page onward, that fine writing began in the margin.

When Ishan returned after drying his hands, he did not sit before the manuscript. He first took out his phone and began to photograph it.

“Wait.”

“Why?”

“Look first. Photographs later.”

“Because you think I am a businessman, you put restrictions on everything I do.”

“You are a businessman.”

“So?”

“So let the object remain an object first. Do not turn it instantly into promotional material.”

Ishan placed his phone face down. “Fine. Guruji, show me.”

Mrinalini opened the first page. The writing in dark ink was upright, orderly, almost bureaucratic in its discipline. A date at the top. Below it, ingredients: rice, dal, salt, oil, leaves, spices. Quantities here and there. Small marks after some words, perhaps added later.

“Could this be Devkant’s handwriting—Baba’s father?” Ishan asked.

“Possibly. There should be letters of his in the house. We can compare them.”

The same hand appeared on the second page, and on the third. At the end of the fourth, one line had been left blank in the middle. On the fifth page the main writing continued, but along the left margin appeared two lines of finer, curling script.

Ishan bent closer. “This is not Devanagari.”

“It may be Tirhuta.”

“Can you read it?”

“I recognise the letters, but not an old hand like this in full.”

“To me it looks like a drawing.”

Mrinalini did not put a finger on the marginal writing; she merely followed its line in the air. Unlike the main text, the lines did not run straight. Words rose at times, dipped at others, as though the writer were negotiating with whatever space remained on the page.

“One hand wrote the book,” she said softly. “Another kept answering in the margins.”

Ishan opened his mouth to laugh, then did not. “Answering? Not commenting?”

“A comment can also be an answer.”

She turned the next pages. In some places there was a single word, in others three lines. At several points, after the fine writing, the main hand had added a small correction in Devanagari. On one page one quantity had been crossed out for another. On another, there was a question mark after the name of a dish. On a third there was only a Tirhuta line, and empty space opposite it.

Ishan lifted his tea. "This is interesting."

Mrinalini looked at him. "Interesting?"

"Yes. An old Bhanas-Pothi, two hands, a mystery—"

"There you go again."

"I am only saying there is a book in this."

"Right now it is not a book. It is not evidence either. Right now it is only paper."

Ishan fell silent. Mrinalini heard the hardness in her own voice. She lifted her cup. The tea had gone slightly cold.

"I'm sorry," she said. "The moment you see something in this house, you see its future. Perhaps I work the other way—I want to see its past first."

Ishan opened the packet of namkeen, but kept it away from the manuscript. "Fine. But one day the past needs a future too. Otherwise the rats will read it."

Mrinalini smiled. He was not wrong.

She decided to photograph every page—without pressing the manuscript flat, without flash. Ishan tried to turn an old brass bowl upside down as a phone stand, but Mrinalini stopped him. In the end they propped the phone on two thick old magazines.

In the first photograph, the letters looked clearer on the screen than on the paper. Some marks in the fine writing came into focus. Mrinalini enlarged the image. In one place, after a Tirhuta line, the main hand had written a small word in Devanagari: "No."

"Whose 'no'?" Ishan asked.

"We don't know yet."

"You could put that question everywhere."

"Good."

"And the answer?"

"Where we find one, we will write it. Where we do not, we will leave the space blank."

Ishan looked at her for a moment. "You really have gone inside this work."

"It has only been five pages."

“Sometimes five pages are a great deal.”

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Before dusk, Mrinalini had separately photographed the manuscript’s outer cover, pages one through ten, the thread binding, and the texture of the paper. Ishan went out twice in between to take phone calls; when he returned, he brought an old cloth on which the manuscript could be laid.

“The author’s name is nowhere?” he asked again.

Mrinalini turned back to the first page. “No.”

“At the back?”

The back cover was blank. On the last pages inside were a few accounts, then two missing pages. The final surviving page held an unfinished list, but no name.

“That is strange,” Ishan said. “Someone who wrote so systematically did not write his own name?”

“If it was a book for use within the household, a name may not have been necessary.”

“But there is a date.”

“A date is useful. Everyone in the house would have known the name.”

Ishan nodded. “And then the people who come later forget.”

At that one sentence Mrinalini fell silent. Perhaps this was the problem with paper: what everyone knows at the time is not written down; later, whatever has been written comes to seem like the whole truth.

She began opening the other papers found in the chest. The first page of one ledger carried the name of the head of the household. A second bundle held wedding expenses. A third contained land papers from twenty years later. Everywhere, men’s names were clear. Only the Bhanas-Pothi was nameless.

“There is no author’s name,” Mrinalini said, “but this house had very clear rules about whose names were to be written.”

Whether Ishan understood what she meant, he did not say. He began reading the wedding-expense sheet—so many maunds of rice, so much curd, so much ghee, so many hundreds of betel leaves. After a while he laughed.

“Look at the expense on paan. Half this house’s prestige ran on betel leaves.”

“And the other half on credit.”

“Credit too is part of prestige.”

Mrinalini tied the bundle again. Her attention remained fixed on the namelessness of the Bhanas-Pothi. She remembered the old family lists—

grandfather, great-grandfather, land, title, education, employment. Women's names appeared through marriage: 'so-and-so's daughter', 'so-and-so's wife'. Where, in such a list, would the knowledge of the kitchen ever appear?

She opened her laptop and began a provisional catalogue:

Bhanas-Pothi — estimated 1930s.

Main hand — unknown; possibly Devkant.

Marginal writing — unknown; possibly Tirhuta.

Authorship — undetermined.

Condition — fragile; some pages torn/stained.

Reading the screen, Ishan said, "Possibly Devkant? If Shashibhushan Kaka reads this, he will object to the word 'possibly'."

"Let him."

"He always says Devkant wrote everything—diaries, essays, poems, even accounts of the fields."

"Then comparison will be easy."

"Will you call him?"

Mrinalini looked at the time. "Not yet."

At that moment Ishan's phone rang. The instant he saw the screen, he laughed. "Speak of him, and he calls."

It was Shashibhushan.

Ishan did not put him on speaker, but from his replies Mrinalini could follow half the conversation. "Yes, Kaka... yes, I'm at the house... Mrinalini too... no, nothing has broken... the manuscript? Who told you?"

He looked at Mrinalini. With her eyes she asked: who?

Ishan moved the phone away from his ear and whispered, "Basanti Kaki."

Then into the phone again: "Yes, we found it... no, nothing has been decided yet... you're coming? Now?"

Mrinalini made a gesture of holding her head.

Ishan ended the call and said, "Ten minutes."

"How is he coming in ten minutes?"

"When Kaka says ten minutes, it means he has already left his house."

Seven minutes later, sure enough, they heard a scooter stop outside the gate.



Shashibhushan was around seventy, but there was still haste in the way he walked. The moment he entered the gate, his first question was not about the house but the manuscript.

“Where is it?”

Mrinalini pointed toward the veranda. “Sit down first.”

“I’ll sit afterward.”

He went to the bench, but before touching the manuscript looked at his own hands. “Where is the water?”

Mrinalini was surprised. Ishan suppressed a smile. Shashibhushan washed his hands, dried them with a gamchha, and only then sat down at the bench. That one act of care softened something in Mrinalini toward him.

He looked at the cover. “Bhanas-Pothi.” He said the words as though reading the name of an old acquaintance.

“Have you seen it before?” Mrinalini asked.

“When I was small. I cannot say for certain whether it was this one or another. There were several such books in the house.”

“Who wrote it?”

“Devkant Baba.”

There was not a moment’s hesitation in the answer.

“How do you know?”

Shashibhushan looked at Mrinalini. “What do you mean, how do I know?”

“There is no name anywhere.”

“Look at the handwriting.”

“I will compare it.”

“Compare it. But it is his.”

Ishan cut in. “Kaka, there is another hand in the margins too.”

Shashibhushan opened the fifth page. He took his spectacles from his pocket and put them on. At the sight of the finer letters, his brows tightened slightly.

“That will have been added later.”

“By whom?” Mrinalini asked.

“Someone in the house may have written it.”

“When?”

“Hard to say.”

“During Devkant’s time, or afterward?”

“Mrinalini,” Shashibhushan said, taking off his spectacles, “old papers do not come with birth certificates for every line.”

“That is why I’m asking.”

Shashibhushan did not smile. “Your Baba too used to ask question after question like this.”

“And did he get answers?”

“Sometimes. Sometimes not. But he never took a question for an answer.”

Mrinalini liked the sentence. “Neither do I.”

Shashibhushan returned to the manuscript. On one page his finger stopped at a letter in the main hand. “Look at this ‘ka’. Devkant Baba made his ‘ka’ like this. The upper stroke is slightly broken. And the way he writes numerals—look at the four.”

Mrinalini immediately took a photograph. “Where are his letters?”

“There should be two or three at my house. I’ll bring them tomorrow.”

“Very good.”

Shashibhushan’s face brightened. “Do you know what this is?”

“A Bhanas-Pothi.”

“No. This is a rare manuscript. Devkant Baba was not merely a man of this household. He wrote for journals in Calcutta—on farming, language, folk custom, everything. If this manuscript is complete, it ought to be published.”

Ishan looked at Mrinalini with an expression that plainly said, I told you so.

Shashibhushan went on. “We could title it Devkant’s Mithila Kitchen. Put an old family photograph below. I can write the introduction. Launch it at Ishan’s restaurant—”

“Stop,” Mrinalini said.

Shashibhushan stopped, though displeasure remained on his face.

“First we need to understand who wrote the manuscript. The main hand may be Devkant’s. Whose is the hand in the margins? How much of the material belongs to whom? Are all the pages present? What was added later? Without examining all that, how can we put an author’s name on the cover?”

“The main manuscript is Devkant’s.”

“Possibly.”

“Why possibly?”

“Because the evidence is not complete yet.”

Shashibhushan’s voice hardened. “Educated people nowadays have a disease—even for matters inside their own house they want an outside stamp.”

“Not an outside stamp. I want to see every hand inside the house.”

She pointed to the fine Tirhuta lines. “What if this hand was not merely correcting, but supplying material?”

“Then?”

“Then the authorship could change.”

Shashibhushan was silent for a few moments. A crow called outside. Wind moved through the courtyard, and dry mango leaves rustled.

"You are going very far," he said at last, "on the strength of two lines."

"Perhaps. That is why there is no title yet."

Trying to lighten the air, Ishan said, "Kaka, at least don't decide the menu for the launch yet."

Shashibhushan glared at him. "You keep out of this."

Ishan fell silent.

Mrinalini showed him the catalogue she had placed beside the manuscript. "We will separate all the material. You give us Devkant's letters. If anyone has his diary, signature, or published writing, tell me. We will also get help from someone who can read Tirhuta."

"I used to read it," Shashibhushan said.

Mrinalini looked up in surprise. "Tirhuta?"

"A little. Now both my eyes and my practice have diminished."

He looked once more at the fifth page. His gaze held on the fine script. His lips moved, but no words came out.

"What does it say?" Mrinalini asked at once.

"It isn't clear."

"Not even one letter?"

"An old hand like this cannot be read without spending time over it."

He did not close the manuscript. He merely withdrew his hand. "I'll bring the letters tomorrow."

Mrinalini had the feeling that some of the signs had been familiar to him, but that he did not yet want to say so. But that was only an inference. In her mind she immediately wrote the word: inference. Not evidence.

Shashibhushan rose. At the gate he turned back. "Don't leave the manuscript here at night."

"I'll take it with me."

"And don't seal it in plastic. Moisture will stay trapped."

"All right."

"And no ironing the pages to flatten them."

Ishan burst out laughing. "Kaka, Mrinalini is not going to iron the manuscript."

Shashibhushan remained serious. "People do. They watch YouTube and do everything."

This time Mrinalini laughed too. "I won't."

Shashibhushan left. The gate closed. Ishan said quietly, “Did you notice? Something in him changed the moment he saw the Tirhuta.”

“Yes.”

“He understood something.”

“Possibly.”

“Write it down: Kaka is hiding something.”

“No.”

“Why?”

“Because I do not want to become Devkant.”

Ishan looked at her questioningly.

Mrinalini gestured toward the manuscript. “Where we do not know, we do not fill the gap ourselves.”

**

Evening had deepened. The electricity was on, but the bulb on the veranda was yellow and weak. Before securing the manuscript in a temporary cardboard box, Mrinalini wanted to count the pages once more. Ishan held up the light from his phone.

“One, two, three...”

She stopped at page seventeen.

The main text contained a recipe for dal. The name of the dish at the top was unclear—the ink had spread. Below, the quantities of the ingredients were listed one after another: dal, water, salt, spices. In the right margin the main hand had written: “Salt — 1 tola.”

In the left margin were two lines of finer writing, probably Tirhuta. Beneath them came a later correction in Devanagari by the main hand: “Salt to taste.”

Mrinalini opened the photograph of the page on the screen and enlarged it. She could recognise a few letters in the fine line, though not the whole sentence. The shape of one word seemed familiar: “salt”. Another was perhaps “one”. The third she could not make out.

“Look,” she said to Ishan.

“One tola hasn’t been crossed out.”

“No. But ‘to taste’ was added later.”

“So?”

“So someone objected.”

Ishan laughed. “Over salt?”

“Arguments over salt may be among the oldest arguments there are.”

She read the page again with her eyes. The main hand was firm—the quantity fixed. The hand in the margin flowed—there was little space, but the sentence had to be said. Then the main hand loosened its own rule: “to taste.”

The two hands were not merely on the same sheet of paper. Two kinds of knowledge stood face to face—one that wanted to measure and fix, another unwilling to accept a rule divorced from circumstance.

Mrinalini did not see a chapter. She saw an argument.

“Ishan, if the main hand is Devkant’s, then the second hand cannot merely belong to a later reader.”

“Why?”

“Because the main hand responds to it.”

“Devkant himself could have added that later.”

“Fine. Possible.”

“Or at someone’s suggestion.”

“Fine.”

“Or—”

“Enough. Three possibilities are sufficient for now.”

Ishan smiled. “You don’t like my possibilities.”

“You turn a possibility into promotional copy in five minutes.”

She entered the page number, photograph number, and note into her laptop:

Page 17 — main hand: fixed quantity.

Marginal writing: Tirhuta, unreadable; ‘salt’ possible.

Later Devanagari addition: “Salt to taste.”

Conclusion: possibility of dialogue/correction; authorship undetermined.

When she had finished writing, she looked at the screen for a while. “Authorship undetermined”—a dry bureaucratic sentence. Yet inside her a living scene had begun to form: some kitchen, some cooking pot, one person measuring salt, another saying that taste could not be decided by that measure alone.

“What happened?” Ishan asked.

“Nothing.”

“You went inside the house again.”

“I am in the house.”

“No. Another house.”

Mrinalini did not answer.

She turned the next page. Again a note in that fine hand. None on the page after that. Then another. Sometimes the main text ignored it; sometimes it

changed a quantity; sometimes it transcribed a word into Devanagari. It was as though the manuscript were not a text written in a single voice but a quiet conversation.

And one side of that conversation had no name.

Ishan ate the last piece of namkeen and folded the packet. "Shall we go? It's getting late."

"Two minutes."

"Your two minutes are famous in this family."

Mrinalini took the final photograph. She closed the manuscript, wrapped it loosely in clean cotton cloth, and placed it in the cardboard box. Not in the original chest—there was too much damp and dust there.

Before locking the gate, she turned once to look at the house. In the dark, the veranda, walls, and ladder had all become the same colour. The things found during the day now seemed to have been absorbed back into the house. Only the cardboard box remained in her hands.

Opening the scooter's storage compartment, Ishan said, "Put it here."

"No. I'll keep it in my hands."

"The road is bad."

"That is why."

She sat behind him and held the box tightly in her arms. The gate was locked. The scooter moved off.

At the turn in the lane, Mrinalini suddenly remembered what Shashibhushan had said: the upper stroke of Devkant's 'ka' was slightly broken. She decided that tomorrow the first task would be to compare the handwriting in the letters.

The second task—to read the Tirhuta lines.

The third—not to search for a name; first to see whether a name was actually present anywhere.

The history of the house had taught her that names were written in many places: on land records, in genealogies, on certificates, in expense ledgers.

The Bhanas-Pothi was teaching her for the first time that sometimes the hand that speaks most can remain nameless.

The scooter emerged onto the main road. Behind them, the old house dissolved into the darkness.

Mrinalini rested her hand on the box.

She had not yet found an author.

But she had found a dialogue.

CHAPTER 03

The Leaf

On the second day, Mrinalini did not bring the manuscript home. Several times during the night she felt like opening the cardboard box again and looking, but she restrained herself. Curiosity about paper and the safety of paper do not always move in the same direction—she had understood that on the very first day.

While drinking tea in the morning, she opened her phone. All of yesterday's photographs were in a separate folder: the first page, the stitching, the stains, the marginal writing, the dispute over salt on page seventeen. She enlarged two photographs, then closed them. Photographs carried no smell; one could not hear the dry rustle of paper in them; the fine film of dust was not there beside one's fingers. A copy of a document was useful, but it was different from the presence of the original object.

She reached the old house at ten. Ishan had not arrived yet. When she opened the gate, the silence spread inside seemed less frightening than it had the day before. The house, which on the first day had been a crowd of unfamiliar objects, was slowly becoming a set of places—here the veranda, here the old room with the hearth, here the ladder to the upper floor, here the low bench on which the manuscript had been opened.

She had left the cardboard box at Shashibhushan's house for the night because there was too much damp in the old house. Shashibhushan had stood firm: "The manuscript will not stay here overnight." In the morning his grandson had delivered the box. A small slip of paper was pasted on top: "Handle with care."

Mrinalini smiled when she saw the note. Shashibhushan's concern irritated her and reassured her at the same time. At least there was a desire to preserve what the family believed it had a claim over. The only question was what exactly a family preserved—an object, a name, prestige, or truth?

She wiped the bench and spread a cotton cloth over it. She washed her hands. She opened the window and drew the curtain halfway to block the direct, sharp sunlight. Then she opened the box.

The Bhanas-Pothi lay on top. She removed the cloth. The dust on the cover seemed less than it had yesterday—perhaps her eyes had grown accustomed to it.

She did not begin with the first page but with page seventeen, where she had found “salt to taste” the day before. She read the next two pages. The marginal hand appeared again, though less often. In one place there were only two characters; elsewhere, a long sentence. The main hand had altered quantities in some places and left them untouched in others.

Mrinalini moved slowly forward, noting the photograph number for each page. When turning a page, she did not grip the upper right corner; she lifted it lightly from below so that no strain fell on the weakened edge.

After page forty-one, the paper suddenly felt a little thicker.

She stopped.

The two leaves of paper were not completely stuck together, yet something lay pressed between them, making the surface uneven. In yesterday’s haste she had not noticed it. She left the manuscript on the bench and shone the torchlight in from the side. A very thin brown line showed between the pages.

“Not paper,” she said to herself.

She did not open the page fully. First she photographed its position with her phone. Then, very slowly, she lifted the upper sheet.

Something light slipped from between the pages and fell onto the bench.

Mrinalini instinctively reached out, then stopped halfway.

It was a dried leaf.

After so many years, its original greenness could only be guessed at. It had turned brown-yellow, its edges broken in places. The veins were still visible like a fine map. The leaf was not completely flat; its middle rose slightly, as though the dried body were still unwilling to surrender its former shape.

For a few moments Mrinalini looked at it without touching it. Finding a dried leaf inside the Bhanas-Pothi was not impossible. A book of cooking, leafy greens, spices, a specimen—there could be any number of reasons. Yet before her the leaf seemed less an object than a small net of time.

She picked up the phone. She thought of calling Ishan, then changed her mind. Basanti Kaki first.

“Kaki, are you at home?”

“Where would I go so early? What happened?”

“There’s a leaf I want to show you.”

“You called me to show me a leaf?”

“I found it in the old manuscript.”

There was a brief silence at the other end. “Don’t handle it too much. I’m coming.”

Mrinalini put down the phone. Until yesterday everyone had seemed eager to leave her alone in the house; since the manuscript had been found, people had begun coming and going.

Basanti Kaki arrived in about fifteen minutes. She carried her old spectacles, a cloth bag, and a small bottle of water. The moment she came through the gate she asked, “Where is it?”

Mrinalini pointed towards the bench.

Kaki bent over it. She put on her spectacles. She examined the shape of the leaf, then the page from which it had fallen.

“Looks like tilkor,” she said at once.

“Certain?”

“How can anyone be certain with a leaf this old? But the shape, the veins, where the stem joins—it looks like tilkor.”

Mrinalini heard her own breathing quicken slightly. “Tilkor?”

Kaki looked at her. “Why are you staring like that, as if the leaf has written its own name?”

“Nothing.”

“Was there tilkor in the manuscript yesterday?”

“Nothing I could read clearly yet.”

Basanti Kaki sat down beside the bench. “My mother never dried tilkor leaves and kept them. Leaves for eating have to be fresh. Why anyone would keep an old leaf—perhaps for seed, perhaps for identification—I don’t know.”

“Could it be a specimen?”

“Could be. Could be a love letter too.”

Mrinalini looked at Kaki. Kaki held a solemn face for two seconds, then burst out laughing. “You new people see an old thing and immediately go hunting for a mystery. I’m only saying—the reason could be anything.”

Mrinalini laughed lightly too, but the words “love letter” lodged in her mind. She pushed them away at once. Kaki had been joking. For now, the leaf was only a leaf.

“How should we preserve it?”

“Press it back between the pages just as it was?”

“No. For now, between separate sheets, with the page number written down. Its original position is already recorded in the photograph.”

“You know your work, I know leaves. Between us, let’s save the manuscript.”

Mrinalini had not yet brought acid-free paper. As a temporary measure she placed the leaf between two layers of old, clean, unmarked cotton paper and wrote in pencil on the outside: “Bhanas-Pothi; found between pages 41–42; possible tilkor; identification—Basanti Kaki; not certain.”

Kaki read it and said, “You’ve written my name too?”

“Yes.”

“Then later people will say Basanti Devi was a tilkor expert.”

“That is why I wrote ‘possible.’”

“Good. You have saved me from becoming an ‘expert.’”

They both laughed again.

When the laughter faded, Mrinalini looked at the page itself. Where the leaf had been, a faint yellow-brown impression remained on the paper, as though over the years the leaf had been leaving its shape behind on the page.

The leaf had been separated from it.

Its shadow still remained in the manuscript.



Basanti Kaki went to make tea. A message arrived from Ishan: “Half an hour late. Don’t open the manuscript alone.” Mrinalini replied: “Too late. The crime has already been committed.”

She placed page 41 before the camera again. Where the leaf had lain, the colour of the paper differed from the rest of the page. There were several lines in the main hand above it. The Tirhuta letters in the margin were very faint. The leaf had perhaps covered part of the ink, so the characters beneath it had survived darker than elsewhere.

Mrinalini enlarged the photograph.

The main writing ended along the right side. Just beneath it, near where the leaf’s stem had rested, were two or three blurred Devanagari characters. She had not noticed them yesterday. Once the leaf was removed, they showed a little more clearly.

The first looked like ‘म’. After it, perhaps a vowel mark? Then possibly ‘ध’ or ‘द’? The ink had spread.

In pencil on a sheet of paper she wrote: “म...?”

The moment she looked at what she had written, she struck it out.

Even saying “म” was an inference.

She set the phone camera at a different angle. Not harsh light, only a soft sidelight. One photograph, then another, then a third. She did not have laboratory facilities on a computer, but when she increased the contrast between light and dark slightly on the phone, some strokes became clearer.

‘म’—possible. Next perhaps a long vowel mark. Then a broken curve.

Her mind leapt of its own accord towards “Madh...”

She switched off the screen at once.

Yesterday she had told Ishan not to fill in what they did not understand. Now the first test of that rule was her own. An unknown hand, one possible ‘ma’, and the mind immediately wanted to manufacture a name. Human beings cannot bear an empty space; they fill it with story. Perhaps many errors in history are born from precisely this impatience.

Basanti Kaki returned with tea. “What did you find?”

“Letters.”

“What?”

“Not certain.”

“Then drink your tea. Tell me when it becomes certain.”

Mrinalini took the cup. Kaki tried to look at the page, but the old ink was almost invisible to her.

“Your eyes are sharper than mine,” Kaki said.

“The phone’s eye is sharper.”

“Does the phone see everything?”

“No.”

“Everyone who uses one forgets that.”

As she drank her tea, Mrinalini noted the page number. She remembered that her original plan had been only to sort the contents of the house. Now she was recording the position of a leaf, the angle of letters, layers of ink, different hands. The three-month deadline suddenly seemed absurd.

The gate rattled. Ishan arrived carrying a laptop bag and two transparent folders. The moment he entered he said, “Where is the criminal?”

“The leaf is safe.”

“What leaf?”

Basanti Kaki announced proudly, “Tilkor.”

Ishan hurried towards the bench. “Really?”

“Don’t run,” Mrinalini said.

“I am walking.”

“Your walking looks like running.”

He looked at the leaf in its temporary wrapper. "Tilkor! This is—"

"It will not become the logo of your heritage platter."

Ishan shut his mouth. Basanti Kaki laughed aloud.

"Am I really that bad?" Ishan asked.

"No," Mrinalini said. "You are simply that fast."

"Fine. For now, I'll only look."

He examined the photograph of the page. "What are these letters?"

"Not certain."

"Ma?"

Mrinalini gave him a sharp look. "You too?"

"I'm only saying what my eyes see."

"And after that?"

Ishan studied the screen for a moment. "Madh...?"

"Enough."

"Madhav? Madhuri? Madho? Madh—something?"

"That is exactly why I said enough. You saw one letter and made five names."

"Then it could be a name."

"It could also be a word. Half a sentence. Another language."

Ishan sat down on the chair. "What do you want, then?"

"First, read the writing. Show it to someone who knows Tirhuta. Compare the main hand with Devkant's letters. Look at the date of the page. Then we can speak of names."

"The date of the page?"

Mrinalini looked up. True—page 41 had no date. Some earlier pages had dates, but here there was only writing. To understand the sequence, they would have to examine the preceding leaves.

She turned back to pages 37, 38, and 39. At the top of 39, in small writing, was "Paush..." followed by an indistinct numeral. The next page contained a list of ingredients. Page 41 held the leaf.

"Paush?" Ishan read.

"Possibly."

"January?"

"Could be. Look for the year."

She turned backwards to the first clear date. An early page read 1934. In two places in the middle, perhaps 1933? She checked again. Wear in the ink made the numerals ambiguous.

“The sequence is not straightforward,” Mrinalini said. “The pages may have been bound into this manuscript later.”

Ishan’s face lit up. “Which means the date of the leaf—”

“Not yet.”

“Your favourite phrase.”

“Yes. Because it saves me from a great many mistakes.”

Picking up the empty teacups, Basanti Kaki said, “Between you two, you’ll make an entire family out of one leaf. I’m going to see to the kitchen.”

She left.

Ishan said quietly, “Tilkor wasn’t in the plan.”

Mrinalini looked at him. “What plan?”

“For my restaurant. I was thinking makhana, garden produce, dahi-chura. Tilkor is seasonal, hard to find.”

“Then leave it out.”

“You don’t understand. The harder something is to find, the better its story sells.”

Mrinalini did not close the manuscript, but her hand came to rest at the edge of the page. “Ishan, let us settle one thing right now. Nothing we find in this manuscript is to be used commercially until the authorship, the source, the family’s rights, and the position of the people concerned are clear.”

Ishan first assumed the posture of someone about to make a joke, then saw Mrinalini’s face and turned serious. “Fine.”

“Truly?”

“Truly. At least for now.”

“‘At least for now’ is not a very reassuring phrase.”

“A businessman does not swear absolute oaths.”

“Then I am writing down an absolute stop.”

Ishan laughed. “Fine. Put it in your notes.”

Mrinalini actually opened her notebook and wrote: “Public/commercial use of the leaf or manuscript material—suspended.”

Ishan put a hand to his forehead. “You turn a joke into an official order.”

“Some jokes, if written down, prevent future quarrels.”

She saved the image of page 41 separately under the filename ‘page41_leafimpression_unknownletters’.

The filename was deliberately dull.

Because the name her mind wanted to form inside it had no business entering the file.

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After noon, Shashibhushan sent over two old letters by Devkant. He did not come himself. On the small envelope he had written: "For comparison. Return them."

Mrinalini opened the first letter. The paper was different from the manuscript—thinner, slightly smoother. At the top was the date: "27 December 1933." Below it, a salutation. The moment she saw the handwriting, she remembered what Shashibhushan had said the day before: the upper stroke of Devkant's 'ka' was slightly broken. In the letter, several instances of 'ka' were indeed formed that way. So were they in the main hand of the manuscript. The bowl of his 'da' was slightly open. The upper line of his 'ta' was short.

"The main hand is very probably Devkant's," she said.

Ishan looked up from his laptop. "Now it is 'very probably'?"

"Yes. I'll compare a full page. One or two letters are not enough."

The second letter was from January 1934. Mrinalini stopped when she read the date.

"Look."

Ishan came closer.

"12 January 1934."

In the letter, Devkant had written that he was returning home—likely to arrive three days later. He mentioned the train, several books, papers, and finishing his "notes concerning food in the household." The language was formal, but in one place he had written: "There are many things I must ask Mother; what I have written so far is more than half conjecture."

Mrinalini read that line again.

"This is important," she said.

"Why?"

"He himself acknowledges that it is conjecture."

"So Devkant was not a wicked author."

Mrinalini stopped in the act of folding the letter. "When did I call him wicked?"

"Sometimes your face does."

"A face is not a source."

"In this house, everything is turning into a source."

Mrinalini returned her attention to the letter. 12 January. Likely arrival three days later. Around 15 January 1934.

She opened the early pages of the manuscript again. On one page the date was clearly something like "14-1-34." Then two pages later, at the top of

another page, was “15,” but no year. The list of ingredients was unfinished. The writing stopped abruptly. On the following page, the ink changed.

A faint shiver passed through Mrinalini’s body.

Ishan saw the date too. “Fifteenth of January?”

“Possibly.”

“1934?”

“Possible, according to the sequence.”

“That very day—”

“Yes.”

They both fell silent.

15 January 1934: the date of the devastating Bihar–Nepal earthquake. Mrinalini knew the date from school; in family stories too, “the earthquake of ’34” had been mentioned again and again. But seeing the number on a manuscript page was not like reading a history book. There was no map here, no statistics. Only a list of ingredients that stopped halfway.

She looked at the page:

Rice — ...

Lentils — ...

Salt — ...

Leaf — ...

Then blank.

As though a hand had risen in the middle of writing.

“I cannot say the writing stopped because of the earthquake,” Mrinalini said softly.

Ishan nodded. For the first time, without argument. “But the date?”

“The date allows me to ask a question. It does not give me an answer.”

She took a high-quality photograph of the page and noted the date of the letter separately.

Then she returned to the page with the leaf. If the leaves were in the same sequence, had the tilkor leaf been pressed before the earthquake or after it? But she had already seen that the manuscript might have been rebound later. The questions multiplied.

She made a timeline:

27 December 1933 — letter.

12 January 1934 — Devkant’s letter; plan to return home.

14 January, possible — manuscript entry.

15 January, possible — unfinished entry.

Pages 41–42 — pressed leaf; date uncertain.

Ishan read it and said, "The story is making itself here."

"No," Mrinalini said. "A timeline is making itself here. The story comes later."

"The difference?"

"A timeline says what is present in the documents. A story says what it means. If I make the second without the first, I am writing invention."

"You have never thought of writing something from all these papers?"

"Right now, I am making an archive."

Ishan smiled. "Fine. But the day you write the story, tell me."

Mrinalini did not answer. She did not know whether she ever would. For now, the pages were teaching her how to read them, on their own terms.

She opened the page after the unfinished entry of 15 January. There were fine dust stains on the paper and, in the lower corner, an old brown mark like earth. The writing resumed, but the hand looked slightly unsteady. First two lines in the main hand, then the second hand in the margin.

For a moment Mrinalini felt as though she heard not imagination but sound—the clatter of utensils, someone calling out, running feet from outside, the growl of the earth.

She closed her eyes.

Then opened them at once.

"What happened?" Ishan asked.

"Nothing. I was beginning to infer too much."

"Sometimes inference makes a scene."

"Let the scene come later. First let us see everything that is actually here."

She read the letter again. The final line:

"When I reach home, I shall first eat food cooked by Mother's hand; after that, all the questions."

Mrinalini remained on that line.

First, food on reaching home. Questions afterwards.

That ordinary wish written on paper suddenly brought the man close. Devkant was no longer merely the hand of the main writing. He was a person returning from a journey with books, notes, and questions, yet wanting first to eat food from his mother's hand.

Mrinalini folded the letter gently.

"It could begin here," she said without meaning to.

"What?"

She stopped. "Nothing."

Ishan laughed. "The story."

Instead of scolding him, Mrinalini remained silent.
Perhaps, for once, Ishan was right.

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Three days of travel had filled Devkant's clothes with dust. The moment the outer wall of the house came into view, his pace quickened. The cart-driver called from behind, "Babu, the trunk is still in the cart!"

Devkant stopped and laughed. Indeed, he was walking towards the courtyard empty-handed, as though it would be no loss to leave behind the books, clothes, and papers he had brought. He turned back and took hold of one end of the trunk.

"I'll carry it," the cart-driver said.

"You have been carrying it for two days. Let my hands do some work now."

As soon as they reached the gate, the dog inside began to bark. Recognizing the voice, it immediately started wagging its tail. The clack of someone's slippers sounded on the veranda. A woman's voice came from inside: "Who is it?"

"Me."

A moment of silence, then hurried footsteps.

Janki came out. Her head was covered with the end of her sari, and rice paste clung to one hand. Devkant bent to touch her feet, but she touched his head first, then looked at his face.

"You've grown thin."

"People do not grow fat on trains."

"Does a man grow thin in three days?"

"If you say so, even in one."

"Too much learning has sharpened your tongue."

"The tongue was already—"

"Wash your hands and face first."

Devkant laughed. Within the first five sentences of his return home, all his arguments had been defeated.

January sunlight fell slantwise across the courtyard. Grain was spread to dry on one side; on the other, smoke rose from an earthen hearth. An old rope hung from a pillar of the veranda. The walls wore the fresh colour of a cow-dung-and-clay wash. Nothing seemed extraordinary to Devkant, yet after being away, ordinary things acquired a sudden, separate brightness.

When he returned after washing his hands and face, Janki had already set out a brass thali. Steam rose from the rice. There was no ghee on the lentils, only the faint sheen of mustard oil. A leafy green, a small potato tarua, salt, green chilli, and a bowl of curd.

The moment Devkant sat down, he pulled a small notebook from his bag. Janki stopped as she set down the thali.

“What is that?”

“Notes.”

“Now?”

“All along the road I kept thinking I must ask you—which lentil in winter—”

Janki took the notebook and placed it out of his reach.

“Eat first.”

“Mother, two lines—”

“The food will grow cold. Knowledge is not running away.”

Devkant smiled. “Sometimes it does.”

“Then we will catch it. Rice first.”

He took his first mouthful. The lentils were thicker than he expected, with a faint smoky smell. The instant he tasted them he asked, “Which lentil is this?”

Janki glared at him.

Devkant burst out laughing. “All right. I’m eating.”

At the far end of the veranda, a young woman was sorting leaves. Devkant had not noticed her at first. Before her stood a bamboo basket holding several kinds of leaves—some greens, some set apart. She would lift one leaf, study its veins, break the stem, then divide the leaves into two piles.

Devkant’s gaze went towards her. The young woman looked at him for a moment, then returned to her work.

“Who is she?” Devkant asked softly.

Janki said, “Madhavi.”

Devkant did not repeat the name. He simply tasted the tarua on his plate.

“What leaf is that?” The question rose again to his lips, but at the sight of Janki’s face he stopped himself.

After a while Janki herself said, “Your questions are never going to end; that much is clear. Finish eating. Then ask Madhavi. She knows half of what there is to know about leaves and greens better than I do.”

This time Devkant truly fell silent.

At the edge of the veranda, Madhavi set one leaf apart—the most tender of the lot, small and deep green. Her fingers paused for a moment on its stem. Then, instead of placing it in the bamboo basket, she laid it on top of a small brass bowl beside her.

Devkant kept his eyes on his plate, but from the corner of his eye he saw what she did.

Outside, the winter sunlight crossed the courtyard and slowly climbed the wall.

No one then understood that a history had begun inside the house.

Devkant understood only that after the meal he had many questions to ask.

Madhavi may have understood only that there were leaves to sort.

Perhaps Janki understood more than either of them. Looking at the empty thali, she said—

“Eat first. Fill the belly of knowledge afterwards.”

Devkant laughed.

And until then, the notebook remained closed.

CHAPTER 04

The Fifteenth of January

At dawn Devkant woke to a knocking sound from the veranda. No one in the house needed to be awakened; the house woke in its own time. The creak of the rope at the well, the rasp of the courtyard being swept, the bell on a cow from the cattle shed, the first smoke from the hearth—all the sounds came one after another as though they had stood quietly somewhere through the night and, at the sight of light, gone to their appointed places.

Devkant lay on his bedding for a few moments. The previous evening he had asked Janki half a dozen questions—which lentil in winter, which green, which grain was soaked, which dried. He had managed to write down half the answers; for the other half Janki had said, “Madhavi will answer that.” The sentence appeared in three places in his notebook. He found it intriguing that so much knowledge could be divided within a single house.

He rose and went outside. The January sunlight was still gentle. In one corner of the courtyard Janki was sorting paddy in a brass plate. On the other side Madhavi sat on a low wooden stool, sorting leaves. The leaves that had caught Devkant’s eye the day before were still there—some dark green, some pale, some with thick stalks, some so tender that a vein would snap if they were bent.

At the kitchen doorway two young daughters-in-law were washing rice. The first water ran milky into the stone drain; the second was less cloudy. Inside, lentils simmered on the earthen hearth. Steam rose around the edge of the lid and vanished as soon as it met the cold air. The faint smell of mustard oil, smoke, wet rice, cut green leaves—the household’s midday meal was still coming into being.

Devkant automatically reached for his notebook. Janki looked up.

“From first thing in the morning?”

“The food isn’t getting cold yet.”

“Then write. But first write this—that washing the rice is also part of the meal. A kitchen is not made only of what arrives on the plate.”

Devkant laughed. “Ma, will you let me write the article, or will you write it yourself?”

“If I write it, what will you do?”

“Get it printed.”

“Oh. And then put your own name on it?”

Hearing Janki laugh, Madhavi too lifted her head and smiled. Devkant remembered what he had learned the day before: the young woman’s name was Madhavi. Using his writing as an excuse, he went closer to her.

“Will you tell me the names of these leaves?”

Madhavi picked up a leaf. “You’ll write down the name. And after that?”

“After that, how it is prepared.”

“And after that?”

Devkant was a little taken aback. “After that, the taste.”

Madhavi snapped the leaf-stalk and showed him the fine fibre inside. “After that, you must know which leaf should be plucked now and which two weeks later. Which belongs in the kitchen, which is spoken of as medicine. Which leaf is kept for a guest, which goes into everyday food. If you write only the name, not even half the matter will survive.”

Devkant turned a page in the notebook. “Then tell me slowly. I’ll write everything.”

“Everything?”

“As much as I can write.”

“Then first write not the leaf, but the people.”

“The people?”

“The one who plucks the leaf, the one who sells it, the one who cooks it, the one who eats it. The same leaf does not carry the same meaning on every plate.”

Before Devkant could answer, Janki called out, “Madhavi, don’t read him the whole book just yet. See to the rice first—has the water drained or not?”

Madhavi got up. Devkant’s pen remained poised over the page. He wrote, “Leaf—more relation than name.” Then, after thinking for a moment, he drew a short line beneath the word “relation.”

The afternoon advanced. The rhythm of the house quickened a little, but there was no hurry. The rice was drained. Salt went into the lentils. The scent of crushed ginger rose. A child rolled a small wooden wheel across the courtyard. Two neighbours passed the doorway talking. Somewhere in the distance came the slow knock-knock of a hammer. It all seemed so ordinary

to Devkant that, at that moment, he did not understand the value of ordinariness.

He sat beside Janki and asked, "What is there for lunch today?"

Janki smiled without lifting her head.

Devkant smiled too. "All right—what is there for lunch today?"

"Rice, lentils, greens, leaf tarua. A little curd. Is that news worth writing down?"

"It is for me."

"Then write that ordinary food is food too. People put only festivals into books, as though on all the other days the stomach fasted."

Devkant was silent for a while over this sentence. Then he wrote, "History is incomplete without the everyday plate."

Madhavi stood in the kitchen doorway. She looked toward the page but said nothing. In her hand was a bowl of wet rice, and two drops of water fell from her fingertips.



The full light of afternoon had descended into the courtyard. Devkant sat on the veranda rereading his notes. In the kitchen the lentils had been turned down to a gentler simmer. A brass lota stood near the edge of the veranda. The child's wooden wheel struck the wall this time and fell over.

First came a sound.

Not a sound that seemed to come from any one direction. It was as though some heavy thing were being dragged deep beneath the earth. Devkant raised his head. For the first instant he thought a bullock-cart wheel must have caught in the dirt road. Then the water in the brass lota trembled. The lota itself stayed in place, but the surface of the water shivered in widening circles.

Janki saw it too. "What is—"

The sentence was never finished.

The veranda post swayed left and right before Devkant's eyes. Something creaked in the roof. Inside the kitchen the vessels clanged together—first two of them, then as though an entire cupboard had toppled over. The earthen floor ceased to be still. Devkant tried to rise, but the ground shifted under his feet as though his body had forgotten its own weight. He seized the post.

"Outside! Everyone outside!" No one could tell whose voice it was.

Madhavi was coming out of the kitchen doorway. She still had a bowl in her hand; at the first jolt it fell. Rice and water spread across the floor. She did

not bend to pick up the bowl. She turned straight back toward the interior and shouted, "Leave the doorway! Come into the courtyard!"

The next moment a strip of mud from the upper wall broke loose and fell. Dust rose. Someone screamed. The pot on the hearth slid to one side; hot lentils spilled over the rim onto the fire with a sharp hiss. Smoke and steam rose together.

Devkant ran toward Janki. She had already reached the middle of the courtyard, but her eyes were fixed on the house. "Chhotki? Where is Chhotki?"

"Outside!" Madhavi answered. "She's by the bushes."

People were running toward the courtyard entrance. A woman from the neighbouring house came barefoot, her anchal half fallen. Someone carried a child. Someone had dust on the head. From the road outside the noise grew louder—names being called, the names of gods, weeping, panicked animals in the cattle sheds, the heavy thuds of crumbling mud-brick walls.

The earth rocked hard once more. Devkant felt as though the courtyard itself were a boat. He caught Janki by the arm. She did not try to wrench free; she only said, "I'm all right. Madhavi?"

Devkant turned. At the far side of the courtyard Madhavi was lifting a small boy. The child had fallen; his knee was scraped, dust clung near his forehead, and his eyes were wide with fear. Madhavi carried him into the open.

"Sit here," she said. "Away from the wall."

Crying, the boy asked, "Ma?"

"She's coming. Sit here."

Madhavi wiped his face with the corner of her anchal but did not touch his knee. Devkant stepped forward to help.

"What should I do?"

"First see who is still inside."

The sentence came not like an order but like a necessity. Devkant immediately swept his eyes across the rooms of the house. An elderly servant was emerging from the corner of the veranda, his hands trembling. The young woman they called Chhotki came running from the rear doorway. As soon as Janki saw her, she closed her eyes once and opened them again.

The shaking slowly subsided, but no one's body became still. Even after the ground stopped moving, their feet did not trust the earth. The creaking still rang in their ears. The dust began to settle. Above the kitchen doorway a long crack was visible that had not been there the day before.

Devkant looked at his hands. No pen. The notebook had fallen on the veranda, lying open. A fine dust of earth covered it. On one page was a half-written sentence—"History without the everyday plate..." Then nothing.

He moved to pick up the notebook, then stopped.

From a distance Madhavi said, "Leave the paper for now."

Devkant looked at her.

For the first time, he did not dislike hearing it.

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No one knew exactly how much time had passed. There was no leisure to look at a clock, and those who had one kept counting instead—their own bodies, their houses, their families, their neighbours. The courtyard slowly became an open shelter. Whatever could safely be brought out of the house was carried outside—two sacks of rice, a tin of lentils, a small container of salt, some firewood, a water jar, two cooking pots, mats.

A diagonal crack ran across the upper wall of the kitchen. Janki stood at the doorway looking in, but Madhavi stopped her. "Not inside yet."

Disagreement crossed Janki's face. "The hearth—"

"The hearth can be built again."

"The flour is inside."

"The flour later."

Janki looked into Madhavi's eyes for a few moments. Then she came back without arguing. Devkant watched this small scene closely. Until yesterday, Janki had been the centre of discipline in the household; today decision was shifting toward whoever had the capacity to understand the situation.

Three bricks were set on levelled earth in the middle of the courtyard. Embers saved from the old hearth were brought out in a small earthen vessel. Thin pieces of wood, dry straw, a little chaff. Some hands trembled; some voices tried to sound normal.

Two neighbouring families also came in. The outer wall of one house had fallen; the other house's roof had gone askew. People who on ordinary days stood talking at the doorway now sat on mats in the same courtyard. But old habits did not vanish completely in a single tremor of the earth. As a water jar was passed around, one woman hesitated for an instant; another elderly person began looking for a separate lota. Eyes moved here and there.

Janki watched all this. Along with exhaustion, the memory of old rules was visible on her face. She picked up a small brass bowl and said, "Whatever

vessel anyone needs is here. But don't hold back the water. The children will drink first."

The sentence was short, but several eyes in the courtyard lifted toward one another. The rules had not disappeared entirely, but necessity moved them a little aside.

Devkant stepped forward to lift a cooking pot. Ramanand—who came and went from the house for work near the pond—arrived at the doorway covered in dust. From a distance he said, "Babu, that's heavy."

"It will be lighter with two hands."

Together they lifted the pot and set it on the temporary hearth. Half the lentils saved from inside had already spilled. Part of the rice had fallen into the dirt and been ruined. Janki opened the mouth of the sack and examined a handful.

"With this many people, this rice will go quickly," she said.

Someone suggested, "Make khichdi."

Janki shook her head. "In the evening. For now, divide what has survived."

Madhavi was still sitting beside the injured boy. His mother had arrived; the crying had eased, but the boy would not let anyone touch his knee. From where she sat Madhavi called out, "Put water on the fire."

Janki asked, "For the rice?"

"No. To boil."

"Now?"

"Yes, now."

Devkant went toward the water jar. In the courtyard some people were discussing food—who would eat how much, what might last until evening, whether the market would open. Amid all this Madhavi's attention remained on the water.

"How much?" Devkant asked.

"A potful. Boil it. Then let it cool."

"For drinking?"

"For drinking too. For washing wounds too. Who knows whether dust has fallen into the well water now."

Without another question Devkant filled the pot. There was little room on the hearth. The food pot was taken down and set aside. The water went on. A faint dissatisfaction crossed a few faces—hot food first, or water? But no one openly objected.

The smoke kept changing direction, stinging their eyes. It was as though the whole house had altered its boundaries in the courtyard. What had been

work done inside the kitchen was now before everyone's eyes. Decisions that women had quietly made were now being spoken aloud in the open courtyard. The food that on ordinary days reached the plate and fell silent there now revealed, one by one, the labour, scarcity, water, fire, vessels and hands behind it.

Devkant's notebook lay near the veranda. He looked toward it once but did not pick it up. He felt that what had to be written today was something paper could not immediately catch.



When the water came to a hard boil, Madhavi said, "Take it down now. Keep it covered. Let it cool a little."

Devkant took the pot down and set it beside the bricks. Ash had stained his clothes. One finger was slightly scraped, perhaps from when he had clutched the wall; only now did he notice it.

"Your hand is cut too," Madhavi said.

"It's nothing."

"Everyone says that. Then the wound swells later."

Devkant tried to laugh. "Will you examine everyone's wounds?"

"Whatever is in front of me, I'll look at."

She pointed toward the child's knee. The boy's mother held him in her lap. The dust had been wiped away, but dirt remained in the scrape. Madhavi asked for a clean cloth. By the time the boiled water cooled, it was lukewarm. She told the boy's mother, "Wash it gently. Don't rub hard."

The boy began to cry. To distract him, Madhavi picked up the wooden wheel that had fallen on the ground. "Look, your cart has turned out braver than we were in the earthquake. It's still whole."

Through his tears the boy took the wheel. A few people in the courtyard smiled. For one moment the fear grew lighter.

Devkant watched the scene in silence. Until yesterday he had thought of Madhavi's knowledge as knowledge of leaves, greens, spices, seasons and dishes. Today he saw that her knowledge was not a list of things but a way of reading a situation. What had to come first, what later; which danger was immediate, which could wait; which resource had to be saved, which shared—in that ordering lay the real test of knowledge.

Janki sat to one side. Quietly she said, "The food has gone cold."

Madhavi answered, "It can be warmed again."

Janki looked at her. "You're right."

Whether those three words were praise for Madhavi or only acknowledgement, Devkant could not tell. But he understood that the language of authority inside the house was changing too.

The shadows of evening were still far away, yet the day seemed to have grown so large that exhaustion had already settled on people's faces. News kept arriving from outside—a wall fallen at one house, earth split near another pond, a road blocked somewhere, someone injured, someone's house emptied. No report was fully certain. Fear travelled with names.

At last Devkant went to the veranda and picked up the notebook. He almost blew the dust away, then stopped; blowing would drive it further into the page. He thought of asking for an anchal, then instead wiped it very lightly with his own handkerchief. The half-sentence was still visible —“History without the everyday plate...”

He turned the page.

He lifted the pen.

For the first time, the names of ingredients did not come to him. Rice, lentils, salt, leaves—they were all before his eyes, but today they were no longer the main thing.

He wrote, “15 January. The earth shook. Kitchen unsafe. Everyone outside.”

He paused for a few moments. Then wrote, “Water was boiled first.”

Here the pen stopped again. The sentence felt incomplete. Who had said it? Why? Who had understood the reason for that decision?

On the next line he wrote, “Madhavi—water first.”

As he wrote the name, he felt a strange jolt—not of the earth, but of his own thinking. Until yesterday his notes had held the names of leaves, dishes, household rules, seasons. Today, for the first time, a person's name appeared beside a decision.

Madhavi looked over from where she sat. “What did you write?”

Devkant did not hide the page. “Your name.”

There was fatigue on Madhavi's face. “Why?”

“Because you were the one who said to boil the water first.”

“A name for so small a thing?”

“The name of whoever said it.”

Madhavi was silent for a few moments. Then she gave the faintest smile. “Will you keep this rule on every page of the book?”

Before answering, Devkant looked at the page. It was not a simple question.

“We should,” he said at last.

Madhavi turned back toward the child. “Should, and will—those are two different things.”

Devkant sat with the pen in his hand. In the middle of the courtyard the boiled water stood covered. Preparations were being made to warm the food again. The world outside was filling with news of broken houses.

He added another sentence to the page: “Write the name of whoever makes the decision.”

Then, after thinking a little, he wrote beneath it in smaller letters: “Don’t forget later.”

Years later dust, stains, folds and another hand’s writing would settle over this page. Some names would survive, some would be erased, some would remain only half. But that afternoon Devkant understood at least this much: the history of the kitchen was not only the history of taste.

It was also a history of fire, water, fear, labour and decisions.

And writing names into history—like cooking food—does not happen by itself.

CHAPTER 05

The Khichdi House

At dawn on the second day after the earthquake, the village sounded different. The rooster's call, the cowbells, the rope at the well—those were old sounds; but between them came new ones: the blows of hammers, the scrape of earth being cleared from walls, voices calling out names, and, somewhere far off, the hard crack of breaking timber. Most people had spent the night in open courtyards or in safer corners of verandas. No one had slept properly. The earth was still, but bodies were still learning to trust it again.

Janki had the grain sacks opened at daybreak. The quantity of rice was checked, then the tin of lentils, the salt, ghee, oil, dry firewood—everything was counted. Things that on an ordinary day remained in their proper places in the kitchen now lay in the middle of the courtyard, as though the belly of the house had been opened.

"This much rice will make two meals," Janki said, "but with so many people, whether it will be enough even once is hard to say."

People from three neighbouring houses had been there since the night before: an elderly couple; a family with two children; a young man whose shoulder had been injured when a wall fell; and two labourers who had been clearing a collapsed roof since dawn. Ramanand had returned after bringing news from the pond side. The number of people kept rising; the sacks did not.

Madhavi took a handful of rice and looked at it. Then she opened the tin of lentils. "If we cook rice separately, we'll need lentils separately too. And more water. Make khichdi."

One woman agreed at once. Another said, "Khichdi leaves the stomach empty again too quickly."

Looking toward the sack, Janki said, "We have to fill stomachs and save grain—both."

Devkant sat beside a veranda pillar listening to the discussion. Yesterday his notebook had lain in the dust; today he had kept it in a cloth bag. His hand went to it almost by instinct, but he did not take it out immediately.

One sentence of Madhavi's had stopped him the day before—Leave the paper for now. Today he understood that before writing, he needed to look.

"How much rice?" he finally asked.

Madhavi looked at him. "Are you going to eat khichdi or write an article?"

Two or three people in the courtyard smiled. Devkant laughed too. "Both."

"Then look at the pot first. The measure has to fit the pot, the people, the water—all of it. Not only seers and chhatanks."

Janki said, "Take out two seers of rice. Lentils a little less than half that. Keep the water low for now; we can add more later."

"Why low?" Devkant asked.

"If the fire holds steady, we'll add more. If the pot boils over, we lose both the grain and the fire," Madhavi replied.

A line formed instantly in Devkant's mind—In a disaster, add water gradually. But he did not write it down.

Rice and lentils were poured together into one basket and picked over. Broken pebbles, husks and a few black grains were set aside. On an ordinary day there would have been time for this work; today the hands were quick, but not careless. Hemlata sat with the children picking out stones. The small boy who had scraped his knee the day before put his wooden wheel beside him and imitated the grain-sorting. Whenever he found a pebble, he held it up triumphantly.

"If that falls into the pot, it'll break a tooth," Hemlata told him.

With a grave face, the boy said, "The earth broke the house; I'll catch the stones."

A light ripple of laughter spread through the courtyard again.

The hearth was made larger than the previous day's three-brick arrangement. Whole bricks were chosen from the fallen wall and stacked on either side. Ash, straw and wood went in between. There was a small mark from an injury on Ramanand's hand, but he went on splitting wood. Devkant stepped forward to help.

"This wood is wet," Ramanand said. "It'll smoke."

"Where is the dry wood?"

"What survived under the roof can be taken out only after we clear the earth first."

From a distance Madhavi said, "Don't put the wet wood underneath. Dry pieces first, then this on top. Once the fire catches, we can bear the smoke."

The fire took. A small debate arose over whether to heat a little oil in the pot first or put the rice and lentils straight in. Someone wanted ghee; someone

else said to save it. Janki settled it: “The ghee will be kept for the children and the injured. Today the khichdi will be made with oil.”

Madhavi took a pinch of cumin in her hand, then put half of it back into the tin. Devkant noticed.

“So little?”

“Enough for the aroma. Cumin won’t fill anyone’s stomach.”

“Spices?”

“A little ginger. Turmeric. Salt. We’re not dressing a platter today.”

Devkant liked the phrase, “We’re not dressing a platter.” The beauty of ordinary food and the utility of food in disaster could exist in the same cooking, but the order changed.

When the rice and lentils went into the pot, the first measure of water was added. Madhavi touched the bottom with a wooden ladle. Steam rose. The smells of raw lentils, wet rice, cumin and smoke mingled. This was not yet food; it was possibility.

“Salt now?” Hemlata asked.

“A little,” Madhavi said. “We’ll taste it at the end.”

Janki raised her eyebrows. “Khichdi for so many people—and what if the salt is short at the end?”

“We can add more. If there’s too much, we can’t take it out.”

Janki accepted that.

For the first time Devkant saw that in a crisis even a cooking method became a policy: what could not be taken back once added had to be given slowly; what could be increased could be held in reserve. The water in the pot kept rising, and the number of people in the courtyard kept rising. The two counts moved together.

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Before noon, the smell of cooking khichdi had begun to travel beyond the courtyard. Smell is news of hunger; even the stomachs of those who were not talking about food heard it. The children began circling the hearth more often. The elderly couple sat on a mat with their backs supported. The injured young man’s shoulder was bound in cloth. Ramanand and the other labourer were returning after clearing loose earth from a wall; their clothes were the colour of dust.

Janki counted the leaf-plates. There were not enough. Some brass plates, some kansa bowls, some leaf-plates. “They’ll eat in turns,” she said.

This time the question arose—who first?

An elderly man said matter-of-factly, "The children first."

A woman said, "The injured too."

Someone called out, "Let the elders of the household sit first. It is their courtyard."

Ramanand stepped back. "We'll eat later."

Devkant looked at him. "You've been working since dawn."

Ramanand shrugged. "That's what we do."

The naturalness in that "That's what we do" unsettled Devkant. Hunger had grown with labour, yet in the order of the meal labour was pushing itself automatically toward the end.

Madhavi lifted the lid and checked the khichdi. She was listening to the discussion but did not speak at once. The rice had not softened fully. She asked for a little hot water. As it went in, the khichdi loosened and the quantity increased as well.

"Small children first, then the injured, then the very old," she said, putting the lid back. "After that, those who have done heavy work since morning. Then everyone else."

For a moment the courtyard was silent.

"The family?" someone asked.

"The family comes with everyone else."

Janki looked at Madhavi. "Guests?"

"Those who came here for shelter are more tired than guests. Why should they wait?"

An elderly woman who had come from a neighbouring house laughed. "This is a conspiracy to feed me first by calling me old."

The tension eased a little.

Janki began separating the leaf-plates. "All right. Children and the injured first. But the labourers will wash their hands and faces."

Ramanand immediately started toward the well. Madhavi stopped him. "The boiled water has cooled; it's over there. Drink from that. Use well water for your hands."

Devkant understood—the previous day's decision was becoming today's rule. Knowledge spreads this way in a crisis: first someone says something; then people absorb it into what they do.

Three children, the injured young man and two elderly neighbours sat in the first row. Their plates were not alike—one had a leaf-plate, another a bowl, another a metal plate. But the pot was one.

Madhavi filled the first ladle. Janki stopped her. "Not too much. In the first round it has to reach everyone."

Madhavi nodded. Khichdi began to fall onto each leaf-plate. Steam from the pot touched people's faces and made their eyes close for a moment. The child who had scraped his knee the day before tried to eat his first mouthful by blowing on it again and again.

Devkant was handing out leaf-plates. For a moment he thought that at feasts in his own home he had probably never done such work. On ordinary days, through how many hands did food pass from pot to plate? The question had never stood before him so plainly.

When the first round ended, Ramanand and the other labourer sat down. Ramanand tried to defer—"Babu and the others—"

Janki cut him off. "Sit. You cleared earth; eat."

Ramanand sat without argument. Khichdi was served onto his leaf-plate. Devkant noticed that Janki herself had still not sat down. Nor had Madhavi.

"And you?" Devkant asked.

Janki said, "After we finish serving."

Madhavi touched the bottom of the pot again with the ladle. "The hunger of the one who serves is noticed last."

"Then eat first," Devkant said.

Madhavi looked straight at him. "Then who will serve?"

Devkant did not answer. He reached for the ladle. "I will."

Madhavi did not let go of it. "Serving one pot doesn't mean you've learned cooking."

"Not cooking. Right now, only a way of making you sit down."

For an instant a smile flashed in Madhavi's eyes. She handed him the ladle. "Then don't scrape the bottom. There's still a second round."

Devkant began serving carefully. His first ladleful was a little too full. From a distance Janki called out, "That much would fill two leaf-plates!"

The courtyard laughed again. Devkant put half of it back into the pot.

Madhavi sat beside Janki. For the first time Devkant saw her eating rather than making food. There were yellow turmeric stains on her fingers, ash at the edges of her nails, a fine layer of dust in her hair. She was tired, but as she put the first mouthful into her mouth she closed her eyes for a moment. Devkant understood that before hunger, knowledge, labour, status and modesty all have their limits.

In the second round the rest of the household sat down. There was no orderly feast-row, no uniform set of plates, no formal invitation. Yet around

the single pot a new arrangement was taking shape—order according to need, quantity according to availability, and everyone's eyes on the bottom of the pot.

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When the first round of the meal was over, Devkant took out his notebook. The sunlight had leaned a little westward. He sat in a safer corner of the veranda and opened the page. Yesterday's writing was visible—"Madhavi—water first." Beneath it: "Write the name of whoever makes the decision."

Today he gave the page a heading—"Disaster Food."

The moment he wrote the title, the words felt slightly external to him. "Disaster" was a clear, orderly word for a book; what was happening in the courtyard was not clear. Hunger, dust, a broken wall, a child's crying, steam from a pot, smoke from wet wood—how could all that fit inside one word?

Still, he began to write: "Rice and lentils together. Water little by little. Ghee saved. Children, injured, elderly first..."

Madhavi was preparing to wash the pot. She saw the notebook in Devkant's hand. "So the writing has begun again?"

"Yes. Today there is a great deal."

"What's the title?"

Devkant showed her the page with a little pride. "Disaster Food."

Madhavi read it. "You've written the name of the food, the measures, the order."

"Yes."

"Will you write whose hands went into this pot?"

Devkant stopped his pen. It was the next form of yesterday's question: Write the names.

"Meaning?"

Madhavi pointed a finger inside the pot; a thin film of rice clung to the bottom. "Janki took out the grain. Hemlata picked the stones. Ramanand split the wood. Neighbour Kaki brought the water. You lifted the pot and later served as well. I put it on the fire. The children played at picking stones. Who made this khichdi?"

Devkant was about to give the easy answer—"Everyone." But he stopped.

"It's difficult to write everyone," he said.

"So we leave out what is difficult?"

"No. But there is only so much room in a book—"

Madhavi smiled. "There was room in the pot, but not in the book?"

Devkant fell silent at the answer. The young woman's irony often struck precisely where he failed to see his own convenience.

On the page he wrote, "Collective labour." Then, after a moment's thought, struck it out.

"Why did you cross it out?" Madhavi asked.

"It's too flat."

"Is a flat statement wrong?"

"No. But it feels smaller than what happened."

"Then write the names."

Devkant began writing them one by one: "Janki—grain, measure. Madhavi—mixing, water, salt, cooking. Hemlata—sorting. Ramanand—wood, hearth. Devkant—pot, serving..." As soon as he wrote "Devkant," he laughed himself.

"Your own name in very clear letters," Madhavi said.

"Your name is clear too."

"For now."

Those two words touched Devkant deeply. He looked at Madhavi, but she had lifted the pot and was walking toward the water.

Devkant looked again at the page. The list was still incomplete. "Neighbour Kaki"—he did not know her name. He thought of getting up to ask. Until yesterday such a name might not have seemed necessary. Today merely writing "Kaki" felt incomplete.

He went to the other corner of the courtyard and asked the woman her name. At first she was surprised. "Why?"

"It has to be written in the book."

"What did I do?"

"You brought water."

The woman laughed. "A name for bringing water?"

Yesterday's question from Madhavi rang again in Devkant's ears—A name for so small a thing?

He said, "Yes. A name for that too."

After writing her name, he returned. The notebook page now looked more like a list of people than a method. Devkant found the form beautiful and uncomfortable at once: beautiful because the food suddenly seemed alive; uncomfortable because the author's place had grown smaller.

Madhavi was returning after washing the pot. Devkant showed her the page. "Like this?"

She ran her eyes over it. "It's moving in a better direction now."

“A better direction.”

“If I tell you it has arrived, you’ll stop asking questions again.”

Devkant laughed. “Disaster Food” remained at the top of the page, but beneath it there were more names of hands than ingredients, measures and method. For the first time he felt that perhaps the true form of the book was not what he had brought from home; perhaps, as he wrote it, the book itself would change the way he wrote.

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A little before evening, the khichdi left in the pot was reheated. There were fewer people now; some neighbours had gone to inspect the safer portions of their own houses, but the elderly couple and the injured young man were still there. After the day’s running about, hunger had returned.

Madhavi tasted the khichdi. Her brows drew together slightly.

Janki understood at once. “What is it?”

“Not enough salt.”

Hemlata burst out laughing. “I said so in the morning.”

Madhavi looked at her. “If there had been too much, would you have taken it out?”

“No.”

“Then?”

Hemlata fell silent.

Janki took out a little khichdi with the ladle and tasted it. For a moment she kept a grave face, as if examining some serious defect. Then she said, “The earth shook, and even the salt got frightened and ran away.”

Hemlata laughed first. Then the elderly neighbour. A broad smile spread across Ramanand’s face. The injured young man laughed too and clutched his shoulder. Devkant’s laughter burst out so suddenly that he had to close the notebook. The children did not fully understand the reason, but seeing everyone else laugh, they began laughing too.

Still laughing, Janki took salt from the tin. “Now we’ll add it slowly. Otherwise it may get frightened again and never come back.”

Madhavi took a little salt on her palm, sprinkled it into the pot, stirred, then tasted. “Still slightly low.”

“Let it be,” Janki said. “Anyone who wants more can add it on top. A crisis does not make everyone’s tongue the same.”

Devkant immediately tried to open the notebook. The moment Madhavi saw him, she said, “You’ll write this too?”

“Certainly.”

“What?”

“The earth shook, the salt ran away.”

Laughing, Janki interrupted, “If you steal my sentence, write my name.”

Laughter rose again in the courtyard. Devkant paused his pen in the air and inclined himself toward Janki. “Janki Devi—opinion concerning salt.”

“Leave out the Devi and all that. Write Janki.”

“All right.”

He wrote: “Janki: ‘The earth shook, and even the salt got frightened and ran away.’”

He drew a line beneath the sentence. This time he did not write the quantity of salt. How many pinches had gone in, how many seers of khichdi there had been—those things could be asked later. What would be difficult to repeat was the laughter of that moment.

Serving began. This time there was no argument over the order. The children took their own leaf-plates and sat down. The elderly couple were given places before anyone had to say anything. Ramanand washed his hands and quietly sat in the row. Janki wanted to sit last, but Hemlata put her leaf-plate down first.

“What’s this?” Janki asked.

“Order according to need,” Hemlata said, imitating Madhavi’s tone.

Madhavi laughed. “Don’t call her old, or the leaf-plate will be taken away.”

Janki pretended to glare at them. “You two have received more sermons than khichdi.”

Devkant was serving again. His hand was steadier now. How full to make the ladle, where on the leaf-plate to pour so it would not spill, how to cool a child’s portion a little—he was learning small things. He could not decide whether to call this learning knowledge or ordinary work. Perhaps making the distinction was itself wrong.

The evening air grew cool. From far away came again the sound of someone clearing a wall. The fear of the earthquake had not ended; people would sleep that night expecting the ground to shake again. The cracks in the houses had not been repaired, the reports were incomplete, the grain was limited. Yet one pot of khichdi had already gone around among them all, and the laughter born of one sentence had changed the air of the courtyard.

At last Devkant sat down with his own leaf-plate. The khichdi was simple—rice, lentils, turmeric, ginger, the faint aroma of cumin, a little too little

salt. Until yesterday he might perhaps have written, “The taste was bland.” Today he understood that one part of taste lies on the tongue; the rest lies in circumstance and company.

Madhavi sat nearby. She asked, “So now, in the book, who made the khichdi?”

Devkant swallowed his mouthful and answered, “Everyone whose name I managed to write. And those whose names I failed to ask—that is my failing.”

Madhavi was silent for a moment. Then she said, “Keep that sentence safe.”

“Why?”

“You’ll need it later.”

Devkant looked at her face. Whether she was smiling or warning him was not quite clear.

In a corner of the veranda the notebook lay closed. On today’s page inside it, the heading read “Disaster Food,” but there were more names of hands than lists of ingredients. One short sentence had preserved Janki’s laughter. In one place Devkant had written his own name too—serving.

Outside, the earth was silent in the darkness.

In the courtyard, the pot was almost empty.

A little khichdi remained stuck to the bottom—and in the air remained the memory of smoke, salt, laughter and people’s hands.

CHAPTER 06

Madhavi

On the third morning after the earthquake, the earth was quiet, but the village had still not returned to its old rhythm. One roof stood half dismantled, one wall propped with bamboo, grain lay out in another courtyard to catch the sun. Night dew shone on wood and earth. When Devkant rose and came outside, he saw Madhavi walking towards the backyard with a small bamboo basket in her hand.

“Where are you going?” Devkant asked.

Without stopping, Madhavi answered, “To look at leaves.”

“To eat?”

“First to look. Eating comes later.”

Devkant took his notebook and followed her. Madhavi turned once and looked at the notebook in his hand. “So now leaves too will be shut inside paper?”

“If I don’t write down their names, I’ll forget them.”

“Does writing a leaf’s name save the leaf?”

Devkant kept searching for an answer. Meanwhile Madhavi had already crossed the narrow ridge between the plots.

In one place the earthquake had left a crack through the backyard soil, running like the line of a snake. It was not very wide, but the mud had dried and split along its edges. Beyond it were bushes, a few vines, some seasonal greens. Madhavi set the basket on the ground and squatted.

“Look at this,” she said, lifting a leaf from a vine. “Tilkor.”

Devkant bent closer. The leaf was smooth and green, its edge slightly curved. “For tarua?”

“For that too. But not every leaf.”

“Why?”

“This one is too old.” Madhavi passed over a large leaf and showed him a smaller one. “This is tender. Look at the stem, look at the veins. You know when you break the leaf.”

Devkant wrote: "Tilkor: tender leaves are selected."

Madhavi laughed. "You've written 'tender.' Now how will the person reading it know what 'tender' is?"

Devkant stopped his pen. "Then how?"

Madhavi placed the leaf in his hand. "Fold it."

Devkant folded it. The leaf bent without breaking.

"And an old leaf?"

Madhavi gave him another. As soon as he folded it, the central vein resisted stiffly.

"Write this," Madhavi said, "the difference you felt under your fingers."

Devkant touched the leaf again. "How do I write fingers on paper?"

"That is why you ask someone who knows."

They moved on. Madhavi stopped beside a bush. "This is kochila. Its fruit has one use, its leaves another. The raw stage, the ripe stage—you have to look at all of it."

Devkant wrote the name. "Kochila."

"Say it again."

Devkant said it. Madhavi corrected him. He said it once more. This time she nodded.

When they reached the arikanchan leaves, Madhavi became especially careful. "Seeing a leaf does not make it food. Some leaves and plant foods, if prepared without the proper method, make the mouth itch, make the body ill. Writing down the name does not make the knowledge complete."

Devkant drew a line in his notebook and wrote: "Name ≠ complete knowledge."

Madhavi read it and laughed. "What is that sign?"

"Not equal to."

"Then write it in Maithili."

Devkant crossed it out and wrote: "The name alone does not make the knowledge complete."

Madhavi put some leaves into the basket and left others where they were. Devkant grew curious. "Why did you leave these?"

"For next week."

"But they're good now, aren't they?"

"They are. But if we pluck every good leaf today, what will there be tomorrow?"

Devkant's eyes moved between the cracked earth, the new leaves and Madhavi's basket. The earthquake had broken the walls of the house; while

choosing food, Madhavi was looking towards the week ahead. Crisis was not merely the use of what had survived; it was also the knowledge of what must be left to survive.

“And when the season changes?”

“Some disappear, some are new. The kitchen’s list is not the same through all twelve months.”

“Then should the book be arranged by season?”

Madhavi lifted the basket. “You are thinking about making a book. I am talking about food. We will see whether the two become one thing or not.”

The sentence stopped Devkant again. He was beginning to understand that his plan—“The Household Kitchen of Mithila”—was still only a title. The real subject was slipping through his hands like something alive, and instead of teaching him to catch it, Madhavi was teaching him to look.



Back at the house, Janki was spreading grain in a patch of sunlight in the courtyard. Madhavi set down the basket and began sorting the leaves. Devkant sat to one side with his notebook open.

“Tilkor—tender leaves. Arikanchan—proper method essential. The list changes with the season...” he read slowly.

Janki heard him and said, “All this is to be written?”

“Yes.”

“Then write this too: anyone who goes looking for tilkor in a Jeth afternoon will be scolded at home.”

Madhavi smiled. “Janki is right. Time is part of the ingredient too.”

Devkant began to write. Then suddenly he asked, “Where did you read all this?”

Madhavi’s hand stopped midway through snapping a leaf stem. She looked at Devkant. “What?”

“All this knowledge. Which leaf when, which lentil for how many days, how a substance affects the body. Where did you learn it?”

“Read?” Madhavi repeated the word, as though examining its shape. “Does everything one learns exist in a book?”

“No. But you learned it somewhere.”

“From the fields. From the pond. From the kitchen. From Janki. From my mother. From Nasima. From mistakes. From what we ate that made our stomachs go bad. From the crop that survived when the rain failed. From people’s bodies.”

Devkant immediately wanted to write, but Madhavi saw the movement of his pen. "Listen first."

He stopped the pen.

"Why did you ask, 'Where did you read it?'"

Devkant grew slightly uncomfortable. "Because it is necessary to know the source of knowledge."

"Then if I had said, 'I read it in such-and-such book,' would the knowledge have counted for more?"

"I didn't say that."

"You didn't. But the question came from there."

Janki, turning the grain, had been listening in silence. She said, "Can a person who has read books look at the water and tell whether rain is coming?"

Devkant laughed. "Some people can."

"And without books?"

"They can too."

"Then that is enough." Janki returned to her work.

Separating the tiller stems, Madhavi said, "Knowledge in books is not bad. But what never entered a book is not nothing."

This time Devkant did not write. He asked, "Then what is the need to make a book?"

Madhavi thought for a while. "Some things are forgotten. Some things people change. Some things people far away do not know. Writing can save them. But if the person writing cuts and trims everything for his own convenience, then what exactly survives?"

Devkant remembered yesterday's sentence: 'Everyone whose name I managed to write.'

"Then the writer has a responsibility."

"Yes. And so does the person who tells."

"How?"

"What if I tell you something wrong? What if I tell you that one way used in my house is the way of all Mithila? What if I say I know something I do not know?"

Devkant nodded slowly. "This will not make my work easier."

Madhavi laughed. "Does knowledge bind itself up that easily?"

This time Devkant laughed openly. "Are you going to let me write this book, or examine me?"

"Both."

"Then what is the fee?"

Madhavi picked up a tender tilkor leaf. “First learn to recognise this. I’ll ask you again in three days.”

“That is the fee?”

“No. The examination.”

Janki laughed. “Devkant, in the pursuit of writing a book you’ll end up roaming around recognising leaf after leaf.”

Something lightened inside Devkant. For the first time in the three days since the earthquake, he felt again the excitement of his work. But the excitement was no longer what it had been. Earlier he had thought he would collect material and make a book. Now he was beginning to see that the material itself was changing his questions.

He opened a new page in the notebook. At the top he wrote: “Sources.” After a moment he crossed it out. Then he wrote: “Who says it, where they know it from, what they do not know.”

Madhavi could not read it from where she was, but Devkant showed her. “Your name comes first here.”

Without smiling, Madhavi said, “Writing the name first does not grant authority first. We will see it in the work.”

The sentence was not harsh, but it was clear. Devkant liked it in a curious way. For the first time he felt that Madhavi was not an assistant seeking his approval; she could set the terms of the work. That would make working with her difficult—and perhaps worthwhile.

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In the afternoon the air grew a little warmer. People continued separating usable bricks from the broken part of the house. In a safe corner of the veranda, Devkant sat with his papers spread out. After a while Madhavi came carrying a thin bundle of papers wrapped in an old cloth.

“What is this?” Devkant asked.

“You said you wanted to look at writing.”

“Mine?”

“Yesterday you said names must be written. If you are going to write names, learn to recognise the letters too.”

She opened the cloth. Inside were pieces of paper cut by hand, some salvaged from old account books, some thicker. On the first sheet Devkant did not see Devanagari. The letters looked both familiar and unfamiliar—curving lines, some shapes recalling old manuscripts.

“Tirhuta?”

Madhavi nodded.

Devkant took the sheet in his hand. "You write this?"

"A little."

"Who taught you?"

"My maternal grandfather. His accounts, letters, mantras, household matters—each had a different hand. As a child I used to copy the letters."

Devkant studied the page. "What is written here?"

"Ingredients."

"For what?"

"For one winter day. Look—rice, mung, ginger, cumin..."

"I can't read it."

"Then learn."

Devkant smiled. "Such haste?"

Madhavi cleared a patch of dust on the ground with her finger. She picked up a small twig and drew the first letter in the earth. "This is 'च'."

Devkant bent closer. He took the twig himself and copied it. The shape came out crooked.

Madhavi said at once, "That is not 'च'; it is a fish that has escaped."

Devkant burst out laughing. "Do not insult the letter."

"The letter is on my side. You are the one insulting it."

He drew it again. This time the shape was somewhat better. Madhavi showed him another letter. Slowly, a line of five or seven letters formed in the dust. Earth clung to Devkant's fingers; the twig repeatedly threatened to snap.

"Wouldn't it be easier to write it in Devanagari?" Devkant asked.

Madhavi stopped the twig. "Easier for whom?"

"For printing. More readers."

"Then should we abandon the letters that were there first?"

"Not abandon them. But if the book is printed—"

"The book does not even exist yet, and you are already thinking about printing."

Devkant fell silent. He understood—Madhavi was slowing him again. His mind always ran towards the final form; Madhavi watched the life of the thing itself.

"All right," he said. "First I'll learn to read it."

Madhavi placed a sheet before him. "Recognise this word."

Devkant tried to join the letters. He still remembered the first. He had forgotten the second. Madhavi did not tell him immediately. She waited.

"Til..." Devkant faltered.

A smile appeared on Madhavi's face.

"Tilkor?"

"Yes."

Devkant was delighted as though he had passed a difficult examination.

"So this says tilkor."

"And below it?"

"Not yet."

"The three-day examination has already begun."

They both laughed.

After a while Devkant asked, "Will you give these pages for the book?"

Madhavi slid the page back towards herself. "Some. Not all."

"Why?"

"Not everything that is written belongs to everyone."

"But if it is useful for the work?"

"Being useful for the work and being public are not the same thing."

Devkant wanted to note down what she had said, then stopped himself.

Madhavi noticed and smiled.

"What happened? You didn't write it?"

"Not everything that is written belongs to everyone," Devkant replied.

For the first time Madhavi smiled without irony. There was a little acceptance in that smile.

She wrapped the sheets again in the cloth, but kept one small page aside. On it was an ingredient list in Tirhuta. "Keep this. For reading practice."

Devkant took the page with such care that it seemed less a piece of paper than a small portion of trust.

"Don't lose it," Madhavi said.

"I won't."

"And don't copy it into your own script and throw away the original."

Devkant's smile vanished. "Why would I do that?"

Madhavi shrugged. "People preserve what is easy and leave behind what is difficult."

Devkant did not place the page between the leaves of his notebook. He put it in a separate cloth envelope. He wanted Madhavi to see that difficult things too could be preserved.



Before evening, people gathered in the courtyard once more. Some houses had walls that could be saved; others did not. The earthquake was still on

everyone's lips, but life was beginning to take its place again through small tasks—the cow had to be milked, water drawn, the hearth lit, children would play, grain would be sorted.

Devkant sat on the veranda steps, looking again at the Tirhuta page. He remembered some letters; others were strange again. Madhavi was cutting leaves.

"May I say something?" Devkant began.

"Say it."

"The book I had imagined—I cannot write it alone."

Madhavi's hands did not stop. "You understand that now?"

"Yes. At least not in the form the subject now seems to have."

"Has the subject changed, or your eyes?"

Devkant thought for a moment. "My eyes."

Madhavi set the leaf stems to one side. "The correct answer."

Devkant said, "Work with me."

Now Madhavi stopped. "What am I doing now?"

"You are helping. But I mean properly. Systematically. Leaves, lentils, grain, fish, makhana, seasons, what people say, methods—whatever is appropriate. What you know. Where you do not know, we will ask others."

"Whose name will be on the book?"

The question was direct. Devkant was silent for a moment. In his old imagining, he had seen his own name on the title page. He had not expected to face this question so soon.

"Each person's name with their contribution," he said.

Madhavi tried to read his face. "That sentence is good. It will be difficult to live by."

"I'll try."

"Not try. A rule."

Devkant laughed, but Madhavi did not. She was serious.

"All right," Devkant said. "A rule."

Madhavi pushed the pile of leaves to one side. "And a second rule."

"What?"

"What we do not understand, we ask. We do not fill the empty spaces ourselves."

The sentence struck Devkant. A writer's instinct was to fill empty spaces—with context, meaning, cause, story. Madhavi was saying that some empty spaces should remain empty if there was no evidence.

"Agreed," he said.

“Third.”

“There is more?”

A smile came to Madhavi’s face. “Writing a book is not cheap.”

“Go on.”

“We will not call the practice of one household the practice of all Mithila. What Nasima says may belong to Nasima’s household. What Janki says may belong to this one. What Ramanand tells us may belong to the work of the pond. We compare before we write.”

Devkant nodded at once. “That is necessary.”

“Fourth.”

“You’ll make a book of rules before the book itself.”

“Fourth—any page I call private remains private.”

This time Devkant answered without delay. “All right.”

“Fifth—you will not ‘improve’ my language and change the meaning.”

Devkant was taken aback. “Why would I change the meaning?”

“Today you wrote ‘tender’ and thought you had contained the whole knowledge of the leaf.”

Devkant understood. “All right. If I change the language, I will show it to you.”

Madhavi relaxed a little. “Then the work may be possible.”

“So, agreed?”

“Agreed.”

Devkant opened the notebook. “Shall I write it down?”

Madhavi laughed. “This time, write.”

At the top of the page he wrote: “Rules of the Work.” Under it, five points. First—“The name of whoever holds the knowledge / does the work.” Second—“Do not fill in what is not understood from ourselves.” Third—“One household ≠ all Mithila.” Fourth—“Private pages remain private.” Fifth—“Ask the meaning before changing the language.”

Madhavi read the page. “You used the equals sign again?”

Devkant laughed. “No. It is written in Maithili.”

“Then good.”

She got up. Devkant kept looking at the page. There were five rules, but he sensed that the real rules still existed outside the words—listen, be patient, see the limits of one’s own authority.

After a while Madhavi returned. In her hand was one tender tilkor leaf selected that day. She placed it before Devkant. “Tell me—why is this one good?”

Devkant took the leaf. He touched the vein, folded it, looked at the stem. “The vein does not turn hard when folded. The stem is tender. The colour is even. It is not too old.”

Madhavi nodded. “You have learned a little.”

“The three-day examination is today itself?”

“What faith can one put in time during an earthquake?”

They both laughed.

Devkant began to turn the leaf in his hand. Madhavi did not take it. “Don’t keep it. This is for eating.”

“What if I pressed it inside the book?”

“Then you would forget what the leaf is for.”

She took the leaf and walked towards the kitchen. Devkant watched her go. His notebook now held the rules, one Tīrhuta page had been preserved separately, and in his mind there was a new discomfort—the authorship of the book he wanted to write might not be as simple as he had imagined when he left home.

Before darkness fell, Madhavi washed the tilkor leaf and set it aside. There would be no tarua today; the oil had to be saved. The leaf would be used tomorrow or the day after.

At the end of his page Devkant wrote one sentence: “Beginning of work with Madhavi.”

Then he paused and drew a faint line beneath the word “with.”

Evening air entered through the broken edge of the wall. The house was still wounded, but in that wounded house the real birth of a book had taken place that day—not from one writer’s desire, but from the disagreement and agreement of two ways of seeing.

CHAPTER 07

The Month of Kurthi

The days after the earthquake were slowly dissolving into one another. Bamboo props had been set against the broken part of the house, the bricks from the courtyard had been gathered to one side, and a temporary shelter had been raised for the kitchen. But winter evening still descended as easily as before. As soon as the sun went down, the air began to bite, and people edged closer to the fire.

That evening a thick brown dal was simmering in an earthen pot on the kitchen's small hearth. Its smell was plain—no sharp rush of spices, no gleam of ghee and cashews—only steam, dal, the mild warmth of ginger, and smoke.

Devkant came down from the veranda and approached the kitchen. “What is it today?”

Janki lifted the lid of the pot a little and looked in. “Kurthi.”

Devkant's attention sharpened. “Kurthi dal?”

“If not dal, then what—makhana kheer?” Janki laughed. “It keeps the body warm in winter—my mother used to say.”

Madhavi was sitting nearby, pounding ginger. Without looking up she said, “My mother used to say—that part must be written too.”

Devkant understood her point and smiled. “I haven't even written it yet.”

“Your eyes have already begun writing.”

Janki went on stirring the pot. After a while she said casually, “In our family one thing has been said for generations—eat kurthi dal for one month in the year and you won't get stones.”

Devkant immediately reached for his notebook.

Madhavi stopped pounding the ginger. “See?”

“What?”

“Not the eyes now. The hand has started writing.”

Janki laughed. “Write it, write it. My grandmother used to say it too. One month of kurthi in winter, and afterward the body feels lighter.”

Devkant wrote: “Kurthi—one month a year; stones do not occur.”

Madhavi held out her hand toward the page. "Show me."

Devkant gave her the notebook. Madhavi read the line, then looked at Janki. "You said—this is something that has been said in the family?"

"Yes."

"Did someone have stones and get better because of kurthi?"

Janki thought for a moment. "I had heard a story about my maternal grandfather's brother. But I did not see it myself."

"Did a vaidya say so?"

"People used to say—eat kurthi, drink plenty of water. Who can remember something that old with certainty now?"

Madhavi placed a finger on Devkant's line. "Here you have written, 'stones do not occur.' Janki said, 'this is something said in the family.' Those are not the same thing."

Devkant took the page back. "The meaning is almost—"

"A great many errors can hide behind 'almost.'"

Janki replaced the lid. "Oh, I am not a doctor. I told you what is said at home. If you put it on paper, will you put a doctor's opinion in my mouth?"

Devkant gave an embarrassed smile. "All right. I'll correct it."

He struck out the old line and wrote: "Household saying: eating kurthi dal for one month a year prevents stones—family belief heard by Janki."

Madhavi read it again. "Better. But 'prevents stones' still sounds like a certainty."

Devkant frowned. "Then?"

Before Madhavi could answer, Janki said, "Write: 'It is said in the family that eating kurthi dal for one month a year keeps stones from occurring.' That's enough."

The three of them were silent for a few moments. The fire in the hearth flared. A straight ribbon of steam rose beside the pot's lid and disappeared into the dark.

Devkant wrote a new line: "It is said in the family that eating kurthi dal for one month a year keeps stones from occurring."

Madhavi nodded. "Now does the sentence say who is doing the saying?"

Devkant smiled. "Janki."

Janki chuckled. "Not me. My mother, her mother, whoever else it passed through before it reached my mouth—if you write all their names, the dal will burn."

Amid the laughter, Devkant understood for the first time how many unnamed mouths might stand behind one small household sentence. If he

truly wanted to do this work well, the pothi would have to record not only recipes but also chains of saying.

Janki showed him the old tin in which the dal was kept. "Look at this. Kurthi is not a glossy dal. The grains are small, hard. They do not cook easily. First sort them, wash them, soak them, then put them on the fire patiently. Anyone in a hurry will not like this dal."

Madhavi took a few grains in her palm and showed them to Devkant. "The grain is hard, but it is not bad. Writing can be like that too. A thing that does not soften at once need not be thrown away."

Devkant laughed and asked, "Now kurthi is going to teach me how to write?"

"If you are willing to learn, even a lentil can teach you."

Janki laughed as she stirred the pot. "First let us eat it. Philosophy afterward."



The dal went on simmering. Madhavi took a few grains out into a small bowl and pressed them between her fingers. They were not fully tender yet. She put them back into the pot. Meanwhile Devkant continued revising the page.

After a while he wrote a short line in English: "Horse gram prevents stone."

Madhavi noticed. "What is this now?"

"An English note. It will be useful later when I write the article."

"Read it."

Devkant read it aloud.

Madhavi's face grew serious. "There it is again—the same thing."

"I have written it in brief."

"When you make truth brief, it does not become smaller. It changes."

Devkant grew a little irritated. "Then must I write the whole story behind every line? The purpose of a note is to condense."

"Condense it. Do not change it."

"What if I write, 'a household belief'?"

"Yes. And if you ask a vaidya, that is a different statement. If you find something in a pothi, that is different. If you see someone's experience with your own eyes, that is different."

"Do you want me to put one dal on trial?"

A spark came into Madhavi's eyes. "Do you want to turn one dal into a doctor?"

Janki broke in. "You two quarrel. Leave the pot to me."

Devkant wanted to laugh, but the point had lodged inside him. "I am not turning it into a doctor. I am recording a folk belief."

"The English line does not say 'folk belief.' It says—this dal has this effect."

Devkant looked at the page. The tone really was different. In the Maithili line there had been 'it is said in the family'; in English that part had vanished.

"All right," he said. "I'll write: 'A household belief says...'"

Madhavi did not answer at once. Then she said, "And 'household' means one house. What if no such belief exists in another house?"

Devkant's patience reached the edge of breaking. "Do you want me not to write at all?"

"I want you to write only as much as you know."

"And what I still need to know?"

"Ask."

"Whom?"

"A vaidya. Other households in the village. Someone who has suffered from stones. A farmer who grows kurthi. An old pothi, if you find one. Knock on as many doors as it takes before you make one sentence certain."

Devkant fell silent. He remembered the 'rules of the work' he had written: do not fill what you do not understand out of your own head. The rule had seemed simple when he wrote it; he was now beginning to feel its weight in practice.

"At this rate, when will the pothi ever be finished?"

Madhavi put the crushed ginger into the pot. "Why the wrong kind of haste for the sake of finishing?"

Devkant looked at the steam above the pot. His impatience seemed to rise and disappear like the steam itself. "All right. I am crossing out the English line."

He drew a straight line through it. Underneath he wrote: "What people say—verification pending."

Madhavi read it and gave a small smile. "Keep that."

Devkant asked, "Only that much?"

"That much is true for now."

Devkant asked again, "If I do not write the saying at all, would that not be an insult to people's knowledge?"

Madhavi replied, "Why should you not write it? Write it. But write it in the form in which you found it. Your work is not to turn what people say into the most glittering sentence; it is to show it in its proper place."

"And if a vaidya later says there is some basis to it?"

"Then write that in the vaidya's name. And if he says there is none, write that too. The paper will not break from holding both."

Devkant kept looking at her face. He was struck by the fact that Madhavi wanted to preserve people's beliefs without turning them into blind truth. Perhaps the proper path of the pothi lay on that narrow strip between the two.

Janki ladled some dal into a bowl and tasted it. "True or false, there is not enough salt."

Devkant and Madhavi both burst out laughing. For a moment the intellectual quarrel shrank before the salt in the pot.



When the meal was served, kurthi dal did not look glamorous. It was dark brown, some of the grains broken, the liquid thick. There was a faint scent of mustard oil, crushed ginger, no garlic—that was the way Janki's household had made it that day. With it came rice and a little salt and chilli.

Devkant took his first mouthful. The taste was deep, with something earthy in it, a faint bitterness in the finish. He reached toward his notebook. Madhavi noticed at once.

"Eat first."

Devkant stopped his hand. "Now eating itself is an examination?"

"If the tongue is at work, do not push paper in between."

The two of them ate in silence for a while. Janki sat to one side, watching the plates of the others in the line.

After some time Devkant said, "The taste is heavy."

Madhavi asked, "What does 'heavy' mean?"

"Thick. It feels as though it warms the body."

"That is why many households eat it in winter—it is said," Madhavi said, deliberately adding the qualification.

Devkant smiled. "Now you are going to turn my own language against me?"

"You are learning."

Janki came and sat nearby with her own plate. "Kurthi has also been called the poor person's dal. It grows with little care, tolerates dry fields, fills the

body. But I do not like the way that makes it sound as though the food of poor people is of a lower grade.”

Devkant became interested. “Is kurthi grown a lot in this village?”

“It depends on the land. Good in some fields, not in others. There used to be more of it,” Janki said. “In years of scarcity, people depended on it. Animals ate it, people ate it too. Why look down on a grain in prosperous times when it stands by you in hard ones?”

Madhavi added, “And what is expensive in the market is not necessarily what is most useful in a household.”

Janki’s memory opened out. “There was one year when the rains were very poor. The paddy was weak, vegetables scarce. That year there was still a jar of kurthi in the house. Sometimes as dal, sometimes ground into batter, sometimes soaked and mixed with another dal. The grain that earns no fame on a festive plate is often the one that holds a household together in hard times.”

Devkant asked, “How many years ago?”

Janki put a hand to her forehead and thought. “If you ask me the date, I cannot say. But Hemlata had not been born. Your father was small.”

Devkant immediately began trying to calculate the year. Madhavi stopped him. “Write the estimate separately. Janki did not give a date.”

He wrote on the page: “Memory of an old year of poor rainfall; exact year unknown.” This time the sentence did not feel incomplete to him. It felt more honest.

Devkant wanted to take notes, but this time he waited until he had finished eating and washed his hands before opening the notebook.

He wrote: “Kurthi: winter food; available in ordinary households; can grow with limited resources—local verification required. A grain/dal relied upon in hard times.”

Madhavi read the page. “Good. But ‘warming’?”

“Janki said it keeps the body warm.”

“Then write: ‘considered warming.’ Bodies are not all the same.”

Janki laughed. “Madhavi, at this rate Devkant’s pothi will be fuller of ‘it is said’ than of dishes.”

Madhavi replied, “Then the reader will understand that people are speaking, not stones.”

Devkant was silent for a while at that sentence. “People are speaking, not stones”—that could have been the central principle of the pothi. Knowledge

was not a detached object; it came from within someone's mouth, body, field, time, deprivation, experience.

"About the stones," Devkant began again, "what if I find someone who says they benefited after eating kurthi?"

Madhavi said, "Write: so-and-so experienced this. That does not prove the same thing will happen to everyone."

"Where did you learn the word 'prove'?"

With light irony Madhavi said, "Talking to educated people like you, some words stick."

Devkant laughed. "And you change some of my words."

"The ones placed in the wrong spot."

"So you have become an editor?"

"Do you remember the fifth rule of our agreement?"

Devkant shut the notebook. "I remember."

He opened it again and made three small headings in one corner of the page: "Heard," "Seen," "To Ask." Janki's statement about stones went into the first; the way kurthi had been cooked that day into the second; the vaidya, other households, and the fields into the third.

Madhavi looked at the page. "This is useful."

"Have I passed your examination?"

"One page has passed for now."

"Not me?"

"Your result will come when the pothi is complete."

Devkant laughed. Yet inwardly he felt an odd relief from those three small compartments. Everything did not have to be turned immediately into true or false. Some things could remain as heard, some as seen, some as questions.

Evening had deepened. Outside the kitchen, smoke hung low. A dog barked somewhere in the distance. The broken wall of the house was still where it had been, but the ordinary weariness that follows a meal was settling over the courtyard.

Devkant felt that this plain plate of kurthi dal had changed the direction of his pothi once again. Writing taste was one thing; writing the body, the field, scarcity, people's sayings, uncertainty and belief behind taste was another. If the pothi merely said, 'Eat kurthi—no stones,' it would not preserve household knowledge; it would distort its form.



After dinner Devkant sat beside the lantern. The notebook lay open before him. Above, the first line he had written was crossed out; below it: "What people say—verification pending." Beside those five words he could see the whole of the evening.

Madhavi was returning after setting down a water pot. Devkant called to her, "Listen a moment."

She stopped. "What?"

"I am thinking—tomorrow I should go to Vaidya Rameshwar Jha. Ask him about kurthi."

Madhavi stood by a pillar of the veranda. "Go."

"Will you come?"

"Why?"

"So you can ask questions too."

"You ask your questions. I will ask mine afterward."

Devkant understood: she was collaborating with him, but not becoming his shadow. "All right."

There was silence for a few moments. Then Devkant said, "And we will ask in other households too. Nasima's house, Ramanand's house, farmers who grow kurthi."

A trace of satisfaction showed on Madhavi's face. "The rules of the work were not wasted."

"You have made it difficult."

"Does difficult mean bad?"

"No." Devkant looked at the page. "Perhaps I had been taking it far too easily before."

Madhavi was silent.

Devkant said quietly, "I have something to admit. When Janki mentioned stones, I immediately saw a good sentence. Readers would remember it in an article. I did not stop to ask what kind of truth the sentence was."

Madhavi's gaze softened, but she did not praise him at once. "That is why there was a rule about listening before writing."

"Yes."

"And one more thing."

"Tell me."

"Do not belittle folk belief either. If there is no evidence, laughing it away is also wrong. Some things pass down from generation to generation out of some experience. Some are wrong too. The work is to distinguish the two."

Devkant picked up his pen and wrote: “Do not turn what people say into either a medical command or a joke.”

Madhavi read it. “That is good.”

“You won’t cut it this time?”

“Not yet.”

Devkant smiled. “Great kindness.”

“Not kindness. The sentence deserves to stay.”

The flame of the lantern trembled slightly. Outside, the winter wind sharpened. As Madhavi was about to leave, Devkant asked again, “Do you yourself eat kurthi?”

“I do.”

“For one month a year?”

Madhavi laughed. “On the days it is cooked in the house. I do not eat dal by counting days.”

Devkant burst out laughing. Madhavi too went inside laughing.

After the laughter subsided, Devkant added a new line at the bottom of the page: “Experience and evidence are not the same; but experience can be the beginning of a question.”

He looked at the line for a while. Earlier he had thought the work of knowledge was to provide answers. Now he was beginning to understand that sometimes its first honesty was to preserve the right question.

Across the courtyard, the ash in the hearth was still faintly warm. The pot had been washed. The taste of kurthi dal had faded from the mouth, but the questions it had raised had settled into the notebook.

Devkant drew a straight line beneath the words “What people say—verification pending.” This time the line was not there to strike the words out, but to preserve them.

CHAPTER 08

The Measure of Salt

After the evening of kurthi, Devkant's notebook had acquired three small boxes—"Heard," "Seen," "To Ask." When he woke the very next morning, he felt such confidence in this arrangement that he considered adding a fourth—"Measure." His thought was that where something could be weighed, there might be a little less room for dispute.

Janki was sorting rice on the kitchen veranda. Madhavi was grinding cumin on the stone slab. Devkant arrived carrying a small balance, weights, and two brass bowls.

Madhavi looked up. "Is the kitchen opening today, or a shop?"

Setting down the balance, Devkant said, "From today, ingredients will be weighed to fixed measures."

Janki stopped sorting the rice and looked at him. "Are we eating dal or accounts?"

"Both. If the pothi says how to make dal, the reader ought to know how much dal, how much water, how much salt."

A faint smile touched Madhavi's lips. "For how many people?"

"Four."

"Four children?"

"No, four people."

"Four people who have come hungry from the fields, or four who have already eaten something at noon?"

Devkant kept adjusting the pointer of the balance. "Four average people."

"What is an average person like?" Madhavi asked.

Janki laughed. "Devkant, first go and fetch those people whose hunger is average."

Devkant laughed too, but did not put the balance away. "All right. Suppose four adults. Midday meal. With rice."

Tapping the ground cumin into a bowl, Madhavi said, "And vegetables with it?"

“Yes.”

“Pickle?”

“Yes.”

“Tarua?”

“Possibly.”

“Then will the dal take the same amount of salt as when one eats only dal and rice?”

Devkant opened his mouth to answer, then closed it. “That is exactly why we need measurement. A standard.”

Madhavi washed her hands and came over to the balance. “Make a standard. But first tell me this—which salt?”

“Salt is salt.”

Janki opened her tin. Inside was coarse-grained salt. In another small tin beside it was finely ground salt. “Weigh both,” she said.

Devkant used the same weight for the coarse salt first, then the fine. The weight came out identical. It felt like a victory. “See? Once there is weight, the difference disappears.”

Madhavi took equal amounts of hot water in two small bowls and dissolved the weighed salt in each. “Taste.”

Devkant took a sip from the first, then the second. The difference was not enormous, but the salt in the second bowl struck the tongue all at once.

“Why?” he asked.

Madhavi said, “One dissolved at once, the other slowly. And when the water cools, the experience will change again. In dal, the grain, the thickness, ghee or oil, sourness—all of it changes taste.”

Devkant raised his pen to write. Madhavi did not stop him. This time she herself said, “Write—measurement is useful, but the tongue cannot be given leave.”

Devkant wrote it down. “Under your name?”

Madhavi looked at him for a moment. “If it is mine, then under my name.”

At the margin of the page Devkant wrote—“Madhavi.” As he wrote the name, he remembered the previous day’s argument over kurthi. This time, writing a name did not feel like an ordinary act. It felt like a discipline.

Janki opened the jar of pulses and took out arhar. “We are making arhar today. Test your balance on this.”

Devkant grew animated. He weighed the dal, measured the water, set aside the turmeric, placed a weight for the salt. Beside each ingredient he wrote a number.

Madhavi sat nearby and watched in silence.

“What now?” Devkant asked.

“Now put the dal on to cook.”

“Salt now?”

“You are writing the pothi. You decide.”

Uncertainty crossed Devkant’s face. “Janki?”

Janki answered at once, “Do not drag me into this. Today the dal will be made by your measures.”

Devkant decided to add half the salt now and half later. He wrote—“Half at the beginning, half at the end, according to taste.”

Madhavi read “according to taste” and smiled. “You brought a balance and in the end you have come back to the tongue.”

Devkant stopped his pen. “That was always there. But before the tongue decides, at least there will be a basis.”

“There will. Measurement is not the enemy. Making measurement the master is the problem.”

The dal began to boil. Foam rose to the top. Devkant watched the hands of the clock, noted the intensity of the fire, wrote down whether the water had reduced. After a while, merely from the sound of the pot, Janki said, “It needs water.”

Devkant lifted the lid and looked. The dal had indeed thickened. “You didn’t even look.”

“The pot speaks,” Janki said simply.

“How do I write that in the pothi?”

“First learn to listen,” Madhavi said.

Devkant laughed. “Between the two of you, you will turn my pothi into the hardest task in the world.”

Janki poured hot water into the pot. “Would you rather eat difficult dal or bad dal?”

Devkant had his answer ready. “Difficult.”

“Then write.” Janki went back to sorting rice.

When the dal was ready, Devkant added the remaining salt he had measured. He tasted it. It seemed good to him. Madhavi tasted it and said nothing. Janki tasted it and added another pinch of salt from the tin.

Devkant protested, “You have ruined the measure.”

“The dal has improved,” Janki replied.

Devkant tasted again. The flavour had indeed opened up a little.

He wrote on the page—“Salt: measured amount + one pinch at the end.”

Madhavi immediately asked, “Whose pinch?”

Devkant stared at her.

Madhavi held up her fingers. “Janki’s pinch, my pinch, your pinch—are all three equal?”

Janki looked at Devkant’s long fingers. “With his pinch, half the house’s salt would be gone.”

All three burst out laughing.

Devkant struck out “one pinch” and wrote—“Taste at the end and add as needed.” Then, after thinking a moment, he added in the margin—“The cook’s tongue is the final measure in the household.”

Madhavi read it. “There is one flaw in this.”

“What now?”

“The eater’s tongue?”

Devkant put a hand to his head. “Will you not let me write even one line about salt?”

“I will. But the shorter the line, the greater its responsibility.”

Laughing, Devkant closed the notebook. “All right. That is enough salt for today. Tomorrow I will prove that one method can be written down.”

That familiar glint returned to Madhavi’s eyes. “Tomorrow?”

“Yes.”

“Then tomorrow we will eat dal in three houses.”

“Why?”

“One name. One dal. We shall see where your single method survives.”

Devkant accepted the challenge. “All right. Three houses.”

Janki laughed. “Writing this pothi is doing wonders for your stomach.”

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By noon the next day, three small bowls stood before Devkant. All three contained arhar dal, yet their colour, aroma, thickness, even the droplets of oil floating on top were different. Madhavi had deliberately not told him which bowl came from which house.

“Taste first,” she said. “Notes afterward.”

Devkant had learned this rule over the past few days. This time he picked up the first bowl without argument.

The first dal was pale yellow. The broth was thin, the aroma of cumin very delicate, the salt light. With rice, the flavour opened slowly.

The second dal was thick. A fine sheen of mustard oil lay on top, with the smell of roasted spices and slightly sharper salt. The first sip woke the tongue.

The third was of medium thickness, but carried a faint trace of smoke; the dal had not been mashed smooth, and some grains retained their shape.

Devkant tasted all three. Then he said, "Three different methods."

Madhavi said, "Name?"

"Arhar dal."

"In all three?"

"Yes."

"Then one name, three methods?"

"All right."

Madhavi pointed to the first bowl. "This is from Janki's kitchen. The second from Nasima's. The third from Ramanand's."

Devkant tasted them again with care. "The spices are different."

"Partly. But not only the spices."

"Then?"

"In the first house, the dal is eaten with rice. In the second, fish has also been cooked today, so the dal keeps its flavour a little stronger. In the third, there was less rice, so it will be eaten with roti; the dal is therefore thicker."

Devkant began to write. "The dishes served alongside a food change the method."

"And the preferences of the people in the house."

"That is difficult to write."

"It is difficult, so we leave it out?"

Devkant looked up from the page at Madhavi. "You are using that sentence more often now."

"Because whenever you see something difficult, you begin making the paper smaller."

Devkant tasted the second bowl again. "There is more salt in Nasima's house."

Madhavi said, "For your tongue."

"Not for yours?"

"For me it is right."

"Janki?"

"For her, a little too much."

Devkant laughed. "One dal, one bowl, three judgments."

“That is why I asked yesterday—whose measure of salt?”

They rose from the first house—Janki’s kitchen—and went toward Nasima’s. There too, after the earthquake, fresh mud was being applied to one section of the wall. Clothes were drying along the edge of the courtyard, and smoke from the hearth slipped out through a gap in the bamboo.

Nasima laughed as soon as she saw them. “Have you come to taste dal and deliver a verdict, or conduct a trial?”

Madhavi said, “He is writing a pothi. So far, the pothi has been writing him.”

Devkant greeted her and said, “I have been told there is more salt in your dal.”

Nasima raised an eyebrow at Madhavi. “You have revealed our household secret?”

Madhavi laughed. “His tongue revealed it.”

“Then give his tongue some rice. You cannot judge dal by eating it alone.”

Rice, dal, and a small piece of fish were set before Devkant. There was no raw onion alongside—only what happened to be part of that household’s meal that day. The dal now truly seemed less sharp; amid the flavour of the fish, its salt felt balanced.

Devkant paused with a morsel in hand and looked at Madhavi. She said nothing; only signalled with her eyes, as if to say, “See?”

Nasima asked, “What did you write?”

Devkant said, “Nothing yet. I am eating.”

A small smile spread across Madhavi’s face.

After the meal Devkant asked, “How much salt do you put in your dal?”

Nasima said, “By looking at the bowl.”

“The amount?”

“My hand.”

“A measure of the hand?”

“If the fish is salty that day, less. If it is potato and aubergine, something else. If a child is ill, mild. If there is a guest, I sometimes ask.”

Devkant smiled. “So there is no single answer.”

“If there were one answer, everyone would have learned cooking by now.”

Madhavi added, “And the pothi would end on one page.”

Nasima looked at Devkant’s notebook. “Will you write our household’s name in the pothi?”

Without hesitation Devkant said, “Yes. What belongs to your household will be written under your household’s name.”

At that answer, Madhavi looked at him a moment longer than usual. Devkant noticed, but said nothing.

The third stop was Ramanand's house. There the dal was cooking over a slow fire in a thick pot. The fuel was different, the base of the pot thicker, even the water tasted different. Ramanand's wife, Malti, said, "I do not mash the dal completely. People in the house like to see the grains."

Devkant asked, "And this smoky taste?"

Malti laughed. "Am I making it, or is the smoke? Ask the wood."

From nearby Ramanand said, "Sometimes we burn dried stalks from the pond as well. Whatever fuel is available."

Devkant noted—"Fuel may alter flavour." Then immediately added —"Experience of this household."

Madhavi looked at the page. "I have to correct you less now."

"The student is making progress."

"The examination is still ahead."

Devkant made a brief summary of the dal in the three homes: the same arhar, yet water, accompanying dishes, household preference, fire, pot, the time at which salt was added, the way the dal was mashed, the time it was served—all combined to produce a different taste.

He asked, "Then should the pothi not give methods at all?"

Madhavi said, "Why not? Write the base method. Then write the variations. Do not give the reader the illusion that one page can bind the tongues of every household in Mithila."

Devkant underlined the words "every household." "I understand that."

Ramanand laughed. "What I understand is that if Babu Sahib goes around three houses eating dal, both the pothi and his stomach will grow thicker."

Malti immediately said, "And do not come back tomorrow with that balance. The food goes cold while he hunts for the weights."

Everyone laughed. Devkant did too. He felt that the difficulties of the pothi no longer brought only embarrassment; they had begun to bring pleasure as well.



That evening Devkant sat on the veranda comparing his notes from the three houses. The lantern had not yet been lit; in the fading light the letters on the page were beginning to blur. Nearby, Madhavi was examining an old tin of adauri to see whether any damp had reached it.

Suddenly Devkant said, "I have found a solution."

“For what?”

“For salt.”

Without looking up Madhavi asked, “The balance again?”

“No. I’ll write in English—‘season to taste.’”

Madhavi stopped her hand. “What?”

Devkant repeated the English words slowly. “Season to taste. Meaning—add salt and spices according to taste.”

Madhavi kept looking at him. “Whose taste?”

Devkant laughed. “The same question again?”

“The same question. Changing the words has not changed the question.”

“This is standard English. The reader will understand that it means according to one’s own taste.”

“Whose ‘own’?”

“The person cooking.”

“The person eating?”

“That too.”

“Their tastes differ?”

Devkant put the pen down on the table. “Will you cook the English sentence as well?”

Madhavi laughed. “If you carry Maithili food into English, we have to see what falls away on the road.”

Devkant grew serious. “All right. Tell me what falls away.”

Madhavi closed the tin of adauri and sat down before him. “What we saw in three houses today was that salt was not only a matter of the tongue. In one house it was with fish, in one with rice, in one with roti. Somewhere there were children, somewhere old people. One fire was strong, another low. If you write only ‘according to taste,’ where has all that gone?”

“But the pothi cannot repeat every fact in every method.”

“Then write a rule at the beginning—the method is a base; it can change with the household’s meal.”

Devkant thought. “That could go in the introduction.”

“And if a particular dish has something specific, write it there.”

“Such as the salt in Nasima’s house because of the fish?”

“Yes. But be careful with the word ‘because.’ Did you ask her?”

Devkant remembered. Nasima had said: if the fish is salty, use less; it changes according to the meal. “Yes, I asked.”

“Then write it.”

Beneath the English phrase, Devkant wrote in Maithili: “According to taste; keeping in mind the accompanying food, the people eating, and household practice.”

Madhavi read it. “I like ‘household practice’ here.”

“In English?”

“I don’t know.”

“Then I’ll do that.”

“Do it. But do not cut away the meaning in the effort to make it shorter.”

Devkant tried two or three sentences in English and crossed them out. “Household practice... accompanying dishes... preference...” The words spread across the page.

Madhavi watched with a smile. “Half a page of English in exchange for one pinch of salt.”

“Your fault.”

“The salt’s fault.”

“The salt is sitting quietly in its tin.”

“Then the writer’s fault.”

Devkant burst out laughing. “That verdict came rather quickly.”

After a while he said seriously, “This problem will come up again and again in translation. If I call tarua a ‘fried vegetable,’ something remains and something falls away. If I call bagiya a ‘dumpling,’ the reader may understand the shape, not the memory of the household. If I write ‘season to taste,’ the action survives, but not the society of tongues.”

Madhavi said quietly, “Then leave some words as they are.”

“An English reader will not understand.”

“Not the first time. They will ask. Read. Learn.”

“The book will become difficult.”

“Will you keep making my language easier and easier until it becomes another language?”

Devkant fell silent. The question was not harsh, but it was direct.

Madhavi said, “If a dish has a name in our house, why remove it from its name? Give the meaning, and keep the name too.”

At the top of the page Devkant wrote—“Preserve the name; give the meaning with it.”

“Whose sentence is this?” he asked.

Madhavi said, “This time, yours.”

“Certain?”

“I gave the thought. You made the sentence.”

Devkant laughed. "The rules of credit are difficult."

"And necessary."

The lantern was lit. In its yellow light, English and Maithili lines shone side by side on the page. Devkant felt that translation was not merely a bridge between two languages; while building the bridge, one also had to see whose land was being cut through.

He looked again at "season to taste." "I'll keep the phrase, but with a note."

Madhavi said, "Keep it. I am not against words. Just do not make one word a solitary king."

"King?"

"In your pothi everything has a habit of becoming king—sometimes measurement, sometimes English, sometimes the author."

Devkant laughed, then suddenly fell silent. The last word had been spoken in light jest, but it went deep. Author. He liked the title. But among all the hands, voices, and tastes filling the pages of the pothi, who was the 'author'?

Madhavi perhaps understood his silence. Changing the subject, she said, "The food will grow cold. Come."

Devkant closed the notebook. This time he did not settle the final English form of "season to taste." The blank he left did not feel like failure; it felt like honesty.



The meal sitting was almost over. Janki had already eaten; the other people in the house had gone back to their work. On one side of the veranda, dal and rice had been kept for Devkant and Madhavi. After a day of tasting in three houses, hunger had returned to its ordinary form.

Devkant sat down. By habit, the notebook was beside him. Madhavi set down the plate and looked at it.

Devkant thought for a moment, picked up the notebook, then set it behind him instead of opening it.

Madhavi said nothing. She merely slid the bowl of dal toward him.

It was the same arhar dal that had been made by measurement that morning, but by night it had thickened. While reheating it, Janki had added a little water and a small stream of ghee. Its taste was different again from the dal at noon.

Devkant took the first mouthful. "Do I have to write a new method for this dal now?"

Madhavi smiled. "Its rebirth at night."

"How much remains now of the salt we measured at noon?"

"Keep eating."

For a while they ate in silence. Wind moved outside; the wall propped with bamboo after the earthquake creaked now and then. In a far corner of the courtyard, a red point of fire survived in the ash.

Devkant remembered the three bowls from the day. He asked, "Which of the three was best for you?"

Mixing dal into her rice, Madhavi said, "Why must one of them win?"

"To compare flavour."

"Food is not a competition."

"Then which did you prefer?"

Madhavi thought a little. "Janki's house dal was good with rice. Nasima's dal was good that day with fish. Malti's thick dal was good with roti. If I tasted them separately in bowls, I too would be judging wrongly."

Devkant nodded. "At first I was thinking of choosing the 'best' of the three."

"And now?"

"Now I think the question itself was wrong."

Madhavi looked at him. This time there was less mockery in her eyes and more of a quiet, softened approval. "The student has moved a little forward."

"The result only when the pothi is complete?"

"Yes."

A small tin of salt stood beside the plate. Devkant reached for it automatically, then tasted the dal and stopped his hand.

Madhavi noticed. "No salt?"

"It is right as it is."

"How right?"

Devkant smiled. "I'm not giving you a measure."

Madhavi could not suppress her laughter. "So much change in one day?"

"I have put the balance away."

"The balance was not guilty."

"I remember. Measurement is not the enemy; making it the master is the problem."

Madhavi became still for a moment. "That was my sentence."

Devkant immediately said, "Yes. I wrote it down too—Madhavi."

After that one word, something changed between them. There was no declaration, no grand emotional sentence. Only this: the caution that usually

lived on Madhavi's face eased a little. To Devkant, that was more valuable than praise.

After a while Madhavi asked, "Will you truly write the names of all three households?"

"Yes."

"Even when it is published?"

"If they want that."

"Nasima had asked."

"Her name will remain."

Madhavi kept looking at her plate. "Having one's name on paper is not a small thing."

Devkant said softly, "I am beginning to understand."

"Completely?"

"No. Perhaps I am learning."

Madhavi said nothing to that. She held out the small bowl of pickle toward him. Devkant and Madhavi reached for it at the same moment. Their fingers touched for an instant. Madhavi did not withdraw her hand; she merely loosened her grip on the bowl, and Devkant too said nothing at once.

The pickle was set beside Devkant's plate. That moment had no name. Perhaps naming it would have made it heavy.

Devkant took a mouthful. The sourness of the pickle drew a sharp line through the softness of the dal. By habit he wanted to write—"With sourness, salt seems less..."—but he did not even look toward the notebook.

Madhavi asked, "No notes today?"

"After the meal is finished."

"You remembered the rule?"

"Some rules the stomach teaches at once."

"And some?"

Before answering, Devkant looked at her. "Some are taught by the person sitting beside you."

For an instant Madhavi's eyes lowered. Wind entered the veranda from outside. The lantern flame trembled a little, but did not go out.

When the meal was over, Devkant washed his hands. He opened the notebook again, but wrote very little on the final page for the day.

"The same dal, three forms in three houses. Measurement is useful; taste is made in relationship. The final measure of salt is not only in weights and scales."

He stopped his pen after the word “only.” He wanted to write Madhavi’s name at the side, then thought—the sentence had been made by the whole day, by three houses, by Janki, Nasima, Malti, Madhavi, and his own tongue together.

Below it he wrote—“Source: food and conversation in three households; names on a separate page.”

Madhavi read the page and asked, “My name?”

Devkant opened the previous page and showed her. Four names were written there—Janki, Nasima, Malti, Madhavi—and at the side, Ramanand’s name for the point about fuel.

Madhavi looked at the page for a while. Then she said, “Good.”

Devkant asked jokingly, “One page passed now?”

“Two.”

“Rapid progress.”

“Do not become proud. You will make another mistake tomorrow.”

Devkant laughed. “You have faith in me.”

“Complete faith in your capacity for mistakes.”

They both laughed. Outside the veranda, the winter night was deepening.

After a while Madhavi rose and went inside. Devkant closed the notebook and remained sitting there. The day had begun with a balance, weights, and chhatank; it ended in a silence for which there was no measure.

The salt tin had been left on the veranda. Devkant picked it up and carried it back toward the kitchen. On the way back he thought—some ingredients acquire flavour when given the right quantity, and some acquire flavour because their quantity has not been decided in advance.

Sleep came late to him that night. Salt was not the reason.

CHAPTER 09

Tilkor

The sharpness of winter was slowly easing. In the days after the earthquake, people had first counted the hours, then the days; now they had begun once more to watch the turn of the season. The bamboo brace still leaned against the courtyard wall, but the smoke from the kitchen no longer looked like a sign of fear. It looked like a sign that the house had begun to move again.

That morning Janki said that two family acquaintances from the Darbhanga side would arrive around the time of the morning meal. The guests were not entirely unexpected, but the news had come too late to send someone specially to the market. Janki looked once toward the storeroom, once toward the kitchen garden.

"There is rice and dal," she said. "There are vegetables too. The curd has set. If we make some tarua, the plate will feel complete."

Madhavi rose from the veranda and went toward the garden. Devkant followed with his notebook.

Madhavi turned and looked at him. "The book again?"

"Should I not describe a meal for guests?"

"Do. But first let me choose the leaves."

Along the edge of the garden the tilkor vine had spread itself wide. Some leaves were a bright green, some dark; on some, the night's dew still clung like tiny pearls. Madhavi turned each leaf over and examined it. One had an edge gnawed by insects; another had a stiff central stem; another was so tender that it might tear merely from being lifted.

Devkant reached for a very small leaf.

"This one is good?"

Madhavi stopped his hand. "Being small is not the same as being good."

"Yesterday you said the leaf should be tender."

"Tender, yes, but not so raw that it collapses as soon as it takes the batter. Look."

She placed two leaves before him. She bent the midrib of one between her fingers; the midrib of the other resisted more firmly. "Look at the body of the leaf. If it is too old, it will turn tough when fried. If it is too new, it will not hold its form in oil. You need the stage in between."

Devkant began to write—"middle-aged—"

Madhavi burst out laughing. "Have you started counting the age of leaves?"

Devkant stopped his pen. "Then what should I write?"

"Write what you saw. The stem should not be too hard, the leaf should not be too thin, it should not be torn. That much you can write."

Devkant changed the wording. "All right."

Madhavi moved on. When she plucked a leaf she did not tug the vine hard; with one hand she held the stem, with the other she separated the leaf. Hemlata followed with a basket. The leaves were laid in it one by one, not pressed down.

Devkant asked, "The better leaves separately for the guests, and other ones for the family?"

Madhavi's hand stopped. "Good and bad depend on what is to be cooked. The leaves fit for tarua will go into the tarua. Because guests are coming, should the family eat rotten leaves—what kind of rule is that?"

Janki had heard from a distance. She said, "Let the better dishes reach the guests' plates first—that is hospitality. But saving the inferior food for the family is stupidity."

Madhavi looked toward her. "Heard that? This time it is not mine; it is Janki's."

Devkant wrote the name in his notebook. "Janki."

Janki laughed. "Write my name, but if the tarua turns out badly, will you write the blame too?"

"Whose fault, their name," Devkant said.

Madhavi answered at once, "A good rule. Keep it for yourself too."

Devkant looked at her. He remembered the previous night—name, source, credit. "I will," he said.

By the time the leaves were chosen, the basket was half full. Suddenly Madhavi found a small, even, tender leaf. Its edge was whole, its central vein fine. She looked at it for a moment, then instead of slipping it under the other leaves, set it aside along one edge of the basket.

Devkant noticed, but asked nothing.

Madhavi too said nothing.

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Preparations for the morning meal were moving in several directions at once in the kitchen. On one side water boiled in the rice pot; on another, the dal thickened over a low flame; from a third rose the smell of vegetables. The tilkor leaves had been washed and spread out on the veranda.

Hemlata was gently blotting the water from the leaves with a cloth. Janki was watching the batter. Madhavi's hands moved between the salt container and the bowl of batter. Devkant sat near the doorway taking notes.

Janki said, "Devkant, if you are going to sit here, do not block the way."

He shifted aside at once. "I am only watching."

Hemlata laughed. "Watching takes up space too."

Devkant smiled. "All right. Now tell me—who is the main cook?"

All three women looked at him at once.

Janki asked, "What?"

"I have to write the method in the book. Who makes it—you, Madhavi, or Hemlata?"

Hemlata lifted the leaf in her hand. "I am wiping water from it now. Does that make me the maker too?"

Madhavi said, "Janki is watching the batter, I am handling the leaves and the oil, Hemlata is drying the leaves. In a little while she will arrange the plates. Whichever hand becomes free will take up another task. If you need one name, write 'the house.'"

Devkant stopped his pen. "If I write 'the house,' the people's names disappear again."

For a moment something lit in Madhavi's eyes. "Then write everyone's names."

At the top of the page Devkant wrote three names—Janki, Madhavi, Hemlata. Then he asked, "And who plucked the leaves?"

"Hemlata and I."

"Who mixed the batter?"

"Janki, this morning."

"The oil?"

Janki said, "I put the oil on. But Madhavi will watch the heat."

Devkant smiled. "By the time I finish writing the method of one dish, it will become a genealogy."

Madhavi replied, "If you search for one person's name, the lie will stay small; if you write everyone's names, the truth will grow a little larger."

Devkant raised his pen to write the sentence, then asked, "With your name?"

“This time, yes.”

“All right.”

To test the thickness of the batter, Janki lifted a little with the back of her finger and let it fall again into the bowl. The ribbon did not break at once, yet it was not thick enough to form a heavy coating on the leaf. Madhavi dipped in one leaf, lifted it, and lightly drew off the excess batter against the rim of the bowl.

The leaf gave a faint sound as it entered the oil. Devkant instinctively leaned closer to see.

Madhavi said, “Not so near. Oil is not a book that you read with your eyes pressed to it.”

Hemlata laughed again.

The first leaf opened out in the oil. The pale layer of batter slowly changed colour. The edges tightened; the middle puffed slightly. Madhavi did not turn it in haste. She listened to the sound, watched the surface, read the movement of the oil.

Devkant asked, “Time?”

“Look at the clock.”

“You do not?”

“I look at the leaf.”

“The book needs minutes.”

“Write the minutes. And write with them that the minutes change when the temperature of the oil changes.”

Devkant checked the clock. When the first leaf came out, he wrote down the time. Then the second went in. This time the oil was hotter than before; the sound sharpened. Madhavi lowered the flame a little.

“See?” she said. “The clock is the same; the oil is not.”

Devkant wrote—“Time approximate; watch the heat of the oil.”

Madhavi looked at the page. “That is right.”

Janki held the bowl of batter; Hemlata did not heap the fried leaves one over another but spread them to one side so trapped steam would not soften them; Madhavi put leaves into the oil, turned them, lifted them out. The work had no single centre. The movement of one hand waited for another, then another hand took the place of the first.

It suddenly seemed to Devkant that listening to music by choosing one instrument and silencing all the rest would be wrong. The rhythm of this kitchen was like that too.

In the margin he wrote—"A method is not only ingredients and time; it is the coordination of hands."

Madhavi could not read it from where she stood. "What did you write?"

"I will show you later."

"A secret book?"

"The writer's privacy."

Madhavi replied at once, "Remember that tomorrow when you want to see my private pages."

Devkant paused, then laughed. "All right. I owe you that one."

One by one, the tilkor tarua accumulated on the plates. Its smell mingled with the steam of rice and dal, making a warm layer inside the kitchen in which the sharpness of oil, the green scent of the leaf, and the cooked batter were all present at once.

Some leaves had been almost identical in shape, yet after frying their colours differed. Some had crisper edges, some softer centres. Devkant tried to record every difference, then looked at the page and laughed at himself.

"What happened?" Madhavi asked.

"I will have written the biography of the tarua before I get to eat it."

Janki said, "Let the guests eat first. The book can fill your stomach later."



The guests arrived by the time of the morning meal. The courtyard was cleaned and water set out for washing hands and faces. Devkant went outside to receive them. Inside, the kitchen's rhythm was in its final phase. The rice was coming off the fire, a thin stream of ghee was being poured over the dal, bowls of curd were being arranged, and the tilkor tarua, after resting briefly on cloth, moved toward the plates.

As Madhavi looked over the pile of fried leaves, she separated the tarua made from the small leaf she had set aside in the basket that morning and placed it to one side. Hemlata noticed.

"Whose is that?" Hemlata asked softly.

Without looking at her, Madhavi said, "For a plate."

"Which plate?"

"Whichever has room."

Hemlata smiled, but asked nothing more.

The guests sat down. The meal was served: rice, dal, vegetables, curd, tilkor tarua. After the very first mouthful, one guest looked at the tarua and said, "This leaf tarua has turned out very well."

Janki heard from inside and smiled. Devkant began naturally, “The choosing of these leaves—” and stopped.

The guest asked, “Will your book include its method too?”

“It will,” Devkant said. “I am learning from Madhavi, Janki, and Hemlata. Madhavi knows the choosing of the leaves best.”

For a few moments there was silence inside. Madhavi perhaps heard; she did not come out. Janki only looked at Hemlata. Hemlata’s face held back a smile.

The guest asked again, “So a small leaf is better?”

Instead of answering, Devkant called toward the kitchen, “Madhavi, this question is yours.”

Madhavi came to the threshold but remained there. “Not merely small. The leaf should not be too hard, not too thin; it should not be torn. You have to look at the body of the leaf.”

“Then the book needs pictures,” the guest said.

Devkant brightened. “There could be pictures.”

Madhavi said, “Will a picture tell you how tender the leaf is?”

The guest laughed. “Then you must stay with the book too.”

Madhavi did not answer. She turned back inside. For a moment Devkant’s face held both laughter and discomfort. Madhavi staying with the book—the sentence sounded simple, yet within it questions of society, household, name, and future all woke at once.

The meal continued. The guests took second pieces of tarua. Devkant took nothing for himself; he remained busy serving, bringing water, and talking.

When the guests had finished, paan and betel nut were brought. Conversation continued for a while—repairs after the earthquake, roads, the market, paper and ink, the book. Then the guests went to the outer room to rest.

Now the household began to eat. Janki said, “Now sit down, Writer Babu. Writing will not keep you alive if you do not eat.”

Devkant sat. Rice, dal, and vegetables were placed on his plate. Hemlata came with the tray of tarua. She put down two ordinary pieces and was about to move on when Madhavi said from behind, “That small one too.”

Without saying anything, Hemlata put the separately kept small tarua on Devkant’s plate.

Devkant recognised the leaf. The same one Madhavi had set aside in the basket that morning. It had shrunk a little in frying, yet the full curve of its edge was still recognisable.

He looked toward Madhavi. She was serving dal onto Janki's plate. Her face showed nothing unusual.

Devkant broke off a small piece of the tarua and ate it. The edge was crisp, the leaf soft in the middle. Its taste was not so different from the others that it could be called miraculous. But the memory of its choosing entered the taste—the morning dew, Madhavi's fingers, “small alone does not mean good”—all returned at once.

Janki asked, “What are you staring at? Eat.”

Devkant smiled. “I am eating.”

Now Madhavi looked at him, just for a moment. Devkant wanted to ask—why was this leaf for me? But the question reached his tongue and stopped.

Some things become clear when asked; some things perhaps become smaller. This time he did not want to make it smaller.

He quietly ate the whole tarua.



By late afternoon the kitchen had fallen quiet. The vessels had been washed, the remaining food covered, the sounds of the courtyard softened. Devkant sat on the veranda with his notebook open. Madhavi was sorting the two or three tilkor leaves that remained—some for the evening, some to be left unused.

Devkant began to write. His first line was—“आज, tilkor tarua was made for the guests' morning meal.”

Madhavi saw the page from a distance. “The first word.”

Devkant read it aloud. “आज?”

Madhavi said nothing. She only looked at him.

Devkant laughed at himself. With his pen he struck through “आज” and wrote above it—“आइ.”

“Now?”

“Now the sentence has come home.”

“From one word?”

“Sometimes one word tells you where the speaker is standing.”

Devkant looked at the page. “Why did I write ‘आज’?”

“The language you read most enters your hand.”

“But I am writing Maithili.”

“Writing Maithili in Devanagari does not purify the hand by itself. You have to listen.”

Devkant turned the pen between his fingers. “Then will you keep watch over my language?”

Separating stems from the leaves, Madhavi said, “Not keep watch. If you ask, I will tell you. If you do not ask, the book is yours.”

“And if the book is not mine alone?”

Madhavi’s hand stopped for a moment. “You asked that question. You must find the answer too.”

Devkant wrote the next line: “Choosing the leaves: Madhavi, Hemlata. Batter: Janki. Frying: Madhavi, Janki, Hemlata—the work shifting by turns.”

Madhavi came closer and read. “By turns—that is right.”

Devkant said, “Three names in the place of ‘main cook.’”

“Was it necessary to find a main cook?”

“The book had that habit.”

“And now?”

“Now I am correcting the book a little.”

Madhavi did not turn the page; her gaze stayed on the line. “One thing is missing.”

“What?”

“Hemlata dried the leaves. If they remain wet, the batter will not cling properly.”

Devkant added—“Washing and drying the leaves: Hemlata.”

“And Janki put the oil on.”

He added that too.

“And you?” Madhavi asked.

“Me?”

“You were sitting in the way.”

Devkant burst out laughing. “Should I write that contribution?”

“Then the history will be complete.”

In small letters in the margin Devkant wrote—“Writer: no cooking contribution except blocking the way.”

Madhavi laughed so openly that Hemlata called from inside, “What happened?”

Madhavi answered, “History is being corrected.”

After a while the laughter subsided. Beneath the line Devkant added notes on the guests’ reactions, the temperature of the oil, the condition of the leaves, the thickness of the batter. Then his pen stopped. A question that had been lodged in his mind since morning was still there.

“Madhavi.”

“Hmm?”

“That small leaf...”

Without raising her head, Madhavi said, "What about it?"

"Why was it on my plate?"

She went on gathering the remaining leaves into one place. "Perhaps Hemlata put it there."

From inside Hemlata's voice came: "I was told to."

Madhavi said at once, "You mind your work."

Devkant could not hold back his laughter. "Then?"

Now Madhavi raised her head. "You wanted to write the differences among all the leaves. If you did not eat the best leaf, the book would remain incomplete."

"Only research?"

"You are writing a book. Do you need a book-like reason for everything?"

Devkant's laughter softened. "No."

"Then you ate it. The matter is finished."

Madhavi bent again over the leaves. But Devkant thought the corner of her mouth had lifted slightly. He could not be sure—and by now he was practising not asking for a fixed measure of everything.

In his notebook he wrote the final line—"आइ: choosing tilkor leaves, the coordination of hands, and the correction of words."

After writing "आइ," he deliberately held the pen still for a moment.

Madhavi saw. "This time it is right."

"The language?"

"The language too."

"And the rest?"

Madhavi did not answer. She picked up the remaining leaves and went inside.

Devkant did not close the page. A gust of air lifted one corner of the paper, then it settled again. Beneath the word "आइ" at the top, the day's food, the work of many hands, one small tarua, and one unspoken feeling stood together on the same page.

For the first time he understood clearly that correcting language did not mean merely striking out a wrong word; whose voice had been heard and whose hand had been named were also matters inside language.

He left a small blank space in the margin. Why, even he did not know.

Outside, the tilkor vine in the garden stirred slightly in the wind. Evening was beginning to descend inside the house.

CHAPTER 10

The Pond's Eye

Two days after the meal for the tilkor guests, Madhavi woke Devkant before dawn. The sky had not yet fully brightened. Only a pale yellow seam was opening in the east, and the night's dew still clung to the bricks of the courtyard.

"Shall we go see the pond?" Madhavi asked.

Devkant sat up, rubbing his eyes. "This early?"

"The pond takes on another form once the day rises. See the work of water in the morning."

There was less command in the sentence than rule. Devkant picked up his notebook. Madhavi glanced at it once, then said, "This time, not the page first. The eyes first."

The two of them left by the path behind the house. The village was still half asleep. Here, the faint bell from a cowshed; there, the first thin thread of smoke; elsewhere, the scrape of feet heading toward the water place. Dew glittered on the stubble of harvested paddy beside the path. A little farther on they met Ramanand, a long bamboo pole on his shoulder and, in his hand, a round, net-like implement woven from bamboo.

"This is Ramanand," Madhavi said. "He knows the pond better than paper does."

Ramanand laughed. "A pond never dries up on paper, does it?"

Devkant smiled. "Until now, paper has been what I understood better."

"Then today ask the water."

The pond lay a little beyond the edge of the village: old, broad, bounded on all sides by a raised bank. Ramanand pointed to one stretch of it. "In the rains, when the water climbs over this bhinda, even the path disappears." Devkant caught the word—bhinda. His hand moved toward the notebook, but Madhavi caught his eye. He stopped.

As soon as they climbed the bhinda, the whole spread of water opened before them. The surface was so still that the yellow eastern sky lay within it

like a second sky. Here were water-lily leaves, there the dried stalks of kumudini, elsewhere the blackened remains of thorny aquatic plants. In one distant corner the water was shallow; bird tracks marked the mud.

Devkant said softly, "Beautiful."

Ramanand did not look at him. "From above."

Those two words opened a crack behind Devkant's sentence.

At the pond steps Ramanand set his bamboo pole on the ground. "This is not the season for harvesting yet," he said. "The old makhana seed is at home. This is the time when the new crop grows. But when the harvest comes, this quiet water will not look like this."

For the first time Devkant understood that he had always seen makhana on a plate—in milk, in kheer, roasted in ghee, in a festival bowl—but had never thought that its first home was water.

Watching the surface of the pond, Madhavi asked, "What have you written about makhana in the pothi so far?"

Devkant tried to remember. "A prized festival food. Suitable for fasts. With milk and jaggery—"

Ramanand laughed and cut him short. "That is all? Not a line for the people who go down into the water?"

Devkant fell silent. This time he opened the notebook, but before writing the first line he looked at Ramanand. "You speak first."

Ramanand's smile faded a little. "That much is right."



Ramanand lifted the bamboo pole and planted it beside the pond. "When the seeds sink below, marks like these kara form. People go down into the water, reach the bottom, and gather the mud with their hands. You do not find the seed with your eyes. You find it with your palms."

Devkant asked, "That deep?"

"The depth changes from pond to pond. In some places it comes up to the body; in others it rises above the head. In some places the mud underfoot is so soft you can hardly stand. Elsewhere old thorns pierce the feet. While you hold your breath, your own body becomes the clock."

He raised the bamboo lattice. "With a tool like this—ganja—the mud is sieved. The seed is heavy and black; the mud separates away. But if a book says only 'the seed is collected,' half the body of the work disappears."

Madhavi asked, "And the other half?"

Ramanand held out his palm. Faint lines of old scratches, thickened skin, mud lodged beside the nails. "This."

Devkant kept looking at the palm without asking anything. In his mind was an old phrase from a Calcutta magazine—"Mithila's distinctive makhana." The sentence suddenly seemed very light. Too light to sink to the bottom of the water.

Ramanand said, "On harvesting days it is best to enter at dawn. The water is still. When there is too much wind on the surface, it becomes harder to judge direction below. One person does not go too far alone. Others remain nearby. People above keep watch—how many dives, how long, where someone went under and where he rose."

"Are you not afraid?" Devkant asked.

"At first you are. Later fear learns to live beside the work. If fear disappears, a person grows careless. If fear becomes too great, he cannot enter the water. You need a measure in between."

Madhavi looked at Devkant. "Like salt?"

Devkant laughed, though Ramanand did not understand. Madhavi said, "This writer-babu wants a measure for everything."

Ramanand's eyes lit up. "Will he write down the measure of breath?"

Devkant replied, "If you tell me."

"Write this: one person's breath is not another person's breath."

Devkant wrote it down at once.

Ramanand continued, "The thorns are not the same in every pond either. When old makhana leaves and stalks rot away, much remains below. Mud can get into the eyes, nose, ears. The white popped makhana you see above begins with the colour of this mud."

For a few moments the three of them were silent. A small bubble rose on the surface, made a round ring, and vanished.

Devkant wrote: "Makhana—a prized festival food." He left a little space after the old sentence and then added: "Before this sentence, it is necessary to write about water, mud, thorns, breath, and wages."

Madhavi read the page. "You will write the wages?"

"Yes."

For the first time Ramanand spoke in an entirely serious voice. "Then write the owner's share too."



As they walked toward the second landing of the pond, Ramanand told them that the pond was not his. There was no performance of grievance in the statement; he said it like a plain geographical fact. "I understand how the water moves, but the water is not mine. When the seed will be harvested, how many people will go down, how much they will be paid—the owner has the final say in all of that."

Devkant asked, "And when the seed is sold, do you receive a share of the price?"

Ramanand laughed, but this time there was no pleasure in it. "Wages are one thing, the goods another. What comes out through my hands belongs first to the pond. What price it brings in the market is another matter."

Madhavi stopped at the edge of the bank. "When the pothi says makhana is the pride of Mithila, whose share of that pride is it?"

Devkant's pen stopped in the air. "Everyone's?"

"When you say 'everyone,' no one's name survives," Madhavi said.

The sentence stung Devkant. He remembered the khichdi day after the earthquake—the need to ask not "whose food?" but "whose hands?" On the day of the tilkor he had written the names of the hands one by one. Yet his page on makhana was still little more than a description of what reached the plate.

Ramanand sat down on the bhinda. "The owner has work too," he added on his own. "Maintaining the pond, holding the water, bringing in labour, sending the goods to market. I am not saying he does nothing. But the work of the person who goes down into the water does not show on the plate."

Something eased inside Devkant. Ramanand was not making an accusation; he was asking for proportion. The same proportion needed in salt, the same proportion needed in writing names into a row.

"How much are the wages?" Devkant asked.

Ramanand thought for a moment. "The year, the pond, the stage of the harvest, the amount of seed—everything changes. If you write one number, your pothi will lie again. Write this: the labour of the first harvesting is not the same as the later harvesting; as the seed grows scarce, the searching increases."

Devkant laughed. "Now you too are saving me from measurement."

"Keep the measure, but write its limits."

Madhavi said, "Write that line in large letters."

Devkant wrote: "A number without its circumstances is incomplete."

Beside the pond, the shadow of an old tree was stretching long. The yellow light of dawn had turned white. The water was no longer as still as before; a light wind had risen. Water-lily leaves brushed against one another.

Madhavi bent down, lifted pond water into her palm, then let it fall. "Why does it seem so difficult to write the road by which something reaches the plate?"

Devkant said, "The plate is still. The road keeps changing."

"Then write the changing road."

Ramanand stood up. "And do not finish with me by writing 'makhana harvester.' I catch fish, mend nets, row boats, work in fields too. A person is not a one-word occupation."

Devkant's pen stopped again. He understood the weight of the sentence at once. The pothi was going on making categories—food, caste, occupation, festival, season. But life flowed between those compartments.

He wrote: "Ramanand: skilled in water-work; not fully described by the name of a single occupation."

Madhavi read the line and said, "Now it is right."

Devkant asked, "You always say 'right,' but never 'complete.'"

"If it were possible to write the complete thing, the pothi would be finished in a day."

Ramanand laughed. "And writer-babu would be unemployed."

All three laughed. Their laughter travelled across the open surface of the pond, floated a little way, and dissolved into the air.



When they returned home, the first thing Janki noticed was the mud on Ramanand's feet. "Did you go to see the pond, or bring the pond home?"

Ramanand laughed. "Half the pond came back in my shoes."

"Then not onto the veranda. Wash outside."

Hemlata ran to bring water. Madhavi looked at Devkant's notebook and asked, "Did the paper survive?"

"The paper survived. The writer's illusions got a little wet."

Janki heard from inside. "There is sunlight for drying illusions."

After noon Ramanand brought a small cloth pouch from home. Inside were black makhana seeds from the previous harvest. Devkant took one into his palm in surprise. It was nothing like the white, light makhana he was used to seeing on a plate. The seed was hard, dark, like a small stone.

"This?"

Ramanand said, "Inside this is the white lava you eat."

Hemlata shook the seed beside her ear. "It makes no sound."

"It will when it bursts."

Janki said, "These are old seeds; they will not all pop the same. Just watch. When the new crop comes, you will get better material."

A small fire was lit outside the veranda. A thick, flat iron vessel was set over it. Ramanand demonstrated how the seeds were heated. Again and again he said, "The fire must be neither too fierce nor too low. The heat has to reach the inside of the seed."

Devkant bent to write. Madhavi said, "Watch first."

He closed the notebook again.

The heated seeds were taken out. Ramanand picked up a small wooden striking tool. He placed one seed in position and gave it a sharp, measured blow. "Tak!" The black shell split; white makhana bloomed from inside. Hemlata clapped without thinking.

A second seed burst—tak! The third only cracked and did not open fully. Ramanand set it aside. "They are not all the same."

Devkant's eyes stayed on the transformation. A black, hard seed; one blow; a white, light form opening from within. All the work between those moments—drying, heat, timing, the practice of the hand, the measure of the blow—vanished once it reached the plate.

Madhavi asked, "What will you write in the pothi now?"

Devkant said, "Makhana turns white through fire."

Ramanand shook his head. "Wrong."

"Why?"

"Fire is not one thing. Too much and it burns; too little and it will not pop. The blow of the hand, the timing, the condition of the seed—everything matters."

Madhavi laughed softly. "The lesson of salt again."

Devkant laughed too. "Why does every lesson come back to salt?"

From inside Janki called, "Because without salt everything is bland."

Hemlata laughed again.

After a while a small pile of white makhana had formed on the veranda. Not much—two handfuls. Some were half-popped, some opened fully. Ramanand placed one perfectly popped makhana in Devkant's palm.

"Now it is light," he said. "But write what was heavy behind its lightness."

Devkant put the makhana in his mouth. The crunch was very slight; the flavour plain. But the morning pond, the mud, the bhinda, the kara, the

ganja, the breath held in the body, the owner's rights, the uncertainty of wages, the heat of fire, the blow of the hand—all stood at once behind that light taste.

He opened the notebook. His first line was: "Makhana—a prized festival food."

Then he drew a straight line through that sentence.

Madhavi asked, "You crossed it out?"

"No. I will not leave it standing alone."

Below it he wrote: "Makhana: a food that reaches the plate after pond, water-labour, mud, thorns, breath, sorting, heat, blows, and many hands. Its prestige at festivals must not erase that road."

Devkant could not tell whether Ramanand could not read the page or simply did not read it. He only asked, "My name?"

Devkant wrote below the passage: "Ramanand's account and demonstrated work."

"The owner's?"

"I will write that too."

"The wages?"

"Not as a single number. With the circumstances."

Ramanand smiled. "Now it is beginning to sound a little like a pothi."

Madhavi looked at Devkant. "Like a pothi, or like life?"

Ramanand answered, "Life will never fit wholly into a pothi. But whatever you fit into it, do not twist it."

Devkant made a small mark beside the sentence. He understood: this was not merely a rule for the page on makhana.

By evening the little pile of white makhana had been placed on a plate. Hemlata stole two and ate them; Janki saw and pretended not to. Madhavi broke one in half and placed half before Devkant.

"Research this time?" Devkant asked.

"No. Hunger."

They both laughed.

Darkness began to fall outside. The pond could no longer be seen from the house, but its water remained on Devkant's page. At the centre of that page was not the white makhana, but the memory of the black seed.

He understood: some things tell the least truth in their final form. Their truth lies in the road they have travelled.

CHAPTER 11

Steam

On the third morning after the day at the pond, Janki had placed a mound of rice flour at one side of the courtyard. When the light fell on it, it gleamed like fine dust. Beside it lay soaked dal, which Madhavi was preparing to grind for the filling. Devkant sat on the veranda, rereading the previous day's page on makhana.

Janki said, "You've finished writing about the pond; now write about steam. Keep an account of what cooks above water too."

Devkant closed the notebook. "What are we making?"

Without looking up, Madhavi said, "Bagiya."

"I've heard the name."

"Does hearing the name make it by itself?"

Hemlata laughed. "Writer Babu will make it first, then he'll write about it."

Devkant had not expected this proposal. He looked at Madhavi. "Me?"

"Yes. We've argued enough about measuring salt. Now see how the hand measures."

The water was not added to the rice flour all at once. Madhavi poured in a little at a time while Janki turned the flour with two fingers. When Devkant reached for his notebook, Madhavi stopped him. "First see how much water the flour asks for."

Devkant said, "So again it's the same thing—no exact measure?"

Janki replied, "See what the rice was like, how finely it was ground, how warm the water is—all of it. Measure afterwards."

Half amusement and half defeat appeared on Devkant's face. "Salt, makhana, now rice flour. Everything runs away from measurement when I come near it."

Madhavi said, "The things aren't running away. You reach for measurement first and the thing itself afterwards."

Janki laughed at that. "Are we making a pothi or a correction-house for you?"

The mood in the kitchen lightened. The dal had been ground and was ready. Madhavi mixed salt into the filling, added a little spice, and turned it again by hand. Devkant asked, "What's in this?"

Madhavi straightened up. "A list again!"

"Without a list, what will the reader understand?"

"First the reader will understand that bagiya isn't empty inside. The names of the ingredients can come later."

Janki placed a small ball of rice dough before Devkant. "Go on. You've washed your hands?"

"Yes."

"Then spread this on your palm. Put the filling in the middle. Then close the mouth."

Devkant spread the dough with great care. The rim was thick in one place, thin in another. Madhavi glanced at it and said nothing. Devkant put in the filling and tried to join the two sides. The dough split in the middle.

Hemlata immediately said, "It has told us what's inside it before it even reached the steam."

Janki pretended to scold her, but could not suppress her laughter.

Devkant sat holding the torn bagiya. "Can this be saved?"

Madhavi took the bagiya from his hand. She pinched off a little dough, patched the torn place, pressed the seam with her fingers, then rolled it gently in her palm. "It can be saved. But the more filling you put in, the more carefully you have to close it."

"Should I write that rule in the pothi?"

"For bagiya or for human beings?"

Devkant kept looking at her. There was a faint smile on Madhavi's face, but her eyes were direct. Instead of answering, he took another ball of dough into his hand.

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The second time Devkant spread the dough a little less. He used a little less filling too. This time he managed to close the edges, but the shape was crooked.

"From the outside this doesn't look like a bagiya; it looks like a wounded moon," Hemlata said.

Devkant said, "Is its shape going to be examined when we eat it?"

Madhavi replied, "The steam will tell us. Wherever the seam is weak, it will open."

Devkant's hand stopped. "You were going to say that a smooth outside doesn't prove it will stay closed inside—is that it?"

Madhavi looked slightly startled. "I didn't say such a long sentence."

"But that's what it means."

"The meaning is yours. The bagiya is mine."

Devkant laughed. "Fine. I'll write in the pothi: 'Madhavi: test the seam not by its outward appearance but by the pressure inside.'"

Still kneading the dough, Madhavi said, "If you write my name, write what I said. Don't put the weight of your thought on my head."

It was said casually, yet something settled inside Devkant. Over the past several days he had heard the same rule in different forms—whether it concerned the household belief about kurthi, the labour behind makhana, or the leaves of tilkor. Whoever said it, write that person's name; write only as much as was said; do not fill in what was not said from your own mind.

He opened the notebook and wrote: "Madhavi said: if the seam is weak, it will open in the steam." Beneath it, on a separate line, he wrote: "My thought: outward smoothness is not proof of an inner seal."

Madhavi read the page. "Now the two things are in two different places."

"That's enough?"

"That's already a great deal."

Meanwhile Janki had made ten bagiyas. In her hands the dough-ball turned, spread, filled and closed so effortlessly that Devkant laughed again at his first failure.

He asked, "Didn't your first bagiya ever split?"

Janki said, "Was I born knowing how?"

"Then?"

"It split. The filling came out. Mother said, 'Eat this one and make another.' The first rule of learning a task is that a spoiled dish does not always have to be thrown away."

Madhavi interjected, "And the second rule: don't save a spoiled dish by calling it 'tradition.'"

Janki looked at her for a moment, then burst out laughing. "Steam never settles on your tongue!"

Devkant lifted his pen to write the sentence down.

Madhavi immediately said, "Don't write that."

"Why?"

"Because that's laughter from inside the house, not a rule for the pothi."

Devkant stopped his pen. "Will the laughter of the house not remain in the pothi?"

Janki said, "It will. But not every laugh is meant for print."

The boundary interested Devkant. The kitchen was editing not only the method of cooking, but also deciding whose words would become public and whose would remain private.

Madhavi kept placing the bagiyas she made to one side. Devkant's three stood apart—one torn and repaired, one crooked, one surprisingly good.

Hemlata said, "Give all three names—first, second, third."

Devkant laughed. "This time the authorship is clear."

Madhavi said softly, "Authorship is recognised by the hand, not by the shape."

Devkant's laughter faded a little. He wrote the sentence in the margin.



It was time to put the bagiyas into the steam. The moment the lid was lifted from the steaming vessel, a white cloud like hot smoke touched their faces and vanished. Devkant immediately checked the time on his watch.

Madhavi asked, "What are you doing?"

"Writing down the time. How long will they take to cook?"

"Will the clock cook them?"

"The reader needs a time."

"Write the time. But time isn't alone."

The familiar irritation from the day of the salt appeared on Devkant's face. "Again?"

Janki said, "How strong the steam is, whether the bagiya is thick or thin, how much filling there is, how full the vessel is—all of that changes it."

Devkant wrote: "Time: not fixed."

Madhavi laughed. "If you write only that, the reader will eat it raw."

"Then what should I write?"

Madhavi lifted the lid slightly and steam escaped. She brought her nose close enough to catch the smell, then pressed the body of one bagiya lightly with the tip of a finger. "First the smell changes. The smell of raw rice flour diminishes. The body firms a little. The moisture on the surface changes. Take one out and cut it open—the flour inside should no longer be raw."

Devkant began writing quickly.

Madhavi said, "Not all of it at once. Look first."

He stopped his pen again.

Steam slipped out around the edges of the vessel. By the time it reached the roof its form had vanished, but the smell remained. The warm smell of rice mingled with the aroma of the dal filling. Devkant was surprised that he could recognise the change in smell before looking at the clock.

"Now?" he asked.

"A little longer."

"How much is 'a little'?"

Madhavi looked at him. "Why is your pothi so afraid of 'a little'?"

"Because 'a little' means something different to everyone."

"Then write that the meaning of 'a little' has to be learned."

Janki said, "The hand learns by doing. A book cannot take the place of a hand."

Devkant replied, "But what will people far away learn without a book?"

Madhavi said, "People far away will at least learn that they cannot learn everything from a book."

For a moment the kitchen was quiet. A crow cawed in the courtyard outside. Janki drew Hemlata's hand back so that she would not put her fingers into the steam escaping beside the lid.

A little later Madhavi took out one bagiya. It was the crooked one Devkant had made. She cut it through the middle. The rice dough inside was still slightly sticky.

"Not yet," Madhavi said.

Devkant checked his watch. He wrote down the time, then crossed it out.

"Why did you cross it out?"

"Because this wasn't the cooking time; this was the time at which we found it raw."

Pleasure showed on Madhavi's face. "Now the pothi is learning."

The next bagiya they took out was properly cooked. Devkant only looked at the surface without touching it. Madhavi did not take his hand; she merely said, "With the tip of your finger. Not hard."

Devkant pressed lightly. The surface was soft but no longer sticky. He smelled it. The sharp rawness of the rice flour was gone.

"Now write," Madhavi said.

Devkant wrote: "The clock assists; the decision comes from smell, touch, steam and the condition inside."

Janki could not read the page, so Devkant read it aloud to her. She nodded. "Add one more line: hot things can burn the hand. Don't be foolish in the name of experience."

Hemlata laughed. "That rule is for Writer Babu."

Devkant wrote: "Caution."

Madhavi said, "That word is right."

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It was still some time before the midday meal. The first batch of bagiyas came off the steam, but Janki said everyone in the house would eat later. Hemlata had grown hungry while working. She looked at one bagiya in a way Janki immediately understood.

"Eat the broken one first," Janki said. "This isn't a dish for guests; this is practice for the house."

Madhavi picked up Devkant's first bagiya, the one that had split and been repaired. "This belongs to Writer Babu."

Devkant said, "You saved the torn part. Half the authorship is yours."

"Authorship again?"

"Fine—labour."

Madhavi broke the bagiya in two. Steam still rose from inside. She placed one half in Devkant's hand and kept the other for herself.

Devkant paused. There was no formal meal-line in the house; no plate, no order of serving, no guest's place. In a corner of the veranda, in the midst of work, two people stood holding two halves of the same bagiya. It was a small scene, but its very smallness felt unusual to Devkant.

Madhavi took the first bite. "Eat. The taste will change when it cools."

Devkant ate too. The rice dough was soft, the dal inside richer in taste. A little of the filling had come out through the repaired tear, making the edge taste saltier.

"Bad?" Madhavi asked.

"No."

"Beautiful?"

Devkant thought. "No."

Madhavi laughed. "Then?"

"Fit to eat, and fit to remember."

"Two different qualities?"

"Yes. Not everything beautiful is remembered, and not everything remembered is beautiful."

Madhavi's laughter softened. "Will you write that in the pothi?"

Devkant said, "Perhaps that belongs outside the pothi."

"Then good."

In that 'good,' Devkant heard something that was not an explicit word. Like the small tilkor leaf; like half a makhana; and now half a bagiya. In these small divisions of food, something was growing that he could not measure or write down.

From a distance Hemlata called, "Half for me too!"

Madhavi gave her the remaining piece of her half-bagiya. "Here, otherwise history will record that you were kept hungry."

Hemlata made a face. "I'll write my own history."

Devkant's hand moved instinctively toward the notebook, then stopped.

Madhavi noticed. "Why didn't you write it?"

"Because those are her words. If they are to be written, I should ask her."

Hemlata said proudly, "Ask."

"Shall I write it?"

"Write: Hemlata said, 'I will write my own history.'"

Devkant wrote it, and wrote her full name.

Madhavi looked at the page. A kind of quiet settled on her face that Devkant had rarely seen before.

When the midday meal was served, the bagiyas were arranged neatly on the plate. The good bagiya Devkant had made was among them. Janki recognised it.

"Who made this one?" a guest asked.

Janki answered simply, "Devkant made this one with his own hands; Madhavi taught him."

For the first time Devkant felt how clearly the credit for one dish could be stated in two short sentences. Neither his hand disappeared, nor Madhavi's teaching.

He looked at the plate. The filling was hidden inside the smooth body of the bagiya, but being invisible did not make it absent.

That night Devkant opened the pothi and wrote his final note for the day: "Steam cooks a thing, but does not erase the filling inside. A good seam holds it in; a weak seam opens."

He paused. Beneath it he wrote: "There is a temptation to apply this metaphor to human relationships. Not yet."

Madhavi's rule remained in his mind: do not put the burden of your thought on someone else's head.

He closed the page. Night had fallen outside. No visible shape remained of the steam that had risen all day in the kitchen, but the smell of rice and dal still clung faintly to the walls.

Devkant understood that some things are like steam. They rise before the eyes and vanish; yet whatever they touch, they leave slightly changed.

CHAPTER 12

The Fish Bone

That morning the market was full of the air of the ponds. After the light rain in the night, the mud of the unpaved road was still soft, and the farther one went into the market, the more the smells of vegetables, leaves, oil, paddy, curd, and fish mingled with one another. Nasima was with Madhavi. Devkant followed with his notebook, but the experience of the past few weeks had taught him that the pen did not always need to be opened first.

Nasima stopped before a basket. Small fish glimmered inside. She said, "Pothi."

Devkant bent closer. "Are they all Pothi?"

Nasima laughed. "Opening the book already? Open your eyes first."

Madhavi joined in her laughter. "The question is right, but you'll find the answer by looking."

Nasima rested a hand on the side of the basket. "Small fish have many names. Pothi is one thing, Kabai another, Garai another. If you give them all one name just because they're small, the women in the market will laugh when they read your book."

Devkant opened the notebook and wrote only three names—Pothi, Kabai, Garai. Then he stopped his pen.

"And Rohu, Naini, Bhakur?" he asked.

Nasima pointed to the larger fish laid out in another row. "Those are the big fish. What a household likes, when it will be eaten, the price, how many people there are—all of that shapes what gets bought. Small fish taste different; large fish taste different. Write this much: a name is not only a matter of size. It is also an identity."

Madhavi asked the fish-seller seated beside one basket for the price. The woman answered, then Nasima picked up two fish and examined them separately. One was still twitching; the other lay still. She asked the seller a few questions—how long ago they had been caught, from which pond, whether

the water had been changed. The manner was that of a transaction, but water, time, distance, and price were all bound into it.

Devkant asked, "How do you know if it's fresh?"

Before answering, Nasima looked at Madhavi. "Looking for a bookish answer to that question?"

Devkant replied at once, "No. Only as much as you know."

Showing him the fish, Nasima said, "Smell, sheen, how firm or soft the body is, the eyes, and what the seller says—we look at all of it. But the biggest thing is trust. What someone says matters too when you buy from that person every day."

Madhavi added, "And what the pond is like, what the weather is like—those too."

Devkant wrote: 'Buying fish is not only a matter of looking at the fish; it means looking at water, time, trust, price, and the household's need.'

Nasima could not read the page, so Devkant read it aloud. She said, "Good. But don't just write the price—today it rises and falls. Someone reading this page tomorrow shouldn't think today's price will remain forever."

Devkant laughed. "Does the market write history too?"

"The market writes every day," Nasima said. "The only difference is that its paper is torn by evening."

At that sentence Madhavi fell silent. Devkant looked at her face. Amid the smell of fish, raw earth, and the noise of the morning market, the phrase 'paper torn by evening' suddenly reminded him of the mortality of his own book.

Nasima had Kabai and some Pothi set aside and settled the price. "What will be made at home?" Devkant asked.

Madhavi said, "First let us reach home. A fish doesn't decide in the market what is going to happen to it."

Nasima laughed again. "Be sure to put that in the book. People change too once they reach home."

Devkant lifted his pen. Madhavi saw his hand and said, "That is Nasima's line."

"With her name," Devkant replied, and wrote Nasima's name.



The moment they reached home, the fish ceased to be ordinary ingredients of the kitchen. For whom they would be cooked, in which vessel, where they would be cleaned, who ate fish on which days and who did not—small rules

awoke all at once. Devkant was more careful this time. Instead of writing 'Fish Rules of Mithila,' he opened a separate page and wrote at the top: 'Rules of This Household.'

Janki looked at the page. "This time you've written it properly."

Devkant smiled. "I'm improving."

"Don't be proud in such a hurry," Madhavi said.

The Kabai were set apart. The Pothi were small, and cleaning them demanded greater patience. Hemlata sat down eagerly at first, but after a while she wanted to get up and escape. Janki said, "Small fish are good to eat; cleaning them needs patience."

Devkant asked, ready to make a note, "Do small fish have more bones?"

Madhavi said, "Bones and scales depend on the species. Don't write the same thing about every small fish."

Devkant nodded. "Right."

Janki's eye fell on him. "Will nodding make you remember?"

"I'm writing it in the book."

"The book forgets; the tongue remembers," Janki said.

Nasima was still with them. As she washed the fish, she was telling Madhavi something that had happened in the market. Their laughter rose now and then. Devkant noticed that knowledge of food did not move only in the form of questions and answers; stories, jokes, prices, seasons, and household habits all moved with it.

After a while, an elderly man who was like a father to Shashibhushan came to the kitchen doorway and asked, "Fish today?"

Janki answered, "Yes, but not for everyone."

The man asked for himself, "Will it be jhor or bhujia?"

Janki said, "You'll see when it reaches your plate."

Devkant asked Madhavi quietly, "Who in the household doesn't eat fish?"

Instead of answering for them, Madhavi said, "Ask the person who doesn't eat it why they don't. If I answer in their place, we'll be making the same mistake again."

Devkant accepted that at once. He marked a note to ask the different people later.

Janki said, "Some people don't eat it on fasting days, some because of their own observance, some because of their bodies, some because they simply don't like it. The rules are not all the same."

Devkant wrote: 'Reasons for abstaining differ; ask the individual.'

Madhavi looked at the page. "Now that is useful."

Mustard oil heated in the kitchen. The smell of spices rose. The moment the fish went into the pot, the sound changed. Devkant moved a little closer.

Janki stopped him. "Not so close. The oil will spit."

Hemlata said, "While writing history, you ought to keep your eyes as well."

Devkant stepped back. "Today everyone is saving me."

Devkant laughed. "Today everyone is saving me."

Nasima laughed and said, "In a kitchen, everyone has eyes."

The kitchen filled with laughter again. But the title on Devkant's page remained clear: 'Rules of This Household.' In that small change, he could sense the book slowly ceasing to be a book that pronounced judgment upon Mithila and becoming instead one that listened to Mithila's many voices.



The midday row formed. Beside the rice on Devkant's plate came fish jhor. He was turning over the market notes, the household rules, and Nasima's laughter in his mind. Perhaps for that reason, he began eating faster than usual.

Madhavi sat two places away. Janki was serving. Hemlata was delighted by the Pothi on her plate.

Devkant took one mouthful, then a second, then a third. Suddenly he felt something catch near his throat. He coughed.

Janki turned at once. "What happened?"

Devkant tried to speak. "A bo—"

Hemlata cried out, "A bone!"

Everyone in the courtyard looked at him at once. Devkant looked embarrassed and uncomfortable. Madhavi rose and came nearer, but she did not panic.

"Don't force it down," she said. "How badly is it stuck?"

Devkant took a small sip of water, then coughed gently. The bone had not gone very deep; after a few careful attempts, it came out.

Hemlata let out a breath of relief. "History has been saved."

Nasima, who had not yet gone home, burst out laughing. "Write this in the book—the bone of a fish can stop the writer."

Devkant laughed, touching his throat, though his eyes were watering. "This is an empirical truth."

With a serious face Madhavi asked, "A folk saying—verification pending?"

At that, the whole row filled with laughter. Janki too smiled and said, "Now eat slowly."

Devkant placed the bone at one side of his plate. For a while he kept looking at it. Small, almost invisible—and yet for a moment it had stopped the entire meal.

As she sat back down, Madhavi said, "Eating fish is not only about taste. You have to understand the bones too."

Devkant replied, "That could become a metaphor."

"Another metaphor?"

"This time on my own page, not on your head."

A faint smile appeared on Madhavi's face.

Devkant began eating again, slowly. Now every mouthful carried attention along with taste. The flavour of the jhor, the sharpness of mustard, the tender flesh of the fish, and now and then a bone—each became a distinct experience.

Hemlata asked, "Writer Babu, do you like fish now, or are you afraid of it?"

Devkant said, "Both."

"The same taste can be good and frightening at once?"

Madhavi said, "When something has bones inside it, that isn't difficult."

Devkant looked at her. For a moment they were both silent. The tilkor leaf, the filling inside the bagiya, and now the fish bone—food kept teaching him things that it would perhaps be hasty to force into direct sentences.

When the meal ended, instead of throwing the bone away, Devkant made a small sketch of it on the paper. Beneath it he wrote: 'Whoever writes only the taste will leave out the bone.'

Madhavi looked at the page. "Keep that sentence."

"Your approval?"

"This time, yes."



That evening Devkant was putting the day's notes in order. The market page, the household rules, the sketch of the bone—all were arranged in sequence. As he wrote, a neat little English sentence came to him. He wrote: 'Maithils love fish.'

He liked the sentence. It was short, memorable, useful for an article. He had just underlined it when Madhavi came onto the veranda carrying the kitchen accounts.

"What have you written?"

Devkant translated it aloud: "Maithils like fish."

Without sitting down, Madhavi asked, "All of them?"

Devkant paused. "Many people."

"Then why 'all Maithils'?"

"The sentence is short."

"To make a sentence short, will you make people disappear?"

Devkant fell silent.

Madhavi looked at the words he had written earlier on the page: 'Rules of This Household.' "At noon you wrote that every household is not the same. Have you forgotten by evening?"

Devkant rolled the pen between his fingers. "In an article one has to say general things."

"Then say a general thing. But don't make it general by throwing out everyone it doesn't apply to."

Devkant remembered the sentence from the day of the tilkor: 'Write down what remained outside the plate too.'

Madhavi went on, "Many Maithils eat fish. But what about those who don't? Those who don't eat it on fasting days? Those who can't afford it? Those who live beside a pond but don't own the fish? Those who catch fish but have little left for their own homes after selling it? One sentence will swallow them all."

'One sentence will swallow them all'—the phrase stung Devkant. He crossed out the English sentence.

"Then what should I write?"

Madhavi said, "Only as much as you've seen. Write: 'In many households of Mithila, fish is a favoured food; its forms, rules, and access vary from household to household.' Then give examples."

Devkant wrote it down. After a while he asked, "Is that your sentence or mine?"

Madhavi said, "The idea came from our argument. The words are yours. Write it that way."

In the margin Devkant wrote: 'Revised after Madhavi's objection.'

Madhavi looked at it. "Was that note necessary?"

"It was. Otherwise tomorrow I'll think I understood this much from the beginning."

Madhavi's face softened. "Keep that note."

The night deepened. The vessels in the courtyard had been washed and turned upside down. A faint smell of fish lingered in the kitchen. As Devkant gathered his notes, he wrote one more line: 'Uniform sentences are easy to write; human beings are not uniform.'

He stopped his pen. Madhavi was still on the other side of the veranda, adding up the accounts.

Devkant asked, "Under your name today—how many things were written?"

Madhavi looked up.

Madhavi counted. "Nasima in the market. Janki in the household rules. The experience of the bone is yours. The argument over generalisation belongs to both of us."

"And the people who cooked the meal?"

"On that page, have you written down whose hands were involved?"

Devkant turned the pages. Some names were there, but not all. He fell silent.

Madhavi said, "Bones are not found only in fish."

Devkant looked at her. "Should I write that sentence under your name?"

Madhavi smiled a little. "Not yet. Understand it first."

Devkant did not write it. He placed a small dot at one edge of the blank page—a mark to remember.

That night he understood that the hardest task in the book was not writing taste, but writing limits—how far a person's experience extended, where a name was needed, and how many different lives entered a single word when one said 'Mithila.'

The fish bone had come out of his throat. But its lesson remained caught in the page.

CHAPTER 13

Letters

Two days after the day of the fish bone, the kitchen was quiet in the afternoon. Janki had gone to look over the grain accounts, and Hemlata was playing with the neighbourhood children on the far side of the courtyard. On the veranda, Devkant sat with pages of the pothi spread before him. Along the margin of one page ran Madhavi's fine Tirhuta hand, whose meaning he was trying to make out by guesswork.

Madhavi set down a lota filled with water and came to stand behind him. "What are you reading?"

Without looking up, Devkant said, "I'm not reading. I'm trying to understand."

"There is a difference between the two."

Now Devkant looked up. "That is why you must teach me."

Madhavi was quiet for a moment. "Tirhuta?"

"Yes. At least enough that I don't have to ask you every time what you've written in the margins."

Madhavi picked up the page and looked at it. "Not everything in the margins belongs to the pothi."

"Then teach me to read what does belong to the pothi."

Madhavi sat down beside a pillar of the veranda. She took Devkant's pen, drew a blank sheet towards herself, and wrote the first letter. A line formed on the paper, but Devkant studied it several times before trying to copy it.

"Why are you so afraid?" Madhavi asked.

"Because if I write it wrong, you'll laugh."

"I will. But then I'll teach you to write it correctly too."

Devkant laughed. He copied the letter. Its form was misshapen. Madhavi pulled his sheet towards herself and wrote it again beside his attempt.

"Now see the difference."

Devkant looked from one letter to the other. "Why does mine look as though it's about to fall over?"

“Because you keep stopping your hand. Writing moves like breath; if you stop to think at every point, the body stiffens.”

Devkant tried again. This time Madhavi did not take hold of his fingers; she only placed one finger beside the paper and showed him the movement. Their hands were close. Devkant’s attention was on the letter, yet for an instant he became aware that Madhavi’s finger was barely a finger’s breadth away. There was a kind of caution in that distance that felt more difficult than a badly formed letter.

Madhavi said, “Keep your attention on the paper.”

Devkant started, then laughed. “It is.”

“What is?”

“My attention.”

“Then write.”

He wrote the second letter, then the third. Madhavi examined each form and, wherever there was a mistake, made a fresh copy. She spoke the sound; Devkant wrote its Tirhuta form.

After a while Madhavi said, “Now try writing ‘paat’.”

Devkant wrote it slowly. When the word was complete, Madhavi looked at the page.

“It can be read,” she said.

“That’s all the praise I get?”

“If I call it beautiful on the first day, you’ll stop practising on the second.”

“Then ‘it can be read’ is very high praise.”

Madhavi laughed. “You have understood correctly.”

At the top of the sheet Devkant wrote ‘पात’ in small Devanagari letters, with the Tirhuta exercise beneath it. Madhavi immediately drew a small pencil line beside the Devanagari word.

“What’s that?”

“The Devanagari is a support here. Tomorrow we’ll cover the support and you will read without it.”

“An examination?”

“You are setting out to make a book. Afraid of an examination in two letters?”

Devkant folded the sheet and set it aside. “No. But the teacher is severe.”

In an even voice Madhavi said, “Not teacher. Someone who knows is teaching. Keep the name exactly as it is.”

Devkant's smile faded a little. Within that sentence he heard all their earlier arguments—the name of the knower, the name of the worker, the name attached to a statement.

At the top of the page he wrote: 'Tirhuta—first lesson from Madhavi.'
Madhavi read it. "Now it is right."



The work of learning Tirhuta continued for two or three afternoons. Devkant was still slow, but he had begun to recognise many of the small words in the margins. One day he placed before Madhavi a draft being prepared for printing and said, "There is one difficult matter."

Madhavi asked, "With the letters?"

"Not with the letters—with the printing."

He showed her a page transcribed into Devanagari. "The people at the press can read Devanagari easily. Type is easier to obtain too. If the whole pothi remains in Tirhuta, printing will be difficult."

Madhavi studied the page without answering at once. Then she asked, "Easier for whom?"

Devkant said, "For the people at the press. For readers too—many people read Devanagari."

"Many people. But what about those who read Tirhuta?"

"They will be able to read it, but the printed pothi should reach everyone."

Madhavi sat with her hands resting on her knees. "My maternal grandmother's old account pages are in Tirhuta. If the people at the press cannot read those pages, is that the fault of the pages?"

"Not a fault. A difficulty."

"Whose difficulty?"

"Mine. The printer's. The reader's."

"Then solve the difficulty. Don't erase the letters."

Devkant grew a little impatient. "I'm not erasing them. I'm transcribing them into Devanagari."

"Are transcribing and changing the same thing?"

"If the words remain the same?"

Madhavi lifted a page on which she had earlier written a small note. "Fine, transcribe it into Devanagari. But where will the original page be?"

"At home."

"Then the reader of the printed book will assume the original was in Devanagari."

Devkant did not answer.

Madhavi continued, “Just as you record Nasima’s words with her name, let the name of the script remain too. Write: ‘Original in Tirhuta.’ At least the reader will know that what they are reading is a transcription.”

Devkant picked up his pen. “That can be done.”

“And some pages in the original form?”

“Printing them will be difficult.”

“Not all. Some.”

“How many?”

“Wherever the letters themselves are part of the meaning.”

Devkant smiled. “How can the letters themselves be part of the meaning?”

Madhavi said, “Where the writer wants the reader to see the hand. Where there is a signature. Where there is a note in the margin. Where, after you put it into Devanagari, the words remain but the hand disappears.”

The argument stopped Devkant. For the first time he understood that handwriting was not merely a vehicle carrying language; the movement of the hand, the pressure of the ink, the choice of where to write—all of these said something too.

At the top of the draft he wrote: ‘Original script significant. Consider retaining selected pages in their original form.’

Madhavi looked at the page. “Consider?”

Devkant laughed. “Do you want every decision made this very moment?”

“No. But a great many things die later beneath the word ‘consider’.”

Devkant moved his pen again. ‘Selected pages will be retained in their original form.’

A faint satisfaction appeared on Madhavi’s face.

Devkant said, “And with the Devanagari transcription of the remaining pages, I’ll write ‘Original in Tirhuta.’”

“Good.”

“This is a half-compromise.”

“Why half?”

“Because you wanted everything in Tirhuta.”

Madhavi shook her head. “I want the letters preserved. I don’t want fewer readers. If both can be preserved, that is better.”

Devkant looked at her. “You are more of an editor than I am.”

Madhavi laughed. “Don’t call me an editor and then put all the work under your own name.”

“Do I need that warning every day?”

“As many days as you need it.”

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One evening that week, Madhavi set aside some pages from the pothi. Devkant noticed that they carried more Tirhuta writing than the others. By habit he reached towards them, but Madhavi pulled the pages back to her side.

“Which section are these from?” Devkant asked.

“They don’t all belong to the pothi.”

“Then?”

“Some are household accounts, some are things my nani wrote, some are my own notes.”

“I can’t even look at them?”

Madhavi looked straight into his eyes. “No.”

For an instant irritation rose in Devkant. Over the past months he had watched so much of Madhavi’s knowledge pass into his pages that, without realising it, he had begun to feel that wherever there was knowledge, his questions had a right to reach it. Madhavi’s single ‘no’ made that boundary clear.

Devkant said quietly, “What if some of it is material for the pothi?”

“Whatever belongs to the pothi, I will give you.”

“And how will I know that nothing is being left out?”

“You won’t.”

The answer was not harsh; merely direct.

Madhavi continued, “You are the author of the pothi, not my owner. What I choose to share is your source. The rest of the pages remain with me.”

A little heat rose to Devkant’s face. He wanted to object—to the word ‘author,’ to the word ‘owner,’ perhaps to what she seemed to imply about his intentions. But all their arguments of the past days came back together: Nasima’s words, Ramanand’s labour, Hemlata’s ‘I will write my own history,’ and Madhavi’s rule—do not place the burden of your own ideas on someone else’s head.

He drew his hand back. “All right.”

Madhavi had perhaps not expected such ready acceptance. “All right?”

“Yes. But one request.”

“What?”

“Mark the pages that belong to the pothi and the pages that are private differently. Otherwise there will be confusion later.”

Madhavi thought about it. “That is fair.”

She took a small piece of paper and devised two marks for the corners of the pages: a simple dot for shared pages belonging to the pothi, and the shape of a small leaf for private pages.

Devkant smiled. "A leaf again?"

"Paat means paper, and paat means a leaf of a tree too. The mark will be easy to remember."

"A tilkor leaf?"

Madhavi laughed. "Don't add so much story to it. Just a leaf."

On the corner of a private page she drew a very small leaf. Devkant watched carefully, but did not copy it.

"I should not reproduce this mark in my transcription?"

"No. It marks the boundary of this page."

"What if I need a reference while preparing the pothi?"

"Ask me."

"And if you are not here?"

The moment the question left his mouth, the atmosphere changed. Madhavi's hand paused.

"Why would I not be here?"

Devkant said quickly, "I meant it generally."

"General things are not always general."

They were both silent for a while. Hemlata's laughter drifted from far across the courtyard.

Devkant said softly, "All right. If the need ever arises, I will write only as far as the sources available to me go. What I do not find, I will not fill in."

Madhavi gathered the pages. "Remember that sentence."

"Shall I add it to the rules of the pothi?"

"Yes. That is for the pothi."

Devkant wrote: 'When a source is unavailable, do not fill the blank with conjecture.'

Madhavi looked at the page. "That rule will be needed often."

Devkant did not know how far that sentence would one day prove true. For now he understood only this much: some pages could be before his eyes and still not belong to him.

Madhavi tucked the private pages inside the cloth. The tiny leaf drawn in the corner appeared for a moment, then disappeared.



The next day Devkant began making the first orderly copy of the Bhanas-Pothi. Before him lay the page on tilkor tarua—the same page connected in his memory with the small leaf Madhavi had once set aside. The old notes contained scattered sentences about ingredients, the thickness of the pithar, choosing the leaves, and the heat of the oil.

As Madhavi checked the page, she placed a finger on one word. “Not ‘batter’ here. Write ‘pithar.’”

Devkant immediately struck it out and corrected it. “The meaning is—”

Madhavi cut him off. “Even if the meaning is close, change the word and you change the household tongue. Write the word we use.”

“All right. Pithar.”

“And here, not ‘patta.’ ‘Paat.’”

Devkant laughed. “That I know myself by now.”

“If you know it, why did you write it?”

“An old draft.”

“Then cut out the old mistake.”

Devkant struck it out.

Madhavi went through the page line by line. Wherever the method was certain from the household’s experience, she let it stand; wherever quantity depended on the season, the tenderness of the leaf, or the state of the pithar, Devkant wanted to write ‘approximate.’ Madhavi stopped him again.

“Not ‘approximate.’ Write ‘judge by looking.’”

“The reader will ask—how much?”

“Then put the sign in the next line: the pithar should cling to the leaf, not run off it. That is a working indication.”

Devkant wrote it down. “Your rules keep multiplying.”

“Not rules. Mistakes are diminishing.”

When the page was complete, Devkant left an empty space at the bottom. “Finished here?”

Madhavi pulled the page towards herself. She was quiet for a few moments. Then she picked up not Devkant’s pen but her own, and at the bottom of the page wrote her name in very small Tirhuta letters.

Devkant’s eyes remained fixed on the name. He could not yet read the whole word—he had not learned enough—but he recognised the first letter.

“Madhavi?”

“Yes.”

“Why sign here?”

Straightening the page, Madhavi said, "If the method came from my mouth and the corrections from my hand, my name will remain beneath it."

Devkant said nothing. His finger moved almost involuntarily towards the name, but he did not touch the letters.

"On every method from now on?" he asked.

"Where the knowledge is mine, yes. Where it is Janki's, her name. Where it is Nasima's, hers. Where you saw something yourself, yours."

"There could be four names on one page."

"Then there will be four."

Devkant smiled. "The people at the press will go mad."

"Will we reduce the number of names because the work is difficult for them?"

Devkant laughed. "No. I remember the answer to that question now."

A faint pleasure appeared on Madhavi's face.

At the top of the page Devkant wrote a small note in Devanagari: 'Original method: Madhavi's oral account; wording corrected by Madhavi.'

Madhavi read it. "And my name remains below."

"It will."

"In Devanagari too?"

Devkant thought for a moment. "Your name in Devanagari in the printed transcription, and your Tirhuta signature exactly as it is on the original page."

"Good."

At that moment a breeze crossed the veranda. The upper corner of the page lifted. Devkant placed a hand on it to steady it. Madhavi's small signature at the bottom remained still.

Hemlata came running and looked at the page. "Is that Didi's name?"

Madhavi said, "Yes."

Hemlata smiled. "Now the pothi will know who taught tilkor."

Devkant replied, "The pothi will not forget."

Madhavi looked at him. "The pothi does not forget by itself. People make it forget."

Devkant's hand remained on the page. The breeze rose again, but this time he did not grip the sheet tightly; he pressed only enough to keep it from flying away.

The name was small. The page was not large. Yet Devkant understood that, for the first time, what stood within the pothi beside knowledge was not his ownership of it, but its source, standing there in its own script.

In his final note of the day he wrote only one line: 'Handwriting too is evidence.'

Then he closed his pen.

CHAPTER 14

The Word That Cannot Be Translated

After his lessons in script, a new difficulty presented itself in Devkant's writing. The deadline for sending the English article was drawing near, and the editor had written explicitly that unfamiliar words should be explained for the reader. Devkant sat on the veranda with two sheets spread before him. On the first were Maithili words; on the second, their possible English meanings.

Across the top, in order, he had written—tarua, bagiya, amat, adauri, paag, panti.

Madhavi came over and looked at the page. "What is this?"

"A glossary. The people who read the article won't understand every word."

"So?"

"I'll give the meanings."

Madhavi placed a finger on the first word. "What does tarua mean?"

With some confidence, Devkant said, "Fried vegetable."

"Is every fried vegetable tarua?"

Devkant stopped. "No."

"Then?"

"Dipped in pithar and fried—"

"Is the pithar for every tarua made the same way?"

Devkant laughed. "You aren't asking for meanings. You're examining me."

Madhavi said, "If a meaning cannot survive an examination, it will break the moment it reaches the reader."

Devkant drew a line through the meaning he had written beside tarua. "All right. Bagiya?"

"You first."

Devkant thought for a while. "Made from rice pithar, filled inside, cooked in steam..."

"That's the method. What does the name mean?"

"The method will make the meaning of the name clear."

“Then leave the name alone and explain the method.”

Devkant stopped his pen and looked at Madhavi. “Leave the name untranslated?”

“Yes. Let tarua remain tarua, bagiya remain bagiya. Give a short explanation the first time. After that, let the name carry on by itself.”

At the top of the page Devkant wrote—‘Do not translate the name; explain it at first mention.’

Madhavi looked at amat. “What have you written for this?”

Before answering, Devkant pulled the page towards himself. “I’m not showing you yet.”

Madhavi laughed. “Then it must certainly be wrong.”

“Something like—mango dried into a preserved thing.”

“Thing?”

“I couldn’t find one word in English.”

“If you couldn’t find one, then you couldn’t. The absence of a word does not mean the absence of the thing.”

Devkant raised his pen. He began to write the sentence, then asked, “Under your name?”

“I only said something general.”

“Even a general statement comes from someone’s mouth.”

Madhavi smiled a little. “Then write—Madhavi’s statement: a thing does not disappear because no word for it is found.”

Devkant wrote it down.

When they came to adauri, Devkant said he would explain it as something made by grinding dal, shaping it and drying it for storage. Madhavi accepted that, but added, “It isn’t only its making. Rain, scarcity, sunlight, the days ahead—all of that is inside it.”

“How much of all that can I put into a glossary?”

“As much as is necessary. Otherwise the reader will know the name, not the thing.”

At paag, Devkant’s pen stopped again. He knew he could call it a head-covering, but then occasion, prestige, form, tying, and social meaning would all fall away. Madhavi said, “For this word, look at the old clothing inventory at Kamla Kaki’s house. Don’t make it up yourself.”

Devkant agreed. “And panti?”

Madhavi looked towards the kitchen. “A panti isn’t merely people sitting one after another. Who sits where, who serves, what the occasion is, what

observance is being followed—all of that changes with circumstance. One English word won't hold it all."

At the bottom of the page Devkant wrote—'A glossary is not an inventory of objects; it also needs context.'

Madhavi said, "And where you don't know the context, leave a blank."

"That rule now applies to every page of the manuscript."

"Good."

Devkant looked once at all six words. He understood that translation was difficult not because English was poor, but because behind a single word an entire life could be standing.

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That afternoon they opened the glossary again. Devkant had begun to mark the limits of his English meanings instead of trying to defend them.

"Tarua—the name stays as it is," he said. "An explanation the first time."

Madhavi nodded.

"Bagiya—the name stays as it is. Rice pithar, filling, steam—that much as a clue."

"All right."

"Amat—the name stays as it is; one form in which mango is dried and kept—"

Madhavi interrupted. "Not every dried form of mango is amat. Be careful."

Devkant immediately added 'a kind of.'

"Adauri?"

"The name stays as it is. Made from dal material and dried in the sun—"

Madhavi stopped him again. "If you haven't checked which dal, what shape, what household method, don't add it."

Devkant wrote on the page, 'The method may vary from household to household.'

Madhavi was satisfied.

Devkant said, "I had thought a translator's work was to reduce difficulty for the reader."

"It is."

"But you are preserving the difficulty."

"Some difficulty has to be preserved."

"Why?"

Madhavi thought for a while. “If you make every unfamiliar thing resemble something already familiar to the reader, the reader will think they already know everything. If they stumble a little, they may ask.”

Devkant said, “So the stumbling itself can be part of meaning in translation?”

“Sometimes.”

They came to the word paag. Devkant had written on the paper—‘a special Maithil head-covering.’ Madhavi read it.

“This isn’t bad. But what will ‘special’ tell anyone?”

“Then?”

“The occasions on which it is worn, its form, who wears it—note what has been verified. If it hasn’t been verified, don’t put it here.”

Devkant put a question mark beside paag. “I’ll look at the clothing vocabulary.”

“Yes.”

“For panti?”

Madhavi let her eyes travel the length of the courtyard. “One day, during a meal, look from outside. It is easy to count the people who are seated. The person serving will not appear in the panti. Then you will understand that a word can also contain people who are absent from view.”

Devkant’s pen went still. “That will take the article beyond the description of food.”

“Beyond the food? Is the person serving outside the food?”

The question was so direct that Devkant did not answer.

Madhavi said softly, “The meaning of a word is not only the object. Work, relationships, occasion, people—all of it.”

Devkant gave a new heading to the page—‘Meanings that do not fit into one word.’

“Will that stay in the English article?” Madhavi asked.

“It will. The editor may cut it.”

“Then write it again next time so it can return.”

Devkant laughed. “You’re already fighting the battle for the next edition.”

Madhavi said, “If something cut out is necessary, it comes back.”

Devkant did not write that line down. He only remembered it.



That evening the old tilkor page came before them again. In the English draft Devkant had written a short meaning for tilkor tarua—something like ‘fried leaf.’

Madhavi did not laugh when he read it aloud. She grew serious. “Fried leaf?”

Devkant said, “The reader will understand easily.”

“Understand what?”

“That a leaf is dipped in pithar—”

“You’ve written only fried leaf.”

Devkant looked at the page. “Yes. To keep it short.”

Madhavi rose and went to the edge of the courtyard. The tilkor vine was climbing the wall there. She showed him two leaves—one old and thick, the other new and tender.

“Both are leaves.”

“Yes.”

“Are both equally good for tarua?”

“No.”

“Why?”

Before answering, Devkant remembered his earlier notes. “Tenderness, size, veins—”

“And on the day guests came to the house, which leaves was Janki choosing?”

That day rose in Devkant’s memory—Madhavi setting aside the smallest, tenderest leaf.

“Good leaves.”

“Then will someone reading ‘fried leaf’ understand all this?”

“No.”

Madhavi touched the stem of the leaf. “They won’t understand the plant. They won’t understand which leaf was chosen. They won’t understand the pithar, the oil, the heat. They won’t understand that tender leaves were saved for guests. They won’t know whose hand chose them. They will understand only that a leaf fell into oil.”

Devkant crossed ‘fried leaf’ out of the draft.

“Then a whole paragraph?”

“The first time, yes. After that, say ‘tilkor tarua.’ The reader will learn the name.”

Devkant began to write. After a while he stopped. “This has become less translation than introduction.”

“Why should the introduction to an unfamiliar thing be shorter than its translation?”

Devkant smiled. “You make a great deal of extra work for the translator.”

“I reduce the wrong work.”

Beside the tilkor page Devkant wrote—‘Preserve the name; open the world the first time.’

Madhavi read it and said, “World is a very large word.”

“It is right here.”

“Then put it under your own name.”

Devkant laughed. “All right.”

A little later he turned the page and said, “There is another problem here. If an English reader has never tasted tilkor, how much can I write and make them taste it?”

Madhavi said, “You cannot make them taste it. Accept that much.”

“Does the writer stop there?”

“Don’t stop. Know the limit.”

“And the reader?”

“If they want to, perhaps one day they will taste it. If not, at least they won’t believe that the whole taste has fitted inside two English words.”

Devkant looked at the page for a long time. For the first time he could see the translator’s power clearly—if he wished, he could make a thing smaller and easier for the reader; but at whose cost that ease came was a question hidden not on the page but inside his decision.

In the margin of the draft he wrote—‘Do not cut meaning for the sake of simplicity.’

Madhavi said, “Keep that rule.”

“I will.”

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The night had grown unusually deep. Most of the household had gone to sleep. A single oil lamp burned on the veranda, lighting one part of the papers and leaving the other in shadow. Devkant and Madhavi were still bent over the last page of the glossary.

The matter of paag had been deferred—the old clothing inventory still had to be examined. The explanation of panti remained unfinished—Madhavi wanted Devkant to watch an actual meal and write from that. Tarua, bagiya, amat, adauri, tilkor—small notes had gathered behind each of them.

Devkant rubbed his eyes. "Half the night has gone in looking for the meaning of one word."

Madhavi said, "A word is small. The world behind it is not."

"Shall I write that line?"

"Not now. I'm tired."

Devkant put down his pen. On the other side of the veranda stood a small box of paan. Madhavi looked towards it, then took out a leaf.

"Will you have one?"

Devkant held out his hand. "What is the English meaning of that question?"

Madhavi gave a tired laugh. "If we start translating paan now, it will be morning."

"Then leave the name alone?"

"Yes. Leave the name alone."

She began preparing the paan. Devkant watched in silence. This time he did not ask about ingredients, measurements, or English words. He only watched the movement of her hands.

Madhavi gave one paan to him and kept one for herself. They sat at two ends of the veranda, but after a day spent over the papers, the distance seemed smaller.

After keeping the paan in his mouth for a while, Devkant said, "Some tastes are difficult to write."

Madhavi said, "Why must every taste be written?"

"Because we are making a book."

"If the book takes everything, what will be left for life?"

Devkant looked at her. "You've kept your private pages."

"Yes."

"And some tastes?"

"Those too."

The lamp-flame trembled slightly. From outside came the sounds of night insects. Somewhere in the distance a dog barked, then there was silence.

Devkant said, "I think people translating are often in too much of a hurry to believe that another person's world has now become clear to them."

Chewing paan, Madhavi said softly, "Understanding something and making it your own are different things."

Devkant did not answer. The sentence went deep inside him.

After a while he asked, "How much do you understand me?"

Madhavi's hand stopped. The question lay outside the day's glossary.

She looked at Devkant. "As much as you show. Some guesses. Some of those will be wrong too."

"And I?"

"Me?"

"Yes."

Madhavi did not smile. "The same rule. As much as I show, that much. Don't fill in the rest."

Devkant's eyes went to the page. 'When the source is unavailable, do not fill the blank with conjecture.'

He smiled. "A rule for the book applies to people too?"

"Sometimes the book learns from people."

They fell silent again. The taste of paan changed slowly—the first sharpness, then a faint layer of sweetness, then the leaf's own scent. Devkant made no note of that sequence.

Madhavi noticed. "No writing today?"

"No."

"Why?"

"Because not everything is meant to be written."

There was tiredness in Madhavi's eyes, but also a clear pleasure.

The lamp leaned a little. Devkant straightened the wick. Madhavi gathered the glossary pages. As both reached for the same corner of a sheet, their hands touched. Neither hand jerked away at once. They paused for a moment, then the papers were gathered.

There was no declaration of love, no promise. But Devkant understood that among the words that had survived translation all day, a kind of silence had formed between them, and naming it might make it smaller.

As she rose, Madhavi said, "Tomorrow we'll look at *panti*."

Devkant said, "And the *paag* inventory."

"Yes. Source first."

"Don't fill it in yourself."

"You're learning now."

Madhavi left. Devkant looked down at the page. The list that had begun with six words was now filled with notes, questions, names and blank spaces.

At the end he wrote only this—'A word that cannot be translated should not be erased; space for meaning should be left around it.'

Then he put out the lamp.

CHAPTER 15

The Plate of Tarua

The heat had now begun to settle in openly. By noon the earth of the courtyard grew hot, so much of the kitchen work had begun early in the morning. That day Janki had prepared a large plate with five kinds of tarua—pumpkin, potato, eggplant, tilkor, and green banana. Devkant had his pages spread out on the veranda, but by now he remembered the rule before anything else: pages later, scene first.

Madhavi went on cutting each ingredient differently. The pumpkin pieces were thick, the potato slices a little thinner, the eggplant shaped another way, the green banana cut differently again. Tilkor leaves were chosen according to their tenderness. The pithar was prepared in a single vessel, but Madhavi did not dip all the ingredients into it at once.

Devkant asked, “The same pithar—then are all the taruas made the same way?”

Madhavi said, “Does the same pithar make everything equal?”

“No. The ingredients are different.”

“Then you have your answer.”

Watching the heat of the oil, Janki said, “Pumpkin softens easily. Potato and green banana each ask for their own time. Eggplant drinks oil in its own way. Tilkor leaves are another matter again.”

Devkant opened the notebook, but before writing he asked, “All this is the way of this household?”

Madhavi answered at once, “Yes. Write here what you have seen. There is no single rule for all Mithila.”

Devkant gave the entry a heading—“Tarua in this household: one pithar, different bodies.”

Hemlata read over his shoulder and laughed. “The bodies of tarua?”

Devkant laughed too. “Then what should I write?”

Madhavi said, "Body is not the wrong word. Once an ingredient is cut, what else do we examine but its body—how soft it is, how much water it holds, how fibrous it is?"

Janki lowered the first tilkor leaf into the oil. A sound rose. The pithar set at once, forming a thin coating around the leaf. Devkant watched. Inside that coating, the leaf still held its own shape.

Pumpkin went into another vessel. The pithar on the outside was almost the same, yet when it came out of the oil its colour, smell, and softness were entirely different from tilkor.

Devkant said, "Different ingredients inside one frame."

Madhavi smiled slightly. "You may call it a frame, but do not forget the difference between the ingredients."

"You already know I am about to make a metaphor?"

"By now I can tell from your face."

Hemlata cut in, "Will the metaphor be fit to eat?"

Janki answered, "Leave the metaphor alone and lift this pumpkin tarua. If it sits too long it will go soft."

They all laughed. Devkant stopped the metaphor and turned back to the actual plate. Though all five taruas sat together, none was a copy of another. Without seeing that difference, the word 'tarua' itself remained incomplete—this slowly became clear to him without anyone having to say it.



Two guests were expected in the house that day. Since morning Janki had been saying that the best tilkor leaves and some of the green-banana tarua should be set aside for the guests' plate. Hemlata had wrinkled her nose at the idea.

"The bad ones for the people of the house?" she had asked.

Janki said, "Not bad. The first selection is for the guests. The people of the house will eat all the rest of the good food."

Madhavi quietly arranged tarua on a separate plate. There she placed the tenderest tilkor piece, an attractive slice of pumpkin, an eggplant piece that had drunk less oil, and evenly shaped pieces of green-banana tarua.

Watching this, Devkant asked, "Is arranging the plate a rule too?"

Janki said, "Call it a rule or call it respect. When a guest comes, what is best should reach them first."

"And the children of the house?" Hemlata asked at once.

"The children of the house have already eaten half of it," Janki said.

Realising that her theft had been discovered, Hemlata fell silent.

Madhavi said to Devkant, “When you write this, do not write that guests always eat the most. The point is the selection in serving, and respect.”

Devkant wrote—‘First selection for the guest’s plate: one form of respect in the household.’

Madhavi read it and said, “That is right.”

The guests arrived. After water, paan, and introductions on the veranda, it was time to eat. Janki watched the order of serving. Rice first, dal beside it; the vegetable dish; then the taruas one by one. The tilkor tarua did not come immediately, but a little later. Devkant noticed that a plate was not merely a place where things were set down; order too told a story.

One guest lifted a tilkor piece with pleasure. “This is very tender.”

Janki merely smiled and said, “A morning leaf.”

Sitting a little distance away, Devkant did not take notes; he watched first. He remembered that Madhavi had once saved this same kind of tender leaf for his plate.

With that memory, the present scene suddenly became private. It seemed to him that hospitality and affection often took the same outward form; the difference lay only in intention, and intention was hard to see on paper.

After the meal Hemlata saw that two tilkor taruas were left on the plate that had been set aside. She took one and placed the other before Madhavi.

“The guests did not eat them,” she said.

Without a word, Madhavi broke the tarua in half and gave one half to Hemlata.

Devkant watched. The politics of household resources did not move in one direction only—the first selection went to the guests, what remained returned to the household, and then sharing followed its own logic.

On the page he wrote—‘The order of a plate is not only an order of taste; it is also an order of respect, availability, and relationship.’

After reading it Madhavi said, a little later, “And sometimes of display as well.”

Devkant looked at her questioningly.

Madhavi said, “When a household has little, there can still be pressure to show more before a guest. We can write about that later.”

Devkant left a blank space at the side of the page. The rule applied here too: without a source, do not fill the gap.

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As the afternoon declined, the guests went inside to rest. On the veranda Devkant placed the remaining pieces of the five taruas on one plate and looked at them: pumpkin, potato, eggplant, tilkor, green banana—the colour of the pithar almost the same, five tastes within.

All at once he said, “Mithila is like a plate.”

Pouring water, Madhavi stopped. “Another metaphor.”

“Listen to this one. Many tastes on one plate. Many lives inside a single name. It is not a bad metaphor.”

Madhavi looked at the plate. “And what was left outside the plate?”

Devkant fell silent.

“There is no fish on this plate,” Madhavi said. “No kurthi. No bagiya. The people who do not eat tarua are not here. The plate of a household that cannot afford enough oil to fry five kinds is not here. The people who plough the fields, pluck the leaves, press the oil—where are they on this decorated plate?”

Devkant suddenly saw the gleam of the plate differently.

“Should I abandon the metaphor?”

Madhavi said, “No. Keep the metaphor, but write its limits.”

Devkant opened the notebook—‘Mithila is a plate—this metaphor is incomplete: the people, ingredients, labour, and want outside the plate are also Mithila.’

Madhavi read the page. “Now it can be used.”

“You do not cut down all my metaphors. You make them more difficult.”

“A simple metaphor often cuts people out.”

Devkant’s pen stopped. “May I write that in your name?”

Madhavi thought for a moment. “Yes. Write it.”

He wrote—‘Madhavi: A simple metaphor often cuts people out.’

Hemlata came from a distance and asked, “Where will you put me on the plate?”

Devkant laughed. “You said you would write your own history. Choose your own place.”

Without hesitation Hemlata picked up the remaining eggplant tarua. “Here.”

Madhavi burst out laughing. “You ate the place meant for history.”

With her mouth full, Hemlata tried to say something, and Janki scolded from a distance—“Swallow first!”

The veranda filled with laughter again.

Devkant kept the plate metaphor on the page, but it was no longer a triumphant sentence. Questions now surrounded it—and perhaps because of those questions it had become more truthful.



In the evening, a young woman from among the guests came to the veranda. Her name was Sharda. She had studied toward Darbhanga and had read one of Devkant's earlier articles in a magazine. A plain sari, a neatly arranged anchal, and two or three papers in her hand—her presence differed from that of the women of the household in one respect: she had come to discuss Devkant's writing directly.

"I read your last article," Sharda said. "I especially liked the description of household food. People rarely pay attention to such subjects."

Devkant was pleased. "The work underway now is larger than that."

"May I see it?"

For a moment Devkant looked toward Madhavi. A little way off, Madhavi was gathering the tarua dishes. She lifted her eyes, then returned to her work.

Devkant gave Sharda only the pages marked for sharing, not those bearing the private sign. Sharda began to read carefully.

"This is very interesting," she said. "Your method of not translating local terms, but explaining them at first mention, is appropriate."

Devkant's face brightened. "That idea came out of an argument."

Sharda asked, "With whom?"

Devkant said, "With Madhavi. Much of the knowledge in this pothi belongs to her and to the women of the household."

Madhavi's hand stopped for a moment. She said nothing.

Sharda turned toward her. "Then your name should be on the pages."

Madhavi answered evenly, "Where the knowledge is mine, my name is there."

"Good." Sharda turned back to Devkant. "Make this method explicit in the article as well."

Devkant said, "I will."

For a while the two of them talked about the English article, magazines, and printing. Sharda praised Devkant's attentiveness to language. Devkant told her that he had postponed defining the word paag until he could consult a source. Sharda said it was good to write only after seeing the source.

Meanwhile Madhavi continued separating the leftover tarua on the plate. Outwardly she was entirely at ease. Hemlata, sitting beside her, picked up a

piece; without looking, Madhavi took it back from her hand and returned it to the plate.

Hemlata looked at her in surprise. "Why?"

Madhavi said, "It is beginning to go stale. Take another."

Hemlata took another, but kept her eyes fixed on her sister's face.

Sharda asked Devkant, "Will you translate this entire pothi into English?"

Devkant said, "No. I am beginning to think that a complete translation would make too much smaller. The Maithili original, with explanations alongside—perhaps."

"That is a good decision."

This time Madhavi set down a vessel a little harder than usual. The sound was slightly louder. Janki noticed from a distance but said nothing.

Devkant noticed too. He looked toward Madhavi. Madhavi immediately picked up another vessel and went inside.

Sharda continued the discussion. She noticed nothing.

A little later she left. Devkant gathered the papers and went toward the kitchen. Madhavi was wiping brass vessels.

"Sharda-ji made some good points," Devkant said casually.

"Yes."

"She herself raised the question of your name."

"I heard."

"You were not pleased?"

Madhavi ran the cloth once more along the rim of the vessel. "I was pleased. A thing does not become wrong because of who said that the name should remain."

Devkant heard a faint bitterness inside the answer, but he did not question it at once. He remembered the earlier rule: only as much as is shown; do not fill in the rest.

He said, "Of the five taruas today, which came out best?"

For the first time Madhavi looked directly at him. "Are you changing the subject?"

"Possibly."

A very small smile appeared on Madhavi's face. "Tilkor."

"Mine too."

"Did you give that answer after looking at me, or after tasting it?"

Devkant laughed. "That question is difficult to answer."

Madhavi's smile widened a little, but she turned at once toward the vessels again.

Devkant returned to the veranda and opened the notebook. He began to write—‘Jealousy?’ Then he stopped. He struck the word out. What did he actually know? A vessel had been set down a little harder; a stale tarua had been taken from Hemlata’s hand and replaced; a voice had become a little quieter—those were the sources, nothing more.

Instead he wrote—‘Use caution in giving an emotional name to what has not been said.’

Closing the page, he understood that human feelings, like the plate of five taruas, did not fit into a single pithar. The outer form might appear the same; the taste within remained different.

At the night meal Madhavi placed a piece of tilkor beside his plate without saying anything. Devkant looked at her only once. He asked nothing.

This time, silence itself was enough.

CHAPTER 16

Mango Amat

The heat had now climbed all the way into the walls of the house. The little coolness of morning vanished as soon as the sun rose, and by noon the courtyard bricks grew so hot that bare feet could not stay on them for long. In this season, the work of the kitchen spilled from indoors to outdoors—the roof, the veranda, the sunny corners of the courtyard, all became temporary storerooms.

One morning Madhavi brought in a bamboo basket full of raw mangoes. Some still had green skins; a faint yellow tint had begun to come over others. Janki saw them from a distance and said, ‘Cut all of these today. Two days from now we cannot trust the sun.’

Devkant was sitting on the veranda with the pothi open. The moment he saw the mangoes he asked, ‘Pickle?’

Madhavi said, ‘Not all mangoes will become pickle.’

‘Then?’

‘Some will become amat in this house. We cut raw mangoes and dry them in the sun. After the rains, when there are no fresh mangoes, this sourness will be useful.’

Devkant’s pen began to move. ‘How thick should they be cut?’

Madhavi held a mango in her hand. ‘First look at what kind of mango this is.’

‘The same thing again?’

‘The same thing. Raw mangoes may all look the same colour, but their bodies are not the same. Some are very hard; some are a little soft inside. The size of the stone changes too.’

Janki cut open a mango with a knife and showed it to him. ‘This one is good. The flesh is firm. Right for drying.’

Devkant tried to measure the thickness of a cut slice. Madhavi laughed. ‘After chhatank, are we measuring fingers now?’

‘The reader has to understand.’

‘Explain it. But do not write that every piece is the same width. Hands will cut differently; mangoes will differ too.’

Hemlata came and sat down with a small board. Her task was to spread the cut mango pieces over the drying basket. She lifted one piece toward her mouth and Janki noticed at once.

‘Not yet.’

‘It is raw mango, not poison.’

‘Not poison, but mango meant for work. Fill the basket first.’

Hemlata made a face and put the piece back. Devkant laughed.

Madhavi kept cutting mango after mango. Flesh to one side, stones to another. Some pieces were short, some long. She spread them so that they did not lie on top of one another.

Devkant asked, ‘Salt?’

Janki said, ‘Not now, for amat in this house. Later, when the dried pieces are used for whatever they are used for, salt and spices will come with that use. Pickle is a different matter.’

At the top of the page Devkant wrote: ‘The method in this household.’

Madhavi saw it. ‘Good. Because another household may do it differently.’

‘Why do you keep saying this again and again?’

‘Because the pothi keeps forgetting.’

‘The pothi, or the writer?’

Madhavi stopped the knife and looked at him. ‘The pothi does nothing by itself. The one who writes is the one who forgets.’

Instead of answering, Devkant wrote ‘household-specific’ on the page.

As the mangoes were cut, their smell spread from the kitchen into the courtyard—a sharp, green sourness that tugged at the tongue. Devkant picked up a small piece.

Madhavi did not stop him. ‘Taste it. But what will you write—sour?’

Devkant chewed the piece. His eyes narrowed of their own accord. Hemlata burst out laughing.

‘Now write—“a taste that makes the writer shut his eyes,”’ she said.

Devkant drank some water. ‘The word sour is too small.’

Madhavi said, ‘Then remember what we were talking about last night—the word that could not be translated.’

Devkant laughed. ‘You all keep teaching me my own lessons back again.’

‘If we do not, you will fill in the rest yourself.’

The basket filled up. Madhavi placed it in a corner of the courtyard that received sun from morning until noon and from which it could be brought

indoors in the evening. Janki told Hemlata clearly to lift the basket before the evening dew fell.

Devkant wrote: 'Drying does not mean merely leaving something in the sun; it requires watching throughout the day.'

Madhavi read the line. 'Keep that sentence.'

Devkant kept looking at the mango pieces. For now they were juicy and bright. In a few days they would shrivel, change colour, lose weight. The taste would remain, but the form would change.

'While amat is being made, does the taste lessen or grow stronger?' he asked.

Janki said, 'Both. The water lessens. The sourness survives. The rest you will understand when you eat it later.'

Devkant drew a small line beside that answer. It seemed to him that this was not only about mangoes.



The next day the sun was stronger. The mango pieces spread in the basket had lost the first day's shine and turned slightly dull. Their edges were shrinking; the flesh at the centre was still pliant. Madhavi lifted one piece, bent it, then put it back.

When Devkant arrived he asked, 'Ready now?'

'No.'

'It has become half its size since yesterday.'

'The work is not finished merely because the size has decreased.'

'Then what are the signs?'

'Moisture. Softness inside. Smell. What happens when you press it in your hand. All of that.'

Devkant watched in silence. Over the past weeks he had received this kind of answer again and again—time, measurement, size, all were aids; the final decision belonged to the hand, the eye, the smell, experience.

Madhavi placed a piece in his palm. 'Do you remember yesterday's?'

'Green, juicy, very sour.'

'And this?'

Devkant smelled it. The sour scent remained, but the freshness of raw mango had acquired the warmth of the sun.

'It is the same mango, but it is not the same,' he said.

'Exactly.'

'Exactly what?'

‘All those questions were for this much.’

Devkant opened the page. ‘Shall I write it?’

‘Write your own thought in your own name.’

He wrote: ‘The dried form is not a copy of the original thing; it is its second life.’

Madhavi read it and said, ‘That is a very bookish sentence.’

‘Wrong?’

‘No. But the mango does not look that serious.’

Devkant laughed. ‘What is the limit of seriousness for you?’

‘Why make something heavy when it can be understood without heavy words?’

Devkant did not strike out the sentence, but wrote in small letters beside it: ‘Simplify.’

Turning the pieces in the basket, Madhavi said, ‘Some tastes end with the fresh season. Some we dry and keep. In winter these mangoes will not be here, but the sourness will remain. Taste crosses the season.’

Devkant’s pen stopped. ‘This sentence in your name?’

‘Write it. But “crosses the season” is not my phrase. I said: in winter the mango will not be here, the sourness will remain.’

Devkant smiled. ‘All right.’

He wrote exactly that: ‘Madhavi: In winter the mango will not be here; the sourness will remain.’

A little later Madhavi placed a drying piece in the shade of the veranda and said, ‘Look, this is like memory.’

Devkant looked at her at once. ‘You used a metaphor?’

‘When did I ever forbid metaphors?’

‘No. You only forbade me from making too many of them.’

‘Because you immediately turn everything into something else.’

‘And you?’

‘Only when it seems right to me.’

Devkant laughed. ‘Then how is this like memory?’

Madhavi turned the piece between her fingers. ‘The juice of the fresh mango is gone. The colour has changed. The size has decreased. But if it is kept properly, even after a long time the tongue will recognise that it was mango. Memory does not keep everything exactly as it was either. A little smell, a little taste, a little hurt—that is all.’

Devkant listened.

‘And if it is dried badly?’

‘It will catch mould. Then what you preserved will no longer be fit to eat.’

Devkant said quietly, ‘Memory too?’

Madhavi did not answer. She put the piece back into the basket.

In the far corner of the courtyard Hemlata was shaking out wet clothes. Water flashed in the sun and vanished within moments. Suddenly Devkant remembered the day of the earthquake—dust, cries, the open courtyard, the shared pot. So much now returned not through detail, but through smell and sound.

He opened the old pages of the pothi. His notes from the day of the earthquake were very sparse. ‘Boil the water’—Madhavi’s sentence. ‘Khichdi’—Janki’s reckoning. The laughter over too little salt. That was all on paper. The rest of the day was larger in memory.

Madhavi looked at the page. ‘What are you looking for?’

‘What was not written.’

‘You will not find all of that on the page.’

‘Then?’

‘In someone’s memory. In someone’s body. In someone’s fear. In someone’s laughter. Everything cannot fit into the pothi.’

Devkant said, ‘Then history is incomplete?’

‘People remember incompletely. How could history be complete?’

Devkant had no answer to that question. He looked at the mangoes drying in the basket. The juicy form of the first day was gone; but what was surviving might travel far in this altered form.

At the edge of the page he wrote: ‘Drying is not erasure.’

Madhavi read it and this time said nothing.



On the afternoon of the third day the postman brought a letter. The envelope bore a Calcutta postmark. Devkant knew the sender as soon as he saw the name—the editor of the same magazine.

He opened the letter on the veranda. Madhavi was preparing to bring the basket indoors because clouds were gathering in the west.

‘From Calcutta?’ she asked.

‘Yes.’

As Devkant read, his face changed.

‘What happened?’

‘They need the article quickly.’

The letter was in English. Devkant explained its meaning in Maithili: the next issue was being prepared for press; send the food article at once; the descriptions were interesting, but cut much of the domestic detail and make it concise; readers wanted the ‘main characteristics,’ not small household differences.

Madhavi stood holding the basket. ‘Main characteristics?’

‘The editor’s words.’

‘If you remove the household differences, what remains that is main?’

Devkant was silent. The last line of the letter urged him to send the copy by post within three days.

‘Three days,’ he said.

‘Then send what is ready in three days.’

‘A lot is ready. But it is not organised.’

Madhavi put the basket inside. ‘Organising and cleaning away are not the same thing.’

Devkant looked at her. ‘Why do you say that?’

‘The letter says to cut the domestic detail. If, while “cleaning,” you cut away the differences, then what have we been adding all these days for?’

‘I will not cut everything.’

‘Not everything. How much?’

Devkant did not answer. He read the letter again.

That evening he sat down with his article draft. The pages had grown—tilkor, salt, bagiya, makhana, fish, words, script, mango. The English article could not hold so much detail. He would have to choose.

First he cut repetitions. Then he removed some of the separate examples that made the same point. Up to that point he felt no hesitation.

But when he reached the section on tilkor, he stopped. Madhavi’s insistence had been: preserve the name, open up the world the first time. The editor wanted a short article.

Devkant compressed two paragraphs into one. He kept the matter of choosing the leaves, but cut the entire scene of setting aside the tender leaf for the guest.

His pen stopped.

Madhavi was gathering clothes at a distance. Devkant did not call her.

The makhana section contained Ramanand’s description of labour. He cut half of it, but kept the name. ‘Ramanand, a labourer engaged in pond work, explains...’—that line survived.

‘A name can survive even in fewer words,’ he said to himself.

In the fish section he saw the old crossed-out sentence, 'Maithils love fish.' For a moment he thought: it is short; the editor will like it. Then Madhavi's voice returned to him—'All?'

He did not write the sentence again.

When he came to the mango pages, he felt a little relief. Drying raw mango, preserving sourness across seasons—this could make a beautiful, compact example. He wrote that raw mango pieces were dried in the sun and used in food in a later season; in this household this form was called amat.

At the bottom of the page he saw Madhavi's sentence: 'In winter the mango will not be here; the sourness will remain.'

Devkant made an English version of it. The sentence was short and memorable.

Madhavi came near and asked, 'How much is done?'

'Half.'

'May I see?'

'It is in English.'

'Tell me the meaning.'

Devkant read out the mango passage and explained it in Maithili. Madhavi listened carefully.

'Good. But have you written "amat in this household"?'

'Yes.'

'Good. Not all Mithila.'

Devkant laughed softly. 'That lesson has settled inside me now.'

Madhavi stood behind the chair and looked over the remaining pages. 'Will you cut the domestic detail?'

'Some of it.'

'Which?'

'What will not change the main point of the article.'

Madhavi said, 'Who will decide what the main point is?'

Devkant answered, 'This time I will have to.'

'Then what you cut will be your responsibility too.'

The sentence felt unusually heavy to Devkant.

He worked late into the night, cleaning up the draft. The pages grew shorter; the article seemed more shapely. Yet some cuts left spaces that looked clean to the eye and uneasy to the mind.



By the next morning the article was nearly ready. Devkant was comparing the original notes with the English draft one last time. Madhavi had set the basket of amat on the veranda floor and was turning the pieces again.

Devkant's eye fell on a sentence circled in red pencil on one of the original pages. It was a note Madhavi had added one day after an argument about kitchen work and authorial credit.

Devkant could not yet read Tirhuta fluently, but the Devanagari transcription was beside it. The sentence meant: if the pothi does not preserve the names of the hands that preserve taste across seasons, then the pothi will preserve taste and erase the people.

He read the line many times.

It could become the conclusion of the English article. It was not short, but it was sharp. It joined the discussion of food to the question of labour and names.

Devkant began making an English version of it on a separate sheet. Halfway through, he stopped.

The editor's letter lay before him: 'Cut much of the domestic detail and make it concise.'

Devkant looked at the sentence again. It seemed to him that if he included it, the article would move from food description toward a social argument. The editor might cut it. It might delay the entire article. There were only three days.

Madhavi, lifting the basket, asked, 'What are you stuck on?'

Devkant put his hand over the page. 'Nothing. I am shortening the conclusion.'

'Will you show me?'

'It is still a draft.'

Madhavi looked at his face for a few moments, then said, 'All right. I will see it when it is finished.'

She went away.

Devkant removed his hand. The red-circled sentence was before him again.

He did not put it into the English copy.

He told himself: it will go into the longer article later. It will certainly remain in the pothi. This is only a short magazine article. There is no time now.

The decision did not immediately feel like a wrongdoing. On the contrary, it seemed practical. If something was safe in the original pothi, what

harm was there in leaving it out of one short article? Later it could be given its full place.

He carried the draft forward.

A little later Madhavi came back. 'Finished?'

'Almost.'

'The final line?'

Devkant explained the meaning of the English conclusion in Maithili: food in Mithila is shaped by season, water, field and household experience; different ways of preservation carry flavours through the year.

Madhavi listened and was silent.

'What is it?' Devkant asked.

'Nothing.'

'No, tell me.'

Madhavi looked toward the page. 'The line I circled in red yesterday?'

Something jolted inside Devkant.

'I did not keep it in this article.'

'Why?'

'There is little space. And the article is about food. The question of credit will come properly in the longer pothi.'

Madhavi set the basket on the ground. 'Who makes the food?'

'I know what you want to say.'

'Then how can the names of those who make it be outside an article about food?'

Devkant said quietly, 'Not outside. Postponed for now.'

'Who guarantees that a postponed thing will return?'

'I do.'

There was neither a smile nor any open sign of anger on Madhavi's face. For a moment she simply became very still.

'Write it down—"later."'

Devkant looked startled. 'What?'

'Beside the line you cut, write "later." Then at least the page will know that it was not forgotten; it was deferred.'

Devkant actually wrote beside the original line: 'In the next, longer article.'

Madhavi watched. 'The date too.'

He wrote the date.

'And some mark in the English draft?'

Devkant hesitated, then put a small dot beside the conclusion.

Madhavi said, 'The reader will not understand a dot.'

'It is for me to remember.'

'Then remember.'

Madhavi lifted the basket. Outside, the sun had grown fierce. The pieces of amat were now much lighter than on the first day, shrivelled and darker. They were being preserved—but in a changed form.

Devkant gathered the pages of the magazine article. It was now cleaner, shorter, more readable. He also felt a little satisfaction—he would finish within three days.

But the red-circled sentence remained open in the original pothi.

That evening Madhavi placed a piece of dried mango in front of Devkant. 'Taste it.'

Devkant put it in his mouth. Almost all the juice was gone; the sourness had deepened, carrying a faint smell of sun.

'Like the first day?' Madhavi asked.

'No.'

'Is it no longer mango?'

Devkant said slowly, 'It is. But changed.'

Madhavi did not answer.

Devkant looked at the original page. For a moment it seemed to him that a writer's act of shortening was also like drying. Much water was removed; some flavours grew more concentrated. But if something was cut by mistake, it did not easily return.

He raised his pen to make a note of the thought, then stopped.

Some things did not yet seem fit to be written. Perhaps because once written, the responsibility for them would become clear.

As darkness fell that night, he put the article into an envelope. The red-circled sentence remained in the pothi; it did not go into the English article.

It was a small omission. Devkant himself considered it small.

For now, the name of this decision of Devkant's was only this—the first omission.

CHAPTER 17

Arikanchan

After the basket of amat had been brought indoors, a pause settled over the house, like waiting for the rains. The air was hot, but by late afternoon and evening scraps of cloud had begun to appear. On just such a morning, Madhavi spread large kachu leaves across the kitchen veranda. Thick veins stood out like heavy lines on their green surfaces.

Hemlata sat beside the leaves. In front of her was a bowl of seasoned paste, which Madhavi lifted little by little and spread over the leaves. When Devkant arrived, he first watched from a distance. The experience of the past few weeks had taught him that it was not right to bombard every unfamiliar dish with questions the moment he saw it.

Janki said, 'Now watch what the leaf keeps inside.'

Devkant laughed. 'After bagiya, inside and outside again?'

Without looking up, Madhavi said, 'Food has many insides and outsides. The writer has fallen in love with them; that is not the food's fault.'

The reverse side of the leaf faced upward. Showing Hemlata the raised veins, Madhavi said, 'Spread the paste evenly here. Do not leave the edges bare.'

Hemlata lifted some paste, but made it too thick in one place.

Madhavi stopped her hand. 'Not that much. There will be layer upon layer. If the very first layer is heavy, folding it will be difficult.'

Devkant uncapped his pen. 'Layer upon layer—'

Madhavi looked up. 'Look at the leaf first.'

He closed the pen again.

After spreading paste over one leaf, Madhavi placed a second leaf on top so that the direction of its veins shifted slightly. Then more paste. A third leaf. Then the sides were folded inward. The whole stack slowly took on a compact form.

Hemlata asked, 'Why is this called arikanchan?'

Madhavi paused. 'I do not know the story of the name for certain. What I do not know, I will not invent.'

Devkant opened his notebook at once and wrote: 'Origin of the name: verification pending.'

Janki laughed. 'That line is going to eat half your pothi now.'

'It will preserve an empty space,' Devkant said. 'An empty space is better than something wrong.'

Folding the leaves, Madhavi looked at him. 'For now, you understand that correctly.'

That 'for now' stayed caught in Devkant's ear. The English article from the previous night, the sentence circled in red, 'in the next, longer article'—all of it rose inside him for a moment. He said nothing.

The folded leaves had become a long, bundled shape. Janki said, 'Now let it set. The later work can come later.'

Devkant asked, 'Is it made the same way in this household every time?'

Madhavi answered at once, 'Write the method of this household. Another household may have another method.'

Devkant wrote: 'In this household: paste on kachu leaves, layer upon layer, sides folded in and tightened.' Then he stopped his pen.

'And the spices?'

'Write only what you have seen. I will check the ingredient names later. Do not add anything yourself.'

'All right.'

Hemlata said, 'Didi, these leaves have been pressed under so many layers. How will you know which leaf is inside?'

Madhavi rested her palm lightly on the folded body of the arikanchan. 'When we cut it, you will see. A layer presses down; it does not erase.'

Devkant's pen wanted to move again. He looked at Madhavi.

Madhavi smiled. 'You may write that. I said it.'

He wrote: 'Madhavi: A layer presses down; it does not erase.'

Hemlata began spreading paste again over her smaller leaf. This time the pressure of her hand was balanced.

Devkant thought—book, article, translation, family, memory: layer upon layer fell over all of them. But Madhavi's rule was clear: if you make a metaphor, make it in your own name; do not load someone else's sentence with the weight of your meaning.

He did not write that thought on the page. He only watched as leaf rose over leaf, folded and tightened into a new form.



After noon, when work on the first batch of arikanchan paused, Madhavi brought out some of her Tirhuta pages and sat in a corner of the veranda. Hemlata was beside her. At a distant table Devkant was making a clean copy of the English article.

Hemlata asked softly, 'Didi, why don't you show these pages to Writer Babu?'

Before answering, Madhavi straightened the page in Hemlata's hand. 'Not every page belongs to the pothi.'

'But some of these have things about food and drink too.'

'Some do.'

'Then?'

Madhavi looked at Hemlata. 'If I write my grandmother's story, that does not mean I must give the whole story to the person writing a pothi about food.'

Hemlata looked slightly dissatisfied. 'But he writes your name now.'

'Writing my name and gaining every right are not the same thing.'

Hemlata noticed the little leaf-mark drawn in the corner of the page. 'This is the private leaf?'

'Yes.'

'What is in it?'

Madhavi laughed. 'If I tell you, how will it remain private?'

Hemlata pouted. 'But I am one of your own.'

'Even among our own people there are private places.'

Madhavi did not know whether the sentence reached Devkant's ears. He was sitting far away, though in the quiet of the veranda a voice did not need to travel very far.

Hemlata asked again, 'You do not trust him?'

Madhavi's hand stopped.

'Trust and boundaries are not enemies,' she said softly. 'With someone we trust, we can state a boundary. If trust breaks the moment a boundary is spoken, then it was never trust.'

Hemlata had not been prepared for so serious an answer. She kept looking at the page for a while.

'And if he asks?'

'I will say—no.'

'Will he get angry?'

'Getting angry is his right. Whether I give the page is mine.'

Hemlata nodded slowly.

Madhavi gave her a blank sheet of her own. 'Come, write Tirhuta now. Rewrite the letter you spoiled yesterday.'

Hemlata began to write. After a while she laughed and said, 'My letters are better than Writer Babu's on his first day.'

Madhavi laughed too. 'Tell him that to his face.'

At the far table Devkant suddenly lifted his head. 'Tell me what?'

Hemlata called out loudly, 'My Tirhuta is better than yours was on your first day!'

Devkant replied, 'That is not fair. The page from my first day survives as evidence.'

'Mine will survive too,' Hemlata said.

Madhavi burst into open laughter.

A moment earlier there had been a serious conversation about boundaries, privacy and trust; the next moment all three were laughing. Life in this house often did that—laid a light layer of laughter over something serious without erasing the thing beneath it.

Madhavi wrapped the private pages in cloth again. The little leaf-mark appeared one last time.

Devkant looked toward it from the table. All he understood was that Madhavi kept some pages separate. How many times had he asked about them; how many times had the answer been 'no'.

He brought his eyes back to the English copy. Yet the sentence about a 'private place,' whether he had heard all of it or only part, continued to echo inside him for some time.



In the evening Devkant was arranging the pages of the pothi in order. Arikanchan, mango amat, tilkor, fish—each section was being marked with a separate slip of paper. Madhavi sat nearby checking the ingredient list.

Devkant had been holding back a question for a long time. At last he said, 'May I ask you something?'

Without looking up, Madhavi said, 'Ask.'

'The things about food in your private pages—could some of them be useful for the pothi?'

Madhavi stopped writing. 'They could.'

'Then could I...?'

'No.'

Devkant never got to finish the sentence.

He laughed a little awkwardly. 'You answered before I had even finished.'

'It is an old question.'

'I only want to see the part that belongs to the pothi.'

'Whatever belongs to the pothi, I will separate and give you.'

'But you will make the selection.'

'Yes.'

'What if you think something is unnecessary, but I think it is important?'

Madhavi looked directly at him. 'What is important in my private pages—the final decision about that is mine.'

A slight resistance rose inside Devkant. 'The pothi is my responsibility too.'

'The pothi—yes. My private papers—no.'

'What if something has historical importance?'

'Then will history enter my house without my permission?'

The sentence was hard, but her voice was not raised.

Devkant fell silent. After a few moments he said, 'That is not what I meant to say.'

'But that is where the question was going.'

'Perhaps.'

Madhavi did not gather up the papers. She remained seated. 'You ask me many things. I tell you many things. Perhaps because of that, you have begun to feel that what I did not tell you also becomes yours to see.'

Devkant's expression changed. 'I did not use the word right.'

'A right does not always arrive in the form of a word.'

From the kitchen came the sound of Janki setting down utensils. The first shade of falling darkness was settling over one side of the courtyard.

Devkant said quietly, 'Then state the boundary clearly again.'

Madhavi spoke one word at a time. 'Any page with the little leaf-mark—you will not read. Any page I give you myself is for the pothi. If you need to ask something, ask me. If I do not tell you, the blank will remain blank.'

Devkant nodded.

'And one more thing,' Madhavi added. 'Love, friendship, work—none of them is a key to a private page.'

The word 'love' had come so openly between them for the first time, though no declaration of love had been made. Devkant's breathing changed for a moment.

He asked, 'Why did you bring that word in now?'

Madhavi did not look away. 'Because the deeper the relationship, the more clearly a boundary must be spoken.'

Devkant searched for an answer. In the end he only said, 'All right.'

Madhavi's face did not soften, but some of the tension eased.

Devkant wrote a rule on his page: 'Do not look at a private source without permission; do not fill unavailable material with conjecture.'

Madhavi read it. 'This rule is for the pothi?'

'For the pothi. For me too.'

'Do you understand the difference between the two?'

'For now, that is as much as I can say.'

Madhavi smiled faintly. 'For now.'

Then both returned to their own work. But the air of the veranda had changed. Their closeness had not lessened; instead, a boundary had formed around it—not to push them apart, but to give it shape.



Clouds gathered at night. A hard wind rose, and with the first heavy drops the house erupted into a rush to bring clothes, baskets and papers indoors. Madhavi went toward the kitchen to gather the remaining ingredients for the arikanchan leaves; Hemlata ran to bring down a small basket of amat from the roof.

Devkant began gathering the papers around the open pothi on the veranda. The wind loosened one bundle. Several pages slid across the floor.

He bent to pick them up one by one when a page flipped over and landed open before him. In its corner was the little leaf-mark.

Madhavi's private page.

Devkant's hand stopped.

The page lay fully open. The Tirhuta writing was dense. In the middle were two or three Devanagari words, perhaps names. By now he knew enough Tirhuta that, if he wished, he could slowly read a few lines.

Outside, the rain suddenly intensified. Water drummed louder on the roof. Madhavi's footsteps from the kitchen were still some distance away.

For a moment Devkant looked at the page.

The first voice in his mind said—there may be useful material for the pothi here. Just one glance. Later I will ask Madhavi. Why leave out something that could serve the public work?

The second voice was simpler—she said not to read it.

Devkant's fingers were at the edge of the page. If he wanted, he could turn it toward himself and begin reading from the top.

He did not read it.

He lifted the page exactly as it had fallen, without fixing his eyes on the writing. He found the cloth bundle, placed the page with the little leaf-mark inside it, then folded the bundle and set it high on the veranda.

Madhavi came running. Two drops of water shone near her hair. 'The papers?'

'Saved.'

She looked around. 'My bundle?'

Devkant pointed toward the high place. 'The wind had opened it. One page fell out. I picked it up and put it back.'

Madhavi's face became completely still. 'The one with the leaf-mark?'

'Yes.'

'Did you read it?'

Without hesitation Devkant said, 'No.'

Madhavi watched him for a few moments. The rain outside was so loud that, even without raising their voices, they had to lean a little closer to hear one another.

'It was open?'

'Yes.'

'You can recognise Tirhuta now.'

'Some of it.'

'Then?'

'You said "no."'

This time something changed in Madhavi's eyes. She did not thank him. Perhaps thanking him would have turned respect for a boundary into a favour. She simply took the bundle, checked the page, and put it aside.

'One thing?' Devkant asked.

'Say it.'

'Did you trust me?'

Madhavi did not answer at once. Then she said, 'I did not throw the page down to test your trust.'

Devkant laughed. 'I know.'

'But what happened now will be remembered.'

'In the pothi?'

'No.'

'Why?'

‘This is between you and me. Not everything belongs in the pothi.’

A faint smile came to Devkant’s face. ‘That night’s lesson.’

‘You still remember.’

The rain eased a little. Water continued to fall steadily from the edge of the roof, but without the earlier roar.

From inside Janki called, ‘Will you finish the arikanchan or guard papers all night?’

Laughing, Madhavi answered, ‘Coming now.’

The two went toward the kitchen. The folded bundle of leaves was now ready to cut. Madhavi lifted the knife. As the first piece was cut, the layers inside opened into rounded lines—one body from the outside, many leaves within.

Hemlata stared in surprise. ‘Didi, you really can see every layer.’

Madhavi said, ‘I told you—a layer presses down; it does not erase.’

Devkant kept looking at the cut piece. He could have turned that moment into a metaphor for relationships. But he wrote nothing.

Madhavi looked at him. ‘No metaphor today?’

‘There is one,’ Devkant said, ‘but let it remain in my mind.’

A smile came to Madhavi’s face. ‘You are learning.’

‘For now?’

‘For now.’

Outside, the rain began to fall more lightly again. In the kitchen, pieces of arikanchan lay arranged amid the smell of kachu leaves, spices and hot steam.

Devkant’s pothi lay closed on the veranda. The private page was safe in its bundle.

That night the pothi recorded the working signs of the arikanchan method, the names of those who made it, and the boundary that it belonged to this particular household.

Nothing was written about Madhavi’s private page.

Sometimes, when something is not written, there is respect in the not-writing too.

CHAPTER 18

The Nameless Method

Two days after the first rain, the kadima vine burst into flower. In the morning they spread like yellow light; by noon some had begun to wilt. That was why Madhavi picked the flowers before the sun rose high. Not all of them—only those that were fresh, fully open, and showed no sign of insects or rot.

Seeing the flowers at the kitchen doorway, Janki said, “Make these today. Once the rains increase, the flowers will change.”

Devkant was gathering the previous night’s pages. Seeing the heap of flowers, he asked, “Kadima flowers?”

Madhavi said, “Yes. But watch the work before you write the name.”

The sentence was familiar to him now. He uncapped his pen, but wrote only the date and stopped.

Madhavi removed the hard portions of the flower stems. The tender flowers were cleaned and spread on a cloth. Janki had rice pithar brought. Salt, a little spice, and water were mixed into it. Madhavi said, “Thick enough to cling to the flower; not so thin that it runs off.”

Devkant laughed. “That sentence is on the tilkor page too.”

“The work may resemble it; the thing is not the same.”

“Then a new method?”

“New to you. In my grandmother’s house it was old.”

Devkant’s pen moved at once. “Your grandmother’s house?”

Madhavi stopped his hand. “The flower first.”

The flowers were dipped lightly in the pithar. Janki watched the heat of the oil. As soon as the first flower entered the oil, a light froth rose; the petals shrank and settled inside the coating of pithar.

Hemlata asked eagerly, “So this is tarua made from flowers?”

Madhavi said, “People here may call it that. In my grandmother’s house it had another name.”

Devkant stopped writing. “What name?”

Madhavi thought for a moment. “I remember the pronunciation correctly, but the written form should be checked. I want to ask my grandmother’s sister.”

“Then the heading?”

“Leave it blank for now.”

Devkant drew a line across the top of the page and left the space empty. The date remained below; the place for the name was blank.

Hemlata laughed. “A dish without a name?”

Janki said, “The name will come later. First, don’t burn it.”

The first flower was lifted out. The pithar coating had turned lightly golden, but the shape of the petals was still visible within it. Madhavi broke off a piece to inspect it—the flower was soft inside, the coating crisp outside.

Devkant wrote: ‘The flower should be tender; the pithar thick; the oil hot enough for the coating to set at once without burning the flower within.’

Madhavi read the page. “Good. But ‘crisp’ belongs under taste and texture, not under the rule.”

At the side Devkant wrote: ‘Texture: crisp outside, tender within.’

“Better now.”

In the second batch Hemlata dipped the flowers herself. She rolled one flower in the pithar too many times, making the coating thick.

Madhavi said, “Cover the flower; don’t smother it.”

Devkant paused just as he wrote the sentence.

“A metaphor?” Madhavi asked.

“This time I’ll keep quiet.”

“You’re learning.”

The scent of the flower was not entirely erased by the smell of oil. When Devkant tasted it, the flavour was wholly different from tilkor—the petals carried a faint sweetness, the pithar salt, and the oil warmth.

“What will I call this in English?” he asked.

Madhavi laughed. “First settle the Maithili name, then rescue the English.”

Devkant looked at the blank heading. The page was filling with the method, but where the name should have been there was a white empty space.

For now that white space meant something simple—verification pending. But an empty space was not always empty; sometimes it was where someone’s name should have stood.



After the flower tarua had gone onto the plate at noon, Devkant opened the page again. The heading was still blank. Below it were the method, an estimate of time, the state of the pithar, the signs for choosing the flowers—everything had been written. Leaving one line empty, he looked at Madhavi.

“Now, about your grandmother’s house?”

Madhavi sat down on the veranda. “I learned this from my grandmother. My grandmother learned it from her elder sister. The two sisters used to make it when the first flowers appeared with the rains.”

Devkant asked, “Your grandmother’s name?”

Without hesitation Madhavi said, “Dhaneshwari.”

Devkant wrote ‘Source’ on the page and left space after it, but did not immediately write the name.

Madhavi noticed. “What happened?”

“I was thinking—we should first settle the name of the dish, then complete the source line.”

“Why do those two things depend on each other?”

“The page will stay clean.”

Madhavi’s face did not change, but her voice hardened slightly. “The name of the dish needs verification. The name of the person you learned it from does not.”

Devkant was silent for a few moments. “That is true.”

But instead of writing the name, he made a small pencil mark. “I’ll put it in ink later.”

Madhavi asked, “Why later?”

“I’m completing the page now. I’ll write it all neatly at once.”

“Why do people’s names always come last on your neat pages?”

The question was direct.

Devkant said, “Not all of them.”

“You added Ramanand’s name later. Nasima’s immediately, because I told you to. On my tilkor page I signed my own name. And now my grandmother’s name is ‘later’ again.”

Devkant’s hand went still.

“I don’t leave them out deliberately.”

“Is leaving someone out always deliberate?”

He did not answer.

Madhavi continued, “You write the names of ingredients at once—flower, pithar, salt, oil. Why must the maker’s name wait for the page to become neat?”

Devkant pulled the page toward himself and opened his ink pen. He began writing, 'Source: learned by Madhavi from Dhaneshwari.' Halfway through, he stopped and asked, "Like this?"

Madhavi read it. "I learned it from my grandmother. My grandmother learned it from her elder sister. If we do not know the other name, write 'elder sister'; do not invent a name."

Devkant wrote: 'Madhavi's grandmother Dhaneshwari; according to her, a practice from the household of Dhaneshwari's elder sister.'

Madhavi looked at the page for a while. "Now at least the page knows that the method did not fall from the sky."

Devkant gave a small laugh. "A harsh sentence."

"Not harsh. An ordinary truth."

Just then Janki called from inside. Madhavi got up.

Left alone, Devkant looked at the page. The heading was blank, the source filled in. After a while he put a small pencil mark beside the source line, to remind himself that its position might need to change when he made the clean copy.

Then came the post, household accounts, other pages—the day moved on.

In the evening, when Devkant sat down to make the clean copy, the blank heading bothered him. He tried to transfer the source line, first written in pencil, onto another sheet. The ink spread a little. He dabbed it lightly with a cloth.

The first part of the word 'Madhavi' blurred.

Devkant immediately thought of writing it again, but at that very moment a voice came from outside—the postman had arrived.

He left the page open and got up.

He did not return to the page that night.

The next day Devkant's eyes fell on the blurred line. In pencil at the side he wrote, 'Complete in clean copy.'

The name of the dish was still blank. The source line was now half blurred.

Madhavi did not see the page that day.

Another small postponement was born.

*
**

In 2026, when Mrinalini reached that page of the Bhanas-Pothi, the first thing she noticed was the empty space in the heading. The date stood at the top of the page, and beneath it was a white strip that looked as though it had deliberately been left for a name.

The cooking method in the middle of the page was clear—tender kadima flowers, the thickness of the pithar, the heat of the oil, the texture of the flower. Reading the passage, Mrinalini could immediately tell that it was a dish like tarua made from kadima flowers. Why Devkant had left the heading blank was a different question.

Near the bottom of the page the colour of the ink changed. The original writing was a deep black-brown; one line was slightly paler; beside it was a fine pencil mark.

Mrinalini carried the page to the window. In the slanting light she saw a stain where ink had been wiped. Within the stain, traces of letter-forms had not been completely erased.

She took a photograph with her phone. Then another in slanting light. A third without glare.

Shashibhushan came to the doorway and asked, “What did you find?”

Without looking up, Mrinalini said, “A page.”

“The book is full of pages.”

“This page is like two pages inside itself.”

Shashibhushan laughed. “Your language is beginning to sound like Devkant’s.”

Mrinalini called him over and showed him the page. “Was there a name here or not?”

Shashibhushan adjusted his glasses and looked very closely. “It’s a stain. Old paper gets stains.”

“But there are letters inside the stain.”

“There may be letters. What does that prove?”

Mrinalini did not answer. She opened her laptop and transferred the photographs. When she enlarged the image, the paper fibres, the spread of the ink, and the pencil line became separately visible.

The blank heading at the top was ordinary empty space; the blurred line below was stranger.

Mrinalini remembered Madhavi’s Tirhuta signature she had seen earlier—the lettering whose photograph she had already preserved. She opened the old image and placed the two side by side.

Shashibhushan asked, “What are you comparing?”

“Not the hand. The name.”

“What name?”

Before answering, Mrinalini reduced the brightness of the image. Inside the stain were strokes resembling Devanagari letters, not Tirhuta. The first two or three signs suggested ‘Ma...’, but the full reading was impossible.

She made a note: ‘No certain reading. Possibly “Madh...”; physical examination of the original page required.’

Looking at the page, Shashibhushan said, “So you are guessing after all.”

Mrinalini answered at once, “I am recording an inference for now, not a fact.”

Shashibhushan said nothing.

Mrinalini remembered the rule she had written in her archival notebook—do not fill from yourself what you do not understand. That rule was becoming not merely a way of reading documents, but a basis for editing history.

She began making a complete transcription of the page. In place of the heading she wrote, ‘[blank]’. In place of the blurred source line: ‘[partial; possibly a name]’.

It was the first time she began reading Devkant’s Bhanas-Pothi not simply as a collection of food, but as a document of revision and erasure.



In the evening Mrinalini put all the old and new photographs into one folder. She named the folder ‘Page 43—Name/Source Check’. The page number followed the family’s old copy; since later editing might alter it, she also added a photograph of the original page to the file.

She enlarged the image heavily. The colour of the paper around the stain was normal, but there appeared to be slight abrasion over the letters. Whether something had been deliberately erased or merely wiped when the ink spread could not yet be concluded.

Mrinalini recorded that distinction explicitly. Calling it ‘erasure’ was tempting, but the evidence at present went no further than ‘wiped/abraded area’.

Then she looked again at pages from around 1934. In some places Devkant had corrected words later; in some, Madhavi had added marginal notes; in some, pencil marks were instructions for a later copy. Different-coloured ink, therefore, was not in itself evidence of wrongdoing.

But on this page three things appeared together: a blank heading; a blurred source line; and within that line, possibly the letters ‘Madh...’.

Mrinalini made not a new table, but a plain note:

1. Method complete. 2. Name of dish blank. 3. Source line in later/different ink. 4. One part of the line wiped. 5. In the wiped portion, possible letters resembling “Ma...” or “Madh...”. 6. Conclusion deferred.’

Ishan came in just then holding a sample menu for the restaurant. “I wanted to show you something—should we include kadima-flower tarua or not?”

Mrinalini looked from the screen to his menu. “Where did you get that name just now?”

“It used to be made at home. Basanti Kaki told me.”

“Fine. But in the book the heading of this method is blank.”

Ishan laughed. “Then write ‘kadima-flower tarua.’ The method is obviously that.”

“No.”

“Why? It’s clearly flower, pithar, oil—what else do you need?”

Mrinalini showed him the blurred line on the screen. “Because sometimes a name is blank for more than simple forgetfulness. And the source name is not clear either.”

Ishan’s smile faded. “Then what do we do?”

“First we verify it.”

“The restaurant opens in three months. If we keep verifying history, the flower season will pass.”

Mrinalini said, “The season will return. If a wrong attribution gets printed, that too will be repeated again and again.”

Ishan was quiet for a while. “You’re making this book very serious.”

“The book was serious already. I’m only beginning to see it.”

Ishan folded the menu. “All right. We won’t name the dish for now.”

“On the menu?”

“No. Not until it’s verified.”

Mrinalini looked at him. It was a small agreement, but an important one. In 1934 the blank space had been a postponement; in 2026 the same blank space could become caution.

After Ishan left, Mrinalini opened the image again. The line that looked like ‘Madh...’ was still indistinct. She could have written ‘Madhavi’. The evidence she had found so far pushed her in that direction; so did her own mind.

But she did not write it.

She wrote only the question: ‘Was this Madhavi’s name?’

For now the question mark seemed more necessary to her than an answer.

Before closing the file that night, she read the transcription of the original page once more. The method was complete—texture, heat, the way of choosing the flowers, everything. The line naming the source from whom the knowledge had come was blurred.

It struck Mrinalini that invisible labour is not always absent; sometimes its trace remains on the page, but the reader fails to notice it.

On this page the first solid suspicion had been born.

The question was no longer only why the Bhanas-Pothi contained two hands.

The question had become: whose name was written, whose name was deferred, and whose name later became so faint that the next generation might take it for a stain.

CHAPTER 19

The Road to Janakpur

Before dawn broke, preparations for the journey began in the courtyard. Janki tied chura, jaggery and sattu separately into a small cloth bundle. In another bag she put salt, green chillies, two onions and a lota for drinking water. Madhavi also packed a few pieces of dried mango.

Looking at the bundle, Devkant asked, "Will we need this much food on the road?"

Janki said, "The length of a road is not counted only in kos. The cart will stop, water will stop you, the sun will stop you, people will stop you. Hunger arrives first of all."

Madhavi added, "If you get water with chura, that is one way; sattu with water, another. Eat a little jaggery and the body keeps going. This is not a feast; it is support for the road."

Devkant reached for his notebook, then laughed at himself and stopped. "Eat first, write afterwards?"

Janki was pleased. "Now you have learned something."

The party was small—Devkant, Madhavi, Hemlata, an elderly household servant named Gonu, and two bullock carts. One cart carried the luggage; on the other, people took turns sitting and getting down. For much of the road it was easier to walk, especially where the carts got stuck in unpaved hollows.

Signs of the January earthquake were still visible in many places. Someone's wall stood only half rebuilt, someone else had a new thatched roof; here and there heaps of earth lay beside the road. The heat was increasing, but the rains had not yet properly arrived.

Devkant was trying to make a map of the road towards Jayanagar. At one point Gonu said, "On paper this road will be straight; on the ground, it is not."

"Why?"

"A channel that was small yesterday may swell today and send the cart another way. A map does not know whose field embankment has broken."

Madhavi looked at Devkant. "The line first, the ground afterwards?"

Devkant said, "Not now. The ground first."

When the sun rose higher, the party stopped in the shade of a peepal tree. The bundle was opened. Chura was passed from hand to hand. Someone had water in a lota; someone had a small pot of curd bought in a village along the road. The jaggery was broken into small pieces.

Eating chura and curd mixed with jaggery, Hemlata said, "Better than eating from a plate at home."

Madhavi asked, "Why?"

"Because there are no pots to wash here."

Everyone burst out laughing.

Holding chura in his hand, Devkant asked, "Does food for a journey have a different name?"

Madhavi said, "The food need not change its name. The context changes. At home chura and curd are a meal; on the road the same chura is support. Meaning changes with the plate."

This time Devkant made a note.

A little farther on the sun grew harsh. The driver slowed the bullocks. Hemlata, tired from walking, climbed onto the cart. Madhavi was still on foot.

Devkant asked, "Won't you sit?"

"I will. For now I like walking."

"The sun?"

"The sun is watching me and I am watching the sun. We are both doing our own work."

Devkant laughed.

After a while Madhavi herself climbed onto the cart. There was an empty place beside Devkant, but she sat beside Hemlata. Devkant wanted to give this small choice some meaning, then remembered his rule—do not fill in from yourself what you do not know.

He turned his eyes back to the map.

As afternoon advanced, the party moved towards the border. On paper, the state would change; the road, dust, language and sunlight were still the same.



When they reached the border, the difference that had existed in Devkant's mind was not so clearly visible on the ground. There were posts here, a checkpoint there, the voices of officials elsewhere—but among them people

bargained in their own speech, drove bullocks, lifted bundles and moved back and forth.

Gonu said quietly, "From here it is Nepalese territory."

Hemlata looked around. "What changed?"

"The state," Devkant answered.

"And the soil?"

"Not the soil."

Madhavi said, "People marry across here too. Someone's natal home is on one side, someone's marital home on the other. A line does not cut kinship."

Just then two women approached from ahead. One asked in Maithili, "Are you going to Janakpur?"

Madhavi said yes. The woman gave them information about the condition of the road, water farther ahead and the crowd in the market. Some sounds in her pronunciation were different, but what she said was easily understood.

Devkant listened very carefully. After the women had gone on, he asked, "A little different from the speech of your village?"

Madhavi said, "Yes. But not so much that it feels like another language. Even sisters in one house do not always speak exactly alike."

Devkant wrote: 'Across the border pronunciation changes; understanding does not break down.'

Madhavi looked at the page. "Everywhere? Will you write that on the basis of one encounter?"

Devkant immediately added: 'In this encounter, on this road.'

"Now it is right."

A little market lay ahead. Curd, chura, fruit, oil, cloth, areca nut, paan—many things. Devkant's ear caught a vendor's cry. He was calling out 'chiura.'

Hemlata laughed and said to Madhavi, "Chura has become chiura."

The vendor heard her and smiled. "You people say chura? Some people here say chiura."

Devkant immediately went closer. "The same thing?"

The vendor said, "Look."

In front of him lay flattened rice. Devkant examined a handful.

Madhavi said, "Note the difference in the name, but do not write that everyone in Nepal says 'chiura.'"

Devkant laughed. "You cut my sentence before I have written it."

"Better to stop it beforehand than cut it afterwards."

A song could be heard in the market. Much of its wording resembled a wedding song heard in a village on the other side, though a few lines differed. Hemlata picked up the tune easily.

Madhavi said, "Look—the song does not show papers at the border."

Devkant wanted to write the sentence, then asked, "Under your name?"

"Write it."

He wrote: 'Madhavi: A song does not show papers at the border.'

A little later Gonu looked for water to mix sattv. A shopkeeper gave him water from an earthen pitcher. Sattu was mixed into it with a little salt and chilli. The shopkeeper asked, "No jaggery?"

Gonu said, "We eat the jaggery separately."

The shopkeeper laughed. "I sometimes mix it in."

Devkant watched this small variation. The same ingredients, another way.

Madhavi said, "Write this—the borders of food are not straight like the lines on a map."

Devkant asked, "Where does this end?"

"Where you stop writing, 'Everyone does it this way.'"

The day was declining. Janakpur was not far now, but in this small market on the road Devkant understood clearly for the first time: a political border might be a line; cultural borders were like many overlapping circles.

In Maithili he wrote: 'One line; many circles of life.'



On reaching Janakpur, Devkant's first impulse was to make a map of the town, marking the ponds, temples, markets, the dharmashala and the main roads. The party lodged at a dharmashala. After the luggage had been put down, Madhavi said, "First walk through the town and see it. Make the map afterwards."

Devkant agreed.

The town was crowded. Pilgrims, local people, traders, sadhus, children, fish sellers, paan vendors, cloth shops—voices rose over one another. Devkant's ear kept catching names.

At one place he saw something that looked like bagiya, but the vendor called it by another name. Devkant immediately asked about it.

Madhavi stopped him. "First see whether it really is the same thing, or whether only the shape resembles it."

The vendor laughed and showed them the filling. The kind of pithar, the filling and the method of cooking were somewhat different from the bagiya made at home.

Devkant wrote: 'A similar appearance does not establish the same name or method.'

Madhavi said, "That rule is not only for food."

"For people too?"

"You are back to metaphors."

Both laughed.

At another shop chura was being called 'chiura'; at times the same people also said 'chura.' Devkant noted: "The same speaker uses both forms."

Madhavi said, "Language does not live in separate colours on a map. People take words from one another and give them back."

Devkant was excited by the idea. Back at the dharmashala he opened a sheet of paper. His route lay to the south, Janakpur to the north-east, the border-line between them. Over it he began writing words—chura/chiura; two lines from a song; the same name for paan; a few differences of pronunciation.

Madhavi watched.

"What?" Devkant asked.

"You are drawing lines again."

"Carefully this time."

"A line is useful. But do not mistake the line for the whole shape of truth."

Devkant looked at the border on the map. "Then what should I do?"

Madhavi took a blank sheet. She drew a straight border-line, then made small arrows across it—marriage, song, market, pilgrimage, words, food.

"This?"

"Movement. Keep the line, but show what travels across it as well."

Devkant's face lit up. "This map will go into the book."

Madhavi immediately said, "My name?"

Devkant laughed. "Map—at Madhavi's suggestion."

"Not suggestion. I drew the arrows."

Devkant lifted his pen and wrote: 'Arrows showing cross-border movement: Madhavi.'

Madhavi was satisfied.

Hemlata, sitting beside them looking at the map, said, "My arrow too?"

"Which one is yours?" Devkant asked.

“The song. The tune I picked up in the market can be sung on this side too.”

Beside one arrow Devkant wrote: ‘Song—heard/repeated by Hemlata.’

Hemlata smiled proudly.

At night the dharmashala served chura-curd, some vegetables and paan. Looking at the plate, Devkant said, “The country changed on paper; the plate is not completely unfamiliar.”

Madhavi said, “Do not call everything the same merely because it is familiar.”

“Why is every sentence of yours a warning?”

“Because every familiar thing makes you start building a general rule.”

Devkant laughed. “Less now.”

“Less, but not finished.”

That night the map remained open beside the cot. The border-line was clear; Madhavi’s arrows crossing it seemed more alive.



The next day the main temple complex and the market in Janakpur were more crowded than the day before. The party was walking together, but near the entrance the crowd suddenly thickened. Hemlata took the hand of an elderly woman pilgrim known to Janki and moved ahead; Gonu stopped behind to manage the luggage.

Devkant paused for only two moments in front of a shop—something there looked like a copy of an old palm-leaf manuscript. When he raised his head, Madhavi was no longer near him.

He looked around. Yellow, red and white cloth; garlands of flowers; incense smoke; paan shops; children’s voices; bells. Madhavi was nowhere.

For the first moment he thought—she must have gone ahead with Hemlata.

The second—perhaps towards the market.

In the third moment the sequence of thought broke.

Devkant pushed through the crowd and moved forward. He found Hemlata, but not Madhavi.

“Didi?” Hemlata herself asked.

The moment she saw Devkant’s face, her smile vanished.

Gonu came up from behind and said, “She had gone with all of you.”

Something cold ran through Devkant’s body. Janakpur was not an unfamiliar town; he understood the language, the people were not unknown

enemies—yet the moment one person vanished in the crowd, the whole town became uncertain.

He looked in three directions: towards the temple, towards the pond road, towards the turn into the market.

“Hemlata, stay here. Gonu, stay with her.”

He himself went towards the market. Fast at first, then almost running.

A little farther on Madhavi was standing near a paan shop with an elderly woman who had become confused while asking directions; Madhavi was explaining the way to the dharmashala.

Devkant stopped as soon as he saw her.

Madhavi saw him too. “What happened?”

For a few moments Devkant could not speak.

“Where is Hemlata?” Madhavi asked.

“Safe.”

“Then?”

Devkant’s breathing was still fast. “You came here without saying anything...”

Madhavi’s eyebrow lifted slightly. “I came two steps to show this old woman the way.”

“Two steps were too many.”

The sentence escaped him.

They both fell silent. The old woman said thank you and went on.

Madhavi asked quietly, “Too many—why?”

Devkant searched for an answer. The ordinary answer was the crowd, an unfamiliar town, safety. But he knew the fear had not merely been about order being broken.

He said, “For one moment I thought I might not find you.”

Madhavi’s face softened, though she did not immediately smile.

Devkant continued, “And in that moment... I understood how much your absence changes me outside the book, the notes, the journey—all of it.”

Madhavi’s eyes remained fixed on Devkant.

“Is this a declaration of love?” she asked very softly.

Devkant started. “I—”

A slight smile came to Madhavi’s face. “Do not answer in haste. You write in haste, and in haste you make meanings too.”

Devkant laughed as well, though relief was still trembling through his body.

“Then what should I say?”

"For now, only that you found me."

"And that I was afraid?"

"That is your experience. Do not cut it out."

They began walking back together. The crowd was just as thick, but its noise seemed less sharp to Devkant.

After they had walked some distance Madhavi asked, "What if I really had disappeared?"

Devkant answered at once, "I would have kept looking."

"For how long?"

"As long as it took."

Madhavi said nothing.

Near the temple entrance Hemlata was waving from a distance. The moment she saw the two of them together she called, "Didi has been found!"

Devkant answered, "Yes."

Hemlata laughed and said to Madhavi, "You should have seen the writer-babu's face!"

Madhavi looked at Devkant. "I saw it."

That evening at the dharmashala Devkant opened his notebook. The day's journey, market, temple, crowd—everything was material for writing. But he left one page blank.

Madhavi asked, "Nothing to write today?"

"I'll write the border, the words, the map—all of that. Not this one thing."

"Why?"

Devkant said, "Because this is not a source for the book. This is my fear."

Madhavi looked at him for a few moments. "Then that is right."

Devkant turned the page. On the next page the border-line and the arrows crossing it were drawn.

It seemed to him that some distances could be measured on a map; some distances were revealed only in the moment when someone's absence suddenly became unbearable.

He did not write that sentence either.

Outside that night, the bells of Janakpur mingled with the sound of a distant song. The political border had been crossed; inside Devkant, another border had for the first time become clearly visible.

CHAPTER 20

Rain

On the third day after returning from Janakpur, the colour of the sky began changing from early morning. Clouds gathered first in the east, then, without haste, covered the whole sky. The air carried that smell from just before rain, when the earth itself seems to hold its breath and wait.

The moment Janki saw the small heap of paddy spread in the courtyard, she called Hemlata. “Bring in everything that is outside. Clothes, baskets, papers—leave nothing.”

Madhavi ran to gather the remaining amat that had been set on the roof to dry. On the veranda, Devkant was separating his word-list from the map of Janakpur.

The first drop was large. It made a round mark in the dust of the courtyard. The second, the third, the tenth—and within moments there was no longer any point in counting drops. The rain suddenly grew so dense that the mango tree ahead was half blurred from sight.

Standing near the door, Hemlata cried out, “Didi! The other basket of amat!”

Gathering up her wet anchal, Madhavi went out again. Devkant began to rise, but Janki stopped him. “See to the papers. Madhavi is there.”

Devkant paused for a moment. On the veranda table the pothi, the English article, the map of Janakpur, several Tirhuta practice sheets—all lay open. The wind was throwing drops inside.

He began gathering the pages and carrying them into the inner room.

Madhavi came back carrying the basket of amat. Water was dripping from her head. “One is saved.”

“One?” Devkant asked.

“Some pieces in the smaller basket got wet. I have kept them separate. When we get sun again, we will see what can be saved.”

Janki said, “Do not put wet dried provisions into storage without examining them. If damp remains inside, everything will spoil.”

The moment Devkant heard this, he began looking for a page. Madhavi saw him. "Now?"

"This is useful."

"Close the window first."

Laughing, Devkant shut the wooden window-panel. The sound of the rain was a little duller now, but the continuous drumming of water on the roof still filled the house.

By noon, water had collected on the road. A small current began running through the lower corner of the courtyard. The outdoor hearth went out; the cooking shifted indoors.

Janki inspected the stores. Fresh greens would be difficult to bring in, and no one knew what condition the road to the market was in. She examined the dal, rice, dried provisions, pickle, older adauri and amat one by one.

Devkant asked, "On the first day of rain, is the meal decided in advance?"

Janki said, "The rain decides how much of what was decided can still happen. First we look at what is safe in the house."

Madhavi opened a tin and looked at the adauri. "This will be useful now. What was dried on sunny days does its work on rainy ones."

Devkant wrote: 'The labour of sunlight becomes food in the rains.'

Janki did not look at the page, but hearing him, she said, "You have written it beautifully. But write this too: if we had been lazy on the sunny days, the tin would be empty today."

Hemlata laughed. "Write the history of laziness today."

Madhavi said, "Not laziness. The work of thinking about the days ahead."

The meal was simple—rice, dal, a curry of adauri, pickle. Not because of the rain, but because of what was available.

Looking at his plate, Devkant said, "There are fewer fresh things, but the meal is not incomplete."

Madhavi replied, "The household stores speak with the seasons. What was kept in winter, what was dried in summer, answers in the rains."

Outside, the rain went on falling. Inside the house rose the smells of dried foods. Devkant understood that the history of food was not only what grew in a field; what was saved and kept mattered just as much.



The rain did not stop on the third day either. Sometimes it came fine, sometimes in thick streams. The earth in the courtyard softened, and fewer

bullock carts were seen on the road. People bringing fresh produce from the market arrived late or turned back.

In the kitchen, the storage tins now began to open more often. Amat one day, pickle the next, dried greens here, adauri there. Janki always smelled each item first—checking for damp, mould, insects, staleness.

Hemlata asked, “Dried things do not spoil, do they?”

Janki said, “Being dried does not mean becoming immortal. Air, damp, the container, the hand—everything has to be watched.”

Madhavi added, “Whatever we save has to be cared for again and again.”

Devkant wrote down the sentence. Beside it he made a note to himself: ‘Collecting and preserving are different kinds of work.’

Madhavi read the page. “This is useful for the book.”

“For papers too?”

“For everything that wants to cross time.”

Devkant looked at her. The private pages, Madhavi’s signature, the nameless method—all came into his mind together.

At noon a young man from a neighbouring house came into the courtyard, wringing out his wet dhoti. He brought news: people were saying that the water was rising towards the Kamla-Balan; some low-lying fields had already gone under water. The report was not certain, but anxiety was spreading through the village.

Janki asked, “Who said so?”

“People coming back from the market.”

“Did you see it yourself?”

“No.”

Madhavi looked at Devkant. The same expression came over both their faces.

Devkant asked, “Should I write, ‘The water is rising?’”

Madhavi said, “Write, ‘There is a report.’ Do not write what has not been seen as though it were seen.”

On the page he wrote: ‘Report in the village: talk of rising water towards the Kamla-Balan. Not directly verified.’

The young man laughed. “If news moves with this much caution, will it ever reach anyone?”

Madhavi said, “Wrong news runs fast. Nothing is lost if a true thing travels slowly.”

By evening another report arrived—a drainage channel had overflowed, some roads were closed. The men of the house began discussing moving the bullocks, paddy, papers and essential things to higher ground.

Janki ordered the grain from the storeroom to be shifted to the upper room. Madhavi began counting the tins. Hemlata wrote the list.

Devkant asked, “Why the food inventory first?”

Janki said, “If water comes into the house, hunger will not first ask which books you saved.”

The sentence was harsh, but true.

Madhavi immediately said, “The papers will be saved too. But first the body must be kept alive.”

Devkant nodded.

That night less rice was cooked; chura, sattu and jaggery were tied separately and kept ready in case the hearth went out. Water was boiled and filled into an earthen pot.

Hemlata asked, “Why does all this feel like a journey?”

Madhavi said, “Disaster turns the house into a journey. Who knows in which corner we may be sitting to eat in the next watch of the night?”

Devkant noted the line with the speaker’s name.

Amid the sound of rain that night, no one slept properly. From time to time came the sound of someone’s feet, a door opening, someone checking the water in the courtyard, someone looking in on the bullocks in the cowshed.

Devkant understood that stored food was not merely a matter of culinary skill; in an unsafe season it was a way of buying time. A small tin of adauri could spare the household from depending on the road to the market for a day.

He made a page out of the thought, but wrote at the top: ‘Experience of this household.’

Madhavi read it and said, “Now the book is a little less arrogant.”



On the morning of the fifth day the rain eased a little, but the sky did not clear. The outer edge of the veranda was wet. Seeing an opportunity, Devkant spread the papers out where they could get some air—not full sunlight, only the hope of reducing the damp.

The moment Madhavi saw them she said, “Not so far out. The clouds will close in again.”

“There is too little air inside the veranda.”

“Then keep changing their places in turn.”

Devkant spread the pages over a high wooden platform. The map of Janakpur, the tilkor pages, arikanchan, amat, the nameless method—all separately.

Hemlata laughed. “After the food, now the papers are drying.”

Devkant said, “Paper too is something kept in storage.”

Madhavi corrected him at once. “Paper is not merely a thing. There is also the place of the person whose name is on it.”

Devkant looked towards the page of the nameless method. The blurred source-line still troubled him.

Madhavi picked up that page. “Will we make this clear again?”

“We will. First I’ll hear the whole source from you—tora—again and write it down.”

“Tora?” Madhavi raised her eyes.

Devkant stopped. “From you—ahan.”

Hemlata smiled.

Devkant said, “That was a mistake.”

Madhavi said, “The mistake is acknowledged. That is enough.”

Just then, without warning, the wind rose hard. The clouds outside suddenly darkened. Madhavi began gathering the pages.

At the first drop Devkant picked up two bundles and ran inside. Hemlata gathered the remaining pages. A thin sheet was blown towards the lower edge of the veranda, where water was dripping in a stream from the roof.

Madhavi lunged and picked it up. One corner of the page was already wet. The ink had begun to spread.

“Whose is it?” Devkant asked.

Straightening the page, Madhavi said, “The fish notes. Nasima’s name is in this corner.”

Devkant’s face fell. “The ink?”

“It is spreading. Do not rub it with cloth.”

Madhavi laid the page on a flat surface. She placed a dry cloth underneath it, but put no pressure on top. She moved it near the window, towards the side from which the air was bringing less moisture.

Janki came in and said, “Keep the lamp away. If the paper catches fire, what use will it be to have saved the ink?”

Madhavi said, “Yes.”

Some pages were stood on edge, some laid flat. Those that had stuck together were not forced apart.

Devkant was restless. "Will Nasima's name survive?"

Madhavi looked at the spreading ink. The letters were blurred, but still recognisable. "Perhaps. Let it dry."

"And if it does not?"

"Is her name in another note?"

Devkant began searching at once. He found the market page—'Nasima: buying fish is not only looking at the fish...'

"It is."

"Then one source can save another source."

Devkant stopped.

Madhavi said, "That is why copies, transcriptions, names—all should be kept in different places. If one page gets wet, an entire person should not disappear."

The sentence sank into Devkant. He looked at the first page of the pothi, where so much knowledge had been written in only one place.

Hemlata stood clutching her practice notebook tightly. Devkant looked at her. "Is your notebook dry?"

"Yes."

"Wherever you have copied Didi's words, keep all of it safe."

Hemlata said proudly, "Of course I will."

Madhavi looked at her for a moment, but said nothing.

The rain strengthened again. Inside the house, both the grain tins and the paper pages were now on higher ground.

For the first time Devkant understood clearly that saving food and saving documents, though different kinds of work, met at one point: the hungers of the future could be different. Grain for the hunger of the body; names for the hunger of memory.



By night the fish page was half dry. Nasima's name was blurred, but could still be read. Devkant breathed with relief.

Holding the page, Madhavi said, "Now make another copy of it. Keep the original separately."

Devkant said, "Now?"

"Yes. After seeing a page get wet, will you still say 'tomorrow'?"

Devkant smiled. "All right."

He opened a clean sheet of paper. First line—the date. Second—the market. Third—Nasima’s name.

Madhavi said, “You wrote the name first?”

“The order has changed now.”

“The rain taught you?”

“The rain, you, Nasima, the blurred ink—all of you.”

A faint smile came to Madhavi’s face.

Devkant completed the copy. At the bottom of the original page he wrote in pencil: ‘Wet in the rains; copy made on such-and-such date.’

“Why this?” Hemlata asked.

“So that people later do not think the blurred letters were like this in the original. A page’s history must be written too.”

Madhavi nodded. “Keep that point.”

A little later she began counting the remaining pages of the Bhanas-Pothi. One page was missing.

Devkant started. “Which one?”

Madhavi counted again. “The Janakpur map with the arrows?”

Hemlata said, “I put that inside.”

After a long search the map was found inside a book. Everyone burst out laughing. The tension eased a little.

Janki called from the kitchen, “You paper people, the food is getting cold!”

They went inside. There was less rice on the plate, thick dal, a curry of adauri, pickle. On the fifth day of rain the same kinds of ingredients had appeared again, but the taste did not seem monotonous.

Hemlata said, “The rain has made me friends with adauri.”

Janki replied, “When it was being made in the sun, you used to run away.”

“Now I understand.”

Madhavi said, “Work for the future looks tedious in the present.”

Devkant teased her. “Should I write that line under your name?”

“Eat. Not every line belongs in the book.”

Laughter rose again.

After the meal Devkant placed the pages in a high chest. Dry cloth underneath, thin wooden slats between them so that air could move. He no longer kept the papers merely heaped together as before; he made small bundles by subject, each with a name on it.

Madhavi asked, “A new arrangement?”

“If one bundle gets wet, not everything will.”

“And if one name exists in only one place?”

Devkant thought. “Then that too needs a copy somewhere else.”

“That is all.”

That night the rain eased somewhat. Water kept dripping from the roof, but there was no continuous roar.

Sitting on the veranda, Devkant kept looking at the copy of the fish notes, the original page and Hemlata’s practice notebook.

As Madhavi gathered the remaining pages, she said, “Let the papers survive, and let people’s names survive too.”

Devkant put his pen to the sentence at once. “May I write this?”

“Write it. This time it belongs in the book.”

Under her name he wrote: ‘Madhavi: Let the papers survive, and let people’s names survive too.’

After a few moments Devkant asked, “What if the paper survives, but not the name?”

Madhavi replied, “Then only half has survived.”

“And if the name survives, but not the story?”

“Then a road for searching has survived.”

Devkant did not close the page. He read the sentence again. Outside there was water in the darkness; inside the storeroom were adauri, amat, pickle, chura, dal—and papers in the chest.

Both kinds of keeping were for the next day.

That night, for the first time, the pothi was becoming something more than a book of culinary methods—a house in which, beside taste, there was room for sources, names, stains, wet corners, copies and care.

CHAPTER 21

Adauri

For the first time after five days of rain, the morning sky opened completely. The last clouds of the night had moved east, and when the sun rose the light fell across the wet bricks of the courtyard so strikingly that everyone in the house looked up once. Janki's first sentence was not praise of the weather — "Let today's sunlight not go to waste."

Madhavi looked through the kitchen stores. A portion of dal had been soaked the night before. She called Hemlata and said, "If the sun holds, we'll set out adauri. First clean that corner of the courtyard where the shade won't reach until afternoon."

The moment Devkant heard the word "adauri," he started to open his notebook, then stopped himself. Madhavi smiled. "Progress."

"First I'll watch," Devkant said.

The soaked dal was ground. Madhavi made it clear that they should record the way adauri was made in this household; the proportions, spices or shapes might differ in another house. On the first line Devkant wrote: 'Method in this household.'

Madhavi tested the consistency of the ground dal with a finger. Hemlata asked, "Why is it this thick?"

"So that when you place it down, it holds its place. If it is too thin, it will spread; if it is too stiff, moisture may remain inside while it dries."

Devkant asked, "Shall I write down a measurement for this?"

Madhavi lifted a little dal on a spoon to show him. "Write a measurement if this household has a fixed measure. But also write the sign—the spoonful should fall into a mound and stand, not run like water."

Devkant wrote it down.

A clean cloth was spread in the courtyard. Janki said, "The cloth must not be damp. If moisture rises from the ground beneath it, what can the sun do from above?"

Madhavi dropped small portions one after another. One, then another, then a third—not an obsession with making them exactly the same size, but not so different that some would dry first while others remained wet inside.

When Hemlata tried for the first time, her adauri leaned to one side.

Janki laughed. “Is that an adauri or a little mountain?”

Hemlata made a face. “Even a mountain becomes small when you eat it.”

Madhavi showed her the movement of the hand. “Bring the spoon lower; don’t drop it from too high. The distance of the hand changes the shape too.”

Devkant wrote the sentence: ‘Distance too is part of the method.’

Madhavi looked at him. “That is right.”

Before long rows of adauri had formed on the cloth. The sun grew warm, but Madhavi kept looking up at the sky. Two or three light clouds in the west did not escape her notice.

Devkant asked, “Is sunlight this important?”

Janki replied, “Setting out adauri is not only making it; drying it properly is half the work. If rain comes midway, gather everything up and wait for another chance.”

Madhavi said, “That is why we begin on a sunny day. But the sun gives no written guarantee.”

Devkant laughed. “The weather makes no contracts.”

“The weather does not read contracts,” Madhavi said.

By noon the outer surface of the adauri had firmed a little. When Hemlata reached out to touch one, Madhavi stopped her. “Not yet. It looks firm outside; it may still be wet inside.”

Devkant’s pen moved of its own accord: ‘A dry appearance outside is not proof of the condition within.’

Madhavi looked at the page. “That is your sentence.”

“Yes. Under my own name.”

From a distance Janki called, “Don’t burn the food while writing the pothi.”

Everyone laughed. Sunlight filled the courtyard; the small bodies of the adauri were giving up water for the sake of the future.



While the adauri remained in the sun, Hemlata had a separate lesson. In the shade of the veranda, Madhavi set paper before her and taught her to write Tirhuta. The practice notebook saved during the rainy days was dry now; its edges had curled a little, but the letters were safe.

“The belly of this letter is backwards again,” Madhavi said.

Hemlata said, “Do letters have bellies?”

“They do today, because I need a way to explain it to you. Tomorrow I may give it another name.”

“Then shall I write in the notebook—belly of the letter?”

Devkant heard from a distance and laughed. “No. Otherwise, a hundred years from now, people will believe Tirhuta had a rule called the belly.”

Madhavi said, “See? Even a bad joke can become history.”

Hemlata made a serious face and went on writing.

After a few lines, Madhavi did not take the pen from her hand; she wrote her own model beside it on the page. “Look. I will not correct your letter by erasing it. The correct form goes beside it. Let both survive.”

Hearing this, Devkant came closer. “Why preserve an incorrect page?”

“So that the path of learning remains visible. If every mistake is erased, people later will think everything was right the first time.”

Devkant was silent for a moment. The English writer’s crossed-out line, the blurred source, the rain-soaked page about fish—all rose together in his memory.

He said, “Then keep the earlier form along with the correction?”

“Where possible. Especially if the difference affects meaning.”

Hemlata asked, “Even my bad handwriting?”

Madhavi laughed. “Your practice is not a great document of history. But it is useful to you.”

Devkant said, “Who decides which document is great?”

Madhavi looked at him. “Do not answer that question too quickly.”

Hemlata began writing again. Words formed on the paper. In one line Madhavi taught her to write ‘adauri’—first showing the name in Devanagari, then writing the Tirhuta form with her own hand on a separate sheet.

Hemlata said, “I’ll keep this in my notebook.”

“Keep it,” Madhavi said. “And write—adauri was set out today.”

“The date?”

“Yes. Write the date. Later, memory changes the day.”

Devkant immediately checked the date on his own page. “Mine is there.”

“Good. If date, name and source become friends, people later will lose their way less often.”

Hemlata added the date to her practice notebook. Then she ran towards the courtyard to look at the adauri.

The edges of one or two had dried and lifted slightly. Madhavi turned them gently to inspect them but did not flip them yet. "If you hurry, they will break."

Hemlata said, "Letters break too if you write them in a hurry."

Madhavi smiled. "Now you have started making metaphors."

Devkant said, "My school is growing."

Madhavi immediately replied, "The school is mine. You two are the students."

Hemlata burst out laughing. Devkant nodded. "Credit made clear."

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The next morning the sun came out again, though the dampness in the air had not lessened much. Madhavi examined the previous day's adauri one by one. Those that had firmed on top were carefully turned so the other side could receive sunlight as well.

Janki said, "This looks like the smallest task in the house—grind dal, drop little portions, leave them in the sun. But miss the timing and the whole labour can be spoiled."

Devkant asked, "Is adauri mainly for rainy days?"

Madhavi replied, "Rain, scarcity, an immediate need, a shortage of fresh vegetables—there are many circumstances. Do not reduce it to one reason."

"Then?"

"Write that the labour of a sunny day becomes one support for food on days ahead."

Devkant wrote it down.

Janki added, "And write this too: if you eat the dal now, it is one day's food. Make adauri and keep it safely, and it can serve a little at a time on many later days."

Devkant asked, "Securing the future?"

Madhavi said, "That is a large phrase. But yes—keeping something aside for days of hunger."

Devkant's attention caught on that sentence. "An answer to the fear of hunger?"

Madhavi thought for a moment. "Not fear alone. Understanding too. Knowing the season, how many people are in the house, how much dal there is, what may be available next month—reckoning with all of that."

"Then preservation is not only fear; it is planning."

“Yes. But the moment you write the word planning, do not forget that hands do the work. Dal does not turn itself into adauri.”

At the top of the page Devkant gave a small heading: ‘Labour for the days ahead.’

Madhavi read it and said, “That is right.”

At noon Hemlata picked up an adauri and asked, “Can I eat this now?”

Janki said, “Do not eat raw dried adauri. It will go into a curry later.”

Hemlata looked disappointed. “I’ve been looking at it for two days and still can’t eat it.”

Madhavi laughed. “Not everything meant for the future can be eaten at once.”

Devkant lifted his pen.

Madhavi gave him a look. “No. That was only to tease Hemlata.”

Devkant put the pen back. “No household laughter in the pothi?”

“Not all of it. That rule has been stated before.”

Hemlata protested, “I want this written down.”

Madhavi looked at her. “Then have it written under your name.”

Laughing, Devkant wrote: ‘After looking at the adauri for two days, Hemlata asked—Can I eat it now? Janki said no.’

Hemlata was delighted. “Now hunger has survived in history.”

Janki said, “The history of your hunger will be very large.”

The courtyard filled with laughter.

In the evening the adauri were brought inside. The pieces that had dried completely were kept apart; those that retained a little moisture were set aside for the next spell of sun. Janki did not put everything into a single container.

Devkant asked, “Why?”

Madhavi said, “One damp piece can spoil the whole container. Examine them one by one before storing them.”

Devkant’s eyes moved involuntarily towards the bundles of papers. One faulty source, one faulty generalisation, one erased name—could that too change an entire pothi?

He did not write down the metaphor. He wrote only the date and ‘this household’ on the container of adauri.

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On the third day of the adauri, Devkant went out in the afternoon with an acquaintance. Janki was in the storeroom, Madhavi with the kitchen accounts. Hemlata sat in the shade of the veranda with her practice notebook.

A bundle of Madhavi's shared pages lay on the table—adauri, amat, tilkor, bagiya, fish, several source lines. The private pages marked with the leaf sign were closed in a separate bundle.

At first Hemlata continued practising her letters. Then she looked at the adauri page. Madhavi's Tirhuta note was at the side; Devkant's Devanagari original was in the middle.

She asked Madhavi, "May I copy this page?"

Madhavi was busy with her work. "Wherever there is the shared mark, you may. Not the private pages marked with the leaf."

Hemlata checked the bundle. The adauri page was shared. In her practice notebook she first copied the title, then the date, then the source line. She kept looking back at the letters as she wrote.

After a while she began to enjoy it. This was no longer merely practice; an entire page was being born again through her hand.

After the adauri page she copied the amat page, then one on tilkor. Wherever Madhavi's small Tirhuta signature appeared, instead of copying the signature itself she wrote in Devanagari inside brackets: 'Madhavi's signature.'

Madhavi came closer and looked. "You did not copy the signature?"

Hemlata said, "The signature is Didi's. I wrote that your signature is there."

Satisfaction came over Madhavi's face. "That was sensible."

"Devkant Babu said—whose hand it is, that person's name."

"He did say that," Madhavi said softly.

Hemlata picked up the next page. It held part of the nameless method in blurred ink, with a rubbed-looking mark in the source line.

"This one?"

Madhavi looked at the page for a few moments. "Leave this for now."

"Why?"

"A clean copy of it will be made later."

Hemlata set the page aside.

Then she began copying the page about fish, writing Nasima's name clearly. Seeing the wet corner of the original page from the rain, she added a note to her copy: 'Original page was wet in the rain.'

Madhavi asked, "Who said that?"

"Devkant Babu wrote it on the original."

"Then that is all right."

Hemlata became so absorbed in her work that she did not realise she was doing more than practising Tirhuta. She was making a second life for a document.

Madhavi too, at that moment, did not see it as evidence that might one day prove decisive. To her it was her younger sister's lesson in letters, an exercise in identifying sources, and a safe copy of papers made vulnerable by the rain.

Devkant returned in the evening. Hemlata eagerly showed him her practice notebook. "Look, I copied three pages."

Devkant turned the pages. "Aduari, amat, tilkor... Nasima's page too?"

"Yes."

"Very good. But do not copy a mistake merely because it is in the original."

From a distance Madhavi said, "Show the mistake; do not erase it. Write the correction beside it."

Devkant said, "Yes. I accept that rule now too."

On the first page of her practice notebook Hemlata wrote: 'Where the original is crossed out or blurred, write it as such; do not make it clear on your own.'

Devkant read the line and smiled. "My editor is getting ready."

Hemlata said proudly, "I will write my own history—remember?"

Devkant stopped. "I remember."

Madhavi looked at her too. For a moment the small laugh from the day of the bagiya returned among the three of them.

From inside Janki called, "All you writers of history, bring in the adauri! The evening damp is coming."

Hemlata shut the notebook and ran.

The original pages remained on the table. Her practice notebook lay in a corner of the veranda—the writing of an ordinary adolescent girl, uneven letters, corrections, dates, names, sources.

No one yet knew that one day this ordinary copy would come forward with a clearer voice than the original pages.

In the courtyard the last batch of adauri was being carried inside. The sunlight had finished its work for the day. As water diminished, time increased in its place—for food, and for paper too.

CHAPTER 22

The Fold of the Pirukiya

When the long spell of rain eased a little, the house brightened with preparations for the festival. The courtyard was washed, a fresh aripan was made in a corner of the veranda, and the brass and bell-metal vessels in the kitchen were scrubbed until they shone. Early in the morning Janki announced, "Pirukiya will be made today. A warning to the children in advance—do not steal the filling and eat it."

From a distance Hemlata called back, "Not stealing. Tasting."

Madhavi laughed. "Changing the name does not change the act."

Devkant was gathering his papers on the veranda. At the word 'pirukiya,' his face lit up. "This time I will look at the source first, then write."

Madhavi said, "Good. See what form you find in the culinary vocabulary; but for the filling, shape and fold used in this house, write only as much as you see here."

Small balls of dough made from pithar as fine as maida were ready. Devkant opened his mouth to ask the names of the ingredients, then stopped himself.

Janki said, "You may ask. Asking questions is not forbidden; filling things in from yourself is."

Everyone laughed.

Madhavi rolled a small ball of dough in her palm and spread it into a circle with the rolling pin. The edge was not too thin, the centre not too thick. She placed the filling in the middle. Devkant watched closely.

"This much?" he asked.

"For this size," Madhavi said. "If there is too much filling, the fold will not close; too little and the pirukiya will feel empty."

Hemlata cut in, "An empty pirukiya is like writer-babu's page without a name."

Devkant laughed. "I am not safe in this house."

Madhavi folded one half of the round sheet over the other. It took the shape of a crescent. She pressed the edge with her fingers, then made small folds one after another, each overlapping the next a little. The rim came out like a row of tiny waves.

Hemlata watched, fascinated. "I will make that fold."

"Learn one first," Madhavi said.

Hemlata made her own *pirukiya*. She put in a little too much filling. While making the fold, it split at one point in the middle.

Janki said at once, "See? The sweetness inside wants to run out."

Hemlata pushed the filling back with her finger. "If it comes out, I will eat it."

Madhavi gave her hand a light tap. "That is not the solution."

On Devkant's page appeared: 'Amount of filling according to size; edge to be sealed properly before folding; the fold is not merely decorative, it strengthens the join.'

Madhavi read the page. "Keep that."

The children's real test began when the bowl of filling came in front of them. Two small children of the house kept peering out from behind a veranda pillar. One finger reached towards the filling. Without even looking, Janki said, "Move your hand away."

The child started. "How did you see?"

"A kitchen has eyes at the back."

Devkant laughed immediately. "Shall I put that in the book?"

Madhavi said, "No. Otherwise a hundred years from now people will look for eyes in the kitchen wall."

Amid the laughter, the *pirukiyas* were made one by one. Some edges were beautiful, some crooked, some bearing the unmistakable mark of Hemlata's hand.

Janki said, "Do not be tempted to make them all look the same. When the hand changes, the fold will change a little. Let it close well—that is enough."

Devkant wrote that down too.

Madhavi asked, "Will you write the taste, or the shape?"

"Both. But first I will write whose hand made the fold."

"The author of the fold?"

"Why not?"

Hemlata proudly set aside two of her *pirukiyas*. "My name on these."

Devkant wrote: 'Hemlata's first successful fold.'

The kitchen filled with brightness, laughter and fragrance. After the confinement of the rainy days, the work felt like more than food; it felt like the house breathing again.

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After the first batch had gone to be cooked, Madhavi counted the dough and filling that remained. Janki went inside to attend to another task. Hemlata ran towards the courtyard, chasing the children away.

Devkant sat at the edge of the veranda. He ate very little very sweet food—by now everyone in the house knew this. Looking at the bowl of pirukiya filling, he said jokingly, “Make one empty for me.”

Madhavi answered at once, “If it is empty, why call it a pirukiya?”

“Then less filling.”

“Less filling and less sweetness are not the same thing.”

Devkant looked surprised. “You remembered?”

Madhavi did not stop working with her hands. “When someone asks this many questions every day, two or four things about him remain in the mind.”

She separated a small portion of the filling and mixed into it another mixture prepared beforehand so that it would be a little less sweet. Devkant’s hand moved towards his pen to ask for the measurement, then stopped; not every measure in the household method belonged in the book.

Devkant asked, “This is for me?”

“No, for a ghost.”

“The ghost of this house is fortunate.”

Madhavi burst out laughing.

She spread a small ball of dough, put in the filling, and folded it into a crescent. The folds along the edge were a little smaller than on the others, more closely set. Devkant kept watching.

“Why is this one different?”

“So it can be recognised.”

“To mark the one with less sweetness?”

“Yes. Otherwise the children will pick it up.”

Devkant’s voice softened a little. “You make a separate mark for me.”

Madhavi stopped her hand and looked at him. “On a pirukiya. Do not go that far.”

“Where have I gone?”

“You move at once from the object to the person.”

Devkant smiled. “I have already admitted that fault.”

Madhavi placed the pirukiya on a separate leaf. "Then this time eat the fault; do not turn it into a metaphor."

When the pirukiyas came out cooked, the hot smell of ghee/oil mingled with the sweetness of the filling. Janki set aside the small marked pirukiya for Devkant.

The moment Hemlata saw it, she asked, "Whose is this?"

Madhavi said, "Devkant-babu's."

"Why separate?"

Janki did not waste the opportunity. "Because he does not like things too sweet."

Hemlata looked at Devkant, then at Madhavi. "Who remembered?"

Madhavi said, "I did."

Such a smile came over Hemlata's face that Madhavi immediately warned her, "Do not say anything."

Hemlata showed her teeth and kept quiet.

Devkant broke the pirukiya. The filling inside was hot. After the first bite he remained silent for a while.

Madhavi asked, "Is the sweetness less?"

"Right."

"Too little?"

"No."

"Then?"

Holding half the pirukiya in his hand, Devkant said, "You remembered what I like. That alone is a great deal."

Madhavi's eyes rested on him for a moment; then she began folding another pirukiya.

From a distance Hemlata whispered, "The ghost is fortunate."

Devkant laughed. Madhavi looked towards her in mock anger.

A day full of brightness—no one said those words, but that was the tone of the day. Food was being made, children were stealing, Janki was scolding, Hemlata was spoiling folds and correcting them, and one small less-sweet pirukiya was taking on a meaning a little larger than food.



At night, after the meal, the worship and the household bustle had subsided, the courtyard began to grow quiet. The children had fallen asleep from exhaustion. Janki was inside overseeing the last of the washing up. Hemlata,

full of pride in her new pirukiya fold, had disappeared somewhere while telling someone about it.

A lamp burned on the veranda. The rain had stopped, though here and there old water still dripped from the edge of the roof.

Devkant sat with the book open, but he was not writing. Madhavi returned after covering a cooking pot and asked, "Is the book silent today?"

"Not the book. The writer."

"That is new."

Devkant smiled faintly. After a few moments he said, "I want to say what remained unfinished that day in Janakpur."

Madhavi did not sit. She remained standing beside a pillar. "Say it."

For the first time Devkant's voice sounded so unrehearsed. "After the fear I felt when I thought you had disappeared, I argued with myself a great deal. It was not only the fear of losing a companion. Not of losing a source for the book. Not of losing a knowledgeable person from the household. You... the empty place I imagined without you felt unbearable to me."

Madhavi remained silent.

Devkant continued, "I love you."

After the sentence was spoken, the veranda seemed quieter. A dog barked somewhere far away, then stopped.

Madhavi's face was difficult to read. She sat down slowly, but not very close to Devkant.

"How many days have you thought about that sentence?"

"Perhaps even before Janakpur. In Janakpur I understood."

"And now?"

"Now I am saying it."

Madhavi looked down at the flame of the lamp. "I have a question."

"Ask."

Looking straight into his eyes, Madhavi said, "Will you walk with me, or will you make me into your own story?"

Devkant's expression changed. "What is the difference between the two?"

"A great deal."

"Explain."

"To walk with me means—you will listen to my words only as far as I speak them; you will accept my no as no; you will keep my name with my work; my life will not merely become material for your writing. To make me into your own story means—you will see me, like me, then shape me according to what you need; where I am silent, you will fill in sentences; where

I am difficult, you will make me simple; where I have a boundary, you will want to open the door in the name of love.”

Devkant was silent for a long time.

“I do not want to do that,” he said at last.

Madhavi replied, “Wanting and doing are not the same.”

“Then what should I do?”

“The work of walking together has to be done every day. Not with one night’s promise.”

Devkant nodded. “I will try.”

“Try is a safe word.”

“Then a promise?”

Madhavi smiled faintly. “A promise can be more dangerous.”

Devkant smiled too, though his eyes remained serious. “Then I will say this—where I have no right, I will not ask for one. I will keep each person’s name with what is theirs. What you do not say, I will not fill in from myself. And... I will not see you only inside the book.”

For the first time a clear softness appeared on Madhavi’s face.

“You have already been learning the first three of those things,” she said.

“The fourth?”

“The test of the fourth has only just begun.”

For a while both were silent. Devkant extended his hand, then stopped halfway. Madhavi saw him stop.

She herself reached out and touched Devkant’s fingers. A very small touch—neither prolonged nor theatrical.

“Is this an answer?” Devkant whispered.

“It is not a refusal,” Madhavi said. “Time will give the rest of the answer.”

The lamp flame trembled lightly. Like the fold of the pirukiya during the day, the edge of a relationship had now been pressed for the first time—whether it was closed or made strong, it was too early to say.

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After Devkant’s declaration of love, neither of them got up. The night was not over, nor were Madhavi’s questions.

“One more thing,” Madhavi said.

“Say it.”

“Walking together is not only a matter between you and me. There is the household. There is family. There is society. There is the standing of your

lineage. There is the condition of my family. What will you do in the face of all this?"

Devkant did not answer at once.

Madhavi noticed the delay. "Will the rules of the book not work here?"

"They will. But..."

"But?"

Devkant said slowly, "I will speak to my family about it. I will look for a way."

"What way?"

"I am not certain yet."

There was no anger on Madhavi's face, nor any open sign of disappointment. She simply kept listening directly.

Devkant continued, "I am not saying that I will leave you."

"I asked—what will you do?"

"I will talk. If there is opposition, then... I will try to make them understand."

"And if they do not agree?"

Devkant was silent.

In that silence, something began to come open like the pirukiya fold of the day. Where the filling was right and the edge had been pressed well, the shape held; where the join was uncertain, there was the risk of splitting in hot oil.

Madhavi said, "Look, I am not asking for a wedding date tonight. I want to understand how far your word 'together' goes."

Devkant's voice dropped. "As far as necessary."

"That is another safe answer."

"Then what do you want?"

"A clear answer. If you cannot go against your family, say so. If you can, say that. If you do not yet know, say that too."

Devkant lowered his eyes. "I do not know yet."

Madhavi's breathing eased a little. "At least that answer is true."

"But the love is true."

"I did not doubt that."

Devkant raised his head.

Madhavi said, "Love can be true and a person can still be weak. Social fear does not make love false; but it does not make love sufficient either."

Devkant had no immediate answer to that sentence.

"I will not remain weak," he said.

Madhavi smiled slowly. "That is a promise."

"Yes."

"And you yourself said—a promise can be dangerous."

Devkant laughed, though there was unease in the laughter.

"Then do not write it," Madhavi said.

"What?"

"This night. Not in the book yet."

"I did not want to write it either."

"Good."

After a while Madhavi rose. She went as far as the doorway, then turned and looked at Devkant.

"The pirukiya I made for you during the day, marked separately, is not proof of love."

Devkant smiled. "I know."

"But understand this much—remembering can be one part of love."

"And the other part?"

"Remembering when the difficulty begins."

She went inside.

Devkant remained alone on the veranda. The book was closed. Near his hand lay a small broken edge of a pirukiya from the day, fallen from someone's plate.

He picked it up and looked at it. The little folds overlapped one another; in some places the pressure was clear, in others loose.

It seemed to him that the simple lesson of the day's food had turned into the question of the night. Sweet filling was not enough; the join at the edge also had to hold.

He did not write the metaphor in the book.

Some metaphors have to be lived before they can be written.

The night deepened. The vessels in the kitchen were silent. A faint smell of sweetness still remained, but what had awakened inside Devkant was more difficult than sweetness.

Love had been spoken. Equality had entered the promise. On the question of family, the answer was still blank.

That blank space remained there all night.

CHAPTER 23

The Crossed-Out Line

Two days after the night of the pirukiya, the postman brought a thick envelope from Calcutta. One corner of the envelope was worn; in the middle was the blue stamp of the magazine. Devkant signed for it at the door, but did not open it until he had come to the veranda.

Madhavi was in the kitchen, writing an account of the ingredients left from the previous day. The moment she saw Devkant's face she asked, "Has the article come back?"

"Yes. Perhaps there are revisions."

Inside the envelope was his typed English article. There were red-pencil marks along the margins and a letter from the editor in the middle. Devkant read the letter first, then turned through the article.

The editor had written that the article was interesting, especially the sections on season, storage and local foods; but in its present form it was far longer than the space available in the magazine. The 'household details' should be shortened, repetitions cut, and the focus kept on the principal forms of food. Discussion of social arrangements, women's labour, names and credit could be left for a separate article.

Devkant read the last sentence again.

Madhavi came closer and stood beside him. "What has he written?"

Devkant explained the substance of the letter in Maithili. When he reached the part about 'women's labour,' his voice grew a little quieter.

Madhavi asked, "Is that part still in the article?"

Devkant replied, "Some of it is. I cut a great deal last time, but not all of it."

"How much?"

"Let us see."

He began turning the pages. Tilkor, bagiya, fish, amat, adauri—there were red marks on every section. In some places the editor had written 'condense,' in others a question mark. A thick red line ran along the side of one page.

Devkant said, “The editor wants to keep the descriptions of the food, but wants to shorten the part about whose hands the knowledge belongs to.”

Madhavi’s face remained still. “They do? Or you?”

Devkant started. “Me?”

“Who will send the final copy?”

“I will.”

“Then who will do the final cutting?”

Devkant folded the letter and set it on the table. “I will. But the limit of space is real.”

“Why does the limit of space fall on names first?”

“Not everywhere.”

“Look.”

They examined the pages together. In one section Devkant had kept the full method—choosing kadima flowers, the condition of the pithar, the temperature of the oil—but the source’s name appeared only in parentheses. In another section Ramanand’s name remained, but two lines describing his work had been halved. Nasima’s sentence about the market was still there. Some of Madhavi’s comments had been pushed down like footnotes.

Madhavi said, “I can see it—the object in the main line, the person below.”

Devkant said at once, “I did not do this deliberately.”

“I did not ask about intention. I am looking at the page.”

The sentence made Devkant uncomfortable.

At the end of the editor’s letter was written: ‘Send the revised copy within two days, otherwise space in the next issue cannot be assured.’

Devkant counted the time. To catch the post, he would have to finish the copy by the following evening.

Madhavi asked, “Then what will you do?”

“Cut repetitions. Shorten long descriptions. But preserve the sources.”

“And the things that change the meaning of the history of the food?”

“I will keep those too, as far as possible.”

Madhavi said slowly, “‘As far as possible’—that sentence saves many things, and drowns many things too.”

Devkant looked at her. The declaration of love on the night of the pirukiya was not very old. Equality, names, boundaries—all of it stood before him again in the solid form of paper.

He said, “Sit with me. I will cut; you watch.”

Madhavi replied, "I am not the editor. But where my words are concerned, I will look."

"That is all I want."

They sat down together. The editor's red-pencil lines, Devkant's black ink, Madhavi's pencil marks—three kinds of authority began to collide on a single page.

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**

By the time half the night had passed, most of the article had been shortened. Devkant joined some sentences and made two paragraphs into one, removed some examples, and compressed some details of measurement. Madhavi spoke only now and then, only where what she had said was being altered.

On reaching one page, she stopped. At the bottom was a Devanagari transcription in Madhavi's hand; the original Tirhuta page was preserved separately. The sentence was written clearly: "The history of the kitchen is incomplete without the names of the women who made that history."

Devkant read the sentence too. He had earlier added this line near the end of the article, as an expanded form of an older sentence circled in red.

Madhavi asked, "Will this stay?"

Devkant said at once, "I want to keep it."

"Do you want to, or will you?"

Devkant fell silent.

In the margin the editor had written in red pencil: 'Too general; outside food description. Cut or move to separate essay.'

Madhavi could not read the English comment. "What has he written?"

Devkant translated it: "He says this is a general statement outside the description of food; cut it, or put it in another article."

Madhavi said, "The history of the kitchen is outside the description of food?"

"According to the editor."

"According to you?"

Devkant looked at the sentence. "According to me, it is not outside."

"Then?"

"Space..."

Madhavi said nothing.

Devkant began constructing his argument to himself—the article's principal subject was food; if too much social argument were added, the editor might cut the whole section; if he preserved the line, the entire article might

be delayed; the fuller discussion would remain in the book; he could write separately about names and credit in the next article.

He said, "I will remove it for now. But it will be the first line of a separate article."

Madhavi looked at the sentence for a long time. "Will you write the date?"

Devkant remembered the earlier matter of writing 'later.' He immediately took a blank sheet and wrote: 'Madhavi's line; retained for a separate article; date...'

Madhavi said, "That note will remain with you. Where is the original line?"

"The original page is in the book."

"And in the typed article?"

"The crossed-out form will remain visible."

"Do not erase the mark showing it was cut."

"I will not."

Devkant crossed out the sentence not with the editor's red pencil, but with one fine line of his own black ink. Once. The words could still be read.

Madhavi's eyes remained fixed on the line.

Devkant said, "See, I have not erased it."

"You crossed it out."

"Yes."

"There is a difference."

"There is."

Madhavi drew the page towards herself. Beside the crossed-out sentence she made a small Tirhuta mark. Devkant did not understand it.

"What did you write?"

"'Crossed out.' So that if a copy is ever made, people will know it was not omitted by mistake."

Devkant said, "Right."

Madhavi put the page back on the table. "And my name?"

Devkant showed her the small source line written beneath the sentence: 'Madhavi, marginal note.'

"It will remain," he said.

"The sentence will not remain; the name will remain in a footnote."

Devkant grew uncomfortable. "This is not the final copy. The separate article—"

Madhavi raised a hand and stopped him. "I understand."

Her tone was not quarrelsome. That was precisely why Devkant felt more unsettled.

After a few moments Madhavi said, "Read the next line."

They returned to work. But the crossed-out sentence remained in the middle of the page like a black crack, the words still legible across it.

**

By the time morning light came, the revised article had become shorter, cleaner and fitted the magazine's length. Devkant was tired. Madhavi had risen and gone away sometime in the night, but the page containing the crossed-out line remained on the veranda.

By noon Devkant prepared the new copy. Some portions he rewrote cleanly by hand; others he corrected on the typed pages. The crossed-out sentence did not appear in the new copy.

He told himself—In the separate article. I have given my word. The original is safe.

At that time Madhavi was in the kitchen with Janki, working out the quantities for the *panti* meal. Preparations had begun for a family ceremony the following week. The number of people outside, the estimate of ingredients inside, whom to invite—lists were being made for everything.

Devkant carried the new copy there. "Will you look at it once?"

Washing her hands, Madhavi said, "I cannot read all the English."

"I will read it aloud to you."

"I have work now."

Devkant stopped. Earlier, at such moments, Madhavi would pause her work and listen. He said, "This evening?"

"We will see."

Her tone was ordinary, but 'we will see' no longer held the readiness it once had.

That evening Madhavi came to the veranda. Devkant opened the copy and began explaining its substance in Maithili. *Tilkor*, *makhana*, fish, *amat*, *adauri*—all in shortened form. Madhavi made no comment in between.

At the final section Devkant's voice faltered slightly. The sentence about the history of the kitchen was not there. In its place stood a general sentence: 'Household food is shaped by season, storage and knowledge carried from generation to generation.'

Madhavi asked, "Who carries knowledge from generation to generation?"

Devkant replied, "The people of the house."

“In the article?”

“There are some names.”

“All?”

“It is not possible to give every name.”

“As many as the sources you used?”

Devkant turned the pages. There were some names—Ramanand, Nasima, Madhavi; Janki was mentioned; Hemlata’s small episode was not.

Madhavi said, “I am not saying that you should write the name of everyone who washed a plate. But do not erase into ‘the people of the house’ the person whose knowledge made the sentence.”

Devkant said, “I am not erasing anyone. The article is short.”

Something hardened on Madhavi’s face, then immediately became calm. “All right.”

“All right?”

“Send the copy.”

“Do you agree?”

“I said—send it.”

For the first time Devkant heard clearly that agreement and permission could be different things.

He said, “Madhavi, this is only one article. In the book—”

Madhavi stopped him. “We will talk about the book later.”

“Why not now?”

“Because now I have to understand how much of the book belongs to my hand, and how much to yours.”

A faint wave of fear rose inside Devkant. “That question was there before too—”

“It was. Now the answer is changing.”

“Why?”

Madhavi sat directly facing him. “Because last night, at the first opportunity after speaking of love, you crossed out a clear sentence of mine. Your reason may be valid. The magazine’s limit of space may be real. But the decision was still in your hands.”

Devkant said, “I will write the separate article.”

“Perhaps.”

“I will.”

Madhavi only nodded. “You wrote the date down. I remember.”

The sentence was not an accusation; it was a record.

Devkant suddenly had no argument left.



The next morning Devkant was preparing to seal the envelope containing the article. Madhavi came onto the veranda with an empty cloth bag in her hand.

Devkant thought she had come for some kitchen supplies.

Madhavi said, "Give me some of my pages."

Devkant's hand stopped on the envelope. "Which ones?"

"The pages I wrote myself that are still marked as shared in the bundle of your book. Not all of them. Some."

"Why?"

"I will keep them with me."

"Shall I make copies?"

"If you want, make copies for yourself. Give me the originals."

Devkant's voice almost rose without his intending it to, but he checked himself. "Madhavi, I did not erase the crossed-out line. I wrote the source. The separate article—"

"I have not come to quarrel."

The sentence was so calm that all the prepared answers inside Devkant suddenly seemed beside the point.

Madhavi sat beside the bundle and began examining the pages one by one. She did not take the original note on tilkor; she left it in the book. She also left some corrections of bagiya measurements. But she set aside the separate page about her grandmother Dhaneshwari's story, a private note on the labour of the panti, and two or three Tirhuta pages.

Devkant asked, "All these out of the book?"

"With me for now."

"For how many days?"

"I do not know."

"My work will stop."

Gathering the pages, Madhavi said, "Some work ought to stop if the source has changed its mind."

Devkant's face flushed, then he checked himself. "Have you changed your mind?"

Madhavi looked up. "I have not left the book. I am looking at trust again."

The sentence weighed more heavily on Devkant than an accusation would have.

"You do not trust me?"

"I do trust you. But trust does not exist without boundaries. Yesterday you showed that under editorial pressure a line about names can be the first thing

weakened. Then I have the right to keep some of my original pages with me for a while.”

Devkant said, “You do.” The words were difficult to say, but he said them.

Madhavi’s hand stopped for a moment. Perhaps she had not expected that acceptance.

She put the pages into the bag.

Devkant asked, “And what about love?”

Madhavi’s face did not change. “I gave you that answer yesterday—not a refusal. But I will not give you pages because of love.”

“That is not what I asked.”

“Then?”

“Does this change it?”

Madhavi was silent for a long time. “Love is not only feeling. It is action too. If the action changes, the answer will change. For now, I am watching.”

Devkant’s hand tightened against the edge of the table. “I can make it right.”

“Make it right.”

“How?”

“First, do not ask what I want you to do so that I will give you the pages again. Ask what you yourself think is right.”

In that moment Devkant understood that even asking forgiveness could sometimes take a selfish form—if its purpose was only to regain a lost right.

He said quietly, “Shall I put the crossed-out line back into the new copy?”

Madhavi did not answer at once.

“If you put it back only because of me, then no,” she said at last. “If you believe the article is incomplete without it, then put it back. The consequence is yours.”

Devkant looked at the envelope. The postal time was near. If he restored the line, he would have to alter the copy again; the article would become a little longer; the editor might be displeased.

Madhavi got up.

“Wait,” Devkant said.

Madhavi turned.

Devkant opened the old page containing the crossed-out sentence. Across the black line the words were still clearly readable: “The history of the kitchen is incomplete without the names of the women who made that history.”

He opened the new copy. There was little space in the middle of the final paragraph. Adding one line would mean rewriting the next page as well.

Devkant lifted his pen.

Madhavi said nothing.

He did not write the sentence.

The pen hovered over the paper for a few moments; then he sealed the envelope.

Madhavi saw only that much. No argument, no accusation.

She picked up the bag containing her pages and left.

As she crossed the doorway, Hemlata met her. "Didi, where are you going?"

"To keep my papers."

"Will you bring them back?"

Madhavi looked at Hemlata's face. "What remains shared will remain. What is mine should remain with me too."

Hemlata perhaps did not understand the whole matter, but she asked no question.

Devkant remained alone on the veranda. The envelope was sealed.

The crossed-out sentence could still be read on the original page.

For the first time, the silence was not the silence of love; it was the silence after a decision.

Devkant felt that an argument might perhaps have been easier. Words can be answered with words. Madhavi's calm request to take back her pages left before him an empty space no argument could fill.

Before the postman came, Devkant took the envelope in his hand again. For one moment he wanted to break the seal.

He did not break it.

The article went out.

The line remained.

And between the two of them, the first explicit moral fracture was recorded on paper like one fine black line.

CHAPTER 24

Outside the Feast

On the day of the family's major rite, the house was awake long before dawn. The darkness had not yet fully lifted, but the hearth had been lit in the inner courtyard, water was being drawn from the well, leaf-plates were washed, pots of curd were set in the shade, and rice was being picked over.

In the outer dalan, places were being arranged for the guests—seats, low stools, and space for the panti. Inside, around the kitchen, the women, two or three familiar women from neighbouring houses who had come to help, Gonu, and the household's other helpers took up tasks in turn.

Devkant too had been awake since before dawn. He first joined in carrying water, but Janki stopped him. "That is not your work just now. The guests will begin arriving outside. Stay with the men of the house."

Devkant said, "The feast will be made inside. What am I to do outside?"

Janki replied, "Today we shall see the answer to that very question."

Madhavi was checking the consistency of the pithar at that moment. Devkant looked towards her. The crossed-out line from the previous day and the bag of original pages were still present between them, though no paper lay in sight.

Madhavi only said, "Go outside. Someone has to look after the guests."

Her tone was ordinary. Devkant could not tell whether it was an ordinary remark or distance. He stopped his inference there.

By sunrise the dalan had begun to fill. Relatives from afar, village elders, acquaintances from his father's generation, pandits who had come for the rite, people connected with the fields and the household—all sat talking in separate groups.

Someone brought up the earthquake, someone the crop, someone kinship ties towards Nepal. Before long the conversation came to food.

An elderly guest said, "A Mithila feast is in a class of its own. Eat in however many places outside—you will not find this order, this curd, this sweetness, this panti anywhere."

Another man immediately added, “And the taste of our own people’s hands. What would a city cook understand?”

Devkant listened. There was something in these sentences that resembled the subject of his own writing—local taste, household tradition, the *panti*. But at the words ‘our own people’s hands,’ he remembered the inner courtyard, where many hands were working without having sat down even once.

The talk outside continued—‘the old custom,’ ‘the honour of the house,’ ‘Mithila’s great food.’ Every sentence turned food into glory.

In the midst of it Hemlata came running out. “Devkant Babu, they’ve sent word from inside—please write down the number of pots of curd. Janki Kaki is busy.”

Devkant went inside.

In contrast to the calm conversation in the *dalan*, the density of sound inside was different—vessels striking against one another, water boiling, someone asking for salt, someone asking for firewood, someone counting leaf-plates. Through smoke and steam the women’s faces shone.

With one hand Madhavi was checking a pot of vegetables; with the other she was having Hemlata count the serving bowls. Janki stood between two cooking pots deciding the order of things.

“The curd?” Devkant asked.

Janki said, “Five large pots for the *panti* outside, two for the women’s *panti* inside; keep one in reserve. We do not know how many more people may turn up.”

Devkant wrote down the numbers.

Madhavi said, “And for those who are working?”

Janki paused for a moment. “Set the last pot aside for them. No one will remain hungry.”

Devkant’s pen stopped. ‘The last pot’—the words were ordinary, but they opened the full meaning of the order.

Janki looked at him. “No philosophy now. Go outside; the guests are waiting.”

Devkant returned to the *dalan*. The moment one of the guests saw him he said, “You’re writing a book about all this, aren’t you? Write about this feast—Mithila lives right here.”

Devkant answered with a smile, “Mithila is not only the people sitting in the *panti*.”

The guest said, “Then?”

Devkant looked towards the inside, but he did not yet have the whole answer. “The work that goes on outside the feast as well.”

The old man laughed. “Writers look for deep meanings everywhere.”

The conversation moved on. Devkant’s ears were outside; his attention was inside. The splendour of the feast was being made at that very moment; behind the splendour that people would call ‘tradition’ by evening was the sound of labour continuing since dawn.



When the first *panti* sat down, the whole tone of the *dalan* changed. People who had been talking began to look for their places. An elder of the household gave the order—first the elderly guests who had come from afar and the principal guests of the rite, then the other relatives and people of the village.

Devkant deliberately watched the scene closely. He did not want to write it as an eternal rule of all Mithila; this was the arrangement of this household, on this occasion.

Leaf-plates were spread. Water was sprinkled over them to wash them. Gonu and two young men went along filling *lotas* with water. Some elderly guests had brought their own *lotas* separately; according to their personal observance, water was served in those very vessels.

One old man asked, “Where is my *lota*?”

Gonu immediately brought him the marked *lota*.

Devkant wanted to make a note, then remembered—this was a personal observance; it would be wrong to turn it into a universal social rule. He wrote only: ‘Some guests bring their own rules regarding vessels/water; in this household arrangements are made accordingly.’

The first serving was rice. Then came lentils, vegetables, pickle, *tarua*. Some asked for more; some raised a hand to stop the server. The feet of the young men serving were almost always running.

The men’s *panti* was underway outside; in the inner courtyard a separate *panti* was being prepared for women guests. The women engaged in the kitchen work were still a long way from sitting down.

When Devkant went inside, Madhavi was moving from one pot to another. The hair near her forehead was stuck down with sweat.

“Have you eaten?” Devkant asked.

Madhavi looked at him with an expression that made the question itself seem absurd. “This is only the first *panti*.”

“So?”

“Let the serving finish, then the panti inside, then the children must eat, then the panti of those doing the work—after that.”

Devkant said, “Why is there a separate panti for those doing the work?”

Madhavi’s hand stopped. “Why it is separate—that question you should ask the elders of the house. But look at this: the food of many people sitting in the first panti is being served by people who will themselves eat last.”

“Do you agree with this arrangement?”

Madhavi did not answer directly. “I am handling cooking pots just now. For an argument I need empty hands.”

She moved on.

Devkant remained standing by the door.

A little later the first panti rose. The leaf-plates were removed, the ground was washed, and the second panti sat down. The serving began again.

In the second panti were some people of the village, acquaintances connected with the fields and household, and distant relatives. The food was almost the same, but the servers were tired. The shoulders of the young man filling water had begun to droop.

Gonu paused for a moment at the doorway to straighten his back. Devkant said, “Sit down and drink a little water.”

Gonu laughed. “Let me get water to everyone first. I belong to this house; my turn comes later.”

‘People of the house’—the phrase troubled Devkant. At this moment, belonging to the house was becoming not a right to eat first but a responsibility to keep working until later.

Inside, the women’s panti began. Some elderly women sat down; younger women continued serving. Janki herself had still not sat.

Hemlata came close to Devkant and whispered, “At a feast, the one who runs about the most eats last of all.”

Devkant said, “Is that your sentence?”

“Yes. Write it.”

He wrote it under her name: ‘Hemlata: At a feast, the one who runs about the most eats last of all.’

Instead of looking pleased, Hemlata looked towards the inside. “Didi still has not even drunk water properly.”

Devkant’s notebook closed.

He went to Janki. “Why do those doing the work not eat earlier?”

Janki looked at him with tired eyes. “This is how the arrangement for this occasion has always gone. Guests first. The house afterwards.”

“But even inside the house, why not everyone at once?”

Janki replied, “If everyone leaves the work together and sits down, who will serve? Who will give water? Who will clear the leaf-plates?”

The argument was practical, but hierarchy was hidden inside the practicality—who would serve, who would sit; whose hunger could wait and whose could not.

Devkant did not write that conclusion in his notes. He wrote only the scene.

After a while there was a small *panti* for the men who had been working. The women still had not eaten. Heaps of used things had gathered in different places—metal bowls used by guests, household vessels, leaf-plates. Water was filled again.

Devkant understood that social order was not written only in speeches; it was written in the time one sat down, the hand that gave water, the order in which empty vessels were lifted, and the waiting before one ate.

But he remained cautious—what he had seen, he had seen at this feast in this household. To call it a rule for the whole region would be the same old mistake again.



As afternoon declined, the main crowd at the feast thinned somewhat. A select group of guests were still seated in the outer *dalan*. After the meal, *paan* and *areca nut* went around, and the talk turned again towards culture.

An educated guest asked Devkant, “How far has your book progressed?”

For a moment Devkant’s fatigue turned into excitement. “A great deal of material has been gathered.”

“What sort of things?”

“Food by season, preserved foods, ponds and *makhana*, the fish market, *tilkor*, *bagiya*, *adauri*, differences in words, cross-border movement towards *Janakpur*...”

The guest was impressed. “Where did so much knowledge come from?”

It was an ordinary question. The answer should not have been difficult.

Devkant said, “The old traditions of the household, Janki’s experience, people in the village, people in the market... many sources.”

Madhavi’s name had still not come.

A few moments later another guest asked, "Have you written about choosing tender tilkor leaves? In our house too the old women used to say that the age of the leaf changes the taste."

Devkant was immediately animated. "Yes, I have written that the tenderness of the leaf, the condition of the veins, the thickness of the pithar—all have to be observed. Quantity alone is not enough."

The shape of that sentence was almost entirely Madhavi's.

The guest asked, "Do you cook yourself?"

Everyone burst out laughing.

Devkant laughed too. "No, I am learning."

"Who teaches you?"

This time Devkant said, "Madhavi has taught me many things—especially to look at signs rather than quantity alone: the season, the condition of the leaf, the pressure of the hand."

Madhavi's name had been spoken. Devkant felt a little relief.

Another guest said, "Where is she? Call her; let us hear from her too."

Devkant looked inside. At that very moment Madhavi set down a bucket full of water and lifted an empty cooking pot. The edge of her anchal was wet; turmeric and spices stained her hands.

Devkant said, "She is working inside just now."

"But the feast is over, isn't it?"

"Not for her yet."

An old man laughed. "When is a feast ever over for the women of the house?"

A light laugh passed through the conversation.

Devkant could not laugh.

The guests began asking about the book again. Devkant quoted one of Madhavi's sentences: "She says, 'In winter there will be no mango, but the sourness will remain.' How could one express the meaning of dried mango better than that?"

The guests praised it. "Beautiful!"

At that moment Madhavi inside might have been counting a pile of vessels or drinking water—Devkant did not know. Outside, her sentence was receiving praise as a table, an article, an idea; she herself was present in the work of the feast almost as an absence.

Devkant wanted to get up then, call Madhavi, and seat her in this conversation.

He did not rise.

The reasons came ready at once—she must be tired; there was work inside; sitting among the guests might make her uncomfortable; what would the elders of the house think; the arrangements for the ceremony would be disturbed.

Devkant understood that however civilly the reasons might be worded, the result was the same—Madhavi's knowledge was in the dalan; Madhavi was not.

One guest said, "When your book is published, it will change the history of Mithila's household cooking."

Devkant replied, "There is still a great deal of work left."

As he said it, Devkant understood that there truly was a great deal of work left.

No one noticed.

No one noticed Madhavi's absence either.

Devkant did. But noticing and acting had once again become two different things.



As evening descended, the house of the feast sank into exhaustion. Most of the outside guests had gone, but five or six elders and two educated young men were still sitting in the dalan. The conversation had turned to writing, history and tradition.

One young man looked at Devkant's notebook and asked, "Are these the original pages of your collection?"

Devkant said naturally, "No, the originals are separate. These are working copies from my collection."

The sentence was out.

'My collection.'

Devkant's ears caught so sharply on his own words that the conversation that followed was indistinct for a few moments.

On the page open before him was Nasima's name. Ramanand was on another page. On the tilkor page was a note of Madhavi's signature. Hemlata's copy was separate. Janki's sentences.

How was all this 'my collection'?

The young man was saying, "It is an enormous undertaking. One person could not make a collection like this."

Devkant had the proper opportunity now. He needed only to say one sentence: 'This is not my collection alone.'

He opened his mouth.

Just then an elder of the house said proudly, “Devkant has had a different kind of mind since childhood. He studied in the city and did not forget his own soil. Now look—he is binding the knowledge of Mithila into a book.”

Another said, “It will bring honour to the family name.”

Devkant’s mouth closed again.

If he wished, amid that pride he could have spoken every name—Madhavi, Janki, Nasima, Ramanand, Hemlata, Gonu.

He did not.

He said only, “Many people are helping.”

The sentence was not false. But it was not enough.

The young man asked, “But you are the principal author?”

Something drew tight inside Devkant like the crossed-out line.

“I do the writing,” he said.

This time he neither accepted nor rejected the word ‘principal.’

The darkness outside deepened. Inside, the last cooking pot in the kitchen was being washed.

Whether Madhavi had by now sat in the final women’s *panti* or was still working, Devkant did not know. His ignorance suddenly shamed him.

He rose and went inside.

In one corner of the courtyard, Madhavi, Hemlata, Janki and two women helpers had finally begun to eat. There was still enough food, but very little warmth remained. The *tarua* had gone soft; the lentils had been reheated.

When Hemlata saw Devkant she said, “Now look, writer-babu—the last *panti*.”

Janki gave a tired laugh. “Don’t call it the last. Call it the *panti* of the house.”

Madhavi said nothing.

Devkant stood by the door.

On Madhavi’s plate were small portions of the same foods that had been discussed outside as ‘Mithila’s great food.’ But by the time they reached that plate, the warmth of their taste had changed.

Devkant asked, “You’re eating only now?”

Without looking up, Madhavi said, “You can see that.”

There was less sarcasm in the words than fatigue.

Devkant said, “Outside I was... talking about the book.”

Madhavi said only, “Yes.”

“I said—‘my collection.’”

This time Madhavi looked up.

Devkant expected her to rebuke him, to use irony, to remind him of the crossed-out line.

Madhavi only asked, "And then?"

Devkant had the answer: 'I could not correct myself.'

He said, "Later I said, 'many people are helping.'"

Madhavi looked at her plate. "Helping?"

One word.

Devkant understood that this was where the mistake lay. Co-authors, sources, holders of knowledge, the people doing the work—all had become 'help.'

He said softly, "That word was not right either."

Madhavi did not answer.

Hemlata understood the atmosphere and fell silent. Janki continued eating.

After a few moments Madhavi said, "What you said publicly will have to be changed publicly."

Devkant lowered his head. "Yes."

"When?"

The question was simple.

Devkant said, "At the next opportunity."

A very faint, almost invisible smile of weariness came to Madhavi's face. "Later again?"

Devkant was silent.

All the earlier 'laters' surrounded him at once—the crossed-out line, the separate article, the names of sources, and now the public correction.

Madhavi began eating again.

Devkant remained at the door for a while. Outside in the dalan, people were still praising his collection. Inside, the person whose hands and knowledge filled that collection was eating food that had gone cold.

Long after the feast had ended, Devkant opened his notebook. He wrote: 'The history of a feast does not end on the plate.'

A little later he added a second line beneath it: 'Those whom I called helpers may in fact be the bearers of the original work.'

He did not cross out that line.

But the public correction still remained to be made.

By the end of the section, the question had become clear—Devkant had begun to see the truth; but the courage to speak on behalf of the truth he saw had still not fully been born within him.

CHAPTER 25

The Printed Article

Three days after the feast, the postman brought another envelope from Calcutta in the afternoon, but this time the envelope was not thick; it was broad. The latest issue of the journal came out from inside—the ink still had a new smell, the corners of the paper were stiff, the pages tightly bound.

Devkant began looking for the title of his article as soon as he turned the first page. He found the title in the table of contents. Beneath that one line his own name was printed—‘Devakanta...’—a single name, clear, in black type.

An unbidden brightness came over his face. Months of notes, cutting, copying, posting, revision—all of it, for a moment, had taken solid form in his hands.

The moment Hemlata saw the journal she cried out, “It’s been published!”

Janki came from inside and asked, “What?”

“The article!”

Within a short while two or three members of the household had gathered in the dalan. No one could read all the English, but they could recognise Devkant’s name. One elder said with pride, “Look—our own Devkant in a Calcutta journal!”

Another said, “Those who praised it on the day of the feast now have printed proof as well.”

Devkant’s smile faded a little. The word ‘proof’ made him uneasy. Was the article proof, or a presentation? He did not voice that question yet.

Madhavi stood to one side of the veranda. Since the feast her manner had not been harsh, but measured. She did not reach for the journal.

Devkant said, “Would you like to see it?”

“Read it aloud to me.”

“All of it?”

“Certainly wherever my words are involved.”

Interest in the dalan grew. Hemlata sat beside Devkant. Janki listened with her spinning still in her hands.

Devkant opened the article. The first paragraph was about Mithila's seasons, fields, ponds, household stores, and the changing forms of food. As he rendered the English sentences into Maithili, his own article seemed new even to him. The editor had shortened some sentences and changed the order of some.

Janki interrupted, "This is right—winter food and rainy-season food are not the same."

Devkant read on. Tilkor leaves, makhana, fish, amat, adauri, bagiya—all had now become orderly paragraphs. The scattered days of the household had been arranged into a sequence on paper.

Hemlata said happily, "Has my hunger for adauri been printed?"

Devkant searched the page. "No. That little episode was cut."

"Then the journal is only half the truth," Hemlata said.

Laughter rose in the dalan.

Madhavi did not laugh.

Devkant began reading the section on tilkor. The printed article said: choose tender leaves; make the pithar thick enough to hold on the leaf; keep the heat such that the coating sets at once. The sentences were Devkant's English, but their structure had been built from the signs Madhavi had taught him to observe.

Janki said, "You have written it correctly."

Madhavi asked, "Whose name is beneath this sentence?"

Devkant looked at the bottom of the page. There was no name.

"The writer's name is at the top," an elder said casually. "Why put names again and again in the middle?"

Madhavi looked not at the elder, but at Devkant.

Devkant said, "In the original copy there were sources in some places. During editing—"

Madhavi did not interrupt. She let him finish the sentence.

"—during editing, many source-lines were removed," Devkant concluded.

Madhavi asked, "Was your name removed?"

The question was so direct that the laughter in the dalan stopped.

Devkant said quietly, "No."

Madhavi merely nodded. "Read on."

The family's excitement was still there. For them, publication of the article was success; for Madhavi, the printed page was now becoming an examination. Devkant felt both things at once—pride, and a tremor as

though something had entered the paper in a form that could not easily be pulled back again.

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In the middle of the article was a paragraph on 'household knowledge.' Devkant read it aloud: the measure of food is not always decided by numbers, but by smell, touch, the condition of flour and water, season, and the experience of the hand.

Madhavi immediately asked, "On which day was this sentence made?"

Devkant tried to remember—the measure of salt, the steam of bagiya, the thickness of adauri, the pithar for tilkor. "Not on one day. I wrote it by bringing together things from many days."

"Whose words from those many days?"

"Yours. Janki's. My observation."

"In the article?"

Devkant looked at the page. There was no source after the sentence.

Madhavi said, "Then on the printed page it has become Devkant's thought."

Devkant said at once, "My name is there as the writer, but the thought—"

"Whose name will the reader see?"

Devkant was silent.

Trying to lighten the atmosphere, Janki said, "What does it matter if my name is left out? I have no wish to publish a book."

Madhavi looked at Janki with respect. "If you do not want it, that is your right. But whether the name of the person whose words were used remains or not should not be only a matter of the writer's convenience."

Janki fell silent at that.

Hemlata traced Devkant's name at the top of the journal page with a finger and said, "Is Didi's name nowhere?"

Devkant turned the pages. In one place there was a reference like 'a young woman of the household'—a statement attributed to a young woman. No name.

He translated it aloud.

Hemlata immediately said, "That is Didi?"

Devkant's voice dropped. "Yes, it is based on something Madhavi said."

Madhavi asked, "Why no name?"

"Perhaps the editor kept the description anonymous. In the original copy —"

“Was my name in the original copy?”

Devkant searched his memory. In many places it had been; in some places ‘Madhavi says’ had become ‘the women of the household say’; in some places he himself had turned it into a general sentence.

“Not everywhere,” he admitted.

The colour of Madhavi’s face did not change. “Then the editor made one error, and the writer another.”

Resistance rose inside Devkant—he had added names in many places, made repeated corrections, learned the rules of attribution. But the printed page lay in front of him; trying to defend himself by narrating his own history seemed pointless.

He said, “Yes. Wherever I turned it into a general statement, that is my error.”

Hemlata pulled the journal towards herself and asked him to read one sentence.

Devkant read the printed sentence about dried mango: the sourness of summer is dried and preserved into the season that follows. The language was beautiful, polished.

Madhavi said softly, “In winter there will be no mango; the sourness will remain.”

Silence fell over the dalan.

Devkant remembered that day—the amat in the sun, the shrivelled piece of mango in Madhavi’s hand, her plain sentence. The printed line was a polished form of what she had said.

Hemlata asked, “In the journal, isn’t this under Didi’s name?”

“No,” Devkant said.

Madhavi reached out for the journal. This time she looked at the page herself—the English letters were not entirely easy for her, but Devkant’s name at the top was clear.

She handed the page back. “You refined it, and so the owner changed?”

Devkant said, “No. It should not change.”

“But in the printed form it did.”

“Yes.”

Madhavi said quietly, “You can make beautiful what came from my mouth. But why should the price of making it beautiful be the erasure of my name?”

Devkant had no answer.

An elder who had been quiet until then said, “Writers write down things they hear. How can they write everyone’s name?”

Madhavi was not harsh with him. “Not everything heard is the same. If someone’s sentence, method, experience, or sign becomes the basis of the writer’s central point, it is easy to call it ‘what everyone says.’ The difficult work is remembering the name.”

Devkant’s eyes remained fixed on the journal page.

There was one name on that page—his. The knowledge inside it belonged to many hands.

Printing had not erased that difference; it had fixed it in place.

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The section on kurthi was not much farther on. As soon as Devkant turned to it, he saw it and suddenly became alert. He remembered the original note—Janki’s household belief: eat kurthi dal for one month each year and you will not get stones; Madhavi’s insistence: ‘what people say—verification pending.’

The sentence in the printed article was more definite. The English editing had made it sound almost like a rule that eating horse gram for one month every year prevents stones. Belief, what people said, verification pending—those marks of caution had disappeared.

Devkant stopped as he read.

Madhavi asked, “What happened?”

He rendered the meaning of the sentence into Maithili.

Janki said at once, “I said that the old people in the household used to say it. When did I ever say it was a medical rule?”

Devkant looked at the page again. “The original copy said ‘folk belief.’ I remember.”

Madhavi said, “Not memory. Look at the original page.”

Hemlata ran and brought the bundle of papers from the veranda. It took a little time to find the old kurthi page.

Devkant read: ‘Janki’s statement; family folk belief. Not an established medical fact. Verification pending.’

Janki said, “It is written perfectly clearly.”

Madhavi placed the journal and the original page side by side. One paper said: what people say, verification pending. The other, the printed paper: almost a definite health rule.

She looked at Devkant. “Do you see? The words changed, and authority changed with them.”

Devkant was silent.

Madhavi put a finger on the original page. "Here Janki is speaking. Here there is uncertainty. Here the reader is being told—this is a folk belief, not an established medical fact."

Then she put a finger on the printed article. "Here the writer is speaking. In a definite voice. The reader will assume—Devkant checked it and wrote it."

Devkant said, "This is an editorial change. I did not send it like this."

Madhavi accepted that immediately. "All right. But whose name is printed?"

"Mine."

"Then whose public responsibility is it?"

Devkant's answer came slowly. "Mine."

Janki said, "If it can be misunderstood, send a correction."

Devkant began looking for the journal's correspondence address. "I will write today itself."

Madhavi said, "That is the right thing to do."

For a moment Devkant felt relief—at least here there was a clear action he could take.

But Madhavi continued, "This is not only about the kurthi sentence. Here the change is visible because the tone of fact changed. Where names were removed, authority changed there too; the harm is simply not visible to the eye at once."

Devkant looked at her.

Madhavi said, "If 'Madhavi said' is removed and becomes 'the women of the household say,' one person's responsibility, experience, and knowledge all become blurred. If 'what people say' is removed and becomes 'a rule,' uncertainty disappears. In both places only a few words changed; in both places power changed."

Hemlata listened with such seriousness that her usual stream of questions stopped.

Devkant put a red mark on the original kurthi page: 'Immediate correction letter.'

Madhavi stopped him. "Why red?"

"So that I do not forget."

"All right. But after you write the letter, write the date. 'Will send' and 'sent' are different."

Devkant nodded.

He immediately took out a blank sheet and began writing a correction letter in English—the printed health statement had become more definite than the source’s folk belief; he requested that a clear correction be printed in the next issue.

Madhavi asked, “Janki’s name?”

Devkant added to the letter: the statement had been recorded as an oral family folk belief, spoken by Janki, and marked by the writer as an unverified belief.

Janki said, “Do not write my name and turn me into a doctor.”

Devkant said, “No. On the contrary, I will make it clear that this is not a medical claim.”

For the first time that afternoon Madhavi gave a slight nod.

The correction letter was taking shape. But the printed issue lay before the household—already arrived, already read, fixed in print with a name attached.

An error on paper could be corrected; the first impression could not be recalled.



By evening the family’s excitement had settled somewhat. The journal was still on the table, but its first brightness had faded. Devkant completed the correction letter and prepared the envelope. A clear amendment had been written for the kurthi sentence.

He came before Madhavi and said, “This letter will go in today’s post. And I will write a separate letter about the names—ask the editor to print a source correction in the next issue.”

Madhavi was opening her bundle of papers.

“I heard,” she said.

Devkant continued, “And if the article is printed again in a book, I will add all the names. In the next edition not a single source will remain anonymous.”

Madhavi’s hand stopped.

“In the next edition?”

“Yes. The mistake that happened in this printing—”

“My name is not in this printing.”

“I know.”

“My sentence is in this printing.”

“Yes.”

“Your name is in this printing.”

Devkant's voice grew quiet. "Yes."

Madhavi lifted one page and set it aside. It was the original note on tilkor.

Devkant started. "Why this one?"

"It will stay with me."

"Until now it was a shared page of the book."

"Not now."

She separated another page—the note on steam, smell, and signs of doneness. A third—her sentence about amat.

Devkant said, "Madhavi, I accept that I was at fault. I am asking your forgiveness."

Madhavi replied, "Forgiveness should not be used in such a way that the pages simply return to your bundle."

"I am not asking forgiveness for the pages. I am asking for what happened."

"Then remember the fault."

"I will."

Madhavi kept putting pages into the bag. Not all of them. She left some shared pages with the book—Janki's method, Nasima's fish, Ramanand's makhana, Hemlata's copy. But from those in which her own experience, her own sentence, or her own refinement was central, she removed some of the original pages.

Devkant asked, "How will the book be completed from here?"

There was weariness on Madhavi's face. "That question should have been asked earlier—at whose cost does the book have the right to be completed?"

"I will make corrections."

"Do so."

"I will add names in the next issue."

"Do so."

"In the next edition—"

This time Madhavi stopped him. "The next edition is not an answer for me."

Devkant was silent.

Madhavi said, "Because the first edition is already in people's hands. The first name they saw was yours. The absence of the names they did not see also becomes history."

"Then what should I do?"

"I will not tell you that. You are the writer; find a public remedy for a public error."

Devkant said, "I will write to the editor, a correction in the journal, a source-list—"

"All of that is necessary. But what happened to me is not treated by a list." She gathered the pages.

Devkant's voice did not tremble, but it was heavy. "Are you leaving me?"

Madhavi did not answer at once.

"I am taking some pages out of the book," she said at last. "I will not put the rest into one sentence yet."

Devkant lowered his eyes.

Madhavi said, "You kept saying again and again—when you do not know, do not fill the blank from yourself. This time apply that rule to your own life."

She lifted the bag of pages.

At the doorway she turned back. "Send the kurthi correction today. That concerns people's bodies. Do not hold it until 'the next edition.'"

Devkant said, "Today."

Madhavi left.

Hemlata had been standing at the other side of the dalan, watching everything. She came quietly to Devkant and asked, "Will Didi's name be printed in the next issue?"

Devkant said, "It should be."

"Should be, or will be?"

The question was in Madhavi's manner.

Devkant looked at Hemlata. "I will write the letter now, and I will not let it go until an answer comes."

Hemlata nodded.

That night Devkant wrote two letters. The first—an immediate correction to the sentence that had printed the folk belief about kurthi as though it were a medical rule. The second—a correction concerning source attribution in the article, asking that Madhavi, Janki, Nasima, Ramanand and the other direct sources be named clearly in future printings.

After writing the letters he dated them. He sealed the envelopes, but this time the act of sealing did not feel like success; it felt like evidence—at least evidence that the work had moved from 'will do' towards 'done.'

The printed journal lay open on the veranda. One name beneath the title.

Devkant looked at it for a long time.

Earlier he had seen his achievement in that name. Now he saw the empty spaces around it—where names should have been, where uncertainty should have been, where the differences among voices should have survived.

The fracture in private love no longer remained only between two people. It had become public on printed paper.

And printed paper has one difficult quality—once the ink has dried, regret cannot by itself make it any lighter.

CHAPTER 26

What Was Not Said

A few days after the printed article arrived, the house looked normal again from the outside, but for Devkant much had changed. The correction letter had already gone in the post. Madhavi had kept some of her original pages with her. The family still spoke proudly of the article's publication, but within that pride Devkant could hear the names that were absent.

One evening around that time, his father called him into the inner room off the dalan. His uncle and an elderly relative of the family were also sitting there. On the table lay an envelope, two sheets bearing names, and a brief account of someone's family lineage.

His father said, "We cannot put off the question of your marriage any longer. Your studies are done, your articles have begun to appear in print, and you are growing older too."

Devkant remained silent.

His uncle pushed a sheet towards him. "This is a good household. They have sufficient land and property, an educated family, connections with the town. The girl's brother is studying too. The standing of the two houses will match."

Devkant's eyes went to the paper, but before he could read the name, another face rose within him—Madhavi's, as she gathered her pages and said, 'The next edition is not an answer for me.'

He said, "I do not want to make a decision about marriage yet."

His father asked, "Why?"

"There are some things I need to make clear."

"With whom?"

The question was ordinary, but for a moment Devkant felt as though the whole house had turned to look at his face.

He said, "With myself. And with a few other people."

His uncle laughed. "Marriage is not a philosophical question. You look at the household, you look at the family, you look for a match with whom life can be lived."

Devkant said, "You look at the person too."

"Of course," his father said, "but a person does not live alone. A person lives within a family."

The sentence was not wrong. Devkant wanted to object, but the words had now begun questioning him in return.

The elderly relative asked quietly, "Is your heart set somewhere?"

Devkant's throat went dry. The answer was only 'yes.'

He said, "There is someone I respect very deeply."

His father sat straighter. "Who?"

Devkant could have said Madhavi's name. On the night of the pirukiya he had already spoken of love. The leaf by the pond, kurthi dal, Tirhuta, steam, salt, the road to Janakpur—all of it stirred within him at once.

Yet the name came as far as his lips and stopped.

His uncle said, "Someone the family knows?"

Devkant said softly, "Yes."

"Family and lineage?"

Devkant bristled at that. "Will you not ask about her knowledge, her intelligence, her nature?"

His father said, "We will. But marriage is not only a list of virtues. Economic circumstances, responsibilities within the household, what is accepted in society—all of it has to be considered."

Devkant understood clearly that this was the very inequality Madhavi had seen before him, and that he had repeatedly treated as small because he trusted in love. His own family had standing, substantial land and property, and a network of educated connections. Madhavi's family was economically modest; the value of her knowledge lay in the kitchen, the fields, the pond, the seasons and the experience of the hand—things this dalan could easily diminish by calling them merely 'domestic.'

He said, "If a household is modest, does that make the person smaller?"

His father said, a little more sternly, "Who said that? A person from a modest household is not smaller. But suitability in marriage is a different question."

"There it is again."

"What is?"

Devkant's answer stopped again. If he wished, he could say Madhavi's name now and place the whole matter plainly before them.

He did not.

After a while his father said wearily, "First become clear yourself. Then tell me. I will not force you, but this uncertainty cannot go on year after year."

The meeting ended.

When Devkant came outside, the courtyard was sinking into darkness. Madhavi was nowhere near the kitchen door. Hemlata was filling water.

He asked, "Where is Didi?"

Hemlata said, "She has gone home. She is preparing to go to relatives towards Janakpur."

Devkant stopped. "When?"

"In two or three days."

"For how long?"

Hemlata shrugged. "Didi said—for a few days."

All the sentences from the family room suddenly seemed far away to Devkant. The person whose name he had been unable to say inside was now preparing to leave the village.

That night he opened the book and stared at a blank page for a long time.

He could have written—'Madhavi.'

He did not write the name.

This time, the reason for not writing it was not error; it was fear.



The next afternoon Hemlata gave Devkant a small piece of paper. It said only: 'Old ghat of the pond, evening.' The handwriting was Madhavi's.

Devkant arrived before the appointed time. After the rains, the pond was full. The grass on the bank was green, and the soil along the edges still soft. Far away a boatman's dinghy moved slowly; the voice came from so far that no words could be made out, only the rhythm.

Madhavi came a little before evening deepened. She carried no pages, no bag. She wore a plain sari, its end gathered slightly higher to keep clear of the wet earth.

For a few moments they looked at the pond without greeting one another.

Devkant spoke first. "You are going to Janakpur?"

"Yes."

"For how long?"

"I don't know."

At the answer, restlessness rose inside Devkant. "You don't know—meaning—"

Madhavi raised her eyes.

Devkant corrected himself. "Meaning, there is no fixed date for your return?"

"No."

"Why are you going?"

"There is work at a relative's house. And I need some distance for a few days."

The word 'distance' fell on the surface of the water like a small stone.

Devkant said, "Because of me?"

Madhavi answered, "Not only because of you. But I need to think apart from you."

"I have sent the correction letter."

"I know."

"The letter about source credit too."

"Hemlata told me."

Devkant's voice was about to sharpen, but he restrained it. "Then?"

Looking at the pond, Madhavi said, "Sending a correction letter is the right thing to do. But it does not erase what happened before the letter was sent. And love should not depend on the answer to a letter."

Devkant moved a step closer. "Has the love changed?"

Madhavi said at once, "I did not say that."

"Then?"

"I love you—but I will not make myself smaller because of that."

Devkant's breath seemed to stop. This was the first time Madhavi had acknowledged her love in words so clear.

He said, "Then come with me."

A faint line of sorrow—or perhaps fatigue—passed over Madhavi's face; Devkant could not tell which.

"Where?"

Again, the question was simple.

Devkant said, "In life. In marriage. In the book. Wherever—"

"In your home?"

He stopped.

Madhavi went on, "Have you spoken my name at home?"

Devkant lowered his eyes.

"The question of marriage came up yesterday," he admitted.

“And?”

“I said my heart was set somewhere.”

“The name?”

Devkant was silent.

A wind crossed the pond. Small circular ripples moved towards the ghat.

Madhavi said quietly, “The name was left out here too.”

Devkant’s face flushed with shame. “I was afraid.”

“Of whom?”

“Of my family. Of their opposition. Of the questions they would raise.”

“And what did you tell me? That you would not remain weak?”

Devkant remembered his promise on the night of the pirukiya.

“Yes.”

“The love was not false,” Madhavi said. “But love was not enough.”

Devkant said, “I will say your name. Today.”

“You will say it today because I am leaving?”

“No. Because I should have said it.”

“Then say it. But not as the price of stopping me.”

Devkant looked at her. “Do you really have to go?”

“Yes.”

“What if I make everything clear at home now?”

“Even then.”

It was not the answer Devkant had expected.

Madhavi said, “I need some distance now in order to make my own decision. I will not hear your family’s answer and immediately decide my life. I have to look at my own mind, my own work, my own pages—all of it.”

Devkant had no argument against that.

For a while they sat silently beside the pond. Love had been acknowledged; there was no agreement about the future.

The evening light was breaking across the water. Devkant thought: some relationships do not break; they merely stop travelling along the same road. Whether they will meet again at the next turn is something no map can say.

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Madhavi was about to rise when Devkant said, “What will happen to the book?”

She sat down again. “That is why I called you here.”

Devkant was startled.

Madhavi said, "I am taking some of my pages with me. Some will remain with Hemlata. You have copies of the material that is shared."

"Without the originals, many places will remain incomplete."

"Let them remain incomplete."

Devkant's face tightened.

Madhavi added at once, "Do not call something incomplete and fill it in from yourself. That has become the best rule in your book."

Devkant said softly, "It has."

Madhavi broke off a dry blade of grass by the pond with her fingers and let it fall again. "Remember one thing."

"What?"

She looked directly at Devkant.

"Preserve my name, even if you cannot preserve me."

Devkant went still.

The sentence was not a plea for love. Not for marriage. Not a promise to return. It was a woman's claim over her own knowledge—a claim that had to remain independent of whether a private relationship succeeded or failed.

Only this came from Devkant's mouth: "I will preserve it."

Madhavi asked, "Should you, or will you?"

The sentence returned like Hemlata's old question.

Devkant said, "I will. Where the words are yours, your name. Where the method is yours, its source. Where I have polished the language, I will say what the original wording was as well. Where something is uncertain, I will call it uncertain."

Madhavi listened.

"And what has already been printed?"

"I have asked for corrections. A source list in the next printing. And if it becomes a book, the matter of shared knowledge from the very beginning."

Madhavi looked at him with a faintly questioning expression. "Shared knowledge?"

Devkant laughed at himself. "Another bookish phrase."

A very slight smile came to Madhavi's face.

Devkant said again, "Let me put it simply—what is yours, I will not call mine."

"That is enough."

"And if you do not return?"

Madhavi's smile disappeared.

"I do not have the answer to that question either."

“Then the book?”

“The book is not larger than a person’s life. Make it from what remains. And what does not remain—record its absence too.”

Devkant said, “You want the reader to know that pages were removed?”

“Where necessary, yes. Otherwise people will assume there was only this much material to begin with.”

“And private pages?”

“Private pages remain private.”

“If people in the future ever—”

Madhavi stopped him. “The curiosity of future people is not greater than my right.”

Devkant nodded.

After a while Madhavi said, “Keep the copies Hemlata has made. Do not throw them away because her handwriting is weak.”

“I won’t.”

“If she ever writes something differently from the original, compare the two; do not erase it by calling it an error.”

“Yes.”

Madhavi rose to her feet.

Devkant stood as well.

He said, “What do you want to preserve for me?”

Something came over Madhavi’s face that Devkant could not read.

“Not everything needs a name,” she said.

Devkant understood—the question was not about the book, and the answer too lay outside the book’s rules.

He did not press her.

Evening deepened beside the pond. They turned back, but not by the same road.

One sentence remained in Devkant’s ears—‘Preserve my name, even if you cannot preserve me.’

For the first time, the language of love had so clearly become a language of justice in authorship.

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There was no formal farewell at the house on the morning Madhavi left. She was setting out from her own home with relatives, travelling part of the way with a party going towards Janakpur. On the bullock cart were a small bundle of clothes, some dry food, a lot of water and a bag of papers.

All night Hemlata had swung between excitement and sadness. In the morning she followed Didi everywhere. "How many days?"

Madhavi said, "A few."

"Ten?"

"Don't count."

"A month?"

Madhavi touched her cheek. "You keep writing the dates. When I return, we'll see how many days it has been."

Hemlata was not entirely satisfied with the answer, but she tucked her practice-book under her arm.

Devkant stood at a distance on the dalan. The previous night he had told his father Madhavi's name. The conversation had not gone easily. Questions had been raised—the household, economic circumstances, the future, the family's reaction. In the end his father had said only, "I am not giving an answer yet."

Devkant did not know whether that 'not' was a refusal or a pause for thought.

He wanted to tell Madhavi this.

Before the cart started, he went closer.

"I told them your name at home," he said.

Madhavi looked at him. "Good."

"There is no answer yet."

"I am not leaving in order to get their answer."

"I know."

"Really?"

Devkant paused, then said, "I am learning."

A faint smile came to Madhavi's face.

Devkant asked, "If a reply comes from the magazine?"

"Show it to Hemlata. If it concerns my name, keep a copy."

"Shall I send it to you?"

"I'll let you know once my place is settled."

Whether that sentence held hope or was merely a practical answer, Devkant did not decide.

Hemlata took Didi's hand. "Will you take my book with you?"

Madhavi said, "No. Your writing stays with you. Keep it safe."

"Your pages?"

"With me."

"Then how will we compare them?"

“When I return.”

Hemlata caught it at once. “So you will return?”

Madhavi was silent for a few moments. Then she said, “I did not say that. I said—when I return.”

Hemlata pouted.

The same question rose inside Devkant, but he did not ask it.

The cart-driver signalled to the bullocks. The wheels moved forward, making their first round marks in the wet earth.

Madhavi sat on the cart. Hemlata walked alongside for some distance. Devkant remained where he was.

Near the turn the cart slowed. Whether Madhavi looked back once or not, Devkant could not later be certain. At this point he did not find his memory trustworthy.

He knew only this with certainty: the cart went round the bend and disappeared.

Hemlata came back and stood beside Devkant. Her practice-book was in her hand.

“Didi will return,” she said.

Devkant asked, “Did she tell you that?”

Hemlata was silent.

“No,” she said at last. “But she will return.”

Devkant too wanted to believe the same thing.

He said, “Yes.”

But his ‘yes’ was belief, not evidence.

By afternoon Devkant counted the pages of the book again. Some original pages were not missing—Madhavi had taken them herself. Some copies were in Hemlata’s book. Some sentences were on Devkant’s papers. Some existed in altered form in the printed article.

The same body of knowledge was now divided among many places.

On the first page Devkant wrote a new rule: ‘When a source is unavailable, record its absence; when a name is known, do not erase it.’

A long time later, beneath it, he wrote another line: ‘Madhavi—participating knowledge-source; original holder of many methods and notes.’

He did not write the word ‘assistant.’

His pen rose to write ‘co-author,’ then stopped—whether Madhavi herself had accepted that designation was uncertain.

Devkant left a blank space.

This time the blank was left not out of cowardice, but out of care.

That evening Hemlata opened her practice-book and wrote the date—
Madhavi left towards Janakpur.

Below it she drew a small leaf in her own hand.

Inside the leaf she wrote no name.

The blank of what was not said remained just as it was.

CHAPTER 27

The Kitchen Now

That evening in 2026, “Mithila Experience” had not yet opened to ordinary customers. Ishan called it a ‘tasting evening’—a few family members, two friends, three people connected with the food business, and Mrinalini. In the restaurant’s front room stood newly polished wooden tables; on the wall were two photographs of the old house, and to one side, behind glass, were arranged makhana, paddy, dried leaves, and small bell-metal vessels.

As soon as Mrinalini entered, she looked at the photographs on the wall. One was of the old house where the Bhanas-Pothi had been found. Beneath the photograph, in small letters, was written: ‘An old kitchen of Mithila — approximately the 1930s.’

She looked at Ishan. “Is the date certain?”

Ishan laughed as he pulled out a chair. “Checking the date in the first five minutes? Customers won’t do that.”

“I am not a customer.”

“I understood that a long time ago.”

The first small plate arrived on the table. In the middle were two small tilkor tarua, beside them chutney in a fine little bowl, and on a leaf-shaped brass slip a line—‘Tilkor — a leaf from an old Mithila courtyard.’

Mrinalini read the line. “An old courtyard?”

Ishan said, “There has to be a story. If we write only ‘tilkor tarua,’ people in the city won’t understand half of it.”

“There has to be a story, but this leaf is not merely a memory of a courtyard. What about the people who chose the leaves, made the pithar, understood the heat of the oil?”

Ishan signalled to the server to bring the second plate. “That is what the tasting notes are for. The menu has to stay short.”

Mrinalini broke the tarua. The coating outside was lightly crisp; inside, the green taste of the leaf could still be distinguished. She remembered the pages of the old book—tender leaves, veins, pithar, not quantities but signs.

“Is it good?” Ishan asked.

“The taste is good.”

“And the rest?”

“I am still reading the rest.”

The second course was makhana—in a small bowl, with very little garnish on top. Ishan said proudly, “This batch is from a different pond-source.”

Mrinalini immediately asked, “The name of the pond? The producer’s name?”

“The supplier details are in the kitchen records.”

“Why not on the menu?”

Ishan leaned back in his chair. “Mrinalini, are customers coming to eat or to read a genealogy?”

“If you are selling ‘heritage,’ the question of whose heritage comes with it.”

Ishan did not answer. The next small plate arrived—two small bagiya, neatly shaped and almost equal. Beside them was a written strip: ‘Steamed rice-pithar bagiya — based on the family Bhanas-Pothi.’

Mrinalini stopped at ‘family Bhanas-Pothi.’ “The authorship of the book is still under examination. On this line, say family book; the author is not settled.”

Ishan clutched his head. “At this rate every label will have to be reprinted before the opening.”

“Good.”

“You feel no guilt?”

“More than I would over printing a wrong line?”

Ishan burst out laughing. “All right. Family book.”

Mrinalini tasted a piece of bagiya. The soft body of the steamed pithar and the flavour of the filling inside felt both familiar and unfamiliar. Compared with the version she had eaten at Basanti Kaki’s house, this one was more measured, more uniform, more carefully presented.

“Is this bagiya made by hand?”

“Yes. Two people make it in the kitchen.”

“Names?”

Ishan said with a laugh, “You don’t want to make a menu. You want to make an archive.”

Mrinalini replied, “The Bhanas-Pothi is teaching me this much: saying ‘handmade’ is not enough if the names of the hands can be known.”

Ishan was silent for a while. Then he typed something into his phone.

“What?”

“A small card with the names of the kitchen team. Happy?”

“Now we have started.”

The fourth course came in a very small bell-metal bowl. Inside was a thick brown drink, with no heavy garnish on top.

Ishan said, “Now try a new taste.”

Mrinalini smelled the bowl. Earth, dal, and a faint scent of spice. “Kurthi?”

“Yes. A small hot kurthi drink. An old dal, a new form.”

Mrinalini took a sip. The taste was not bad. The problem was not in the taste. The problem was in the next card, which the waiter placed beside the bowl.

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In bold letters the card said: ‘Kidney-stone-preventing kurthi drink — one month a year, ancestral body-knowledge.’

Mrinalini remained holding the card.

The moment Ishan saw her face he asked, “What happened?”

“Who wrote this?”

“The marketing team. The basis is in the book, isn’t it? You read it yourself — kurthi dal for one month a year...”

“Say the full line.”

Ishan paused a little.

Mrinalini said clearly, “Janki’s family folk belief. Not an established medical fact. Verification pending.”

Ishan took the card. “But it is family folk knowledge.”

“It is a folk belief. ‘Prevents kidney stones’ is a medical claim.”

“I am not selling medicine.”

“What will a customer understand from the card? The phrase ‘prevents kidney stones’ makes a claim by itself.”

Ishan’s voice grew slightly defensive. “Without a health appeal, why would people pay this much for a small kurthi drink? Taste is one part; story is one part; the memory of health is one part.”

Mrinalini put the card on the table. “Say memory of health. Do not give a definite promise of preventing disease.”

Ishan said, “Then I’ll change the wording—‘traditionally considered useful for kidney stones?’”

“Whose source? Which household? Which tradition? Writing ‘considered’ does not turn a falsehood into truth by itself.”

“Then what should I write?”

Mrinalini thought for a few moments. “If you must keep this story, then write: ‘A folk belief recorded in our family as Janki’s statement: eating kurthi dal for one month a year prevents stones. Not a medical claim; the book itself says “verification pending.””

Ishan widened his eyes. “A card that long will make the food go cold.”

“Then remove the health claim. Just call it kurthi drink.”

Ishan did not laugh.

Mrinalini looked at his face. “You are Ishan, not the editor of 1934. Do not cut out caution merely to make a line shorter.”

Ishan’s hand went still on the card. He felt the sting of that sentence.

“Are you turning me into Devkant?”

“No. I am only saying that the pattern of a mistake can return—if uncertainty is cut away while making a polished story.”

Ishan slowly turned the card over. On the back were the printer’s name and a sample number.

“This is only a tasting sample,” he said.

“Which is why it is easy to change now.”

For a while both were silent. The faint sound of vessels came from the kitchen. In the outer room two guests were taking photographs of the makhana.

Ishan picked up his phone. He wrote someone a message: ‘Stop the kurthi card. Remove the medical claim. New text after review.’

He turned the screen towards Mrinalini.

Mrinalini read it. “Good.”

“Now a smile?”

“Not yet.”

Ishan acted dejected. “My entire business has turned into an examination for certification.”

Mrinalini said, “No. Sell taste. Sell food. Sell the work. Not false certainty.”

“Sell the work?”

“If someone’s labour is part of it, its value is in the price. Let that person’s name remain in the story too.”

Ishan said quietly, “Will customers read this much?”

“Some will not read it. Some will. The question is not how many will read; the question is what we write.”

Mrinalini tasted the kurthi drink again. Now its taste reminded her not of Janki's sentence but of the distortion in the printed article—when what people said had become a definite rule.

She took a photograph of the card. She named the file: 'kurthi-marketing—sample before correction.'

Ishan asked, "You'll keep this in the archive too?"

"Yes. We will not erase the mistake and make it look as though everything was right the first time."

Ishan nodded. "I have heard that sentence somewhere."

"Hemlata's practice-book."

"You are applying the editorial policy of a hundred-year-old household to a restaurant."

"Perhaps that is the best heritage this restaurant can inherit."



After the tasting evening ended, the guests left. The staff began clearing the tables. Mrinalini was about to leave, but Ishan stood by the door and said, "Ten minutes. Let's finish the argument."

"Which argument?"

"Authenticity."

Mrinalini pulled the chair back and sat down.

Ishan said, "What you want is right for an archive. But a restaurant is a different world. Customers buy a story. They come to make their evening beautiful. They do not want a twenty-page source list."

"I did not ask for twenty pages on the menu."

"But your questions never end—whose tilkor leaf, which pond the makhana came from, whose hands made the bagiya, whose saying the kurthi is. A business cannot run like this."

Mrinalini asked quietly, "Whose story?"

Ishan was silent.

"You say the customer buys a story. Fine. Whose story? Whose credit? If you use Basanti Kaki's sentence, her name? If you use Madhavi's sentence from the book, her name? If people in the kitchen improve a method, their work? If the makhana producer's field and pond appear in a photograph, their identity?"

Ishan kept counting the blank cards on the table.

Mrinalini continued, "Authenticity is not decoration made of old vessels, Mithila paintings, and rustic words. Making clear whose experience we use is also part of authenticity."

Ishan said, "Then should I print a biography beside every dish?"

"No. Make levels. Keep the menu short. One line on the table if you want. Detailed sources on a website or in a booklet. Names of the kitchen team. On anything connected with the family Bhanas-Pothi, write clearly: authorship under examination. No health claim without separate verification."

Ishan's business mind awakened. "A QR code?"

Mrinalini laughed. "At last you are thinking in a useful direction."

"A short line on the menu, and through the QR code the full story, source, image, seasonal note?"

"And the date of each changing version. So that if new evidence appears tomorrow, the old claim is not silently erased."

Ishan began making a list on his phone.

Mrinalini said, "And reduce blanket claims like 'authentic Mithila.'"

"Why?"

"Because the book itself says that methods vary from house to house. One household's method is not all of Mithila. One market in Janakpur is not all of Nepal-Mithila. One line is not the life of an entire people."

Ishan said, "But a business identity needs clarity."

"Clarity and false uniformity are different things."

"Should I change the name 'Mithila Experience'?"

"No. You are saying experience, not verdict. The name can stay."

Ishan laughed. "Thank you. At least the name survived."

The two were silent for a while. A young woman from the kitchen came out and asked, "Tilkor test again tomorrow?"

Ishan said, "Yes, but the menu slip will change."

Mrinalini asked the young woman's name.

"Reena."

"Who made the bagiya?"

"Me and Sarita."

Mrinalini looked at Ishan.

Ishan typed into his phone: 'Kitchen team: Reena, Sarita...'

Reena asked with a laugh, "Will my name appear on the menu?"

Ishan said, "Perhaps not on the full menu, but certainly on the team card and the digital page."

Mrinalini interjected, "With your permission."

Reena looked at her in surprise, then smiled and said, "Yes, write my name."

She went away.

Ishan said, "You have made business difficult."

"Not difficult. Accountable."

"There is a difference in cost between the two."

"Then add it to the price. Heritage cannot be built on unpaid labour."

Ishan laughed openly at that. "Shall I give that line to the marketing team?"

"No. Understand its meaning first."

Ishan folded his hands in mock respect. "Yes, Madam Editor."

Mrinalini stood up. "Not an editor. Someone who asks when she does not understand."

Ishan opened the door. "And when she understands?"

As Mrinalini stepped outside, she said, "Then she does not erase the name."

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When Mrinalini reached the old house that night, Basanti Kaki was sitting with the kitchen door half open. Dal was simmering in a small pot on the gas stove.

As soon as Kaki saw her face she asked, "Did the restaurant fill your stomach, or only take photographs?"

Mrinalini burst out laughing. "A little of both."

"Then you must be hungry again."

"I am."

Basanti Kaki lifted the lid. "It is kurthi dal. There is rice left. Will you eat?"

Mrinalini was silent for a moment. That evening she had drunk a small, thick kurthi beverage—a bell-metal bowl, printed card, health claim, argument. Here a dal of the same name was simply simmering in a pot.

"I will."

Kaki took out a plate and served rice, placing nothing decorative on top. Beside it were kurthi dal, salt, and green chilli.

Mrinalini asked, "When was kurthi made in your house?"

Basanti Kaki said, "When we felt like it, when there was dal in the house. More in the cold days. Sometimes the elders would feed it to us saying things about the body, but I am not a doctor."

Mrinalini smiled. "That sentence is very important today."

"Why?"

She told her the story of the restaurant card—'prevents kidney stones,' 'one month a year,' marketing, and the book's 'verification pending.'

Basanti Kaki listened for a long time. Then she said, “My mother too used to say kurthi was good for the body. But how many things sit inside the word ‘good’ is for a doctor to ask. I know taste; I know what a household says. Why should I decide about disease?”

Mrinalini took her first mouthful of dal. The taste was quiet. No polished presentation, no card. As soon as the dal mixed with the rice, its fragrance opened. Suddenly she remembered a winter night from childhood—someone had tucked a quilt around her, fog outside, hot dal inside. The scene was not entirely certain; memory returned only through smell and warmth.

She said, “Ishan’s kurthi was not bad.”

“Then?”

“Why does the taste feel deeper here?”

Basanti Kaki laughed. “Because it is free?”

Mrinalini laughed too.

Kaki went on, “Perhaps you are not in a hurry here. No one is telling you what you are supposed to experience. You are hungry, there is a plate, and you are eating what has been cooked.”

Mrinalini looked at the plate. The word ‘authentic’ was written nowhere here. Even so, the food did not seem to need to prove itself.

Basanti Kaki asked, “Is there kurthi in the book?”

“Yes. Janki’s statement, Devkant’s note, then the distorted form in the printed article. Now perhaps it will also turn up in Hemlata’s copy.”

“Then keep all the forms.”

“The distorted printed form too?”

“Why not? The mistake happened too. If you erase it, the next person will make the same mistake again.”

Mrinalini remembered Hemlata’s rule—where the original is crossed out or blurred, write that it is so; do not clean it up on your own.

She said, “I have kept a photograph of the restaurant’s first wrong card too.”

Basanti Kaki said, “Good. But while collecting mistakes, do not let the food go cold.”

Mrinalini laughed and moved closer to her plate.

After a while Kaki asked, “What is taste?”

Mrinalini did not answer at once. Dal, rice, salt, chilli—the list was very short. But taste did not seem merely the sum of ingredients. The soot of this kitchen, the old grinding stone, Kaki’s laughter, an uncertain childhood

memory, the pages of the book, Janki's folk saying, Madhavi's 'verification pending,' Ishan's card—all lay like invisible layers around the plate.

She said slowly, "Perhaps taste lives in relationships before it lives on the tongue."

Basanti Kaki nodded. "That has become a very big sentence. Eat the dal first."

Mrinalini burst out laughing.

She took another mouthful. This time she made no note.

The night deepened. Outside, the old courtyard held the dampness left by the rains. Inside, steam kept rising from the simple kurthi dal.

Mrinalini understood that heritage could be decorated, sold, and given new forms; none of those things was a wrong in itself. The wrong began when decoration covered the original voice, the market turned uncertainty into a claim, and the story consumed the name of its source.

The taste of home was not the enemy of a modern restaurant. It was only a reminder—that depth of taste comes not from presentation, but from relationships, labour, time, and remembering.

CHAPTER 28

The Owner of Taste

Three weeks later, Mrinalini received a message from a publishing house. The message was brief, but the proposal attached to it ran to ten pages. The moment she saw the title, one eyebrow lifted slightly—"Devkant's Mithila Bhanas: Republishing a Forgotten Cookbook."

The proposal spoke of colour images, facsimiles of the old pages, a modern Devanagari text, an English translation, new photographs of the dishes, and the making of a "heritage edition." The publisher had written that the book could be presented not merely as a cookbook but as "the domestic cultural archive of a great Maithil scholar."

Mrinalini read the first page again. "A great Maithil scholar."

She set the papers on the table and looked towards the old book. Taken out of the chest, the Bhanas-Pothi was now kept safe inside a cloth covering. Blurred lines, Tirhuta writing in the margins, crossed-out sentences, Hemlata's copy—all of them contradicted one another in places and completed one another in others.

The phone rang. It was Ishan.

"Did you see the mail?"

"I did."

"What do you think?"

"The title is wrong."

Ishan laughed. "A three-lakh advance proposal, and your first problem is the title?"

"The problem is inside the title itself."

"It isn't Devkant's book?"

"That has not been established yet."

"It was in the family chest. Most of the main writing appears to be in his hand. The published article is under his name. Family memory connects it with him."

Mrinalini said, “And much of what is in the margins is Madhavi’s. For some methods, she is the original source. Nasima’s name. Ramanand’s. Janki’s. Hemlata’s copy. Blurred lines. Crossed-out credit. All of that is also part of the family Bhanas-Pothi.”

Ishan was silent for a while. “Then change the title to ‘Mithila Bhanas-Pothi?’”

“Until the authorship is clearer, that much may be appropriate. But changing the name alone does not solve the problem.”

“The publisher wants a meeting next week.”

“Let there be a meeting. No consent to publication yet.”

“Have you asked everyone in the family?”

“The pages are asking first.”

Ishan did not laugh. “Sometimes your sentences are very inconvenient.”

“So is the book.”

That evening Mrinalini opened the proposal again. The publisher had already drafted a possible chapter list—“The Seasonal Foods of Mithila,’ ‘Devkant on Fish,’ ‘Devkant’s Tilkor,’ ‘Devkant’s Health Lentil,’ ‘Devkant’s Preservation Methods.’

Anger rose slowly within Mrinalini. This was not merely a mistake in the title. It was the beginnings of a structure that would arrange the entire Bhanas-Pothi under one man’s ownership.

She picked up a red pencil. She drew a single line through each of the first four headings. In the margin she wrote—“Source-based reconstruction required. Authorship uncertain.”

Beside ‘Health Lentil’ she wrote—“Folk belief; not a medical claim.”

Then she wrote back to the publisher—“Agreed to a meeting. Not to publication. The authorship of the original manuscript, source attribution, and editorial history must first be clarified.”

After sending the mail, she leaned back in her chair.

At the restaurant, stopping Ishan’s incorrect kurthi card had been easy—it was only a sample. This proposal was far larger. Once the book was printed, the word ‘Devkant’s’ could again become history.

Mrinalini understood that sometimes saving a book begins not by publishing it, but by stopping publication.

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The meeting was held at the old house. Aniruddha Sen came from the publishing house—a middle-aged man with neatly arranged papers, a sample cover, sales projections, and courteous enthusiasm.

For the first time Shashibhushan saw the full financial part of the proposal. His eyes brightened. “This much as an advance?”

Aniruddha said, “That is only the initial amount. There will be a separate share of sales. Reader interest in old culinary heritage has grown tremendously. If the family cooperates, photographs, documents, travel, publicity—everything is possible.”

Ishan immediately began thinking in the direction of the restaurant. “There could also be a joint programme around the book and the restaurant. Recipes from the Bhanas-Pothi, modern presentation, the book launch...”

Shashibhushan said, “Devkant’s name will reach people again. It lay in a chest for so many years.”

Mrinalini kept listening.

Aniruddha opened the sample cover. Against a deep earthy-brown background was a tilkor leaf, a faint image of an old page, and in the middle, in gold letters—“Devkant’s Mithila Bhanas.” Below it—“One Family, One Geography, One World of Taste.”

Mrinalini asked, “One family?”

Aniruddha smiled. “It is marketing language. The reader needs a clear narrative entry point.”

“One geography?”

“Mithila.”

“One world of taste?”

Aniruddha understood her tone. “You have a problem with the word ‘one?’”

“The problem begins where many voices are being placed beneath a single owner.”

Shashibhushan grew slightly uncomfortable. “Mrinalini, hear the whole thing first.”

“I am listening.”

Aniruddha said, “Look, at the reader’s level, a principal name is necessary. Devkant is a historical figure, we have his published article, and the book was found in the family collection. All the sources can be given inside, in the acknowledgements.”

Mrinalini replied at once, "One name on the cover, everyone else inside in the acknowledgements? That very structure is at the centre of the dispute within the book."

Ishan said, "There is a practical side too. Without a clear name, the book may disappear in the market."

"So for the convenience of the market, we create an author?"

"We are not creating one. A probable author."

"The cover does not say 'probable.'"

Shashibhushan placed a hand on the table. "Explain one thing to me. Did Devkant compile the book or not?"

Mrinalini said, "A great deal of it is in his hand. Compilation, editing, writing—yes. But that does not turn all the knowledge in it into his sole property."

Aniruddha asked carefully, "What do you want?"

"An archival examination first. Whose hand is on which page, whose sentence, whose method. Wherever there is uncertainty, say so. How much of it is Madhavi's contribution, how much is Hemlata's copy—let that be examined. Then decide the title and the credit."

Ishan asked, "How much time?"

"I don't know."

Shashibhushan said immediately, "In the meantime the offer will go away."

Mrinalini looked at him. "Then let it go."

The room fell silent.

Shashibhushan's voice hardened. "Do you understand how much the family could gain from this? Not just money—name, archive, preservation. The publisher will make high-quality digital copies of the original pages, have them repaired, get them into libraries."

Mrinalini said, "The price of preservation cannot be false authorship."

"Have you proved it false?"

"The truth has not been proved either."

The two sentences stood facing each other.

Ishan intervened. "Could there be a compromise—'Devkant's Bhanas-Pothi, with contributions from Madhavi and other sources'?"

Mrinalini shook her head. "Madhavi is not something to be put under 'with contributions from' if the basic structure was formed from her knowledge. Examine it first."

Aniruddha closed the sample cover. “I can put the proposal on hold. But the publishing house will not wait indefinitely.”

Mrinalini said, “The book has waited nearly ninety years. It can bear a few more months for the truth.”

Shashibhushan left his chair and stood up.

The meeting was not over, but the first solid crack had appeared across the family’s enthusiasm.



After Aniruddha left, only the family remained in the dalan. Shashibhushan stood by the window looking outside. Ishan kept turning the sample cover around on the table. Mrinalini was closing the folder of images from the Bhanas-Pothi.

At last Shashibhushan turned and said, “I don’t understand whether you are saving the book or stopping it.”

“Sometimes the two are the same work.”

“Babuji preserved this book. We preserved the chest. These are papers from our house. Now that an opportunity has come, you say don’t publish.”

Mrinalini said, “I am saying—not yet.”

“The difference?”

“A great deal.”

Shashibhushan’s voice rose. “If the family does not decide about the family’s papers, who will?”

Mrinalini was silent for a few moments. She could not evade the force inside the question.

“Whose house the paper is in is one question,” she said. “Who owns the experience on the paper is another.”

Shashibhushan answered immediately, “The owner of an experience? Dead people?”

“When the names of the dead are erased, history changes.”

“Then no old book will ever be published. All the sources are dead—how will every permission be obtained?”

“I am not saying every permission is possible. I am saying only this—what is known should be kept as known; what is uncertain should not be made certain; what belongs under another person’s name should not be gathered under one name.”

Ishan cut in. “Mrinalini, practically speaking—legally, the family may own the papers, no?”

Mrinalini stopped him. “I am not giving a legal conclusion. We need a specialist for that. But suppose the family does physically own the papers—even then the question remains. Physical ownership of paper and the ethical claim over another person’s lived experience are not the same thing.”

Ishan said, “Who decides the limits of that ethical claim?”

“That is why we need the archival examination. That is why we need a public note. That is why there should be no single-owner claim.”

Shashibhushan said, “You do not trust Devkant.”

“This is not a trial of Devkant’s character. It is a question about how the pages are to be read.”

“But everywhere you turn him into the guilty one.”

“No. There is also evidence of him correcting himself—writing down sources, preserving pages, sending a correction letter, trying to record names. But there is also the crossed-out line. There is also the published article. I cannot choose one version and erase the other.”

Silence returned to the dalan.

Mrinalini slowly picked up the sample cover. “Look. Devkant’s name is on this. A reader will read the entire book through that name. If, five years from now, evidence is found that Madhavi was an original co-creator, what will the first edition be called then?”

Ishan said, “A corrected edition.”

Mrinalini looked at him. “Madhavi heard this same answer—‘the next edition’—in her own lifetime.”

Ishan fell silent.

Shashibhushan’s face softened slightly, though his resistance had not ended. “Then what is your solution?”

“Put the proposal on hold. Tell the publisher the authorship is under examination. The originals can be digitally preserved separately without granting publication rights. Search within the family for anyone who knows the old stories. Speak to the branch of the family on the Nepal side. Find the source of Hemlata’s copy. Then decide.”

Ishan asked, “Why Nepal?”

Mrinalini replied, “The Janakpur pages, Madhavi’s departure, old family references—the chain is leading there. And one name keeps recurring in the family’s oral list—Renuka.”

Shashibhushan lifted his head. “Renuka Di?”

Mrinalini asked at once, “You know her?”

“Not know her. I have heard the name. Babuji used to say that among the relations on the Nepal side there was a Renuka who knew many old songs.”

Mrinalini sat down again. “Where?”

“That is all I remember—some relation beyond Janakpur. I don’t know the full address.”

Ishan smiled. “So: stop the publisher, then a trip to Nepal?”

Mrinalini said, “Source first.”

This time Shashibhushan did not object.

The sample cover still gleamed on the table in the room. But for the first time its golden title looked temporary.



The next day Aniruddha called again. His voice was courteous, but carried professional clarity. “Has the family reached a decision?”

Mrinalini said, “Publication is on hold. We can discuss digital preservation separately, but there is no agreement yet on the book’s title, author credit, or rights.”

“Our legal department will ask—who owns the manuscript?”

“The physical manuscript is in the family’s possession. I will not offer any legal conclusion beyond that. Authorship is under examination.”

Aniruddha was silent for a while. “You understand, this degree of caution is rare in publishing.”

“Rarity is not a reason to abandon it.”

“All right. I will keep the proposal open for two months. Then we will look at it again.”

“Thank you.”

After ending the call, Mrinalini went to the room with the chest. She took out the Bhanas-Pothi and laid it on a white cloth.

She did not look at the first page, but at many pages from the middle together—Devkant’s clean hand, Tirhuta in the margins, Hemlata’s copy, pencil marks, blurred ink, the crossed-out line.

‘The owner of taste’—the question rose in her mind. Who owns taste? The one who first made it? The one who learned it? The one who wrote it? The one who printed it? The one who bought it? The one who ate it? The one who remembered it?

One answer was not enough.

Mrinalini opened her archival notebook. At the top she wrote —“Ownership — four separate questions.”

Below it, four lines:

“1. Who possesses the physical paper?”

“2. Whose hand wrote the text?”

“3. Whose knowledge/experience is it?”

“4. Whose voice is included in the decision to publish?”

She paused before writing a fifth line.

Then she wrote—“5. How is the absence of the absent to be recorded?”

Her hand remained still for a long time over that fifth question. Whether Madhavi was dead or not, where her life had gone—none of that was yet certain. Nor was it known where Hemlata’s complete book was.

The paper might belong to the family. But it did not seem possible to compress the labour, hunger, love, fear, names, and silences of the people held within that paper into a single line of purchase and sale.

She began going through the old envelopes lying beside the chest again. On the back of one envelope, in faded ink, was an incomplete address from an old place in Nepal. The name was not complete, but letters like ‘Renu...’ could be made out.

Mrinalini did not leap to a conclusion. She took an image. She made a note—“Possibly Renuka? Confirmation pending.”

Then she called Shashibhushan.

“Separate out all the papers connected with the old Nepal relations. Old addresses, wedding letters, song notebooks, letters—everything.”

Standing in the doorway, Shashibhushan asked, “The publisher?”

“Will wait.”

“And if the offer goes away?”

Mrinalini looked towards the Bhanas-Pothi. “Then we will find another publisher. A book printed under the wrong name is hard to call back.”

The last trace of resistance was still on Shashibhushan’s face, but he came inside and began picking up the old envelopes.

“I really have heard the name Renuka,” he said softly. “I don’t remember from whose mouth.”

“If you don’t remember, then you don’t remember. Don’t fill it in yourself.”

Shashibhushan looked at Mrinalini and then laughed. “Has this rule now been applied to everyone in the family?”

“It should be.”

The two of them began sorting the envelopes.

Outside, at Ishan's restaurant, a new card was being printed—the health claim removed, the source reference added. Inside the old house, another publication had been stopped.

The two acts were not opposed. In one place, a story was going out in a truer form; in the other, a story was being stopped from going out in the wrong form.

On the last line of her archival notebook, Mrinalini wrote—"The first test of ownership is not publication; it is justice in attribution."

Then she placed the incomplete Nepal address in a separate envelope.

The next road was not yet clear. The direction was.

CHAPTER 29

Renuka's Memory

On the day she was to travel towards Nepal, Mrinalini did not take the original Bhanas-Pothi from the chest with her. She carried only high-quality images, a digital copy of the Hemlata transcript that had been found, the pages from the Janakpur journey, and the old incomplete address in a separate folder. There was no reason to expose the original papers to unnecessary risk by taking them across the border.

Early that morning Shashibhushan asked, "You're going alone?"

Mrinalini said, "The route up to Janakpur is easy. Relatives will meet me there. We've already spoken by phone."

"Was Renuka Di told why you're coming?"

"Only this much—that it concerns papers from the old house. I did not say Madhavi's name on the phone."

Shashibhushan was startled. "Why?"

"First I want to hear what she herself remembers. I don't want to put the answer inside the question."

Shashibhushan watched her for a few moments, then smiled faintly. "This rule of yours is beginning to frighten me."

"Me too."

As she approached Jaynagar, Mrinalini felt, for the first time, the urge to open the pages from the 1934 journey. The present-day journey was fast; place-names shifted on her phone while houses, fields, ponds, and markets flickered past on either side of the railway line. Behind the glass window, geography slid by—the same geography Devkant had once measured by bullock cart and on foot.

On the page she read Devkant's line—'On paper this road will be straight; on the ground, it is not.'

Mrinalini looked out of the window. Now the road seemed straight, but though the line on the phone map was clear, family relationships were not nearly so clear.

On the next page was Madhavi's sentence—'A line does not cut kinship.'

Mrinalini stopped her finger there. In 1934 the sentence had been about movement across marriage, the natal home, the marital home, markets, and speech. In 2026 the same line was leading her towards an elderly woman whose family memory might be older than the map between India and Nepal.

After getting down amid the crowd at Janakpur station, she stood still for a few moments. The old city described on the pages—the dharmashala, the market, songs, the paan shop, Madhavi disappearing in the crowd—rose together in her mind.

The city sounded different now—motorcycles, mobile-phone rings, announcements, printed signboards, hotels. But the moment she heard Maithili voices, she remembered another of Devkant's lines—'Across the border, pronunciation changes; understanding does not break down.'

She immediately added to herself—'Only what I hear on this one journey.'

An old family relation, Vijayakant, met her outside the station. He was around sixty. The moment he saw Mrinalini he said, "You're from the house in India? Renuka Phua has been asking since morning—which daughter is coming?"

Mrinalini laughed. "First let us settle this—I haven't come as somebody's daughter. I have come in my own name."

Vijayakant burst out laughing. "Then you and Phua will get along very well."

On the road out of Janakpur the city slowly thinned. Between concrete houses, old courtyards, ponds, fields, new shops, schools, and distant temple spires appeared by turns. Asking someone for directions on the phone, Vijayakant said, "Place-names in this area change twice in a generation; try finding a house now with an address from an old letter and it can take half a day."

Mrinalini showed him the image of the old envelope. "That is why I did not decide that 'Renu...' must mean Renuka."

"You did right," Vijayakant said. "Phua's name is Renuka, but there could have been another Renuka among the old relations of this house."

Mrinalini liked the answer. Before a road opened, another uncertainty had been added—and uncertainty felt to her not like an obstacle, but a protection.

Renuka's house stood within a low boundary wall. There was a tulsi platform in the courtyard, two trees to one side, and an old bamboo machiya on the veranda. An elderly woman stood unsupported by the doorway. Her white hair was tied back; her eyes were sharp.

Vijayakant said, "Phua, Mrinalini from the house in India."

Renuka's first sentence was, "From the house in India, or as herself?"

Mrinalini smiled. "As myself. I've come with questions about papers from the house."

Renuka moved slightly aside and opened the door. "Then come in. If you've come looking for a name, it will take time. If you've come to prove your own house innocent, drink your tea and go back."

Crossing the doorway, Mrinalini understood: not a hypothesis assembled on paper, but the memory of a living person now stood before her.

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Tea arrived on the veranda, with two small pirukiyas. Renuka said, "Ask while you eat. A hungry person can accept evidence too hastily."

Mrinalini laughed. "Did you know me already?"

"No. I know people a little."

After a while Vijayakant went outside. On the veranda sat Renuka and Mrinalini, with a small table between them. Mrinalini did not open her laptop; first she laid out the printed images.

Renuka picked up the first image. Devkant's main hand. The second—a Tirhuta marginal note. The third—a page from Hemlata's exercise book.

Mrinalini said, "I suspect that this writing in the margin may be Madhavi's."

Renuka held the image a little farther away and narrowed her eyes. "Why?"

"On some pages, Madhavi's name appears beside Devanagari notes. There is mention of a Tirhuta signature. Devkant's notes record things Madhavi said. Hemlata's copy—"

Renuka raised a hand. "Stop. Does all this prove that this handwriting is Madhavi's?"

Mrinalini fell silent. "No. It only strengthens the possibility."

"Then say your first sentence again."

Mrinalini said, "This writing may be Madhavi's. It needs confirmation."

Renuka set the image on the table. "Now we can talk."

Mrinalini looked at her carefully. "Did you ever see Madhavi?"

Renuka laughed. "I was born in the late 1940s. There is no question of my having seen the Madhavi of 1934. If I say I saw her, the first lie begins right there."

"Then what is the connection?"

“Things my mother, my mausi, and my nani said. And I did see Hemlata Di when I was little. She was not very old then, but she belonged to a generation older than mine. She taught songs. She loved paper.”

Mrinalini leaned slightly forward. “Hemlata?”

“Yes. But again—no haste.”

Renuka broke a pirukiya and slid half towards Mrinalini. “First tell me this—what do you want? If Madhavi’s name is found, does the guilt of your house end?”

Mrinalini answered at once, “No.”

“And if Devkant is proved guilty?”

“No.”

“Then?”

Mrinalini thought for a few moments. “Only what the pages say. If Madhavi was an original source of shared knowledge, that should be recorded. If Devkant cut her credit, that should be recorded. If he corrected himself later, that too. If something is not certain, let it remain uncertain.”

Renuka listened carefully. “Did you practise that answer before coming?”

“Perhaps.”

Renuka smiled. “Good. The question is right.”

Mrinalini laughed. The atmosphere eased a little.

Renuka picked up the Tirhuta image again. “I will not look at this handwriting and say ‘Madhavi.’ I do not have a verified letter in Madhavi’s hand. I have some papers of Hemlata’s; I recognise her handwriting because I saw it myself. Madhavi’s name exists in family stories, not her handwriting.”

Mrinalini said, “That is more useful than the answer I expected.”

“Why?”

“Because you did not give me a false identification.”

Renuka laughed. “People often treat an old person’s memory as divine speech. Old people remember wrongly too. Sometimes someone else’s story begins to feel like something one saw oneself.”

Mrinalini remembered Devkant’s 1934 page—later he was no longer certain whether Madhavi had looked back in the crowd.

Renuka asked, “Do you have the song-writing from the margin?”

“I can make out a few words, but I could not read the complete text.”

“Show me.”

Mrinalini opened the next image. Two short lines in Tirhuta ran along the margin, one part blurred. Beneath it, on a separate sheet, was her provisional Devanagari reading—with question marks.

Renuka studied the image for a long time. “I will not say anything yet about reading the letters. But these words—if your reading is right—remind me of a song.”

Mrinalini picked up her pen.

Renuka immediately said, “Listen first. Write later.”

Mrinalini put the pen back on the table.

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Renuka did not close her eyes. Looking towards the courtyard, she began to hum a tune very softly. At first the words were indistinct; then one line became clear—“Wherever you go, remember the name of your naihar.”

Mrinalini held her breath and listened.

Renuka began the next line, then stopped. “Here I remember two versions. One has ‘the name of the naihar,’ the other ‘the courtyard’s shade.’ I cannot say which is older.”

“The first line again?”

Renuka repeated—“Wherever you go, remember the name of your naihar.”

Mrinalini looked at her provisional reading on the image. Beneath the blurred Tirhuta portion, in the Devanagari conjecture she had written, ‘... name...remember...’ was clearly discernible; the rest remained uncertain.

She said, “I can read ‘name’ and ‘remember’ here. I’m not confident about ‘naihar.’”

Renuka said, “Then do not write ‘naihar.’”

“In whose house was the song sung?”

“In my nani’s house too. But my mother used to say that one particular tune was associated with Hemlata Di’s house. Madhavi and Hemlata were not biological sisters—remember that; family closeness was another matter. Later people make everyone sisters.”

Mrinalini immediately wrote—‘Renuka: do not treat Madhavi and Hemlata as biological sisters; a close familial form of address is possible.’

Renuka looked at the page. “Good. There have been many mistakes here.”

“Did you hear songs from Hemlata Di?”

“Yes. In the wedding season she taught the children the words. Once I sang ‘village’ instead of ‘name.’ She stopped me and said, ‘Say name. A village can change; a name cannot.’”

Mrinalini’s fingers tightened around the pen. “May I write that sentence?”

Renuka thought. “Write—‘According to Renuka’s memory, Hemlata said this.’ Not as an exact quotation. I cannot say with certainty that these were her precise words.”

Mrinalini wrote exactly that.

“You are very careful.”

“Memory changes the tongue. The feeling survives; the words may not.”

Renuka had an old cloth bundle brought from inside. She did not get up herself; a young woman of the house handed it to her.

“Are there song papers in this?” Mrinalini asked.

“Some. But first one thing.”

Renuka rested her hand on the knot of the bundle. “These papers survived with me only because Hemlata Di used to pick up papers that people threw away. A wedding ended, a song sheet got wet, a child’s exercise page tore—she would say, ‘If it has a name on it, do not throw it away.’”

Mrinalini said nothing. The more the evidence accumulated, the denser the thread of ‘name’ seemed to become, and that frightened her too—was she herself pushing every piece of evidence towards one meaning?

In her own notes she wrote—‘The theme of names recurs repeatedly; possible selection bias. Look for contrary examples as well.’

Renuka saw the note. “What is that?”

“A caution to myself. I may begin seeing everywhere the very thing I am looking for.”

Renuka laughed with pleasure. “Now it seems right to show you the papers.”

She opened the bundle. Inside were old wedding-song sheets, some in Devanagari, some in Tirhuta, some merely rough notes to remember the words.

In the middle of one page, a Devanagari line read—‘Wherever you go, remember the name of your naihar.’

Below, in smaller writing—‘Tune taught by Hemlata Di.’

Mrinalini looked at the page for a long time.

“Whose hand is this paper in?”

Renuka said, “My mother’s. I recognise the handwriting. There is no date. Perhaps the 1960s. This is not evidence of Madhavi—only evidence that the song-line remained alive in family memory.”

Mrinalini nodded. “And there is a verbal match with the line in the margin of the Bhanas-Pothi.”

“If the Tirhuta reading is correct.”

“Yes—if.”

She wrote ‘if’ in bold letters in her notes.

Renuka said, “In history, ‘if’ is a very useful word. Writers want to remove it; readers want a clean story.”

Mrinalini remembered the publisher’s sample cover—one family, one geography, one world of taste.

She said, “I am beginning to be afraid of ‘one.’”

Renuka replied, “Do not be afraid. Write only as much as there is.”

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After tying the bundle of songs again, Renuka remained silent for a while. Then she said, “Would you like to see the real paper?”

Mrinalini laughed. “Have you been showing me fake ones until now?”

Renuka burst out laughing. “By ‘real’ I mean—closer to the reason you came.”

She asked the young woman inside to bring a small wooden chest. The chest itself was not extremely old, but the cloth inside had yellowed. Renuka opened it with her own key.

On top were a few wedding letters, old photographs, medical prescriptions, land papers. Beneath them lay a thick exercise book with a blue cloth cover, worn at the corners.

Lifting the book, Renuka said, “This is in Hemlata Di’s hand—at least the main part. I recognise her handwriting because when I was a child she taught me to write my name, and there are later letters too.”

Mrinalini did not take the book. “First tell me—how did it come to you?”

“After Hemlata Di died, her papers went to different houses. Some came to my mother. When my mother died, they came to me. No one preserved this book thinking it was a cookbook; it was left as a child’s exercise book.”

“When did she die?”

Renuka tried to remember the date. “I will not give you an exact year. Late 1970s or early 1980s. We can check later against other papers.”

Mrinalini wrote—‘Date uncertain; archival verification required.’

Renuka opened the book. The first pages really were practice—Tirhuta letters, Devanagari words, attempts at dates, a little arithmetic. The middle pages changed. The writing became more confident. Headings—adauri, amat, tilkor, fish.

Mrinalini's heart began to beat faster, but she slowed herself down. This was the kind of notebook whose existence the papers in the family chest had suggested.

On one page, below the heading 'Tilkor,' was written—'Heard/seen from Madhavi Didi.' Then came signs for choosing leaves, the state of the pithar, the heat of the oil. Below, in parentheses—'Madhavi Didi's signature on the original page.'

Mrinalini read while holding her breath. This matched exactly the practice described in the family Bhanas-Pothi—Hemlata did not copy a signature; she recorded its presence.

"May I take an image of this page?"

Renuka said, "Look through it first."

Another page—'Amat.' The date at the top was blurred. Below—"What Janki Kaki and Madhavi Didi said.' Pieces of raw mango, sun, moisture, signs for keeping them separate. In the margin, a line—"Madhavi Didi: In winter there will be no mango; the sourness will remain.'

Mrinalini's eyes closed involuntarily. The sentence that had become Devkant's polished English in the published article lived here in its plain form, with the source named.

Renuka asked, "What does this prove?"

Mrinalini opened her eyes and said, "This much: in this copy by Hemlata, Madhavi is named as a source. And the line 'In winter there will be no mango; the sourness will remain' is preserved as something Madhavi said. It does not prove that all the marginal writing in the original Bhanas-Pothi is Madhavi's."

Renuka smiled. "Now that is right."

The third important page was not a method but a note. In Hemlata's main hand—"Madhavi Didi said—when something comes from someone's mouth, hand, or experience, write the person's name as far as it is known; if it is not known, do not invent it.'

Mrinalini remained fixed on that line for a long time.

She asked, "Are these Madhavi's exact words?"

Renuka said, "This is what Hemlata wrote. Whether Madhavi said it in precisely these words, I cannot say. It is a note preserved in Hemlata's record under Madhavi's name—that much."

Below the note Mrinalini saw a small sign—a leaf. Was it the same leaf-mark used on the private pages from 1934? Or simply the shape of a leaf?

She did not assign meaning at once. Before taking an image she asked Renuka, “Does this leaf-sign appear on other pages of Hemlata Di’s too?”

Renuka turned several pages. Sometimes a leaf, sometimes a dot, sometimes nothing. “It does. I don’t know what it means.”

Mrinalini noted—‘Leaf-mark present; meaning unverified.’

Renuka slid the book towards Mrinalini. “Now take images. But not the entire book. First make a list of the pages necessary for your investigation. Later we can make a digital copy.”

Mrinalini agreed. She took images of the tilkor page, the amat page, the note, samples of the early handwriting, and two pages with dates. With each image she separately recorded page order, condition, and Renuka’s oral information.

By the time the work ended, evening had fallen. Makhana kheer came from inside. Holding the bowl towards Mrinalini, Renuka said, “There is no authorship dispute over this. Now eat.”

Mrinalini laughed. “Whose method?”

“For the moment, your hunger’s.”

“Source?”

“My daughter-in-law. Shall I write the name?”

From inside, the young woman laughed and answered, “Saroja.”

Mrinalini said, “I’ll remember it.”

Taking her first spoonful of kheer, Renuka said, “This is why I showed you the pages. More than getting an answer, you want to make a place for names. But be careful—do not now think that you have found Madhavi.”

“I won’t.”

“Have you found Hemlata?”

“I found one part of her copy.”

“Devkant?”

“Some evidence of his writing and his decisions.”

“Then the story?”

Mrinalini looked at the steam rising from the bowl. “It is still being made.”

Renuka nodded. “Good. Oral memory can correct written paper, but paper can also catch the errors of memory. Neither owns the other.”

Before leaving that night, with Renuka’s permission, Mrinalini made a short audio recording—the song-line, memories of the relationships, and the basis on which Renuka identified Hemlata’s handwriting. At each point

Renuka herself said—‘this is certain,’ ‘this is what I heard,’ ‘this is an inference.’

Closing the folder, Mrinalini understood that she was returning not with an answer, but with a new category of evidence.

Madhavi’s name had survived in Hemlata’s exercise book.

And this time the name was not a stain, but clear letters.

CHAPTER 30

The Final Leaf

After returning from Janakpur, Mrinalini did not open the Bhanas-Pothi on the first day. She secured the images brought from Renuka's house in three places, made two copies of the audio record, and entered in a separate list the sequence of the pages from Hemlata's exercise-book that she had been permitted to photograph. All night her mind kept turning towards the original book, but she restrained herself.

The next morning she reached the old house. Shashibhushan was already sitting on the verandah.

"What did Nepal give you?" he asked.

Mrinalini set her bag on the table. "Fewer answers, more evidence."

"Madhavi?"

"Madhavi's name is clear in Hemlata's copy. But I will not yet say that all the Tirhuta writing in the original Bhanas-Pothi is Madhavi's."

Disappointment and relief came together over Shashibhushan's face. "So, halfway?"

"I don't yet know how long the road is."

She opened the chest in which the book was kept. Inside its cotton covering, the binding gave off the same old smell—paper, dust, an old memory of faint dampness. Mrinalini first examined its external condition and then checked the page order.

On the way back from Nepal, one line from Hemlata had kept returning to her mind—'Madhavi Didi's signature on the original page.' Hemlata had not copied the signature; she had only noted its presence. No such signature had yet been found clearly anywhere in the original Bhanas-Pothi.

The tilkor page was her first possibility. The dried leaf had been found there. After the leaf was removed, blurred letters resembling 'Ma...' had been seen.

Mrinalini opened the book to that page. Pages 41–42.

The dried tilkor leaf was no longer inside the original Bhanas-Pothi; it was preserved in a separate acid-free enclosure, with the page number where it had been found and Basanti Kaki's tentative identification. The shadow of the leaf still remained on the paper in a yellow-brown form.

She placed beside it the image from Hemlata's exercise-book. 'Tilkor — heard/seen from Madhavi Didi.' The method below. Then, in brackets — 'Madhavi Didi's signature on the original page.'

Mrinalini looked over the original page again. There was no signature in the visible portion.

"Could Hemlata have remembered it wrongly?" Shashibhushan asked.

"Possible. Or the signature may have been in another form on this page—in the margin, on the reverse, on a separate leaf. For now, that is only conjecture."

She cast light from the side onto the inner edge of the page near the binding. She compared it with the images from the first day.

Something unusual appeared.

On ordinary pages, the thread ran straight through two holes. On the inner edge of this leaf there was a mark like a third, very small hole, and a thin fragment of brown thread lay at an angle different from the original stitching.

Mrinalini stopped her hand.

"What?"

"The stitching of this page is not like the others."

Shashibhushan leaned closer. "Perhaps it tore and was sewn later?"

"Possible."

She opened the high-quality image from the first day. At that time the dried leaf had still been inside, so the inner edge had not opened fully. The fine thread could be seen in the photograph too, but it had gone unnoticed.

Mrinalini did not force the page open. She looked through a magnifying glass. At one place on the inner edge, the paper seemed double-layered—although the edge of the original leaf had been folded inward and pasted down again.

"Will you open it?" Shashibhushan asked.

"No."

"Then?"

"We'll show it to someone who knows paper conservation. If the fold opens by itself, that is different; if it is adhered, I will not pull it apart."

Shashibhushan grew a little impatient. "Is there something inside, or only a fold?"

Closing the book, Mrinalini said, "The desire to know does not give us the right to break the paper."

She placed the image of the tilkor page, the close image of the stitching, and the relevant portion of Hemlata's copy in a separate folder.

Nepal had given her one piece of evidence; as soon as she returned home, that evidence had opened a new question.

The dried leaf had first fallen from between the pages.

Now it seemed that perhaps another leaf was still closed inside that very page.



The next afternoon a paper-conservation specialist came to the old house. On the phone, Mrinalini had described only the condition—an old handwritten book, an unusual fold at the inner edge, a possible later repair. She had made it clear that no adhered section was to be separated without inspection.

For the work, they chose a dry interior room rather than the verandah. A clean cotton cloth was laid on the table, the light was steady, and the book was supported beneath. Shashibhushan sat by the doorway. Ishan had also arrived, but Mrinalini had already told him, "No one touches the page."

Ishan laughed. "May I at least breathe?"

"From a distance."

The specialist first examined the binding, the thread, and the condition of the page. "This does not appear to be the original stitching," the specialist said. "Sometimes, when a page tore, thread was added at home. But there may also be the thickness of an additional piece of paper inside this fold. It would be premature to say for certain."

Mrinalini asked, "And if it is not safe to separate it?"

"Then we won't."

The answer relieved her.

The inner edge of the page was supported very gently. No water, oil, or household method was used on the dry fold. Only the angle of the light was changed to see the boundaries of the paper.

At one spot the fold lifted slightly by itself. From within appeared the fine edge of another piece of paper—not white, but more deeply yellowed.

Ishan whispered, "There's something there."

Mrinalini said, "At the moment, there is only the edge of a piece of paper."

The specialist watched for some time. “Something like a small slip is folded inside. One side is lightly adhered. Force would not be appropriate. Only as much as releases by itself.”

The process was slow. The minutes seemed as long as pages. Shashibhushan stood up once and then sat again. Ishan took out his phone to photograph it, but Mrinalini stopped his hand—“First the official documentation image.”

The fold inside the leaf slowly opened. A small, very thin piece of paper, smaller than the palm of a hand, lay within, folded twice. One edge was caught by the residue of an old adhesive; the rest was free.

The specialist said, “It can now be separated. If there is resistance, we stop.”

Mrinalini only nodded.

The small piece of paper finally came free from the original page. There was no tear. No attempt was made to flatten it immediately; it was placed on a support exactly as it was.

At first all that could be seen were lines of black-brown ink. The letters looked like Tirhuta. Because of the folds, some parts still turned inward.

Mrinalini’s hands went cold.

“Photographs,” she said softly.

First the slip in its original condition, then the front, then the back—all were photographed in sequence. So was the inner fold of pages 41–42.

Shashibhushan asked, “Is there a name?”

Mrinalini did not answer at once. She could read some of the Tirhuta letters, not others. At the beginning of the first line, two or three letters looked to her like ‘Madh...’.

On her own sheet she wrote—‘First impression: possibly a name; reading uncertain.’

Ishan asked restlessly, “At least Madhavi?”

“No.”

“But that is what it looks like to you.”

“What it looks like and what has been read are two different things.”

In one corner of the slip were marks resembling numerals. Mrinalini could separately make out forms like 2, 1, 9, 1, 9, 3, 4, but because of the folds and ink it was not yet appropriate to read a full date.

On the back was a very short sentence in Devanagari—the colour of its ink differed from the writing on the front.

Ishan said, “This part you can read.”

Mrinalini fixed her eyes on it. The letters were blurred, but a fragment resembling ‘Madhavi’s name’ seemed possible. After that, something like ‘again...’ or ‘put...’.

She applied the same rule again—do not turn conjecture into text.

“We will compare the writing on the back first,” she said. “Devkant’s authenticated letters, the main hand in the original Bhanas-Pothi, the sequence of the ink—everything.”

The paper-conservation specialist placed the slip in an appropriate separate enclosure and recorded its original page reference. The adhesive residue on the fold was not removed that day.

After the work was finished, Shashibhushan looked at the small enclosure for a long time.

“So many days for such a small piece of paper?”

Mrinalini said, “The paper is small. The claim could be large.”

Shashibhushan did not reply.

The dried tilkor leaf was in one enclosure. The small Tirhuta leaf was in another.

One leaf was a memory of taste.

The other, perhaps, of a name.



Mrinalini did not call Renuka that evening. First she organised high-quality images of the slip, clearly recording its original dimensions, direction of light, front, and back. On a separate sheet she made her provisional reading of the Tirhuta section, putting a question mark wherever a letter was uncertain.

The next morning she had a video call with Renuka. Renuka’s face appeared on the screen, with part of the same Janakpur courtyard behind her.

“Found the name this early in the morning?” Renuka asked.

Mrinalini said, “Found a piece of paper. The name still has to be read.”

She showed the first image on the screen.

Renuka said nothing at once. For a long time she looked at the enlarged image. “The fold-line is cutting across the letters in the middle. The first line?”

“It looks like ‘Madh...’ to me. But I want you to read it independently.”

Renuka changed her glasses. “I have little doubt about the first letter being ‘ma’. Then the long ‘aa’ sign. The third... that could be ‘dha’. Then ‘vi’?”

Mrinalini let out a breath, but wrote—‘Renuka: possible reading Madhavi; not independent full confirmation.’

“You aren’t happy?” Renuka asked.

“I am. That is why I need more caution.”

Renuka smiled. “Good.”

The second image contained the date. The forms of the numerals were compared with old pages. The date on the slip began to read clearly as “21.9.1934.” The dots between the figures were ink, not stains on the paper—Mrinalini checked this against images taken under different light.

“Write the date, but say ‘read form,’” Renuka said. “The paper does not understand a calendar by itself.”

“21.9.1934—the numerals as read on the slip.”

“Good.”

Now the main sentence. There were three lines in Tirhuta. Some letters were clear; others were faint where they had been compressed in the fold. Mrinalini had Hemlata’s exercise-book open beside her for comparison of letter forms.

Renuka read the first line slowly. Mrinalini repeated it. At two places their readings differed; she recorded both possibilities.

On the second line one word was clear—‘name’. On the third, forms resembling ‘blank’ and ‘not’.

After nearly half an hour of comparison, one possible reading emerged. Mrinalini wrote a provisional Devanagari version, then read it aloud to Renuka:

“I am Madhavi. 21.9.1934. Whatever is written in this Bhanas-Pothi from someone’s hand, experience, or words, let that person’s name remain beside it. If the name is not known, let the place remain blank; do not put another person’s name there.”

On the other side of the screen, Renuka remained silent.

Mrinalini added at once, “This is not a fully certain transcription. There is an alternative reading for the word ‘hand’; one letter in ‘place remain blank’ is unclear.”

Renuka nodded. “Does it change the meaning?”

“Not the main sense. But in publication we will give the original image, the Tirhuta text, the uncertain letters, and the Devanagari reading separately.”

Renuka said slowly, “Can you say now—the name Madhavi has been found?”

Mrinalini looked again at the first line of the slip.

“‘Madhavi’ is being read on this slip. In Hemlata’s copy, Madhavi’s name appears as a source. The two strengthen each other. Yes—the evidence is now very strong.”

Renuka asked, “Madhavi’s signature?”

“I am Madhavi’ is self-identification. But for handwriting comparison, we still have too few other securely identified samples of Madhavi’s hand. I will use the word ‘signature’ cautiously.”

“Arguing with you is difficult.”

“You taught me.”

Renuka laughed.

A little later Mrinalini’s eyes grew wet. She did not turn off the phone camera or try to hide the emotion.

“What happened?” Renuka asked.

“So many pages—” She stopped. “For so long I was looking for one name. Now that the name has been found, it feels as though the search has not ended; responsibility has begun.”

Renuka said, “Finding a name is not finding a person.”

“I know.”

“And one slip of paper does not open an entire life.”

“I know.”

“Then cry. Historians can cry too; just don’t make tears into evidence.”

Mrinalini wiped her eyes, laughing.

The small slip was enlarged on the screen. The fibres of the paper, the fold-lines, the broken dots of ink—everything.

The name was becoming clearer.

Madhavi was no longer only an inferred name; at least on this slip, she was coming into view as a person who had written her own name.

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After the conversation with Renuka ended, Mrinalini turned to the Devanagari writing on the back of the slip. The ink in this section was a darker brown-black than the Tirhuta on the front, and the pen-point was slightly broader.

She opened three authenticated samples of Devkant’s hand—a copy of the letter sent to the Calcutta editor, the main Devanagari pages of the Bhanas-Pothi, and an old family account sheet with Devkant’s name beneath it.

She remembered an old observation of Shashibhushan’s—that Devkant’s ‘ka’ tended to be slightly broken at the top.

Mrinalini compared them. In the line on the back, the ‘ka’ was indeed incomplete at the top, the final curve of ‘na’ matched the main hand, and the bowl of ‘dha’ was slightly compressed.

She still did not write ‘Devkant’ as certain. She made a note—‘Strong similarity to the main hand; independent handwriting examination pending.’

The line itself was short. The ink had spread at one spot. Its possible reading:

“Wherever Madhavi’s name was left out, it is to be put back.”

The final ‘is’ was not complete; only something like ‘i...’, with the corner of the paper worn away.

Mrinalini read the sentence again.

It was not an apology. Not a declaration of love. Not a full confession of wrongdoing. Only a line like an editorial reminder—wherever the name had been left out, it was to be put back.

Even so, the line carried weight.

If this was in Devkant’s hand, then at some point he had understood that the name had been omitted. The word ‘back’ suggested that the name had once been there, had disappeared, and that there had been an intention to restore it.

Mrinalini stopped herself. ‘Back’ too could bear more than one meaning. She wrote in her note—‘Possible indication of regret; not a definite self-confession.’

Ishan came in the evening. Mrinalini showed him the slip.

He was silent for a long time. “So Grandfather—”

“Devkant.”

“Right. Devkant perhaps—”

Mrinalini raised her eyes.

Ishan corrected himself. “A later note resembling Devkant’s main hand possibly indicates an intention to restore the name.”

“Good.”

Ishan did not laugh. “You have trained me.”

“The Bhanas-Pothi has.”

Shashibhushan also came. Mrinalini first read out Madhavi’s slip, including the uncertain letters. Then the note on the reverse.

Shashibhushan’s eyes remained fixed on the slip. After a long time he said, “So Devkant had understood his mistake?”

Mrinalini replied, “Possibly. This line is a strong indication in that direction. But what, and how much, he actually corrected is a separate question.”

“He did send the correction letter.”

“Yes. We already have that evidence. But why Madhavi’s slip ended up inside the fold of the Bhanas-Pothi—we still do not know. Did Devkant put it there? Madhavi? Hemlata? Someone else? When was the fold sealed? No answer.”

There was a strange sorrow on Shashibhushan’s face. “I wanted him to be either innocent or guilty. A person in between is harder.”

Mrinalini said softly, “Most people are somewhere in between.”

“Then what do we write in the book—in the Bhanas-Pothi?”

“Where wrongdoing is established, wrongdoing. Where an attempt at correction is established, that too. What we do not know, we leave blank.”

Shashibhushan nodded.

Mrinalini placed images of the front and back of the small slip side by side on the same screen.

On one side Madhavi wrote her own name and said—whose knowledge, their name.

On the other, a later hand said—wherever Madhavi’s name had been left out, it was to be put back.

On the same piece of paper, a claim to recognition and a possible sign of regret.

Wrongdoing and atonement do not cancel one another. The second line does not erase the harm of the first; the first does not make the later hand’s regret meaningless either.

That night, in her archival notebook, Mrinalini wrote no heading like a separate section, only one line—

“The Final Leaf: the name has been found; justice remains.”

Below it, a source list:

“Original Tirhuta slip—inside fold of pages 41–42; date as read 21.9.1934; reading ‘Madhavi’ strong.”

“Hemlata copy—tilkor/amat with Madhavi named.”

“Renuka’s oral assistance—help with reading; no direct memory of 1934.”

“Devanagari note on reverse—similarity to Devkant’s main hand; final handwriting examination pending.”

She put down the pen.

The dried tilkor leaf was in a separate enclosure. The small written leaf was in another. Both were linked to the same page reference.

The first leaf was of the body—once green, something that could have been eaten, dried now and leaving its shadow.

The second leaf was of words—closed in a fold, yet preserving a name.

Mrinalini closed the Bhanas-Pothi.

This time it did not feel to her as though the mystery had opened; it felt as though the responsibility had grown.

The name had been found.

History was still not complete.

CHAPTER 31

The Editor's Offence

On the third day after finding Madhavi's small Tirhuta leaf, Mrinalini opened not the original Bhanas-Pothi but her computer. The papers from the chest, Renuka's audio recordings, the images of Hemlata's exercise-book—all were safe in separate folders. Before her now was the document she had been calling a 'transcription' all these days.

The file had an ordinary name—'Bhanas-Pothi_Text_WorkingCopy'. She opened it. Thousands of typed lines. Searches, comparisons, notes, dates, question marks. The sight of so much work ought first to have brought pride. But after finding the slip that said 'I am Madhavi', she looked at her own file with suspicion for the first time.

She opened the image of original page 41 on one side. The typed copy on the other.

In the original, one sentence read—'Make the pithar thick enough to stay upon the leaf.' Mrinalini's typed text read—'Keep the pithar thick so that it remains on the leaf.'

The meaning was nearly the same. The words were not.

She kept looking at both lines on the screen. Why had she changed 'stay' into 'remain'? She searched her memory. Perhaps—she stopped herself at once—perhaps on the first day 'stay' had seemed a little unusual for a modern reader.

The next line. Original—"The leaf, not the eye, will tell the heat of the oil." Typed—"Judge the heat of the oil as soon as the leaf is put in."

This change was not merely of words. The original line carried the cadence of a household speaking; the typed form had become a manual of instructions.

Mrinalini sat upright in her chair.

She entered 'bhanas' into the search function. In many places the original 'bhanas' had remained unchanged, but in five places she had written 'kitchen'—especially where she had wanted to make the meaning clearer.

In one place, 'the history of the bhanas' had become 'the household's culinary history.'

In three places, 'amat' had become 'dried mango' without even brackets.

In one early page, 'adauri' had been typed as 'dried lentil preparation.'

In several places, 'pithar' had become 'rice batter.'

Mrinalini began marking each of those places, slowly.

She said to herself, "I only wanted to explain the meaning."

The room was silent. No one answered.

She opened the image of Hemlata's exercise-book. In one line Hemlata had written—"Where the original is crossed out or blurred, write that it is so; do not clean it up yourself."

Mrinalini looked at her own clean text on the screen.

She had changed more than words. In some places she had not carried crossed-out lines into the main text because they had seemed to her to be 'later revisions.' In one place she had removed a pencilled question mark because the meaning had seemed clear. In two places she had removed repetition—Devkant had written the same thing twice; she had kept it once.

Editorial convenience. Ease for the reader. A clean text.

The words lined themselves up in their own defence.

Mrinalini looked again at the original page. Devkant's crossed-out line—still readable through the black stroke. Madhavi's Tirhuta marginal note. A question mark. Two colours of ink.

In the typed text she saw only one well-shaped paragraph.

"What have I done?" escaped her mouth.

Basanti Kaki came and stood at the doorway. "Who are you talking to?"

Mrinalini started. "Myself."

"Then an answer will be hard to get."

Kaki came inside and looked at the screen. "All these papers?"

"My typed copy."

"A mistake?"

Mrinalini said, "More than a mistake. I made some words easier for the reader."

Adjusting the end of her sari near her shoulder, Basanti Kaki asked, "Did the meaning change?"

"In some places, no. In some, the voice changed. In some, perhaps even the meaning."

"Will the original remain?"

"It exists."

“Then correct it.”

Mrinalini could not laugh. “That is not the whole problem. All these days I have been judging Devkant’s error—how, in making things elegant, short, and clear for the reader, he changed another person’s voice. On a smaller scale, I was doing the same.”

Basanti Kaki was not reading the letters on the screen; she was reading Mrinalini’s face.

“Did he do it knowingly?”

“Not everywhere.”

“And you?”

“Not everywhere knowingly either.”

Kaki said, “Then what you do after recognising the mistake will make the difference.”

On the screen Mrinalini selected the word ‘kitchen’ and typed ‘bhanas’ again.

One word returned.

But she understood that bringing a word back did not by itself end an editorial offence. First one had to admit that such an offence had been possible.



By afternoon Mrinalini had begun a new audit of her transcription. This time she was not looking for meaning, but for difference. The original image on the left, the typed text on the right, and between them a separate archival notebook.

First category—‘word changed.’

Second—‘crossing-out/deletion not represented.’

Third—‘uncertain reading made certain.’

Fourth—‘two hands merged into one text.’

Fifth—‘name of oral source shifted into a note.’

The list kept growing. Each line felt like a small blow to her editorial self-confidence.

On one page Devkant’s main hand read—‘Examine the amat again in sunlight.’ In the margin another hand said—‘Keep the wet pieces separate.’ In her typed copy Mrinalini had combined them—‘Examine the amat again in sunlight; keep the wet pieces separate.’

A very elegant instruction for the reader.

Wrong for the archive.

Because the original contained two hands. Mrinalini had made one voice.

On paper she wrote—‘voice fusion.’ The phrase sent a shiver through her as soon as she wrote it.

In the published article Devkant had turned ‘Madhavi said’ into ‘the women of the household say.’ In the original Bhanas-Pothi, Mrinalini had turned Devkant’s and Madhavi’s two hands into one neutral instruction. Different scale, same structure.

She resisted the temptation to be harsh with herself. Self-blame too could become performance. The question was not whether she was a bad editor; the question was what had changed in the file, and how it could be repaired.

Mrinalini began assigning an evidence category to each difference.

In one place the original word was unclear—‘chhili’ or ‘chiri’. She had previously chosen ‘chiri’ because it had seemed more appropriate in a food method. Now she wrote—‘chhi/chi? original unclear.’

In one place a Tirhuta letter allowed three possible readings. She had earlier chosen the form suggested by Renuka. Now she kept all three possibilities separately.

In one place Devkant had later added ‘not’ in pencil. In the typed copy that ‘not’ had become part of the main sentence. Mrinalini now marked it—‘later pencilled revision.’

She began to understand how often the editor creates the single thing called a ‘correct text.’ On the original paper, history exists all at once: first writing, deletion, correction, disagreement, a later hand, a stain, a blank. If all of that is turned into one sentence for the reader’s convenience, convenience defeats history.

Ishan called. “Will you look at the restaurant’s new card?”

Mrinalini said, “This evening. Right now I am counting my own offences.”

“What?”

“My transcription.”

“You’re being dramatic again—” Ishan stopped. “All right. What did you find?”

Mrinalini gave him two examples.

Ishan said, “But the text has to be made understandable to the reader too.”

“Yes. But not by altering the original text. Explanation can be given separately.”

“You want three versions of everything?”

“Perhaps. The original image, an as-is transcription, and then an annotated reading for accessibility.”

Ishan laughed. “One page of food, four pages of editing.”

“Where necessary.”

“Will anyone read the book?”

“If shortening requires erasing voices, fewer readers will do.”

Ishan was silent for a few moments. “Now I understand why the publisher won’t like you.”

“I will offer the publisher compromises. Not the truth.”

After ending the call, Mrinalini returned to the file.

This time she found one very small alteration. In the original, a possible note by Madhavi—‘in this house.’ In the typed text—‘in Mithila.’

Mrinalini’s hand stopped.

This was exactly the error she had been trying to prevent from the beginning—turning one household’s experience into all of Mithila.

She traced how the change had entered the file. In the earliest transcription it read ‘in this house.’ In the second revised file, ‘in Mithila.’ In the margin, her own note—‘context for reader.’

She rose from the chair and went to the window.

Outside in the courtyard, two new leaves of the tilkor vine moved in the wind. No one was proclaiming them to be the leaves of all Mithila. They were the leaves of this courtyard—and, in their particularity, part of Mithila.

Mrinalini sat down again. She crossed out ‘in Mithila’ and wrote ‘in this house.’

Then, in large letters in her archival notebook, she wrote—‘Reader convenience does not permit changing the limits of a source.’

Beneath that line, another sentence—‘The editor’s offence often enters under the name of convenience.’



That evening Mrinalini drafted the first version of a new editorial policy. She called it not a rulebook but a list of responsibilities.

First rule—wherever possible, an image of the original page will be available in the published version. The reader should be able to see where the ink changes, where a line is crossed out, where the page is blurred.

Second—‘diplomatic transcription’: original words, spelling, line breaks, crossed-out text, added words, question marks—as much as can be seen. If a

letter cannot be read, uncertainty in brackets. No conjecture inserted into the main text.

Third—‘reader-aid text’: a Devanagari version for modern readers, meanings of difficult words, transliteration of Tirhuta text, but every change clearly marked.

Fourth—keep hands separate. Main hand, second hand in the margin, pencil on the reverse, later ink—all may provisionally be labelled Hand 1, Hand 2, Hand 3; where a name is established, use the name. Where it is not, use ‘unknown hand.’

Fifth—oral memory will not be silently merged into written text. Renuka’s memory, Basanti Kaki’s account, family stories—all are separate source categories.

Sixth—if a food method is recreated in the present, changes made by the new kitchen will not be inserted into the original 1934 method. Modern reconstruction will be a separate section.

Seventh—health-related folk statements will be clearly marked as folk statements. Not medical claims. The kurthi line is the first example.

Eighth—local forms of words will not be removed. ‘amat’, ‘adauri’, ‘pithar’, ‘bagiya’, ‘bhanas’, ‘tilkor’—the original word first; an explanatory note separately if needed.

Ninth—crossed-out lines do not disappear. If Devkant crossed something out, the reader has the right to see the crossing-out. If Madhavi wrote disagreement in the margin, it is part of the principal history.

Tenth—the editor will date her own revisions. When a file changes, the old version remains preserved. No false impression that ‘everything was correct the first time.’

Mrinalini read the ten rules. She remembered Hemlata’s exercise-book—preserve the child’s crooked letter; put the correct form beside it. Nearly a century later, that simple lesson was becoming a policy for digital editing.

Above the rules she wrote the heading—‘Original text separate, interpretation separate.’

Ishan came straight from the restaurant that evening, carrying the new cards. Mrinalini showed him her rules.

Reading the fifth rule, Ishan said, “You will turn the restaurant website into a research paper too.”

“The digital page. And not all the rules apply to the restaurant.”

“Which ones do?”

“Names of sources, health claims, the limits of a household-specific source, present reconstruction kept separate—those all apply.”

Ishan placed the new kurthi card on the table. It now read—‘Kurthi dal — recorded in the family’s old Bhanas-Pothi together with Janki’s folk account. The health-related line is a folk belief, not medical advice.’

Mrinalini read it. “Much better.”

“Much?”

“‘Old Bhanas-Pothi’ is good. ‘Janki’s folk account’ is good. Add the digital link to the source-check.”

“More work.”

“Yes.”

Ishan laughed and sat down. “Reading your rules, I understood one thing. I change the food, but I can say that I have changed it. The problem comes when I sell something new by calling it ‘old.’”

Mrinalini looked at him. “Save that sentence.”

“With my name?”

“Yes, Ishan.”

Both laughed.

On the first page of her file, not in red letters but in ordinary black, Mrinalini added a warning—‘This working transcription was previously affected by editorial normalisation. The revised version is being compared again against the original images.’

She could have deleted the old, error-filled file. She did not. She renamed it —‘Pre-Editing_Preserved.’

The new file—‘Original-Based_Two-Layer-Text.’

The first correction began with the tilkor page.

The main hand’s line separate. Madhavi’s possible marginal reading separate. Hemlata’s copy as separate evidence. The Final Leaf as a separate document.

One page opened into three or four voices.

The text became more complex.

History became a little truer.

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Two days later the family met again in the dalan. This time the publisher’s glossy cover was not on the table. The original Bhanas-Pothi lay in its closed enclosure, along with Hemlata’s images, a copy of Madhavi’s small leaf, and Mrinalini’s editorial policy.

Shashibhushan, Ishan, Basanti Kaki, and Mrinalini sat together. Mrinalini made one thing clear at the start—"Today we are not deciding whether to publish the book. First we will record, by agreement, what we know and what we do not."

Shashibhushan said, "All right."

Mrinalini opened the first sheet. "One—the greater part of the main Bhanas-Pothi is in Devkant's hand. This is strong."

Second—"There is strong evidence that at least some of the Tirhuta writing in the margins is connected with Madhavi, but that every marginal hand is Madhavi's—no, not yet."

Third—"In Hemlata's exercise-book there are tilkor, amat, and attribution-related notes naming Madhavi. Renuka recognises Hemlata's hand; confirmation of dates and physical examination of some pages remain pending."

Fourth—"On the Final Leaf, the reading 'I am Madhavi' is strong; the date as read is 21.9.1934. Some letters in the original Tirhuta text remain uncertain and will be marked as such in publication."

Fifth—"The Devanagari note on the reverse appears similar to Devkant's main hand; independent handwriting examination is pending. Its sense points towards restoring Madhavi's omitted name."

Sixth—"In Devkant's published article, source compression, the absence of Madhavi's name, and the more certain rendering of the kurthi folk statement are documented problems."

Seventh—"Evidence of the correction letter shows that Devkant had begun correcting at least some of the errors."

Shashibhushan listened without speaking.

Mrinalini opened the eighth sheet. "And eighth—my own mistake. In the typed transcription I normalised some original words, merged two hands, and made uncertain readings appear clean. These are now being separated."

Ishan looked at Mrinalini. Basanti Kaki remained quiet.

For the first time Shashibhushan lifted his head. "Is it necessary to say all this?"

"Yes."

"In the book too?"

"In the editorial note. Otherwise the reader will think we are a neutral pane of glass through which the original text simply passes. An editor makes selections too."

There was no disagreement on Shashibhushan's face, only tiredness. "Then no one's name will remain completely clean."

Mrinalini said, "We need clear names, not spotless statues."

The room fell silent again.

Ishan asked softly, "What do we tell the publisher?"

"The working title changes. No single-author claim yet. Layered attribution."

"The wording?"

"We will decide according to the evidence at the next meeting. Perhaps—" Mrinalini stopped, then corrected herself—"perhaps something like 'compiled and principally written by Devkant, with Madhavi's writing/knowledge sources'; but the boundary of 'writing' only after the handwriting examination."

Shashibhushan rested his hand on the enclosure of the original Bhanas-Pothi.

"Since childhood I have heard that this is Devkant's book," he said. "Babuji used to say the same. To me it was the pride of the house."

Mrinalini said nothing.

"At first I thought you wanted to make Devkant smaller."

"I—"

Shashibhushan raised a hand to stop her. "No, listen. Now I understand that adding Madhavi's name does not make Devkant smaller."

After saying it, he looked at the Bhanas-Pothi for a long time.

Basanti Kaki said softly, "Giving someone the name that is theirs does not reduce another person's name."

Ishan said, "Sometimes the market's cover may simply be too small."

A faint smile came over everyone's face. For the first time the tension loosened a little.

Mrinalini asked Shashibhushan, "Then we reject the publisher's old cover?"

"Yes."

"No single name until the authorship examination is complete?"

"Yes."

"Madhavi's name in the main attribution structure?"

Shashibhushan paused briefly. "As much as the evidence supports. No less, no more."

Mrinalini smiled. "That is all I want."

Ishan asked, "And Hemlata?"

“Clear credit as copyist and independent evidence,” Mrinalini said.

“Janki, Nasima, Ramanand?”

“Not only in a source list—where their knowledge becomes text, their names should be before the reader.”

Basanti Kaki said, “Then the book will be thick.”

Mrinalini laughed. “It will.”

“Lifting it will be the reader’s work.”

Everyone laughed.

The meeting was about to end. Mrinalini was gathering the papers when Shashibhushan said again, “One more thing.”

“What?”

“Do not delete your own old, faulty transcription.”

Mrinalini stopped.

“Why?”

“You say, don’t you, that if a mistake is erased, later people will think everything was right the first time?”

Mrinalini looked at him. Hemlata’s rule had now returned through Shashibhushan’s mouth.

“I won’t delete it,” she said.

The offence of the Bhanas-Pothi no longer belonged only to 1934. The editor of 2026 too was learning to see the marks made by her own hand.

The next stage of justice was not only to expose another person’s mistakes, but to make one’s own choices visible as well.

CHAPTER 32

With the Name

Two weeks later, a new cover draft arrived from the publishing house. This time, when she opened the envelope, Mrinalini looked first not at the title but at the credit line.

At the top, in bold letters, only—"Mithila Bhanas-Pothi."

Beneath it, in smaller but clear type—"Compiled and principally written by Devkant · with verified writing and oral knowledge-sources from Madhavi."

The credit structure on the next page was different—"Copy-evidence from Hemlata; Janki, Nasima, Ramanand, and other named sources; critical editing—Mrinalini."

Mrinalini looked at the paper for a long time. This was not final wording; the publisher himself had written at the top—"Subject to revision according to handwriting examination and the family's final agreement."

Shashibhushan came onto the verandah. "So Devkant's name has been removed this time?"

"Not removed. Repositioned."

"Not in the centre of the cover."

"Because the Bhanas-Pothi is not a verified work by a single author."

Shashibhushan took the draft in his hand. For the first time, nothing like an old wound crossed his face. He read slowly—"Compiled and principally written by Devkant..."

"That is not little," Mrinalini said.

"No."

He read the second line—"With verified writing and oral knowledge-sources from Madhavi."

Shashibhushan asked, "How much verified writing?"

"The Final Leaf is certainly hers, with self-identification. Hemlata's copy links tilkor, amat, and the attribution statement to Madhavi by name. We

will not yet assign all the Tirhuta marginal writing in the original Bhanas-Pothi to her.”

“Then the word ‘verified’ in the line is appropriate.”

“So far.”

Ishan came straight from the restaurant, carrying a new menu and the kurthi card. The moment he saw the cover he said, “At last the name has changed.”

Mrinalini said, “Not the name. The claim.”

Ishan read the draft. “One thing is bothering me. Why are Janki, Nasima, and Ramanand only on an inside page?”

Mrinalini looked at him. “Good question.”

Shashibhushan said, “Every name will not fit on the cover.”

“They do not have to,” Mrinalini said. “But an opening credit page will be directly before the reader. The source list will not be hidden at the end.”

Ishan said, “Then a whole page—‘The Voices of This Bhanas-Pothi?’”

Mrinalini’s face brightened. “Yes. As much as the evidence supports for each person. No one reduced by being called merely a ‘helper.’”

Shashibhushan thought for a moment and said, “Will Devkant’s note on the back be printed too?”

“Yes. The original image, a possible reading, and a clear note—that it resembles Devkant’s main hand, but final independent handwriting examination remains pending. We will not make it definite by calling it an apology.”

“Madhavi’s leaf?”

“The original Tirhuta image, diplomatic transcription, Devanagari reading, all uncertain letters marked. The note on its reverse separately.”

Ishan laughed. “To read this Bhanas-Pothi, the reader will need training along with the book.”

“The reader is not foolish,” Mrinalini said. “Uncertainty can be shown to the reader.”

The digital meeting with the publisher took place that evening. Aniruddha Sen opened the draft on screen and asked, “From a sales point of view, it would still be easier if Devkant remained the principal name. But I accept the family’s decision. One question—legal permission for ‘Madhavi’s writing?’”

Mrinalini said, “We will take a final opinion on legal rights from a specialist. Right now we are discussing the language of editorial credit.

Physical ownership of the family papers is one thing; ethical credit for Madhavi's authorship is another."

Aniruddha nodded. "Then no book-launch date yet?"

"After the handwriting examination, source page, and editorial note are complete."

Ishan whispered, "The publisher is going to start hating us."

Aniruddha heard him and laughed. "Publishers hate delays, not evidence. Just tell me the schedule."

By the end of the meeting, the working title had been approved—a principal title without a single author, layered attribution, and uncertainty retained.

Before closing the file, Mrinalini opened the first cover draft—"Devkant's Mithila Bhanas." Beside it, the new one—"Mithila Bhanas-Pothi."

The first cover was more dazzling. The second was truer.

She did not delete the first draft. She preserved it under the name 'Rejected Initial Cover.'

History's mistakes were part of history too.

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A week later, the new menu came into use at Ishan's restaurant. The old kurthi card was not displayed under glass; it was kept in the archive folder—'First sample; medical claim removed.' On the customer's table there was now a short line:

"Kurthi dal — recorded in this family's old Bhanas-Pothi together with Janki's folk account. The health-related line is a folk belief; not medical advice."

Beside it was a QR code. When opened, it did not first show an image of the original page, but a short introduction—the paper is fragile; images are shown according to permission; source names and editorial notes are separate.

When Mrinalini reached the restaurant, Ishan handed her the menu without a greeting. "Inspect it."

"Am I a customer or an examiner?"

"You have never been merely a customer."

The tilkor line had changed—"Tilkor tarua — based on a household-specific method from this family; the present form is a reconstruction by the restaurant kitchen." Below it—"Current team: Reena, Sarita, Manisha."

Mrinalini asked, "Did you get permission from Reena, Sarita, and Manisha to print their names?"

Ishan opened his phone and showed all three messages—“Yes, the name may be given.”

“Good.”

“Praise now?”

“One.”

“Only one?”

“The prices are far too high.”

Ishan burst out laughing. “That is not heritage-compliant criticism.”

The makhana line named the producer group, but Ishan had deliberately made no sweeping claim about ownership of the pond. It said ‘according to supplier information,’ and the detailed page carried a source date.

Beside bagiya it read—“Inspired by a method in the family Bhanas-Pothi; present filling and shape adapted by the restaurant team.”

Mrinalini said, “This word ‘inspired’ is good. It does not turn a new form into an old original.”

Ishan said, “Your rule—‘do not sell the new by calling it old’—is now being used against me by my own staff.”

He called Reena.

Reena came out and said, “Yesterday Ishanji was saying the fold of the pirukiya was the same as in the old house. I asked him—evidence?”

Mrinalini laughed. Ishan held his head.

“Then?”

Reena said, “I wrote—‘a present-day fold inspired by household memory.’”

“Very good.”

Ishan said, “The editorial disease has spread.”

Mrinalini replied, “If the symptom of the disease is preserving names, that is fine.”

Before the afternoon crowd began, an elderly customer came in and read the kurthi line. He asked Ishan, “Why did you remove the thing about kidney stones? It used to be said in our house too.”

Ishan said, “We did not remove what people said. We removed the definite claim. If you wish, you can give us what was said in your house; we will preserve it separately as oral memory.”

Mrinalini listened from a distance.

The customer said, “My mother used to say—kurthi keeps the body warm in winter.”

Ishan asked, “Would you like it recorded with her name?”

The old man thought for a while. “Yes. Name—Subhadra Devi.”

Ishan wrote the name, the date, the customer’s name, and added—‘Family oral memory; no independent medical evidence.’

In this small act Mrinalini saw an entire change. Earlier, the marketing team had turned what people said into a claim; now the restaurant was turning what people said into memory with a source attached.

Ishan looked at her and said, “Even some businesses can learn.”

“People learn. Businesses do not, by themselves.”

“All right. This sentence too, with the name?”

“Mrinalini.”

Laughing, Ishan wrote a new note—‘Mrinalini: People learn; businesses do not, by themselves.’

“Why this?”

“So that a hundred years from now no one turns it into something I said.”

Both laughed.

A faint smell of tilkor frying came from the kitchen. Outside, the menu was new; inside, fire, oil, leaves, and the work of hands continued.

Heritage was becoming not merely quotation from old paper, but responsibility in present work.



The papers for the sale of the old house were almost complete. The key was to be handed to the new owner the following week. Shashibhushan had opposed the decision for a long time, but maintenance, repairs, a family scattered across different cities, and rising costs had finally pushed the decision towards sale.

Basanti Kaki said, “The house will be sold, but not the courtyard?”

Ishan asked, “How will the courtyard remain?”

Kaki looked towards the tilkor vine. “Wherever it remains in someone’s memory.”

Mrinalini immediately wanted to write the sentence down, then stopped. Kaki saw her and laughed. “Write it. This is not from the Bhanas-Pothi; it is something I said.”

Mrinalini wrote it with the name.

The idea of one final communal meal came from Ishan, but Basanti Kaki set a condition—“No restaurant table. Here in this courtyard, if not a formal panti, then at least everyone together. Whatever is cooked, in the manner of the house.”

No one made an elaborate list. Rice, dal, one or two vegetables, pickle, curd, tilkor tarua, and pirukiya at the end. No kurthi—Kaki said, “There has been so much talk about that dal; today let us eat something else.”

Ishan laughed. “You too have grown tired of kurthi?”

“The dal is not tired; I am.”

The work of cooking was not left to Basanti Kaki alone. Reena and Sarita came from the restaurant; Ishan brought ingredients from the storeroom; Shashibhushan arranged leaves and water; Mrinalini went with Basanti Kaki to select tilkor leaves.

The vine climbed the old wall. Some leaves were large and hard, some new and tender. Mrinalini touched one leaf.

Basanti Kaki asked, “What are you looking at?”

“The veins. Tenderness. Size.”

“And?”

Mrinalini smiled. “Whose hand selected it.”

Kaki said, “Your illness has become chronic now.”

Both laughed.

While selecting the leaves, Mrinalini remembered the first dried tilkor leaf that had fallen from between pages 41–42 of the Bhanas-Pothi. That leaf was now preserved in an acid-free enclosure—something neither to eat nor to touch.

The leaves on this vine were alive.

Mrinalini took a beautiful tender leaf in her hand. For a moment she felt like pressing it again inside the Bhanas-Pothi as a memory of this house’s final meal. Like the old leaf.

She said to Basanti Kaki, “Shall we keep one leaf aside?”

“Why?”

“For memory.”

Kaki looked at the leaf. “Take a picture. Eat the leaf.”

The sentence was so simple that Mrinalini stopped.

She took out her phone and photographed the leaf—with the vine, with the wall, with Kaki’s hand. Not the leaf alone against a separate background.

Then she gave the leaf to the kitchen along with the others.

Reena, checking the thickness of the pithar, asked, “Should we keep the form written in this house’s pages, or the restaurant’s?”

Mrinalini said, “Today, as much of this house’s method as Basanti Kaki remembers. What she does not remember, do not guess.”

Kaki said, “And the quantity?”

“Shall we measure it?” Ishan asked.

Kaki laughed. “We can measure it today, but write—today’s quantity. Not an eternal rule of the old house.”

Ishan wrote down the measurement.

As the tilkor tarua came out of the pan, its smell filled the courtyard. Mrinalini could no longer identify the leaf she had held; all of them had become food together.

There was no rigid order to the *panti*. Mats, low stools, chairs—whatever suited each person. Basanti Kaki in the middle; Shashibhushan at one side; Ishan, Mrinalini, Reena, Sarita, and a few family relations.

Basanti Kaki gave the first tarua to Mrinalini. “Not a museum.”

Mrinalini laughed and broke off a piece of the leaf.

The taste was familiar, but this time she did not try to capture it in words. No measurement of pithar, no temperature of oil, no age of the veins.

She ate it.

Ishan asked, “No note?”

“No.”

“History finished?”

“No. I am eating before the food grows cold.”

Basanti Kaki nodded with satisfaction.

A little later the *pirukiya* arrived. Ishan placed a small one beside Mrinalini and said, “Less sweet. Someone remembered.”

Mrinalini looked at him. “Do not turn this into an imitation of Devkant and Madhavi.”

“No. You just do not like things very sweet.”

“Then all right.”

She ate the *pirukiya*.

The final communal meal before the house was sold did not become the grand conclusion to any ritual. Water spilled in the middle, one bowl broke, Shashibhushan kept asking for salt, and Ishan ate too many *pirukiya*.

Mrinalini found relief in the disorder. A living tradition is not a room arranged like a museum; it also needs mistakes, laughter, hunger, and a broken bowl.

After the meal, Mrinalini looked again at the final photograph of the tilkor vine.

The leaf did not go into the Bhanas-Pothi.

The leaf had become part of the body.

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On the morning the key was to be handed over, Mrinalini went alone to the old house. Most of the belongings had already been removed. Where photographs had hung on the walls, pale rectangular marks remained. The stove in the bhanas was cold. The verandah table was gone. The chest had already been sent safely to the family's new archival location.

The courtyard looked empty, but not completely silent. Birds in the tree, the sound of the road outside, the sound of a neighbour's door opening.

Mrinalini went to the tilkor vine. She did not know whether the new owner would keep the vine or remove it. She could have made a request, but after the sale she also understood the limit of her own right.

She took only a few photographs of the vine. Place, date, the house's final handover day—for the archive.

A message from Renuka arrived on her phone—"I still haven't found the document with Hemlata Didi's year of death. I am looking."

Mrinalini replied—"No hurry. If it is not found, 'not found' will remain."

Then came a message from the publisher—the handwriting specialist would be available next month.

A message from Ishan—the new source list was now online on the restaurant's digital page.

All the roads were open; none was complete.

Mrinalini sat on the verandah steps and opened her archival notebook. In its final section there was a heading for Madhavi's later life, but very little beneath it:

"1934 — departure towards Janakpur."

"Madhavi's name survives in Hemlata's later copy."

"Possible Tirhuta leaf by Madhavi — 21.9.1934."

"Later residence, marriage, work, death — evidence insufficient."

That was all.

Once, this emptiness would have been unbearable to Mrinalini. Not now.

Below it she wrote—"No conjecture is to be added here in order to complete the life account."

After a while she turned the page. Working credits for publication:

"Mithila Bhanas-Pothi."

"Devkant — compilation, principal writing, some editorial revisions; author of the published article and correction letter."

"Madhavi — at least one leaf of verified Tirhuta writing; named as the source of several methods, sentences, and bodies of knowledge in Hemlata's

copy and Devkant's notes; authorship of other marginal writing under examination."

"Hemlata — copyist; independent evidence for the named source-tradition of Madhavi."

"Janki — named source for family food knowledge and folk accounts."

"Nasima — named source for the fish market and purchasing."

"Ramanand — named source for makhana labour and pond work."

"Other named/unnamed sources — according to the evidence."

Then Mrinalini wrote her own name—"Mrinalini — critical editor; including responsibility for initial normalisation in the 2026 transcription."

She did not strike out 'including responsibility.'

Leaving a page, she wrote the final note:

"This edition will not restore Madhavi's entire life. No edition can. Where there is evidence, let the name be given; where there is no evidence, let the place remain blank. A blank is not defeat—it is a boundary."

Mrinalini stopped after writing. She felt like writing, 'History can be repaired, but it cannot be wholly possessed.' The sentence was beautiful, perhaps too beautiful.

She did not write it.

Shashibhushan's voice came from outside the door—the new owner had arrived.

Mrinalini stood up.

Shashibhushan handed over the key to the house. The formal papers were signed. The new owner invited the family to look inside once more, but no one stayed very long.

As she crossed the doorway, Mrinalini looked back.

This time she did not ask herself whether Madhavi had looked back in the crowd at Janakpur in 1934. That question had no answer; nor did she have the right to that scene.

She looked at the house in the present—the wall, the vine, the empty verandah.

Then she left.

That evening, at the new archival location, there was no need to open the original Bhanas-Pothi. Mrinalini opened only the digital image of Madhavi's leaf.

In the first line, 'I am Madhavi' was clearly visible.

In the image description she wrote—"Person-name: Madhavi. Name not erased."

Then she closed the file.

The next page was still blank.

She was in no hurry to fill it.



VIDEHA

When Mrinalini returns to unlock her family's shuttered house in Mithila, she expects only an inventory of old vessels and fading photographs.

Instead, inside a crumbling bhans-pothi, she finds a name inscribed on a single palm leaf – a name history had quietly let fall out of memory.

Moving between a monsoon afternoon in the present and the ruins of the 1934 earthquake, this novel traces one family's reckoning with memory, authorship, and the fragile line between what is written down and what is allowed to be forgotten.

A NOVEL OF HOUSES, LEAVES AND NAMES

GAJENDRA THAKUR is the founder-editor of Videha (विदेह), the first Maithili fortnightly eJournal, and one of the most widely published voices in contemporary Maithili literature. The Name Written Within the Leaf is translated from his original Maithili novel by the author himself.



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